



LOVE LOST HER WAY

A TRAGIC STORY ABOUT A GIRL WHO LOST ALL HOPE

JULIE ANNE ADDICOTT

Love Lost Her Way

A tragic story about a girl who lost all hope

Julie Anne Addicott

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Author's Note

This fictional novel contains explicit content including child sexual abuse, violence, non-consensual sexual scenes, disturbingly sensitive and taboo subjects, and mature topics and themes that may be triggering to some readers. Love Lost Her Way is recommended for ages 18 and over.

Julie Anne Addicott an Australian author and writes in British English.

Thank you for reading.

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To the little girls who lost their voices,
and those who helped find them again.
Never apologise for telling your story.

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Dedication

For Yericka.

Sometimes, you find a heart that matches yours, and
in that heart, you find a friend.

Whenever you're lost, just look to the stars and
remember, love will find her way.

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Author's Note

Dedication

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PART ONE

THE GIRL WHO LOST ALL HOPE

Monday's Child

Monday's child is fair of face
Tuesday's child is full of grace
Wednesday's child is full of woe
Thursday's child has far to go
Friday's child is loving and giving
Saturday's child works hard for his living
And the child that is born on the Sabbath day
Is bonny and blithe, and good and gay.

Anna Eliza Bray
Traditions of Devonshire 1838

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In a fictitious world I hide away
To forget the pain I feel each day
Seeking solace between the lines
Words of wonder, poetic rhymes

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1

Monday's Child

CARLIE

April 2

17 years old

I pull the white satin ribbons from my long brown hair then untangle the braids before I run the hairbrush through it, stopping to tug on the ends where they've become a matted mess of limp curls. It's down to my hips now, and for the past two years, I've begged my father to allow me to have it cut, but to no avail.

He's a firm believer, girls should *look* like girls. Long hair, makeup, pretty dresses, and pink lipstick. Pants of any kind are completely out of the question. Although that rule doesn't apply to my little sister, Cathie.

My hope is that when I turn eighteen and become an adult, my father will follow through with his promise of allowing me to choose my own clothes, and finally have my hair cut. His promise, though—like everything else—could be nothing more than empty words I'll soon forget.

There are many things I'd like to forget, but somehow, they stay at the forefront of my mind. Teasing me, torturing me with unanswered questions, and flashes of moments I wish were nothing more than illusions.

My mind often plays tricks on me. My memories flicker, transporting me back and forth between the fractured innocence of my childhood, and the untimely realisation my life does not—and will never—belong to me.

I am a commodity. Owned and bound. Chained to the secrets and lies my father has fed me from the moment I was old enough to understand.

Hope is a wasted wish I make each night before my eyes close and another day comes to an end. *Hope no longer lives here.* I remind myself as I set the brush down and raise my head to look into the bathroom mirror.

The gaunt face and pale features of a stranger stares back at me. Dark circles mar the soft skin beneath her eyes, and her full lips, void of lipstick, are dry and cracked.

Dehydration and malnourishment have taken their toll on my body. Self-loathing, anxiety and fear continue to take their toll on my broken soul and fragile mind.

I reach out to touch my reflection. When my fingertips make contact with the cold surface of the mirror, I close my eyes and let my memories carry me back.

In a moment of clarity, my father appears through the eyes of a little girl who wanted nothing more than to be loved by her daddy.

I'm no longer a little girl, but I still live in an imaginary world. Bound inside books, novels, and encyclopedias are all the places I long to see. My heart, wherever it may be, is lost inside delicate pages, somewhere between poetic prose, fiction, and fairy tales about princesses, enchanted kingdoms and glorious dreams of happily ever after. Words are my freedom, they are my lifeline to a world where my existence includes more than four walls and a roof over my head.

In the real world, I am nothing more than a shell wrapped in a shroud of everlasting misery and lost to the melancholy void of never-ending despair. Every night I die a thousand tiny deaths. Each one brings me closer to the end where all I see before me is a dreary midnight sky, punctured with holes of crystalline stars. I grasp at slivers of hope in a desperate attempt to capture the gaseous light and fill my heart with the wishes I imagine makes the stars shine.

Every morning, in the aftermath of yet another horrific nightmare, I wake to sublime whispers promising an end to the heartache and despair if I can just take the final step. So many times, I've tried, but I cannot do it. Often, I ask myself why the gentle caress of death's own hand has eluded me for so long.

Am I so unworthy, even death will not take me?

I was five years old when it started. I asked my father why I had to bathe three times a day. His big, strong hands lifted me out of the tub and while he knelt in front of me making sure my pale flesh was clean and dry, he told me baths were the only way to wash off the dirt and keep me beautiful. He kissed my cheek and pulled me into him for a hug. That day, it all made sense. If I was clean and beautiful, my father would love me.

He confirmed it when he said, “Carlie, you’ll always be Daddy’s favourite.” I never doubted him.

When my father’s friends visited, they were overjoyed to see how clean and pretty I was. They’d take turns holding me on their laps, stroking my hair, and giving me candy in return for butterfly kisses. The pink candies were always my favourite, and sometimes, if I was extra good and let them touch me, I got big swirly lollipops that tasted like strawberries.

My father always reminded me I was his favourite when I was finally back on his lap and wrapped in his arms. He was my safe place—I never thought it was wrong.

Over time, the candy was replaced with things I had no desire or need for. Underwear with frilly ruffles and tiny, pink satin ribbons I had to show off to my father’s friends. They bought me nightgowns that were cold and soft all at once. And though they were always pink—my favourite colour—I wished for more books and pencils. When they never came, I quickly realised wishes weren’t real, and mine would never come true.

Instead of crying, which always made my father angry, I would sit on his lap and listen to his friends talking about things that made no sense to me at all.

Now, those words are all it takes to send me spiralling into the darkest recesses of my mind.

* * *

When I’ve showered and braided my hair, I pull on my white dress and sit on my bed. For a few short minutes I listen to the sounds in the house. The beat of rock music means my father is in the cellar with my little sister. The knowledge brings tears to my eyes. With an exhale, I take my journal out from under the mattress and place my hand on its pale pink cover.

My journal is my story.

The story I imagine I will write one day. One day when I’m brave enough to pack what little possessions I have, and walk out the front door of the house I’ve lived in since I was born.

My story is no longer the fairy tale I once believed it was. Inside these pages are pieces of my life. Pieces of heartache, despair, loneliness, and pain.

My hands tremble as I open the cover and flick through the pages. Re-reading is almost torturous bliss. Those moments have come and gone—never to be repeated—all that remain are scars and memories. Indelible ink on the pages of my soul, reminding me of what I've endured at the hands of my father, my brother, and the men who've been brought into my life.

When the music coming from the cellar grows louder, I swallow the lump in my throat and cross my legs while I press my back against the wall and begin to write.

April 2

Father has been happy with me and I desperately want to keep it that way for as long as I possibly can. I've been thinking about my brother a lot lately. His life is so different compared to mine. Even as twins, we are polar opposites.

Trystan has a life.

I barely survive.

Yesterday, I peeked outside my bedroom window to see Trystan with two of his friends, Luke and Glen. They were standing by the fence at the side of the house, each one of them with a cigarette between their fingers. They were talking about school, and the homework they had which they'd planned to copy from another boy named Troy. Trystan said he'd paid Troy fifty dollars to meet them at our house after school.

When Troy arrived and they made their way inside, I was sitting at the kitchen table with my father. Luke and Glen acted as though I was invisible. Maybe they believe that if they ignore me, they won't have to think about the vile things they've done to my body. Not that it matters, I doubt they care at all. They're just like Trystan.

Trystan introduced Troy to our father, and Troy, obviously unaware of our father's strict rules, extended his hand to me. I sat in silence while Trystan slapped his hand away and told him he didn't have to talk to me.

I watched Troy's face change. One minute, he was smiling, and his blue eyes were bright. The next minute, he bit his lip and dropped his head before following my brother out of the kitchen.

My father glared at me, but I knew what I had to do. I had to calm him. To prove to him, I had no interest in my brother's friends.

I stood and smoothed my hands down my dress before kissing his cheek and offering to pour him a glass of rum. He didn't reply. His gaze lingered on me as I poured the golden liquid into his favourite glass, then made my way back to the table.

I stood in front of my father as he glanced toward the living room.

I knew what he was about to do.

I've come to know his movements and emotions better than I know my own.

He slid his hand up my thigh until it came to rest on my bare backside. With one hand, he pulled me closer and sucked in a breath as he spread his legs wide.

I knew what he wanted.

I took another step forward, and while my lip quivered, and my brother and his friends laughed in the living room, I whispered to my father, "I love you most of all, Daddy."

I wonder if he's always been sick. Was he this way when he was my age? Is it my fault he's like this? Did I make him sick? My books don't give me all the answers. They don't tell me how to fix him.

I wish I could fix him.

The music stops as suddenly as it started. I close my journal and shove it under the mattress before I smooth out my bed and wait for my father to come in.

When my door opens, Cathie's sobs fill my room. The blush of a purple bruise creates a shadow on her left cheek.

Father pushes her toward me. "Clean her up, I want her ready for the morning."

I nod once. "Yes, Father."

"And teach the brat some manners. She's got an attitude I don't want to hear again."

Another nod. "Of course, Father."

His eyes stay fixed on mine for the longest minute, testing my resolve, waiting for me to crack. Knowing my love for my little sister is the only thing that keeps me going now.

I remain calm, even allowing the corner of my lips to turn up into a slight—entirely fake—smile. It works, and I breathe a sigh of relief as the

door closes and his footsteps disappear down the hallway.

Cathie runs to me, wrapping her thin arms around my waist as I stroke her hair.

“We’ll be okay, jellybean.” It’s a lie, and she knows it.

As I lead Cathie to the bathroom, she sobs while I run the bath. When she peels off her t-shirt, I hold back my own tears as I stare down at the little girl who has lost her will to live. At twelve years old, she should be happier, and of course she should be free from this world where she’s being used, abused, and treated as though she’s nothing more than a plaything.

Once I’ve helped her into the bathtub, she drops her head. “Carlie, I don’t want to do it anymore.”

Kneeling beside the tub, I take the pink loofah and rub it gently across her back, taking care not to scrub too hard. It was only three days ago when father used the belt on her for talking back to him. The wounds have scabbed over, but her thin flesh is still raised and red where the belt cut into her skin.

“Cathie, you have to do as you’re told. You cannot keep talking back.”

She pulls her knees to her chest and wraps her arms around them. “I can’t help it. Shadow tells me what to do. Please can we run away?”

My heart hammers beneath my rib cage. Inside, I am broken.

For the past four years, Cathie’s been telling me about Shadow. A “girl’s voice” that tells her to do bad things. Sometimes, I wonder if there’s something wrong inside her head because of all the times our father has punished her. The times he’s thrown her across the room, or let Trystan beat her.

I hold myself together for her sake. “We can’t. He’ll find us. Please, Cathie, do as you’re told. I’ll ask him to use me instead, but you have to promise me you’ll try to ignore Shadow, okay?”

She turns her head to me. Her wide eyes are empty. Void of love, of emotion, of anything resembling the little girl hidden somewhere deep inside. Her voice drops to an eerie murmur that sends shivers down my spine. “Shadow says you’re lying.”

I swallow the lump in my throat and stroke her hair. “I love you, jellybean, I would never lie to you.”

She brings a finger to her pursed lips. “Shhh... Shadow doesn’t like you today.”

As I wipe a face cloth over Cathie’s face and neck, she begins rocking back and forth. Then, without warning she punches her own forehead. I grab her thin wrists to stop her hurting herself. “Cathie, stop now. It’s me, I won’t hurt you.”

She shakes her head hard. “No!” she shouts. “Leave her alone, Shadow. I don’t want to.”

While my heart beats furiously, I pull Cathie into my arms, her tiny body still in the bathtub and splashing around like a fish out of water. “I love you, jellybean,” I repeat the words over and over until she’s finally silent once again.

When I release my grip on her, her shoulders relax and she drops her head. “Everyone will die here.” Cathie’s voice is an ominous whisper that clouds my mind with thoughts of never ending pain and suffering.

My father hated Cathie from the moment she was born.

I remember the day vividly. My mother’s screams of pain while I dabbed at her forehead with a cold face cloth. My father’s pacing as he waited for the tiny baby to make its way into the world. And my brother, pacing back and forth with him, mimicking his every movement, his every word.

Cathie was born at two minutes past six on the fourth of November. It was a Wednesday. *Wednesday’s child is full of woe.* A single line from an old nursery rhyme written way back in the 1800s plays over in my head.

Wednesday’s child is full of woe. Was this always Cathie’s fate? To be born on a cold Wednesday morning to a father who wanted another son, not a daughter with blonde curls and big blue eyes. Perhaps I was the lucky one. I was born on a Monday afternoon. *Monday’s child is fair of face.* My mother always told me I was beautiful because I was born on a Monday, she said it was why I would always be “Daddy’s favourite”.

I didn’t understand. And for a long time, I wondered why my father never wanted to hold Cathie. He never touched her, never spoke to, or about her until four years ago when he started using her. All his attention was on me. While I was showered with gifts and love, my sister was in her

bedroom, alone. There was always a part of me that wanted her to share some of that love too.

Now, I wish she had been born a boy. Then I would know with certainty she'd be safe.

"Carlie." Cathie's soft voice pulls me from my thoughts. "Why aren't you scared of anything?"

She tilts her head back as I pour a jug of water over her blonde curls.

"I'm scared of water," I remind her.

"But you still have a bath, and a shower."

I squirt the strawberry scented shampoo into my palm then start massaging it into Cathie's scalp. "Sometimes, even when you're scared, you have to be brave."

"I'm brave sometimes, when Shadow helps me. But not all the time."

"I know, jellybean."

She giggles as I wash the shampoo out of her hair. "Can you tell me the jellybean story again?"

I smile when Cathie's eyes light up. It's a rare occurrence, but when they do, it gives me the strength I need to go on, and to protect her no matter what the cost.

I lower my voice to a whisper. "The day you were born Mummy was so, so happy, but she was so tired that she couldn't get up for a little while and needed lots and lots of sleep. Daddy said I could look after you, and once the doctor had gone home, I got your baby clothes out of the drawer and I dressed you in a tiny—"

She cuts me off. "Pink! A pink jumpsuit!" Her smile brings tears to my eyes.

I press my finger to her lips. "Shhh..."

She responds with a nod.

"That's right. A tiny pink jumpsuit. Then, I laid out the fluffy pink blanket Mummy had made especially for you. I put you on the blanket and I wrapped you up tight and lifted you into my arms so I could cuddle you."

"Then what happened?" she asks, even though I've told her the story exactly thirty-two times.

"Then, I sat on the floor and watched you fall asleep. When Mummy woke up, she called out to me, and I took you to her. Mummy started

laughing. When I asked her why she was laughing, she said I wrapped you up so tight that you looked like a little pink jellybean.”

“Did Mummy love me, Carlie, like you do?”

I nod, and this time I let my tears fall. “She loved you so, so much. More than any mummy has ever loved any little girl in this entire world.”

As I rinse out the last of the conditioner from Cathie’s hair, she rubs her eyes. “One day, will we leave this house?” she asks, her voice filled with hope.

“One day, jellybean. One day we’ll be free.”

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Fading, losing
Blood stained, blackened heart
Please take me away from here
From where the nightmares are

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CARLIE**April 16**

Forty-eight days. That's how long I made it without being punished by my father. It's a record.

Everything went wrong today. I dropped the coffee pot this morning, sending the scalding brown liquid across the white tiles as the glass shattered at my father's feet.

An hour later, I slipped in the shower and bruised my forehead. That alone was enough to turn my father's mood sour. My face must always be flawless. There are not many men willing to pay for "damaged goods", especially at the prices my father has set.

To top it all off, Cathie is sick again. For the past seven days, I've been cleaning vomit from her bedding each night as she cries herself back to sleep. She's growing weaker by the day. Her bones are now protruding through her pale, gaunt frame.

Father said he called Jeff—our doctor—but so far, he hasn't shown up, which means I need to care for Cathie while ensuring I don't get sick as well.

As I'm taking another load of soiled clothes and towels to the laundry, Trystan comes out of his bedroom wearing a pair of boxer briefs. I stop in my tracks, glancing into his room where the covers of his bed are twisted around the bare legs of a dark-haired girl.

Trystan runs a hand through his hair and sniffs the air, then glances at the laundry basket in my arms with his nose turned up in disgust. "Ugh, she's still sick."

"Who's that?" I whisper, nodding toward his bedroom.

"Mari. Wanna say hi?"

I shake my head and side step Trystan to continue down the hallway to the laundry, but he puts his hand on the wall, blocking me. He leans

down and whispers against my ear, “I’ll be coming in tonight, make sure you’re clean.”

My heart rate increases and my grip on the laundry basket slips as I swallow the lump in my throat. When I open my mouth to say “no” nothing comes out.

Trystan raises a brow then steps back and extends his hand, letting me pass.

“Tonight,” he calls as I rush into the laundry and close the door behind me.

Leaning against the door, I sink to the floor and let my tears fall. *I don’t want to do this anymore.*

Last night, I dreamed Cathie had died. It should cause me pain and sorrow, but in my dream all I felt was overwhelming relief and a sense of freedom I’ve never felt before. When I woke, despair came crashing down like a lead weight upon my chest. The guilt still coils in my stomach now, a painful reminder of a dream I sometimes wish would come true.

With Cathie gone, I would be able to run, or at least try. While she is here, it’s not an option, no matter how desperate I become.

Freedom is a distant mirage. Untouchable, unattainable. So far out of reach it barely registers a thought most days.

When I’ve composed myself, I throw the dirty clothes into the washing machine and head back to the kitchen to find my father sitting at the table with Jeff.

I clasp my hands behind my back as my father nods toward me. “Come give Jeff a hug, baby girl.”

I force my mouth into a tight smile and walk over to him. His black hair is pulled back into a low, thick ponytail and his neatly trimmed beard almost touches his chest. He’s a huge man. Not fat, but muscly. Jeff’s been friends with my father since before I was born. My father told me they went to school together and have always been like brothers.

When Jeff pats his lap, I swallow the lump in my throat as I sit down. He wraps his arms around my waist and kisses my cheek. “How’s my darlin’ girl? Hope ya’ not gettin’ sick. I’ve got you locked in for Monday.” He raises his brow and slides his hand up to my breast.

My father nods to tell me I can speak. “I’m fine thank you, Jeff. I haven’t been sick at all.”

He rubs my thighs as he continues, “What’s goin’ on with that sister of yours? Goddamn kid’s always sick.”

“Cathie’s been vomiting. She’s had a fever for a few days now, and she’s not eating or drinking. Will you be able to help her?”

“Jeff’ll fix her up, won’t you, mate?” my father says.

“Yep, that’s right. I’ll fix ‘er up.” Jeff pulls my hair to the side and presses his lips to my neck causing a shiver of disgust to run down my spine. “What happened to your head, darlin’? Been disobeying your daddy again?”

My father raises his brow before he orders me to get some more beers from the refrigerator. “She slipped in the shower.” He rubs his chin then crosses his arms over his chest. “Got a fuckin’ buyer coming in tonight too.”

“Carlie girl, you need to be careful. Can’t have your pretty face all messed up, can we?” Jeff says.

“No Jeff. I’m sorry, Father,” I say as I hand him and Jeff their beers.

After making a platter of food for them and making sure there are enough beers in the refrigerator, I’m allowed to leave the kitchen to go back to my room.

Before I reach my bedroom, I stop at Cathie’s room to check on her. I push the door open slowly and peek inside. She’s curled up fast asleep on top of her blankets. I sit on the edge of her bed and stroke her hair, it’s damp, but she doesn’t feel as hot as she did earlier. When I lean down and kiss her forehead, I whisper, “I love you, jellybean.”

She stirs and blinks as she turns to face me. “My tummy still hurts,” she cries. “Shadow wants me to leave this place now.”

“Shhh... you’ll be okay.” I open my hand and put the dry biscuit I stole from the kitchen to her lips, begging her to take a bite. When she does, I encourage her to eat the rest before I wipe her forehead with a damp cloth. “Jeff is here to give you some medicine, you have to be brave.”

She nods once. Her eyes close and she mumbles incoherently. After giving her one last gentle kiss on her head, I leave her room and pull the door closed.

* * *

April 17

3.00am

I'm on my knees in the cellar and my father is furious.

I was turned down by the buyer who was disgusted with the egg sized lump on my forehead, and left without another word. In the past, I could placate my father with nothing more than a kiss on the cheek and the promise I would obey his every wish and command. But lately, he's become more violent and angry, and the whip or belt is used more often than his hands.

I wonder if it's because I'm not a little girl anymore.

"Daddy," I whisper, hoping he'll change his mind and talk to me.

"Shut your pretty little mouth. Daddy's going to teach you a lesson."

His gravelly voice causes my knees to shake as he takes the leather whip from the hook and stalks around me.

He stands over me. Disgust etches his features. Beneath the disgust is a sly, intimidating smirk. His eyes are clouded with hatred, blazing with the fiery rage I've come to know and fear.

"One," he says calmly as the whip slices through the air.

When it makes contact with my back, beads of sweat drip from my hairline. My brow creases and the tiny, salted beads stop on my eyelids. They remind me of the gentle kisses left behind by the delicate, pale pink lips of my mother. Once, she was my safe haven. My protector.

Then she was gone.

As I prepare myself for the next one, I close my eyes and imagine I'm back in my mother's arms. My memory never works that way, and instead I'm thrust into a moment I will never forget. I was five years old, and my mother was crying.

Carlie

5 years old

When Mummy cries, pain flip flops inside my tummy. Sometimes it goes up to my throat, and sometimes, the pain comes out of my mouth. I don't like it because when that happens, Daddy gets very mad. He takes all my clothes off and puts me in the cold, cold water in the white bathtub.

Mummy doesn't like that. She stays outside the bathroom and bangs on the door shouting at daddy to stop touching me.

Daddy never stops.

Daddy says little girls must be clean, always.

Daddy says little girls must be quiet, always.

Daddy says he has to wash off all the dirt so I can be clean and beautiful.

I want to make him happy, so I always do what I am told. Even when his hands hurt me, I try to be brave all the time.

When Daddy has finished washing my whole body, and making sure I'm all clean between my legs, he lifts me out of the bathtub and puts a big fluffy towel around me. He gives me special kisses on my tummy and legs and everywhere, and he tells me he loves me the most. That's why he gives me lots of baths.

While Daddy is outside with my brother, Trystan, I eat my breakfast and watch Mummy wash the dishes. She walks to the fridge and gets the big bottle of milk, then tips it out in the sink.

"Mummy, why are you putting the milk in the sink?" I ask her.

Mummy turns around and tells me the milk is off, and it means she has to throw it all away, but when I tell her I have milk in my bowl, she says my milk is okay.

When Daddy and Trystan come back inside, Mummy says we have to go to the big store to buy more milk. She tells Daddy I have been a good girl and she wants me to go with her. I don't tell Daddy the milk was off because it might make him angry. I don't like it when he's angry.

Daddy pats my head then he leans down and kisses my cheek. When he asks me for a cuddle, I jump up on the chair and put my arms around his neck so I can cuddle him very tight. Daddy always gives me the best cuddles, but sometimes when he puts his hands on my bottom to hold me, it makes my tummy flippity-flop and the sick feeling comes back.

Daddy uses his little bit angry voice for Mummy. "You've got one hour."

"Mummy, can I come too?" Trystan asks.

"No, honey, you stay here. Shopping is for girls, remember."

“Can Cathie come with us?” I ask.

She shakes her head and tells me Daddy will take care of Cathie. I’m worried that Cathie might cry and make Daddy mad, but I’m not allowed to talk back, so I stay very quiet like a good girl.

Daddy puts me back down on the chair and goes outside with Trystan again while mummy gets her bag and my jacket.

I wish my little sister was here, but I like it in the car. The sunshine is big and white, and it makes me warm.

Mummy drives fast. She says the store is closed, and we have to go quickly to another store far, far away, then she puts the music on and I sing to my favourite counting songs.

It’s a long drive to the far away store and my eyes keep closing. When Mummy says she’s going to call Auntie Dianne, and that I can have a nap, I keep my eyes closed and try to go to sleep.

I can hear Mummy on her phone. She says times and days, and a boy’s name that’s Martin. And lots of things about Daddy being bad. Some of the things hurt my tummy, like when she says she will kill my daddy.

I don’t want my daddy to be killed.

I love him.

A grunt from my father drags me back to the cellar. “Daddy wouldn’t have to punish you if you were careful.”

I open my mouth to speak but decide against it when my eyes meet with his. Something inside him has changed. There’s a darkness behind his eyes that terrifies me.

Another strike of the whip follows my father’s voice. “Two.”

A deception coated smile plasters his calm facade. Fear rattles my bones. I blink. Once. Twice. Sweat stings my eyes, salty and scratchy. The pain doesn’t register until he drags his fingers across my back. “My sweet, sweet little girl. When will you learn?”

I swallow the lump in my throat. “I’m sorry.”

A muffled laugh. “Three.”

The crack of the whip sends a scalding shock wave of pain through my body. My knees—already grazed and bleeding—are forced into the concrete as though clawed hands are grasping at my flesh, tearing me to

pieces from the inside. I'm losing the battle between life and imminent death. Disappearing. My body is shuddering. My hands trembling—I don't dare move.

My mind spins out of control replacing the physical pain with more unwanted memories.

Carlie
5 years old.

I can see Daddy. He's very angry.

His face is red and wrinkly, and his eyes are squeezed together. He says lots of bad words and shouts at Mummy. Then he hits Mummy's face and tells her to go inside. When she's gone, he opens the car door and takes me out of my seat to carry me inside.

Daddy says I will stay with him forever, and that makes me happy.

In the bedroom, Mummy is still crying, and my tummy starts to feel sick. I do big, big swallows to make it stop. My brother comes into the bedroom and gives Daddy a long brown rope.

Daddy smiles. Daddy always smiles at my brother, even when he doesn't have baths. Daddy never smiles at my little sister.

He says she is too noisy because she cries a lot like Mummy does. Mummy told me Cathie cries because she's only a baby and she can't talk yet. I'm five years old, so I can talk, that's why I don't cry all the time.

Mummy is sitting on the chair. Daddy ties up her hands even when she says no, and tells him she won't take me away again. I don't know what they are doing, so I ask my brother, but he doesn't talk to me. He stands up straight and tall with his hands by his sides like a soldier I saw in one of my books.

"One," Daddy shouts. The smack of his long black belt hits Mummy's legs. She must have been very bad if Daddy is using his belt again.

I sit on the little circle mat Mummy bought me. It has a picture of a sunshine on it with a big smiley face. Daddy gives me a drink of juice then tells Mummy lots and lots of things. His voice makes my head all dizzy like it does when he gives me the special blue lollies. I close my eyes and pretend I am flying in the big blue sky.

My father's voice grows louder. "Four. Give up yet, Carlie baby?"

He must realise his punishments can no longer break me. There's nothing left inside to break. The physical pain will disappear. I remind myself this is nothing... yet. The last one is always the worst.

"No—" I can't get the words out. As the whip slices across my back, I bite the soft flesh inside my mouth until blood coats my tongue in a sickly, metallic film.

His footsteps pace across the floor before he lets out a heavy sigh. "Five." Clinking chains dragging across concrete. "This last one's gonna hurt."

With a deep inhale through my nose, I steady myself. Palms down and flat on my thighs. The white circle on the wall in front of me blurs into a seamless mass—a pulsating orb of light amidst the darkness I'm trapped in.

My mother once told me I had angels in my heart.

"Carlie, honey, you remember what I told you about your heart?"

"Yes, Mummy. You said I have angels in my heart, and they will keep me safe for all the days."

How foolish I was to believe it was true. The heart that beats inside my chest is empty, a blackened void where love once lived.

Drowsiness takes over. I am beyond tired, so tired my eyes burn, but I cannot close them.

There is no crack of the whip this time. No whoosh as it swipes across my skin. This time, there's a clinking rattle of a chain before it slams against my back, winding me and causing me to choke on the air that's forced violently out of my lungs.

Cold steel meets delicate, thin flesh.

A crack.

Broken bones?

My head is thrown forward. My forehead smashes against the white circle, now splattered with thick drops of deep, red blood. Sweat drips into my eyes. Thick, hot, stinging. No. That's not sweat, I realise, it's blood.

Long, thin lines of blood.

Carlie
5 years old.

“Wake up, Carlie,” Daddy says to me.

When I open my eyes, all I can see are messy red lines everywhere. On the floor there are long red lines with lots of splattery bits coming off them. On the wall there are more long, red lines. On Daddy’s pants there are so many messy red lines that they are all stuck together like a big blobby red mess. I blink my eyes and when I look again, there’s a big puddle of red on the floor.

When my little sister, Cathie, starts crying, Daddy tells me to go and make her be quiet.

I stand up and look at the red puddle to see if I can go around it.

“Go!” Daddy shouts so loud that I feel a little bit of wet in my pants. That always makes him angry, so I keep it a big secret.

I run to Cathie’s cot, but I slip in the red puddle and it gets on my hands and on my face. It smells yucky and makes the sick feeling come back to my tummy and my throat, then it all comes out of my mouth, but Daddy doesn’t take me to the bathroom.

He shouts again and points to the cot. “Shut that baby up, now!”

My feet slip and slide in the red puddle, and I can’t stand up. Instead, I crawl to the cot as fast as I can.

I pat Cathie on her tummy and tell her to be very quiet so Daddy doesn’t use his belt on her. Cathie has red on her too now, and my hands are all red and sticky. Now I will need another bath. I count on my fingers how many baths I had today.

One, two, three...

I hope Mummy can clean up all the red mess before Daddy gets angry again.

“Wake up, Carlie.”

“Daddy?”

“Clean yourself up.” His voice is dead, there’s no emotion, no concern. Doesn’t he love me anymore?

Footsteps.

Chains.

A door slams. He's gone.

Shock takes over and only numbness remains. The pain I felt moments ago has dispersed. My body, drained and exhausted, falls to the concrete. When my head hits the ground, my eyes finally close, and the realisation hits me.

I am nothing.

I am no one.

I am no more.

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And like the rain falls
From the heavenly sky
The world crumbles down
And once again, I cry

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CARLIE**April 25***6.00am*

The lukewarm water barely covers the bottom of the bathtub. I extend my legs and swish the water over my knees and thighs then smooth the bar of soap over my arms and shoulders. I'm thankful my father has forbidden me from using the shower because I don't think I'd be able to stand without falling.

Each movement sends pain shooting down my spine. When I breathe, pain travels into my chest, bearing down and reminding me I'm still alive, for now. My father apologised—for the first time ever—for punishing me so harshly. He made me pancakes with strawberries and ice cream for breakfast and let me sit under the big tree in the backyard to read. For a whole day I wasn't used once.

For a few hours, I wondered if he was still mad and didn't want me anymore, but it didn't take long for the worry to turn into relief. Father said I need to behave the way I used to when I was a little girl, and if I do, he will stop allowing Cathie to be used.

There was no hesitation in my answer. There wasn't a moment I was concerned about what I would have to endure or give up to keep my sister safe.

Whatever my father wants, I will give it to him, willingly. I will be the little girl he needs and desires—just like I used to be.

*Carlie**11 years old.*

In my bedroom, Cathie is sitting on my bed reading a book. I'm so happy to see her that I run over and give her a big cuddle. I wonder if Cathie is the

surprise my father was telling me about. I ask her if she's okay, and she says she's a little sleepy because my father gave her the special blue lollies I now know are sleeping pills.

I wish she wasn't sleeping all the time. I miss my sister.

When I have my pretty pink nighty on, I smooth my hands down the front of it. It's shorter now because I have grown three full centimetres since I was eight years old, but I don't mind because it's nice and warm inside my house.

When my door opens, my father comes in with a big brown box. Cathie jumps off my bed and stands up straight with her hands behind her back. She's scared of our father, and she even says she doesn't love him, but she doesn't say that out loud much anymore, because last time she was punished and left in the cellar for three days.

I was sad then, but father gave me lots of new clothes and books, and even let me watch a movie on the television about a princess who fell in love with a handsome prince. After that, I was happy again. One day, I want to find a handsome prince.

When my father puts the box down, he tells me to open it. Inside are lots and lots of books.

"They're some of Trystan's old school books. And some extra books I bought for you. Principal Chamberson gave me some work books for you as well. You can learn something from them, and teach your sister, too."

I smile so big that my cheeks hurt, then I jump up and wrap my arms around his neck. He kneels on the floor and rubs his hands over my bottom while he kisses me and tells me he loves me the most.

"Cathie, you're staying in here tonight," my father says.

I can't believe my luck. This is the best night ever. "Thank you, Daddy."

He pulls me closer to him and strokes my hair while his other hand slides between my legs and moves against my skin. "You're Daddy's favourite, Carlie. Tonight, you can sleep in my bed."

The sick feeling flips my stomach upside down, and my whole body gets all wobbly and shivery. But I don't let Daddy see my face. I keep it pressed into his shoulder so I don't cry or make him angry. I really wish he would go because the vomit is coming up to my throat, and I don't want to be punished. Now my best night ever is not going to happen.

The bathroom door creaks open, pulling me from my thoughts and sending a chill through the air that covers my body in tiny goose bumps.

Cathie tip toes in. When she reaches the bathtub, she peers down at me. “Are you still hurting?” Her curly blonde hair hangs limp, and the purple bruise on her cheek tells me she’s been punished again. I wish she wasn’t so stubborn.

I shake the water off my hand and reach out to tuck her hair behind her ear. “You shouldn’t be in here. If he catches you, you’ll be punished.”

She shoves a hand into the pocket of her pink track pants and pulls out a small chocolate bar.

I gasp. “Cathie, where did you get that?”

She shrugs and drops her gaze. “Kitchen,” she mumbles. “Shadow was hungry.”

With a heavy sigh, I curse the voice in her head, but a wave of guilt washes over me. Perhaps she made up this imaginary shadow friend so she doesn’t feel so scared and alone.

“Do not move,” I warn.

She nods and clenches her fist around the shiny blue wrapper as though it’s her lifeline. Her eyes don’t leave me as I rinse my hair off, then pull the plug. When I turn my back to take the towel from the rack, she gasps. I wrap it over my shoulders and step out of the tub, looking down at my little sister.

At twelve years old she has endured too much. Her face is gaunt and the dark circles under her eyes hide the beauty and innocence she once possessed. She’s underweight, malnourished, and constantly sick. I always imagined, if I did everything I was told, there would be no reason for Cathie to be used. It never worked that way. I only hope my father will keep his word and let me be used instead from now on.

She follows me to my bed where she sits with her legs crossed. I pry the chocolate bar from her hand and tear it open, then, I fold the wrapper in a wad of toilet paper and flush it down the toilet.

“You can have some too. It might make you feel better,” she says.

I take a tiny bite off the end and hand it back to her. “Yum. Now quick, eat the rest, then you have to leave.”

Her lip quivers. “I want to stay with you. Please, Carlie.”

Tears spring to my eyes and I wipe them away with the back of my hand. I pull the towel around my breasts and hold it tight as I take Cathie's hand and lead her to the door. She doesn't resist. She knows as well as I do, she shouldn't be here.

When I open the door, I pull Cathie to my side and step back, terrified.

His dark hair is scruffy and sticks up in odd places all over his head. He draws his thick, bushy brows together then clenches his jaw and exhales through his nose.

A warmth spreads beneath my foot—Cathie whimpers. I glance down to see her pink pants are soaked through. She tightens her hand around my arm and her tiny fingernails dig into my skin.

He glares at Cathie. "What the fuck are you doing in here you little brat?" His anger boils over, his face turns scarlet, and before I can blink, he pushes me back to the bed and sends Cathie flying backwards where she lands on her bottom, crying.

He rips the towel from my grasp while pointing a warning finger at me. "Don't fucking move!"

Cathie screams, "No, no, let her go. Please, don't hurt her."

He storms over to the bedroom door and sticks his head out. "Trystan," he bellows.

Cathie scrambles to her knees and crawls across the carpet to the other side of my bedroom to squeeze herself between the chest of timber drawers and the pale pink wall. She pulls her knees to her chest and drops her head, rocking back and forth. "No, no, no. Don't let him take me," she repeats over and over.

When he approaches me again, I scramble back on my bed. "I'll do whatever you want, don't hurt her, please." I should know better but the need to protect my sister outweighs my fear of punishment.

By the time Trystan appears in my bedroom, Cathie is banging her head against the wall, screaming, "Not Trystan. Not Trystan."

He laughs as he grips her arm and lifts her to her feet. "Let's go little whore, we're gonna have some fun." A sinister smile dances across his lips, but the rest of his face is always the same. A blank stare and deep, dark eyes. Cathie struggles to free herself from his grasp, kicking and fighting

while screaming to be let go, but he easily overpowers her and drags her out the door, slamming it closed behind him.

I drop my feet off the bed, then kneel on the floor. My father reaches down, grabs a fistful of my hair, and pulls me to my feet. My face is mere inches from his and my toes are barely touching the floor. His breath reeks of tobacco and beer, and with each strangled breath, I force back the bile rising from the pit of my stomach.

He lifts me higher until the floor falls away from my feet and my hair is pulling on my scalp. When he lets my feet touch the floor, my knees shake, but I quickly find my balance.

He cups my cheek, a gentle touch I've come to learn means pain is on its way. "You never learn, do you?" His lip curls into a smile, a smile that will never reach the darkness of his soulless eyes.

"I'm sorry. It won't happen again."

He laughs in my face, then slams my body down onto the bed. Even with the mattress cushioning the blow, my back aches, my bones ache, and my head spins when it hits the corner of the steel bed frame.

With one hand clamped down around my throat and the other pinning my arms above my head, he presses his lips to my cheek, then lowers his voice, "Daddy's got a surprise for you, Carlie."

I beg him, "Please, let me make it better."

He loosens his grip on my throat and slides his other hand down to my thigh where he stops and squeezes it before sliding his hand between my legs. "Oh, you'll be making it up to me, my precious little girl."

Tears well in my eyes and I blink them back before he releases his grip around my neck and tells me to get up. "You're clean?"

I nod.

"In the cellar. Naked," he commands. "We have a buyer. This time you're going to be perfect for me, aren't you?"

Another nod.

He breathes against my ear. "Tonight, you'll sleep with me. You're going to make Daddy very happy."

There's no hesitation. "Yes, Daddy."

* * *

I've been standing in the cellar naked and shivering for exactly sixty-four minutes.

A cold breeze blows through the small, broken window and I catch a fleeting glimpse of sunlight through the shattered glass.

The pain is unrelenting. It's no longer physical pain. It's an emotional ache that never ceases to drag me into the abysmal pits of despair. My mind is lost, longing for the hope I abandoned long ago. I sway like a crumbling autumn leaf on the wind.

For a little while, my life was predictable. There was no punishment, and there was none of the fear that's now buried deep in my veins, rotting beneath my skin. I try with all my might to cling to something—anything, but the allure of death surrounds me. When I close my eyes, I breathe out the words I wish someone would hear. “Let me die.”

Footsteps echo in the stairwell, then voices.

I inhale and hold my breath until the door opens.

My father walks in wearing a black suit, black shirt, and red tie. The outfit he wears to impress his clients. His pine scented cologne masks the stench of beer and cigarettes.

The man with him wears a suit as well, and on his thick tattooed fingers are shiny gold rings.

I exhale as slow and as quiet as possible while I keep my eyes forward and my hands by my sides. My hair is still wet, though it's no longer dripping. My body is covered in goose bumps, and my teeth are chattering. I curl my toes to relieve the pins and needles, but the numbness remains, and as usual, I suffer through it without complaint.

The man points to me. “She's a mess,” he grumbles. “You said you had clean girls.”

He turns to leave but my father puts a hand on his shoulder.

“Wait, I'll give you a discount. Name your price,” my father says before ordering me to stand and turn on the spot.

When I face them again, I clasp my hands behind my back as the male ogles me. He circles me, leaning closer and tilting his head as he rubs his chin. “How old are you?”

I raise my head. “Seventeen.”

His brow creases. “How many lovers have you had?”

From the corner of my eye, I catch my father's gaze. *Lovers*. That's what he calls them.

I'm old enough now to know they're nothing more than dirty men purchasing girls—children—to use and abuse until they get bored or run out of money.

I swallow the lump in my throat as a shiver runs down my spine. "Thirty-seven."

The man has no reaction... at all. Usually they smile, or at least turn to my father and nod as though he's some kind of hero standing on a podium, chanting his victory speech.

Fifty-seven times I have stood in this very spot. My heart beating against my chest so hard I'm certain my ribs will crack under the pressure, and it will explode, sending a hundred shades of red splattering across the walls of the cellar.

Twenty men have turned me down. The first was when I was thirteen years old. That day, two men arrived within an hour of one another. The second man purchased me.

Carlie
13 years old

The man walks around me for exactly sixty-eight seconds before he stops and turns to my father. He shakes his head. "She's too thick. Can I have the smaller one?"

My father scratches his chin where his beard has grown and replies, "She's perfect. The young one isn't experienced enough yet. I'll give you a discount. Forty this time."

The man turns back to me. I suck in my tummy to make it flat and smooth.

He tilts his head, then sighs. "I like them smaller."

Behind him, my father's eyes are narrowed in anger. He hates being turned down. He hates it when the men don't accept his offers. He hates it, and I will be punished for it. Being "too thick" is the worst thing possible. It means my food intake will be limited again to ensure I don't gain weight.

While my hands are behind my back, I put my fingers around my wrist to make sure I can still touch my finger and thumb together, then, I do

the same on the other wrist. I'm still the same. I drop my head to make sure my tummy isn't sticking out. It's still the same too.

My father comes over to me and puts his finger under my chin. "Eyes forward," he reminds me.

I nod once.

"Thirty-five," the man offers.

My father shakes his head. "Not for twenty-four hours. My girls are worth sixty. You're getting a good deal."

The man comes closer and reaches out to me. I don't dare move a muscle.

Not when his hand brushes over my breast. Not when his fingers trace down my waist and stop between my legs. And not when he leans in close to my ear. "Can you fuck, little girl?"

I swallow the lump in my throat and beg the vomit to stay down. I don't reply.

Shivers crawl across my body and tingle down my spine. When the tiny goose bumps appear on my skin, I hope the man doesn't notice. I curl my toes and swallow the huge lump in my throat.

The last man that came, said he didn't want me. My father was furious and said I had to try harder to look like a little girl.

"She will do anything you ask of her," my father assures him.

The man scratches his chin. "Fine." There's a long silence as he opens his briefcase. "I'll give you forty thousand for twenty-four hours."

"Deal," my father says.

When the man clears his throat and extends his hand toward me, I blink myself back into reality. Too many thoughts are rushing through my mind. Thoughts of being crushed beneath this man's body while I cry. Thoughts of blood and pain and steaming showers with strange men in the middle of the night.

My father stops him touching me. "No," he warns. "Not until you've paid."

He nods. "Very well. Fifty, for twenty-four hours."

A low growl comes from my father's throat. His eyes darken, and his lips are pulled into a tight, straight line. "Eighty. She's experienced. She'll

do anything you ask of her.” Pacing toward me, my father continues, “I trained her myself. There’s nothing she won’t do.”

“She’s injured. There are bruises and scars all over her body. Fifty, or nothing.” This man is unbending, and I wonder why my father hasn’t kicked him out yet. He’s not usually this desperate to sell me.

I stand still, watching their faces change as they argue back and forth.

My father insists I’m worth more than fifty thousand dollars. The other man, adamant I’m malnourished and in need of medical attention.

After ten minutes, my father and the man come to an agreement.

I glance at the clock on the wall.

8.01am

I’m purchased by an unnamed man for sixty thousand dollars.

My whispers, they're all hopeless
My heart, it begs for death
Strangers beds at midnight
I keep their demons fed

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CARLIE

April 28

8.00am

When the buyer returns three days later, I'm dressed in a short pale blue skirt and a white t-shirt. I tug the strap of my backpack over my shoulder, then hug my father. He kisses my cheek, lingering for a minute.

"Remember, Carlie, make Daddy proud and you'll always be my favourite."

I only nod before I'm led from my house, and into the back seat of a waiting van. My father reminds me of the rules I must follow, and the consequences of breaking those rules. When he pushes the van door closed, I watch him walk back into the house.

As the man starts the engine he asks, "The other young girl your father has available, she's your sister?"

"Yes," I say, hoping he doesn't change his mind and go back for Cathie as well.

Through the rear-view mirror, his dark brown eyes stare back at me. He doesn't smile, but he doesn't seem annoyed or angry either. Thoughts of freedom race through my mind. What if this man is kind? What if he sets me free? *I should know better*. Wishful thinking has never helped before, and I can't leave without Cathie. She will die without me.

After driving in silence for thirty minutes, the man asks, "What's your name?"

I hesitate. I loathe my name. I hate the way it sounds coming from the lips of my father, and the men who have claimed my body and tainted my soul. I hate the way it reminds me of who I am. Of *what* I am.

"You still awake back there?"

I bite my lip, then murmur, "Carlie. My name is Carlie." When tears puddle in my eyes, I wipe them away with the back of my hand.

"You can call me Eli."

We continue in silence again. Eli doesn't ask me any more questions, and I don't say a word. An hour later, the van hits a gravel road and bumps along until we reach the end of a tree-lined driveway. Through the front windscreen, a small log cabin appears nestled among tall, thin trees with leafy green branches.

Eli parks the van and gets out. When he walks toward the cabin, I check my surroundings.

My first instinct is always to run, or to find somewhere to hide. But instinct is never enough to drag me away. I don't know where I am. This place isn't familiar at all. Usually, I'm taken into the city and kept inside a dingy hotel room, or worse, the basement of someone's house. A few times I've been taken to huge lavish mansions I've only ever seen in magazines and books. The biggest by far was the house I stayed in when I was fifteen and purchased by a man named Rick.

Carlie

15 years old

The house is bigger than any house I've ever seen. It's shiny and clean, and all the floors are pure white and covered in fluffy rugs. There's a giant staircase that leads up to another floor where a huge window looks outside.

The man takes my hand. "You'll call me Rick."

I nod as Rick leads me upstairs and into a large bedroom with a fancy bed that has red drapes hanging over it.

"Take your clothes off and stand by the bed."

I nod and do as he says.

I don't care about being naked anymore. I don't care about their eyes wandering over my body, or their smile that reminds me of everything that is wrong in this world. I don't care about them at all.

I wish it was all they wanted.

When I'm standing by the bed as instructed, Rick comes over to me and the first thing he does is put his hands on my breasts.

Last year, my father gave me a stack of magazines. He said I could read as many as I wanted, and that I should be able to learn something from

them. I learned I was broken. Or defective. There's something wrong with me inside.

I always thought I was supposed to feel sick when men touched me. But according to the magazines, I am supposed to enjoy it, and even ask for more. It still doesn't make sense. Nothing I do with these men is enjoyable. Nothing feels good, or even a little nice. It's all disgusting, and it all makes me want to vomit.

Rick pinches my nipples hard between his fingers. I let out a wince of pain. He smiles and then slides his fingers down my waist until they stop between my legs. "Mmm... so, you're only fifteen?"

I nod. "I turned fifteen ten days ago."

He pushes a finger inside me and inhales into my neck with a loud sniff. "How many men have you fucked?"

I swallow the lump in my throat. I know exactly how many men I've had sex with. But after fifty, I stopped counting how many times they'd used me. According to my magazines, most women will have six sexual partners in their lifetime. Women... adults.

Rick slides his finger out and pushes it into my mouth. I resist the urge to gag.

"How many?" he asks again.

"Twenty-nine."

He lets out a throaty laugh. "Well, well. You are Daddy's Little Whore, aren't you?" He orders me to get on the bed before he unzips his jeans and pushes them down. Then he removes his shirt and underwear.

He grabs his dick in his hand and starts pulling on it. I've always wondered why so many men do that. My brother does it constantly. He says it feels good to do it while he watches me in the bath.

Sometimes he tells me to do it for him, he says my hands are smaller and softer and that I should do it for him, because I love him. Like I love my father and my little sister.

I hate it, but he always gives me something in return, even if it's only food and drinks, or promising not to use Cathie.

I've never wanted to touch my own body. The mere thought of it makes me sick to my stomach.

Rick's voice pulls me away from my thoughts and brings me back to reality. He spreads my legs apart and begins to move on me making strange

and horrible grunting sounds before I feel the pain and burn of him pushing his dick inside me.

I close my eyes like I do every other time, and imagine I'm somewhere far, far away. Somewhere where no one can touch me, or look at me, or talk to me.

Somewhere I don't exist at all.

When Rick tells me to roll over and get on my hands and knees, I don't hesitate.

Again, I pretend I'm somewhere else while he uses my body and tears fall from my eyes. The pain doesn't subside. It lasts for a long time after Rick's finished. Even when I'm in the shower washing the blood away and cleaning myself up, the pain lingers like a knife is being twisted inside me.

When I get out of the shower, Rick tells me I need to stay naked while I get him a beer and a bag of chips from the kitchen.

Back upstairs, he's sitting in the middle of his bed watching a pornographic movie. He pats the bed between his outstretched legs. "Come suck my cock little girl."

Of course, I obey.

It's not the first time I've wanted to die.

And it won't be the last.

I wrap my arms around myself and cross my ankles, waiting. The clock on the dash of the van reads 10.36am. By now, Cathie will be up, and in twenty-four minutes she will know I'm gone. If she has a tantrum, my father will give her drugs to make her sleep. While she sleeps, she will be safe.

Eli comes out of the house and heads toward the van. He opens the side door and extends his hand. For a moment I sit, afraid and anxious.

"Come on, out you get." There's not a hint of anger or authority in his tone.

Keeping my hands clasped together, I shuffle across the wide leather seat and step out of the van. My eyes squint at the sunshine, and I raise my head to feel its warmth. When I breathe in the fresh, clean air, happiness smothers me for one brief, fleeting moment and reminds me, I am still alive.

The happiness doesn't last long when I remember what I am here for.

Eli takes my hand. Instinctively, I pull away and cross my arms. Then, I drop my head knowing he has permission to do anything at all, including punish me.

His finger touches my chin and my stomach coils in knots. I hate being touched. There's an indescribable pain that comes with it, something I will never get used to. A searing heat that spreads into my veins and sets my heart racing. I hold my breath as he lifts my head and stares into my eyes.

"Hungry?" he asks. He's so strange, why does he care if I'm hungry?

I want to ignore him, but the last time I ate a real meal was over twenty-four hours ago, and I'm starving. Before every viewing and pick up, my father limits my food intake to ensure my stomach is smooth and flat. I open my mouth to speak but the words don't come, so I nod and follow Eli into the log cabin.

Inside, a fire is glowing in the open fireplace. Golden orange flames and wisps of smoke travel up into the chimney. On the wall above the mantle, there's a painting of a man sitting on a fallen log. His head rests in his hand, and in front of him, a campfire has little wisps of grey smoke rising from a dark log. *Down on His Luck*. I remember seeing the painting in one of my books at home. The dreary colours, so similar to those outside the cabin Eli has brought me to. Hues of green, brown, and ochre all masterfully brushed onto canvas by an artist named Fredrick McCubbin. I wonder if the artist felt as sombre as the man in the painting looks. As sombre as I feel.

With a heavy sigh, I take a step closer and lean down to watch the flickering flames, but when my face warms, I step back and rub my cheeks.

"You've never seen a fire before?" Eli asks.

"Once," I murmur, remembering the warmth of the fire my father started inside a steel drum in our backyard. I sat, wrapped in my fleece blanket while he stuffed the drum with bundled up towels and old clothes. With each load he threw in, the flames were doused, only to reappear again with plumes of thick, grey smoke. The scent lingering in the air made my eyes water and my throat dry. I imagined it was the scent of death.

To this day I swear it still burns my nostrils when I think about it.

Carlie
5 years old.

It's night time and Daddy says we are having a special fire outside. He tells me to get my blankie and my jacket. I'm so happy that I run inside and jump on my bed before I put my jacket on all by myself, then I pull my blankie up in a big ball.

Before I go back outside, I run to Mummy's bedroom to tell her about the special fire, but she's not there. Maybe she went to the store again.

Outside, Daddy tells me I can sit on his lap. He shows me how to put a pink marshmallow on the end of a long stick. Then he shows me how to hold it near the fire that's all orange and red and smoky. The fire smells yucky and Daddy tells me the smell will go away soon. Some of the things in the fire look like Mummy's clothes and some look like the big towels from the bathroom.

When Daddy pulls my blankie around my shoulders and puts his hands on my legs, I watch the fire swallow up all the clothes and towels like it's sucking them into a dark black hole. Tiny pieces of black float into the air and fly away into the sky.

"Where is Mummy?" I ask.

"She's gone away for a while. Daddy will keep you safe, baby."
Daddy rubs his hands on my legs and kisses my head, then he tells me I can eat the pink marshmallow off the stick.

It's so sticky and yummy and gooey, and it makes me laugh. When I laugh, Daddy tickles my legs and my tummy under my dress, and tells me I'm a good girl.

And even though my tummy is a little bit sick, I still love my daddy.

Eli points to a timber chair at the small kitchen table that's covered in a pretty striped tablecloth. I take a seat with my arms still wrapped around myself while my eyes scan the room.

Everything is so clean and tidy. The sofas I can see from the kitchen, have fluffy white blankets draped over them; and on the seats, big blue and green cushions are scattered. This house... or cabin, is nothing like any of the other places I've been to. There are no bottles of beer on the table or the floor. There are no syringes, and no tiny bags of pills. It's almost as though this is a special, secret place tucked away from the awful realities of the real world.

My gaze follows Eli as he paces across the timber floor and opens the pantry to take out a tray of six cupcakes. Each one is topped with a swirl of thick, white frosting. I think about my sister and how much she would love to see them, how her eyes would light up, and her hands would tremble with excitement.

“You don’t talk much, do you,” Eli says.

I shake my head. “I’m not supposed to talk. I’m here to listen, and to do what I’m told.”

He sits on the chair opposite me and pushes the tray of cupcakes closer after taking one for himself. He bites into it and a layer of frosting sticks to his upper lip. Eli certainly isn’t like the other men I’ve met. His dark brown eyes, masculine features, and the stubble on his jaw remind me of a man I saw in one of the newspapers that was delivered to our house. He was an actor in a movie called *Wolverine* and he had long sharp claws coming out of his hands. I asked my father if I would be allowed to watch the movie, but he got mad and threw the newspaper in the bin.

“Go on, help yourself. And while you’re here, you can talk as much as you like.” Eli leans back in the chair, watching me.

I swallow hard and tentatively reach out for a cupcake. First, I hold it close to my nose and inhale the sweet, creamy vanilla scent. I take a tiny bite, but my throat tightens and I begin to choke. I’m coughing, spluttering, and grasping at my neck.

When Eli stands and comes over to me, I panic and stiffen. He doesn’t step back, instead, he pats my back, rubbing it in long, slow, soothing circles. “It’s okay, just breathe.” He pulls a chair over and sits in front of me while I catch my breath.

I exhale slowly and lift my head to see him staring at me again. If I didn’t know better, I’d think he looked almost... sad. But I was never good at reading people’s faces—except my father’s. I always know what he’s thinking.

Eli walks to the kitchen sink then comes back with a glass of water which I drink down quickly. He hands me the cupcake again.

I shake my head. “I’m not hungry.”

“How long since you’ve eaten?”

I swallow back the lump in my throat. “Twenty-four-and-a-half hours.”

He sighs. “That’s okay. First, we’re going to talk. Then we’ll get some food into that belly of yours.”

Anxiety tears at my chest. I’m mindful of the rules and careful not to break them. As I’ve grown older, the punishments have become worse. Hands have been replaced with belts, whips, and now chains. “I’m not allowed to talk,” I remind him.

He shrugs as though it’s not a big deal. “I won’t mention it, and you don’t need to either.”

I want to trust him, but I learned when I was young that men lie. Especially the men who came to our house and said they wouldn’t hurt me.

“You don’t trust me yet. And that’s okay, I understand.”

I swallow hard. I want to trust someone. And so far, Eli is completely different to all the other men. He hasn’t even asked me to get undressed yet, or stared at me as though my body is something he wants. “I don’t know how to... trust someone,” I admit. Maybe I can try to trust, just this once.

Eli continues, “That’s understandable.” He scrubs his hands down his face then crosses his arms. “Okay, I’ll ask you some questions, and you can nod or shake your head.”

I nod. Anything to stall for time and avoid the bedroom, or anywhere else I may be required to have sex.

“You don’t see the sunshine much, do you?”

I shake my head.

“Have you ever been to school?”

Another shake.

“Your mother is gone?”

Tears well in my eyes and dribble down my cheeks to my jaw as I nod.

Eli scratches at the dark stubble on his chin. “And your father sells you...” He hesitates. “For sex.”

I nod.

“When did it start?” he asks.

I drop my gaze and twist my fingers together in my lap.

“Sixteen?” he asks.

Shake.

“Younger?”

I nod.

He hisses under his breath. “Fuck...”

“Fifteen?”

Shake.

“Twelve?”

I bite my lip, wondering if this is a trap. If he’s going to go back and tell my father everything. If I lie, I will be punished. If I tell the truth, I will be punished.

Eli lowers his voice to a whisper. “Younger?”

I nod slightly.

Fear takes over and I blurt out the words before I can stop myself. “Please don’t tell. Please, I’ll do anything you want. Don’t tell him.” I drop my head into my hands and sob, terrified I’ll be taken back to my house and punished. Even though my father apologised and told me he’d never use the chain again, the fear lingers. Anything is possible.

Eli’s footsteps pound across the shiny wooden floor of the small cabin. When the front door slams, I jump a mile. Through my crying, I hear him talking. From the window I can see he’s on his mobile phone.

He’s calling my father. *I need to run.*

I stand, ready to run wherever my legs will take me, but I’m frozen. Stuck in place and unable to move a muscle. I glance down at the cupcake still on the table. My tummy rumbles. Without a second thought I grab it and shove the soft, sweet cake into my mouth, chewing as fast as I can.

Eli walks in and slips his phone into his pocket. I stop chewing. My cheeks are full of delicious vanilla cupcake and I don’t know whether to swallow it all in one go, or spit it out and beg Eli not to punish me.

“So, you were hungry.”

I cover my mouth with both hands and swallow the cupcake.

“Let’s take a walk,” Eli says.

I follow him out the front door and around the side of the cabin past the black van. He continues to walk along a trail worn into the dirt and grass. It’s rocky, but easy to walk on. The fresh air fills my nose and I take long deep breaths, allowing my lungs to take it all in.

Eli slows until I catch up with him and we continue walking side by side. “How old is your sister?”

“Cathie’s twelve.”

“And she does the same as you?”

“Not often. She’s used at home... in the playroom, or with—or with me.”

When Eli glances at me, I drop my head. “Have you seen a forest before, Carlie?”

The sound of my name on his lips is like a slap to my face. I want to scream and tell him never to say it again, but I hold back the pain. “Not in real life. I only get taken to houses, or hotels. After that I’m taken straight home and I go back to my room, or the cellar if I need more training. Unless Father wants to train me in his bedroom.” Before I know it, I’ve spilled out so many words, and they keep coming. Eli doesn’t interrupt, so I continue, “Sometimes, I’m allowed to sit in the backyard and read. And sometimes, Father lets me talk to Cathie, or watch movies with her.” I sigh, thinking about my sister. “You won’t tell him I told you, will you?”

“No. I won’t be telling him anything.” He extends his hand. “There’s a waterfall ahead, I think you’ll like it.”

I force the words out of my mouth. “Why haven’t you had—”

“Sex?” Eli asks.

I nod.

“I’m not having sex with you. You’re a child.”

I stop in my tracks; my father will be furious. “But... bu—but you paid. He will—he’ll punish me.” I drop to my knees and cry into my hands. “He’ll hurt Cathie.”

Eli kneels in front of me and puts a hand on my shoulder. When I flinch, he pulls away. “I’ll handle it.” He stands. “I’m not going to hurt you. You won’t have to do anything you don’t want to do.”

I rub my head. “I don’t understand.”

“I’ll explain it all later, okay?”

A sense of relief washes over me, though it’s fraught with fear. Eli paid for me. He paid for sex and now he doesn’t want it.

What if I’m not good enough? What if he says I refused?

What if he sells me to someone else? The last time that happened, my father was so angry he beat the man to death then stuffed his body inside a suitcase filled with rocks, and pushed it off the bridge on our way home.

It wasn't the first time I'd seen my father kill a man, and I was sure it wouldn't be the last. He will do anything to keep me with him.

I let out a quiet sigh. There's nothing I can do, so I follow Eli along the winding path in silence.

Cool air blows through the trees and the sound of running water causes me to gasp. I freeze where I'm standing, once again unable to move. Fear has taken over and I'm reminded of the storms that bore down on our house during the winter months, and the cold baths my father gave me when I was young.

Eli stops a few steps ahead. "Come on. It's beautiful."

I shake my head.

He comes closer. I beg my feet to carry me somewhere... anywhere. When Eli is right in front of me, he tilts his head and silence lingers between us for the longest time.

"You're afraid?"

I nod and my body stiffens.

"Of water?"

I nod again.

"Why?"

I bite my tongue until I taste blood in my mouth. I've already said too much, I can't tell him everything. I press my hands to my ears hoping it will block the sound of the water roaring ahead. It doesn't help, and when I clamp my eyes shut, all I can think about is drowning beneath crystal-clear waves.

At ten years old, I was afraid of water. It was as though fear had ingrained itself into the marrow of my bones. In winter, I was terrified to venture outside where my brother, Trystan, played with a red plastic dump truck, scooping up loads of filthy, slimy mud and tipping it into bright blue buckets. His oversized raincoat withstood the worst of the rain, and his little yellow hat protected his face. I was amazed at the way the water fell from the wide brim of his hat and down into the bucket, but overwhelming fear kept me locked inside.

When the worst of the storms passed through, I hid in the corner of my bedroom—squeezed between my bed and the wall—as it poured relentlessly, battering down onto the tin roof of our house. A thunderous onslaught of heavy grey clouds hovered in the sky, surrounded by thin

branches of lightning, and a wall of water so wide I imagined I was trapped in the depths of the raging sea.

Carlie
7 years old.

I have been so good for such a long time that Daddy is letting me go outside. Right out the front of our house where all the kids in our neighbourhood play. Some little girls are wearing dresses with tiny flowers scattered all over them. One girl has pretty, white sandals, and in her hair are big white ribbons tied up in bows. The boys and girls are playing together. Smiling, laughing... living.

I don't think I'm living. A strange feeling curls up inside my tummy. I want to be there with them. I want to play catch with big colourful balls. I want to skip along the sidewalk singing nursery rhymes. But I don't know how. I can't sing, and I don't know all the words.

I stand on the grass close to our green letter box. I'm right beside the fence where I have the best view of the whole street. Daddy said I wasn't allowed to cross the line on the sidewalk. The tippy toes of my shoes are exactly in the right spot. I keep very still so my feet don't slip and push me over the line. I don't want to be punished today, I want to watch the children playing.

None of them see me. No one comes over to say hello or ask me why I'm watching them. Maybe I'm actually invisible, and only grown up men can see me.

When my legs are too tired to stand, I sit and pull my knees to my chest. Then, I twist the ends of my sleeves around so my hands are trapped inside them. I wrap my arms around my knees and watch two little girls throwing stones into squares they've drawn on the ground. After they take turns throwing the stones, they jump and hop into the squares, then start all over again.

A little boy runs over to where I'm sitting. He looks down at me while I gaze up at him. His brown hair is messy, and he's wearing blue pants and a red t-shirt that has a robot on it with a smiling face. In his hand he's holding a red ball.

"Do you wanna play catch?"

I swallow down my words and shake my head. He can see me. I'm not invisible.

"Why? Aren't you allowed to?"

I shake my head again, but I wish my words would come out and tell the truth. I really want to play catch.

"My name's Jayden. What's your name?" he asks as he swaps the ball from one hand to the other.

"Carlie." As soon as I say my name, I push my hands over my mouth. That was a big, big mistake.

"Carlie is a good name." Jayden points to the house across the street where a man is mowing the grass. "That's my house over there. You can come and play if you want."

"I'm not allowed."

"Oh. Are you grounded?"

I'm confused. "What does grounded mean?"

"It means you're not allowed to play because you've been naughty. Did you be naughty?"

He doesn't give me time to reply. "I was naughty one time. I ate all the cookies in the jar and my mum was so angry that she said I couldn't play with Mason." He drops the ball, and it bounces before it lands on the grass beside me.

My hands are sweaty, and I want to pick it up to see what it feels like. To see if it's hard or soft, or if it's heavy or light.

"Throw it to me," Jayden says, pointing to the ball beside me.

"I can't."

"What happened to your neck?" He points to the red line on my neck that hasn't gone away yet. I know the rules. I'm never allowed to talk about the marks or the cuts. Not ever.

When I don't answer, he gets to his knees and reaches out for his ball. "Are you sad? My mum says when I'm sad I have to tell someone."

I blink once, then twice. Jayden talks so much, and I want him to stop asking me questions. I want him to keep telling me all the things I don't know.

When Jayden looks behind me, then stands again, he scratches his head. "Hi Trystan," he says.

My heart starts going faster, and I squeeze my eyes shut. Trystan kicks my bottom. "Get up, Dad said you have to come inside now." He takes a step forward. "Go away from my house, Jayden," Trystan says. "And don't look at my sister, she's only mine and my Dad's."

I stand up slowly keeping my eyes on Jayden who's watching me. "Bye, Carlie," he says.

I don't say another word, but when I follow Trystan into the house, I take one last look back before I walk in the door to see Jayden wave to me.

When it's night time, Daddy fills up the bath tub with water and tells me to take my clothes off. I get in, but when the water swishes around me, it's too, too cold and I start to cry. I ask Daddy to make it warm, but he doesn't answer me. He puts one hand on my head, the other holds my arm while he pushes my head down. It's freezing cold and I can't breathe under the water.

Daddy pushes me under again and when I try to tell him to stop, he pushes harder and this time, water goes up my nose and into my mouth.

I don't want to cry. I want to be brave, but I'm scared, and Daddy isn't talking to me. He pushes me down again and again, five more times until I can't stop screaming.

When he lifts me out of the tub, he wraps me in a thick, warm towel, and holds me tight against his chest. I'm shivering and crying, and my teeth are chattering together so I can't talk properly.

"I—I'm s—sorry, Da—Daddy."

Daddy's big hands hold me close to him. "You're Daddy's little girl, Carlie, you don't talk to boys... ever."

"Ok—okay, D—Daddy." I'm sad because I want to talk to Jayden again, but Daddy will never let me now.

Once I'm dry, Daddy carries me up to his bedroom and tells me I can sleep in his bed. Later in the night, he gets into bed too, but he has no clothes on. When he kisses my cheek and my mouth, he whispers, "Daddy won't hurt you if you be a good girl." His hands move all over my body and it makes me feel sick and dizzy. I wonder if he feels sick too. I think it might be why he always wants to cuddle me when I have no clothes on.

Thinking back, that punishment only happened two more times. The first time, I waved to Jayden while I was sitting on the porch and my father was mowing the grass. The second time, my father let me get the mail from the letter box. Jayden was riding his new bike. He stopped to show me how shiny and red it was, and even let me ring the bell on the handle bar. Even though I didn't speak to him that day, my father was mad, and I was punished.

I never saw Jayden after that, and it would be months before I was allowed outside again.

Eli extends his hand and takes mine. When I pull away, he holds it tighter. "It's okay, Carlie, I'm not going to hurt you." He takes a step forward, and my feet follow.

I try to pull away from his hand again, and again he refuses to let go.

I walk exactly fifteen steps and stand beside Eli at the edge of a cliff where a raging river churns below.

Across the river, there's a glistening stream of water rushing down the centre of the mountain. The water falls all the way to the bottom where it's white and bubbly. The sound is unlike anything I've heard before. And the fear I felt moments ago, has been replaced with a sense of calm as I stare longingly into the waterfall, imagining it washing away the secrets, lies, and pain of my past.

"Told you it was beautiful," he says.

"It's real." My words come out in a whisper.

Eli replies, "It sure is."

She's nothing more than flesh and blood
To feed my aching need
An empty shell, a flowering bud
For me, she'll always plead

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TRYSTAN**April 28***3.25pm*

She is nothing more than holes for me to fill. A flawless face and perfect body made to be fucked.

Made to be broken.

Made to submit.

Those soft, sweet lips of hers were made to be wrapped around my cock. Father may think he's the one who owns her, but I'm going to make sure I get some use out of her too.

Ever since I was a child, I've been jealous of Carlie's relationship with our father. He always wanted to touch her, always wanted to hold her. He made no secret of the fact that she was his favourite. He let her sleep in his bed, and in the mornings, he'd make her pancakes and ice cream. She got everything she wanted, including his undivided attention.

While Carlie got new clothes and books, and was showered with love, I was sent outside to play in the backyard. When she was down in the cellar playing games, I was in my bedroom listening to music or playing computer games, so I wouldn't have to hear her sobbing, or listen to her tell Father over and over how much she loved him.

It made me sick.

Until the day he let me in the cellar as well. That day, everything changed.

I was eight years old, but I still remember it like it was yesterday.

I watched him watch Carlie get undressed. I watched him touch her. I watched him take his pants off and tell her to hold his cock in her hands. She did everything she was told.

I wanted that power over her. I wanted to be the one who made her do those things.

I wanted to be my father.

But he was strict and ensured I didn't get to spend any time alone with her. And with me being at school, I didn't get many opportunities to see Carlie at home. She was either in the cellar with him and his friends, or she'd been sold to men for twenty-four hours at a time.

When I turned fifteen, Father said he had a gift for me. I didn't know what to expect when he led me down to the cellar and into the "playroom" as he called it. It was the first time he'd taken me down there alone.

When he dropped his pants and told me to suck his cock, I laughed in his face. He hadn't used me for almost a year—it was the first time I'd said no to him. He punched me so hard I hit the ground with a thud. But he didn't falter. He already knew what I wanted.

I wanted Carlie, and this was the only way I was going to get her.

Of course, I did it, and less than a minute later, I vomited. My father laughed before he told me to clean it up, then, he walked out as though nothing had happened.

An hour later, he came back down to the cellar with Carlie. She was wearing a tiny, pink silk nighty, and her nipples were showing through the fabric.

My cock throbbed and all I could think about was touching her body and forcing her down onto the bed so I could fuck her. I'd seen it plenty of times. I'd been watching porn since I was eight, and on rare occasions, my father would let me watch him with Carlie.

On my fifteenth birthday, I had sex with my twin sister for the first time. In that moment, I knew I was going to do it again, every chance I got. My obsession with her was only growing stronger.

Now, I have the power over her I always wanted.

Every time my father leaves the house, I take my chance. I go straight to her room. I don't care if she's in bed, or in the bath. I need to see her body. I need to see the look in her eyes when she knows what I want. It's a cross between fear and desperation. She thinks she doesn't want it, but I know her so well. She loves being fucked. That's why she never fights back. That's why she keeps still and doesn't scream.

Last week, I went into Carlie's room in the middle of the night. I got undressed, pulled her covers off and got into her bed. She begged me to get out until I told her I'd use Cathie instead.

Cathie's nothing like Carlie. That brat pisses me off. She never shuts up, not even with my cock shoved in her mouth. She's constantly crying or screaming. I don't know why Father doesn't get rid of her. It's not like anyone would miss the little bitch.

Carlie's different. She'll do anything to stop Cathie being used. Sometimes, I think it's because she's jealous of Cathie. Whatever it is, I don't care as long as I get to fuck her when I want, and how I want.

While I laid in Carlie's bed, I told her to get undressed. Once she was naked, I took her wrists and tied them to the rope attached to the bedhead. Seeing her tied up and under my control always sends a rush of blood to my cock that causes it to throb.

Thinking about her brings back the need to fuck her. I need to hear her desperate, panting breaths as the tears drip from her eyes and she begs me to stop. I need to feel her under me. The memories are not enough. I need her again, and I can't wait.

* * *

While Carlie's gone for twenty-four hours, and my father is training the brat down in the cellar, I've got time to call Mari. For the past six months, I've let her believe we're dating, even though I'm only using her for a quick fuck. Females are stupid, they'll believe anything.

When Mari arrives, I lead her to my bedroom and lock the door behind me. She sits on the end of my bed twisting her fingers together. "Your sister isn't home today?"

I shake my head. "Nope, why?"

"Just asking. She's pretty and seems nice. I wanted to say hi... I guess. It would be cool if she was at school too."

I push Mari back on my bed and sit over her thighs. "Did you come to see my sister, or me?"

She laughs. "You, of course. But Tryst, I don't want to do that stuff we did last time... it hurt."

I raise my brow. She'll do it. She'll do anything I tell her to. And if she doesn't, I'll make her, like my father makes Carlie do whatever the hell

he wants. Now that my father lets me watch him punish Carlie, I've learned a few things about females, and what they think they want.

They're so easy to use.

Trystan

17 years old.

Father was furious when the buyer brought Carlie home after three hours and demanded his money back. Carlie was crying while the male threw his arms in the air and called father every name under the sun. Turns out Carlie wasn't as good at taking it in the ass as the guy had expected.

While father paid him back, I took Carlie to the cellar. I was desperate to see what kind of punishment she'd get this time. I wanted to see her pain—to see her beg him to stop.

When our father came into the cellar, he grabbed Carlie by the wrist and slapped her face, leaving a raised red welt of his handprint behind. He rarely touched her face, and it pissed me off. I hated her skin being marked, but when the fear appeared in her eyes, I relished in it.

Once her wrists were tied to the steel bar that extended from one side of the room to the other, Carlie spoke, "Father, please, I tried, but it hurt so much."

He tightened the ropes, then took the leather whip from the hook on the wall.

My heart raced with anticipation. She was already crying, already begging. I wanted to see her come completely undone.

Father paced back and forth in front of her while I stood, leaning against the wall with my arms crossed over my chest. "You've done it before. Why the fuck did you refuse? Do you know how this looks for me?" Father shouted.

Through sobs, she tried to apologise. "I'm sorry, Father. But I didn't refuse. I tried, and it was too hard. He was bigger than the others. There was too much pain, then there was blood, so mu—"

Her words were cut off by the snap of the whip against the bare flesh of her ass. Her body shook as she let out a scream of agony before the whip struck her again. Father pulled her head back by her hair and lowered his voice. "You should have tried harder. You want your sister to go instead?"

Carlie shook her head hard, and I laughed. She'd probably die for that fucking brat.

"No, no, no. Please not Cathie."

A smile spread across Father's lips before he traced his fingers around her nipples.

My cock was growing harder by the second and I pushed it down, not taking my eyes off Carlie's thin, naked body writhing in pain right in front of me.

"Tryst, come here," my father ordered.

I didn't hesitate. I looked Carlie up and down before I stared into her eyes. They were filled with fear. I could see it so clearly and all I wanted to do was fuck her right then and there.

Father cupped Carlie's cheek and lowered his voice. "Some more training then. We'll have to loosen you up my precious little girl. Trystan's going to give you some training, then it will be my turn." He forced two fingers into her while she silently cried. Tears ran down her cheeks and dripped onto the pale flesh of her breasts.

A smile spread across my lips, and when my father told me to drop my pants and fuck my sister, I didn't bat an eyelid. I was having her, no matter what. Her being tied up was icing on the cake.

I stood behind her, gripped her tiny waist with my hands, and thrust my cock into her ass. She was perfect, and the tiny moans of pain that left her lips with every breath she took, made me crave her body even more.

Father paced back and forth, watching. "Now, Carlie baby," he said, "be a good girl and tell me what you want."

She sobbed. "Please—It hurts..."

Father's eyes narrowed. "Tell me," he roared.

When he raised his voice, her body tensed, and she tried to move away from me. I gripped her hips and thrust harder, losing myself in the moment. As the rush of pleasure built, I clamped my eyes shut and focused only on her hot flesh, tight around my aching cock.

Her voice was barely a whisper, "Please, Fath—Daddy, please... please give me more training. I want to make you happy."

When I reached the climax, I bit down on Carlie's shoulder and she let out a scream of pain. I threw my head back and exhaled as I pulled out of her and stepped back.

My father looked down at my cock and raised his brow. "That's my boy," he said. I leaned into Carlie's ear and whispered, "You're a good fuck, sis." Then I slapped her bare ass. "See, that wasn't so hard, was it? Hardly any blood at all."

Father laughed before he turned his attention back to Carlie. "And there's Daddy's good girl. Now, tell me how much you love me."

"I love you so much, Daddy. I love you most of all."

I'm pulled out of my memory of Carlie by Mari rubbing my cock through my pants. She has no fucking idea what she's doing.

"You won't do it this time?" she asks.

I kiss her neck and whisper, "I'll do whatever you want, baby."

I unbutton Mari's shirt to expose her bare breasts, then, I slide down her legs and pull her jeans and shoes off. Her body is nothing like Carlie's.

She's got huge breasts, thick thighs and a round stomach. Her hair is black, and her face is covered in makeup. Her body disgusts me. There's nothing I like about her unevenly tanned skin, or the small dirt-coloured freckles that litter her flesh.

I push my pants down and kick them off before I spread Mari's legs and kneel between them. She doesn't smell like Carlie either. She smells fruity, sweet... disgusting.

Once I'm inside Mari, she starts moaning, and that pisses me off too.

Carlie's moans turn me on. They remind me *I* have the power, not her.

I clamp my eyes shut and imagine my sister is beneath me, still, silent, submissive. Nothing like Mari who keeps moving and moaning and saying my name as though she knows who the fuck I am and what I want.

I sit back on my heels and tell Mari to roll over onto her stomach. She bites her lip. "Not in my ass again though, okay?"

"Roll over," I say again.

She does it, and before she has a chance to stop me or move away, I pour some lube into my palm and stroke my cock a few times. When I force my cock slowly into Mari's ass, she lets out a scream of pain and begs me to stop.

Ignoring her, I keep going, forcing her head down onto the mattress as I move. "Shhh... relax, it won't hurt as much."

She tries to move beneath me. "Please stop, Trystan, it hurts." When she starts to cry, I go harder, but that makes her cry louder.

"Shut up," I growl.

Finally, the rush of adrenaline takes over, and I groan as a wave of pleasure overcomes me. It's nothing like the high I get from fucking my sister, but it's enough to satisfy me, for now.

When I get off her, she jumps to her feet. Her eyes are red and puffy, and mascara and lipstick are smeared across her face. She pulls on her pants and shirt and glares at me. "You said you wouldn't! I hate you, Trystan. I hate you and I never want to see you again."

I laugh and pull the door open. "Fuck off then."

When she walks out, she slams the front door behind her, and from the kitchen, my father laughs. "Thank fuck that one's gone," he says. "Where's the little blonde one you had last week?"

I sit at the kitchen table and he hands me a beer. "Fucked her off too." I take a mouthful of beer. "How's the brat going?"

"I'll break her," he says. "Couple more weeks and she'll be Daddy's good little girl."

I screw my nose up in disgust. "She's not even your daughter. Why the hell do you bother with her?"

"She keeps Carlie in line. Need some leverage, remember that, son."

"Too bad she's always sick. We could be doubling the money with her."

Father shrugs. "Tell me about it. Jeff's trying to get some meds. Something wrong with her immune system. Defective, that's what she is."

"Fucking waste of space is what she is." I change the subject. "Can I have Carlie when she gets back?"

To my surprise, he doesn't hesitate. "Go for it. I'm going to Edgewater, you need to step up and take charge while I'm gone. But if I get back and there's one mark on her..." He raises his brow and smirks. "You'll be punished."

Fuck that, he should know I don't like her marked. I'll follow his rules no matter what. There's no way I'm sucking his cock again. "Got it. So, what's in Edgewater?"

He opens another beer. "Randy. Fuckin' dumbass piece of shit got arrested."

“I wondered why he hadn’t been around. What’d they get him for?”

He sighs and crosses his arms. “What do you think?”

I shake my head. Some of my father’s so-called friends are the biggest losers I’ve ever met. They come here wanting to fuck Carlie, but when they see her, their eyes glaze over and they start mumbling and talking shit. Randy was the worst. He couldn’t keep his hands off her. He’d show up every Tuesday at three on the dot, and for the first ten minutes he’d watch Carlie as though he’d never seen a girl before. When Father finally said he could touch her, he was all over her like a rash. Then he’d take her for twenty-four hours and bring her back the next day with a smile on his face. Pathetic.

“You think he’ll talk?” I ask.

“Not after I’m done with him, he won’t.” He laughs.

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Daddy doesn't love me
Because I'm always bad
But I don't like him either
He always makes me sad

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6

Bad Girl

CATHIE

April 28

4.45pm

12 years old

My father calls it a playroom. There are no toys, no games, and there's certainly no fun. It's not a playroom at all. It never was. It's a dimly lit, pink walled room filled with everything I hate. I hate the pink bed and the cold satin covers. I hate the blonde haired, blue eyed doll that wears a tiny dress and no underwear. My favourite colour is blue. But no one knows because no one has ever asked.

Everything in this room reminds me of pain, vomit, and darkness.

I hate it.

I hate my father.

And I hate my brother even more.

Shhh... he'll hear you. The voice whispers, urging me to be careful with my thoughts, and especially with my words.

I sit in the corner of the room on the pink sofa. Everything is pink because it's Carlie's favourite colour. Carlie is my father's favourite, that's why he lets her sleep in his bed, and lets her have books and pencils and all the things I'm not allowed to have. Most days, I don't even get to eat, and no one cares.

No one except Carlie. She cares about me, she tells me that she loves me too. She's my favourite. She's the only person I love in the whole world. Sometimes though—Shadow—the voice in my head, tells me that Carlie doesn't love me, and that she's going to run away and leave me here all alone. When Shadow says those things, I bang my head against the wall until she stops.

I pull my legs up and cross them on the sofa while I wait for my father.

Carlie is gone. Another man bought her early this morning. I heard her leave, but if I had come out of my bedroom, my father or Trystan would have punished me.

I wish I had the chance to say goodbye. *Wishes are for babies.* I pinch myself hard when Shadow reminds me, I'm not a baby anymore.

I'm supposed to be naked and ready for my father. I never do what I'm told. Shadow tells me to keep screaming "stop" and because of her, I'm always punished.

When footsteps pound down the stairs, I clamp my eyes shut and count them. It sounds like there are two people this time. I hope one of them isn't Trystan.

Here they come... are you ready?

My father enters the playroom and glares at me. A few steps behind him is Jeff, our doctor—another man I hate. If I think about it, there's not one man I've ever liked in my entire life. Sometimes, when I'm in my bed at night, I press my palms together and pray to God to kill all the men in the world. I pray for Him to save my sister. I pray for Him to save me. It never works, and I'm sure it's because *He* is a man too.

It's because he hates you. Everyone hates bad girls.

"Get your fucking clothes off." His voice sends a shiver of fear down my spine, but I shake my head and pull my knees to my chest.

Jeff laughs as he sets his black briefcase down on the small chest of drawers. "Defiant little brat, aren't ya."

I don't reply, my eyes are glued to my father as he paces toward me, his face red with rage. I swallow down the lump in my throat and tighten my arms around my knees.

Bad girl. Bad girl. Shadow teases.

My father stares down at me in disgust. He's never looked at me the way he looks at Carlie, or even the way he looks at Trystan. When he looks at Carlie, he has a weird smile, but he's not angry. When he touches Carlie, he's always gentle. When he looks at me, my body shrinks down to half its size as he towers over me like a dark, menacing cloud. When he touches me, it hurts all over.

He grabs my wrist and lifts me off the sofa with one tug of his hand. As he drags me to the bed, I struggle against him and beg him to let me go. *Kick him!* He's too fast. He holds me down with his hand around my throat

while Jeff holds my arms above my head. I gasp for air and desperately try to kick my way free, but I'm not strong enough.

I always feel sick, and I always feel sore. Father doesn't feed me often, and the drugs he gives me make me vomit. Jeff gives me medicine when he visits, and when I spit it back out, he gives me injections instead. They hurt and leave behind big grey and blue bruises. One day, I heard Jeff telling father there was something wrong with me. He said I was malnourished, and my immune system was low. I didn't know what it all meant until I asked Carlie. She said it means I don't get enough food, water, or sunlight, and that's why I always feel sick.

You are sick. A sick, bad girl. That's why he hates you. Shadow knows everything about me. Sometimes she helps me, but sometimes she says things that hurt me.

As my father pulls my pants off, he lowers his voice, "Now, now. Daddy's bad little girl is going to be punished."

Don't let him touch you. I shake my head. "No, no, please let me go. I don't want to."

Jeff laughs again as he helps my father remove my t-shirt.

I'm naked, and they both hold me down while I try to squirm out of their grasp.

When my father's hand slides between my legs, I scream as loud as I can for him to stop. He presses his hand over my mouth, ignoring my screams as he forces his fingers inside me.

Pain shoots through my body and I clamp my eyes shut to try to focus on each breath. I shake uncontrollably as the pain takes over; wave after wave of unrelenting agony.

A few minutes later, he stops and orders me to stay lying down. Of course, I don't listen, and I scramble back into the corner of the bed and pull my knees to my chest again as tears smother my face.

"Strap her down," Jeff says. "Why the fuck can't she be like Carlie?"

Father shrugs, then glares at me. "This one's useless. Carlie's perfect. Isn't that right, brat?"

I don't say a word. Just stare at him, hoping the hate in my eyes will burn through his brain and kill him.

I tried to kill him once. I was ten years old and Father told me to make his breakfast because Carlie wasn't home. I spread the butter on his toast, then walked across the kitchen and placed the plate on the table in front of him. When he turned away, I gripped the butter knife tight in my hand and forced it down into his shoulder.

He was furious. His face contorted with rage and his eyes were squeezed into tiny slits. Spittle flew from his mouth as he called for Trystan while blood oozed from his shoulder. I didn't scream. I didn't even move. Not until father told Trystan he could punish me.

Cathie

10 years old

My big brother Trystan is a monster. A real, true monster. He does bad things to me all the time, and if I scream, he doesn't care.

I should have known better than to try to kill my father, but the voice in my head told me to do it. I call the voice my shadow because it's always there, even when I don't want it. I can't run away, and I can't hide. It always finds me, just like my father does. Like Trystan does.

When Trystan pushes me down onto the bed in the play room and tells me to take my clothes off, I say "no". When he comes closer and slaps my face, lots of fuzzy stars appear in my eyes and I start to cry. "Take your fucking clothes off, bitch."

I shake my head and cover my cheek with my hand. Shadow tells me to run, but there's nowhere to go. Sometimes, I think Shadow is scared of Trystan too.

Trystan narrows his eyes and tilts his head to one side before he grabs my arm and starts pulling my pants off. He doesn't loosen his grip while he unbuttons his jeans and lets them fall to the floor. "I'm gonna fuck you up, little whore."

"Nooo!" I kick him as hard as I can. "Get away from me. I hate you!" As soon as I make contact with his thigh, his face changes. His jaw moves slightly before a smile spreads across his lips.

With both his hands, he grabs two handfuls of my hair and locks my knees together between his legs. I punch at him, but he's too strong for me, and every punch I land causes him to laugh.

“Let me go,” I scream.

Another slap. “Shut your fucking mouth.”

“Carlie!” I call for my sister, but she won’t hear me.

I’m about to scream again, but this time, Trystan forces his dick into my mouth. I throw my arms around, frantically trying to force him away, but it only makes him laugh louder. “That shut you up little whore, didn’t it— Try screaming now.”

I push my hands against his stomach, and when he doesn’t budge, I try to scream, but instead of screaming, I vomit.

Trystan pulls me off the bed and throws me to the floor. “Fucking bitch!” He kicks my ribs. I vomit again, and again until there’s nothing coming out of my mouth but greenish yellow ooze with streaks of red I think must be blood.

Three days later, I’m finally allowed to leave the playroom.

Father sends me into Carlie’s bedroom where he tells her to clean me up.

Shadow tells me to die, but I don’t know how. If the knife didn’t kill my father, I’m sure it won’t kill me either.

While I scream and cry, Father straps my wrists and ankles to the bed so I can’t move, then he goes back to Jeff. When they start talking, I try to hold back my sobs so I can listen. I don’t want Carlie to get into trouble because of me, and I don’t want Father to let Trystan punish me again.

“Carlie’s been fine with it. She’ll be fine too,” Jeff says as he holds up a long, thin plastic tube. I don’t know what it is, or what he’s going to do with it, but ripples of fear spread through my veins.

My father lights a cigarette, then blows the stinky grey smoke into the air. “Don’t bother knocking her out.”

Jeff laughs. “Sadist.”

Shadow tells me to be quiet and not to move at all.

My father walks over to me. “Lost your voice, brat?”

I shake my head. “What does sadist mean?” No. Don’t ask him. It’s too late.

He takes a long puff of his cigarette then leans down and blows the smoke in my face. When I start coughing and choking, he whispers in my ear, “It means Daddy likes to hurt bad girls... like you.”

A hot, burning pain presses into my side. I scream so hard I can barely catch my breath. I lift my head a little to see my father pressing his cigarette into my skin.

Fight back!

Jeff is laughing, and my father smiles. "Let's get this done."

While tears sting my eyes and my crying turns to uncontrollable, panting sobs, my father frees my legs from the straps. I'm dizzy and I can't focus on anything but the ceiling that seems to be spinning in circles.

Father sits on the bed and pulls my legs back as Jeff pushes something inside me.

I clamp my eyes shut. The more I move, the more I shake. "No, no. No! Stop, it hurts," I cry.

"Hold her still," Jeff says.

My father shouts for Trystan, and terror envelops me in a cold sweat.

I swallow back the fear and choke on my tears. Shadow tells me to keep screaming, but I can't. I'm too afraid of what will happen if I don't keep quiet.

I told you to scream! He's coming... he's going to hurt you.

First, his footsteps pace toward me. Next, he sits on the bed. Trystan places one hand on my forehead and speaks to me as though he likes me.

"Aww, poor little girl. Does it hurt?"

Scream!

His eyes seem darker than usual, and again, Shadow tells me to scream. Instead, I shake my head hard to free myself from the voice.

"Stop... it hurts."

"Hush little one," Jeff says, "keep nice and still or I'll have to start all over again."

Trystan stands and goes to the end of the bed. "That's all it takes to stop her getting pregnant?" he asks. "What is it?"

"This little thing here is called an IUD. Once this is in, you can have your fun without worrying about knocking her up," Jeff replies.

"Did Carlie scream like this?" Trystan asks.

My father tightens his grip on my legs. "Carlie was drugged up for it. Need to keep our favourite girl happy."

"Least she doesn't fight back like this one," Jeff says as another surge of pain tears through my body.

I told you to SCREAM!

I can't hold it back anymore. It forces its way out of my lungs until I'm gasping for air. Vomit rises in my throat, but I can't swallow it down.

"Tryst, keep her fucking still," my father shouts before the voices fade away and I'm pulled into the darkness where the pink walls I hate so much, disappear along with Shadow.

* * *

6.50pm

When my eyes flicker open, a bright light shines into them. I squeeze them shut again. *Wake up now.* Shadow is back.

"Cathie." Someone shakes me, and when my vision clears, I see my father. *Kill him. He needs to die. All the men need to die.* I shake my head. I can't move, my head is too heavy to lift, and there's a pain in my tummy that makes it twist and turn. It feels as though a whole lot of needles are trying to escape from inside me.

"Wake up," his voice is rough.

I shake my head. I can't wake up properly. I don't want to wake up. I want the pain to go away and leave me alone.

Wake up. It's time to fight.

I blink a few times, then turn my head to the side to see my father sitting on the pink sofa by the bed. I move my fingers. I move my toes. Then, I lift my arm to scratch my head.

"Is Carlie home?" I ask. *Carlie doesn't want you. She ran away. Now you have to run away too.* "No. No she didn't," I tell Shadow.

"What the fuck are you talking about?"

"Carlie..." I take a deep breath.

My father stands and comes to the bed, when he sits at the end of it near my feet, I pull my legs up, but he pulls them back down and holds them apart. "Bleeding's almost stopped. Get up and have a shower. I want you clean."

NO! Don't listen to him. You need to kill him. You need to run.

I'm too sore to fight, so I listen to my father and slowly sit up before I drop my feet off the bed. I walk to the shower in the corner of the room.

Shadow doesn't stop. *Don't listen to him. Don't get in that shower. You have to fight.*

I punch myself in the head over and over until my father shouts at me. "Cut it the fuck out!"

I freeze, still shaking my head. "I can't. It hurts," I tell Shadow, but Father must think I'm talking to him.

He grabs my arm while he turns on the shower. When he pushes me under the cold water, shivers crawl across my skin causing hundreds of tiny goose bumps to appear. I fall to my knees and let the icy blast of water pound against my head as my teeth chatter and Shadow taunts me.

You're going to die here. Get up! Bad girls fight.

I watch the water rushing down the drain along with streaks of pinkish red blood that I realise is coming from me.

"Stand up," my father growls.

It takes me a few tries and when I finally reach my feet, he drags me out of the shower, turns it off, then throws a towel at me before pointing to the bed. "Put that dress on and brush your fucking hair."

I hold the towel against my chest and cross my arms tight around myself. I shake my head. "No." *There's the bad girl. Now... fight.*

"NOW!" he bellows, and like it did when I was little, pee runs down my legs causing my cheeks to burn with shame. He laughs and turns the shower back on. "Back in there. Daddy's going to get Trystan. I know how much you love your big brother."

Fear rattles my bones. "No. I will get clean, Daddy. I will put the dress on too." Maybe if I act like Carlie, he won't call Trystan. *No! You're a bad girl. Bad girls don't let men touch them.* Ignoring Shadow, I get back under the cold water and scrub my body all over with Carlie's pink loofah and her body wash that smells like sweet strawberries. This time, when I get out, I dry myself off right away and walk over to the bed.

I pull the white dress on over my head, then brush the knots from my hair as my father stands, watching me.

"Daddy, if I be a good girl like Carlie, can I have some food?"

He raises his brow then laughs before he walks toward the stairs.

"You'll never be like Carlie."

I drop down onto the bed letting my hairbrush fall to the floor. *You'll never be a good girl.* Shadow reminds me.

A little while later, he returns with a small bottle of water and tells me it's time for my medication. I open my mouth to let him put two small pills on my tongue before he hands me the water.

Don't swallow it. Bad girls don't do what they are told. My tummy is sore. Between my legs is sore, and it feels like I'm burning inside. I don't want to fight anymore, it hurts too much.

Father goes to the table and comes back with a needle filled with clear liquid. It looks like the water he took off me as soon as I swallowed the pills. He presses the tip of the needle into the inside of my arm.

My father's hands aren't rough now. They're not hurting, but I don't want them on me. I try to push him away. My arms don't work properly, they're heavy and weak. When I blink, the room is spinning in big pink and black circles. I'm on my back and my father is over me. My body moves back and forth making me dizzy, and I have to squeeze my eyes shut so I can't see anything.

Shadow is calling me. *Cathie... please open your eyes. You have to fight now. It's time to fight back.*

My father's voice replaces hers. "Now you're Daddy's good little girl. You like this don't you—no more fighting—"

You have to fight. He's killing you, Cathie!

I open my mouth to beg him to stop, but my words are all jumbled up. "Not good... bad gir—not... don't... want no—"

Shadow sends whispers through my mind. *You'll die here. You should have tried har—*

There's nothing else.

There's no more pain.

There's no more light.

There's no—

The wind carries whispers
And the secrets I keep
I want to be loved
Before forever, I sleep

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CARLIE**April 28***8.00pm*

It's been twelve hours since Eli brought me to his home. I haven't had sex with him, and he hasn't asked me to do anything at all, not even take my clothes off so he can look at me. For that reason alone, trusting him is a little easier.

I'm sitting at his kitchen table with a plate of food in front of me. Eli sits opposite me and pours himself a glass of red wine then offers me some cola.

I can speak to him now although I'm not sure what to talk about.

"I've had wine before."

"You're seventeen."

"Yes. Some of the other—" I stop and take a mouthful of the fizzy cola.

"They gave you wine?" He sounds annoyed—or surprised.

"Yes. Some just a little. Some until I couldn't stand up or move properly. I didn't like it. Father says I'll get used to it if I have it more often."

Eli returns his focus to his plate, so I do the same. I scoop up a forkful of fluffy white mashed potato and savour the taste by chewing slowly. Then, I scoop up some peas and swallow them down, along with another mouthful of cola. My stomach rumbles and each time I swallow, my throat tightens reminding me I need to slow down.

Eli breaks the silence again. "The young boy at your house, he's your brother?"

"Yes, that's Trystan. We're twins."

Eli's eyes widen. "Does your father sell him for—"

I shake my head before he can say the word. "He says Trystan can make his own choices. He has two girlfriends now."

"Two?" Eli questions.

I nod. "Yes. But not at the same time. They stay at our house on different nights unless Trystan tells them to leave. Father says he needs to learn not to become attached to females."

"Has your brother tried to have sex with you?"

My stomach coils in knots. I don't want to admit that I've let my brother use me, or that my father allows it.

Carlie

15 years old.

When my door opens, I don't expect to see my brother. "Have fun?" he asks.

I shake my head.

He raises his brow and closes my bedroom door.

A shiver runs down my spine. "Where's Father?"

"Gone into town." He shoves his hands into his pockets.

I shuffle back on my bed and wrap my arms around myself. "What do you want?"

"Your body," he says. "I'm gonna fuck you."

I shake my head hard. "No. Father said only when he is home."

Trystan laughs as he pulls his t-shirt off. "Want me to use Cathie?"

It's always the same. He knows Cathie is my weakness, and I'll do anything to protect her. "Please, Trystan, leave her alone. She's a little girl, please... stop hurting her."

"You're right. She's a little girl. Nice and tight too." Another step toward me. "But nah. I love the way she screams. You should see her with my cock in her mouth. Soon, she'll be begging for it, and so will you. Now... take your clothes off."

Bile rises in my throat. He's been using Cathie all this time. I should have known better. Why didn't she tell me? I'm terrified, but as usual, I stand and obey.

Trystan watches with a licentious glare while I unzip my dress and let it fall to the floor at my feet.

“Lie down,” he commands.

When I’m on my back, he stands beside my bed and traces his fingers over the scars inside my thighs. “I don’t like this. Do it again, and I’ll punish Cathie.”

I swallow the lump in my throat. I can’t stop. Red lines. Red lines. It swims through my head taunting me. Reminding me that if I don’t cut, I might forget about the life blood that flows through my veins. I can’t let that happen.

Trystan slips his pants off and when they drop to his feet, he kicks them across the floor. The bed dips beneath his weight as he kneels between my legs.

“Please d—” I beg as I press my hands to his chest to push him away.

He grabs my wrist and holds it above my head to tie it to the bedhead. “Shhh... don’t worry, sis, I’ve had heaps of practice since last time. You know how many girls at school want to fuck me?”

He takes my other wrist and ties it up too.

I bite my tongue and squeeze my eyes shut as Trystan lowers his body over me. He kisses across my breasts and all over my neck and collarbone before he presses his mouth to mine. His breath reeks of cigarettes and alcohol, and his lips are rough and dry.

When I don’t kiss him back, he grips my jaw in his hand and forces my mouth open before his wet tongue glides across my lips and into my mouth. “Mmm. You taste good, sis.”

I shake my head and pull on the ropes to try to free myself, but when Trystan smothers my mouth with his hand, I let my body go limp as he begins to move inside me. Each thrust of his hips slams against mine, and with each groan he moves harder and faster until he falls into a rocking motion.

I lie beneath him; my eyes open as I watch his face intently. His brown eyes—now staring blankly into oblivion—match mine perfectly. His lips are the same as mine too, and even his nose has the same little curve that I have.

I always knew we were twins, but before he started using me, I never saw him as my brother. He was merely another child in the house.

For exactly two minutes and ten seconds, Trystan uses me while I lie still beneath him. When he stops, he reaches over to untie my wrists, then he sits back on his heels. “Get up and suck me off.”

I shake my head. It’s the most disgusting thing I’m forced to do, and I always vomit afterwards. I beg him to do anything else but that, but it’s no use.

“Get up, Carlie, or I’ll get Cathie, and I’ll show you how she sucks cock.” Trystan grabs his dick in his hand and pulls on it a few times.

“Come on, you want it.”

Tears well in my eyes. “No. I don’t want to. If he comes home, we will both be punished.”

He grabs my wrist and tugs me toward him, then, with one hand holding my jaw, he brings my head closer. With his other hand, he forces his dick into my mouth. “Do it. Now!” he orders.

I shake my head again, trying to resist the urge to vomit.

Trystan puts his hand around my throat and tells me to open my mouth. I clench my teeth together. Any other time, I would not dare defy a male who has told me to do something. But with Trystan, it’s different. He knows as well as I do that our father will be furious. He only allows Trystan to use me if he’s home, or if Jeff is here.

“Cathie!” Trystan calls.

Panic takes over and I stutter. “D—Don—don’t... don’t call her. I’ll do it.”

He laughs. “You’re so fucking easy. No wonder Father loves your little whore mouth. You love sucking Daddy’s big cock, don’t you? And you’re gonna love sucking mine too.”

With tears streaming down my face, I open my mouth while Trystan holds my head in position and rocks his hips toward me. He starts off slowly at first, then harder, and faster until I’m gagging and desperately trying to push him away so I can breathe. I try to pull his hands off my head, but he’s too strong.

“Don’t stop,” he says urgently as he forces himself into my mouth and I gag again.

“You’re so good, Carlie.” With one hand twisted through my hair, he uses his other hand to squeeze my nipple between his fingers before his

hand slides down my waist and comes to rest between my legs. When his fingers move roughly inside me, I try to bring my knees together.

He doesn't stop talking. "You like this don't you. Yeah... suck my cock like a good girl."

I want to scream. I want to hit him, and beg him to stop but I can't move, and I can barely breathe. "You're my favourite, Carlie. You'll always be my favourite."

When the door opens and slams against the wall, Trystan pushes me back on the bed and his eyes grow wide as my father glares at him, his face red with rage.

"What the fuck, Trystan!" he roars.

I scramble back on my bed and cross my arms around myself, struggling to swallow down the bile rising in my throat. I never argue with my father. And I never speak unless he tells me to. Whatever Trystan says now will determine my punishment.

"She asked for it," Trystan says. "Been walking around naked practically begging for my cock."

My father tilts his head, then cracks his knuckles and walks toward my bed. Trystan stands and pulls on his pants.

"Get the fuck out. Go get me a beer," my father tells him with a nod of his head.

I swallow the lump in my throat as my father points to the floor.

Slowly, I drop my feet off my bed, then kneel in front of him.

"Did you ask for it?"

"No, Father."

With one finger he motions for me to stand. When I do, he pushes his fingers inside me, then pulls them out and looks down. "You're wet. You wanted it, didn't you? You like fucking your brother?"

I shake my head. "No, Father."

His fingers go back inside me. He doesn't stop, even while he talks. "What did he say to you, my sweet, baby girl?"

My lip quivers and the tears fall again. Please stop. "He said..." I stutter through my sobs. "He said... he... would use Cathie if I didn't do it. I didn't want to. I told him not unless you are home."

He pulls his fingers out and wipes them across my lips leaving a thin, sickly film. When he orders me to sit on my bed, he unzips his pants and

drops them to the floor. “You know what to do.”

I nod. And with every breath, I think about my little sister, and how everything I do is to protect her from my brother—from my father, and from the men he brings into our lives.

I think about death, and how it would feel to be buried beneath the ground where no one can touch me.

When my father is done, he pulls up his jeans and steps back, rubbing his chin. “In the cellar. I’ll be down shortly. Make sure you’re ready.”

I nod and stand, but when I walk toward the door, he grabs my wrist and stops me. “Carlie, baby, I’m doing this for you. One day you’ll be old enough to choose them yourself.”

I nod again. “Yes. I know.”

As I walk out my bedroom door, Trystan is waiting in the hallway. He glares at me. “We’re doing that again, and next time you’ll finish me like you do for him.”

I keep walking with my head down and my eyes on the floor while I silently beg death to take me away.

I twist my fingers together in my lap. “Why are you asking so many questions?”

Eli takes a bite of steak. When he’s swallowed it, he says, “I’m... well, I’m someone who tries to stop this happening.”

“This?”

“You, your sister. Other girls. What your father is doing is wrong, Carlie. It’s against the law.”

*I swallow hard and stand up crossing my arms around myself. *Oh no. This isn’t good.* “Take me home. My father will be so mad. Please take me home.”*

“You don’t need to protect him,” Eli says. “It’s time for this to stop now.”

“Please stop.” I pace the kitchen feeling queasy. The room begins to spin, my eyes dart around searching for a spot on the wall I can focus on. I don’t find one. I fall to my knees and place my hands on my lap. “Please, have sex with me, and let me go home.”

Eli kneels in front of me. “Listen to me, Carlie. In the morning, I’m going to get your sister and bring her here. Then I’ll be taking you both

somewhere safe. Somewhere your father will never find you.”

Tears stream down my face.

My home.

My father.

It’s the only life I’ve ever known. I barely know the world outside my own front door. Running away was always a thought, but I never imagined it would be a possibility. I’m terrified. Uncertainty weaves its way through my heart spreading tendrils of fear to the marrow of my bones.

Eli could be lying. What if he brings Cathie here and uses us both? I need to protect her.

Inside my head, there’s a tiny voice telling me to trust him. But fear overwhelms me. I stand, my knees shaking—my heart pounding.

The clock on the wall reads 8.10pm.

I run.

My feet move quickly, stomping down onto the dirt path, carrying me away from Eli and his twisted promises of salvation and freedom. Eli doesn’t know I need to stay with my father to protect him, to make sure his sickness doesn’t get worse. I’m the only one who can help him get better. The only one who understands what he needs. *My father needs me.*

As I run away from the cabin, the sky grows darker. Stars are scattered above and I want to stop and marvel at their beauty, but I can’t. I continue running until I reach the cliff where the waterfall is rushing down the mountain. The calmness I felt earlier doesn’t come as I scan the area searching for a place to hide.

To the left, the moonlight casts a glow on a large boulder between the trunks of two tall trees. I run over and sink to the ground pulling my knees to my chest and sobbing into my hands. *Don’t make a sound.* I’m alone. Lost in the forest in the middle of nowhere. I beg my knees to stop shaking and my heart to stop beating. The sound of the rushing water, and the darkness hovering over the forest, envelops me in a veil of fear.

Above me a bird squawks and leaves rustle in the trees. In the distance, a growl threatens to force a scream from my lungs. I bite down on my tongue until blood fills my mouth. *Don’t make a sound.* Pressing my hands hard over my mouth, I breathe through my nose.

Eli's voice is carried through the trees. "Carlie, come on back to the cabin. It's too cold to be out here."

Footsteps close in and I clamp my eyes shut. I wish I knew if he was telling the truth.

"Come on, Carlie. I'll make you a hot chocolate and we can talk some more."

A shiver crawls down my spine as a chilly breeze blows through the trees. There's a rustle in the thick undergrowth behind me, then the hoot of an owl. Squeezing my eyes shut I count the seconds in my head. One, two, three, four...

When I reach thirty-six, his voice is right above me. "There you are." Eli reaches down. "Come on, it's okay now."

I choke back tears. Maybe I can take Cathie's place at home and Eli can help her instead.

"I don't—" I rub my hands over my arms. "I don't know if you're lying..." My lip quivers. Hope is dangling in front of me, a forbidden fruit I'll never touch. I want to reach out and lunge at it, but there are too many unanswered questions. Too many whys. Too many what ifs.

Eli steps back and shoves his hands into the pockets of his dark blue jeans. "What do you need from me... to prove I'm not lying?"

I shrug. "Are you police? Do you have a badge?"

He shakes his head. "I'm with a private agency. We protect children and bring people like your father to justice."

Justice? Prison? My father is sick. He's not bad. *He's not.* "What's your agency called?"

He doesn't hesitate. "Hearts of Innocence. Come back to the cabin, I'll show you some of my paperwork."

I push my hands into the cold dirt and get to my feet.

Eli extends his hand, this time I take it and walk back to the cabin with him.

At 9.04pm I watch Eli make a mug of hot chocolate for me. He drops in one white and one pink marshmallow, then invites me to sit beside him on the soft brown sofa. He places a black briefcase on the table. It's the same type as the ones the men bring when they pay my father.

"Do you want to take your shoes off?" he asks. "You're allowed to."

I don't reply, but I kick them off and place them neatly beside the sofa.

When Eli opens the briefcase, there's a pile of yellow folders, and a large white envelope. He takes the folder from the top and pushes the briefcase aside.

"Can you read and write?" he asks, handing me the page.

I nod. "Father says we must read and write every day. I taught Cathie myself, but Trystan's school principal sends workbooks home for me too."

When I read through it, I see my own name, my date of birth, and my mother's name. "This is about me?"

He nods. "Yes. There was a tip off. Your father's name came up on our system. We've been looking into him for quite a while."

"How long?" I ask.

Eli props his elbows on his knees. "About five years now. When Children's Services went to your house, they always came back with nothing. Everything looked perfect, at least from the outside."

I'm confused. Children's Services? Who are they? "No one came to our house."

Eli's brow creases as he flicks through the paperwork in the yellow folder. He drags his finger down the page and stops to read out the words. "We arrived at the premises at 10.00am, Monday, and found the children, two girls and one boy having breakfast at the kitchen table with their father. They were happy and healthy, and the house was clean and tidy. Nothing further to report."

I lean forward to look at the page. "They never came to our house. And we have breakfast at 8.00am, always."

His eyes narrow like Trystan's do when he knows I'm lying. "You've never seen any social workers at your house?"

"Never. Father would never allow anyone to view me unless they've made an appointment and paid the viewing fee."

Eli stands and paces the room mumbling under his breath. I catch a few swear words, but everything else is too quiet for me to hear. "Is something wrong, Eli?"

He scrubs his hands down his face. "I've got pages and pages of visits here." He points to the yellow folders. "And you're telling me you've

never seen anyone other than the men who purchase you... it doesn't make sense."

My stomach turns, and I wrap my arms around myself. "I'm not lying. I'm not, I promise. No one comes to our house unless my father says so. Even Trystan has to make special times for his girlfriends, or his friends from school."

Eli drops back onto the sofa and sighs. "It's okay, Carlie, I believe you."

"Do you know what happened to my mother?" I ask.

He rubs his chin. "You don't know?"

I shake my head. "Father said she left. She loved me though. She promised we would leave together."

"Carlie," Eli says, "your mother has been missing for over ten years. We assume your father killed her, but so far there's not enough evidence. With you, we can put him away for a long time."

I jump to my feet. The world is spinning—tumbling down and threatening to crush me. I snatch the folder from the table and throw it on the floor. "You're lying," I scream. "She's coming back for me." I run into the bedroom and slam the door behind me then fall to the floor sobbing. My father wouldn't do that. He loves my mother. He loves me.

Your head's fucked up, Carlie. You don't remember. My brother's words force their way into my mind, attacking me from the inside, bringing with them the reminder that my father was a killer. *Is a killer.*

Carlie

16 years old.

"I was right there when he killed mum. I watched him stab her. I watched him slice through her flesh and saw through her bones. I helped him wrap her body parts in towels then put them into the steel drum in the backyard."

I shake my head, trying in vain to get the horrific images out of my mind. "That's not true, Trystan!"

His eyes travel down to my breasts and he licks his lips as a shiver crawls down my spine. My words fall on deaf ears as he continues. "You toasted fucking marshmallows over your mother's burning body." He

grunts. “Your head’s fucked up, Carlie. You don’t remember.” He leans against my bathroom sink watching me as I rinse my hair off in the bathtub.

“I remember everything. But not that. Father wouldn’t have killed her. He loved her.”

Trystan laughs. “He loves you. Only you. And it’s not normal love. You have no fucking idea. You’re locked inside this house every single day playing his fucked-up mind games, letting him use your body like a dirty little whore. If I wanted to use you right now, you’d let me. You fucking love it and don’t try to deny it. You’re as sick as he is. As sick as we all are.”

I shake my head hard. It’s not true. “No!” I know it’s wrong, but I have to do what I’m told. It’s the only way to make sure my father loves me. To make sure he doesn’t punish me. I can’t be punished.

“I don’t love it. I don’t.” I begin to cry, but Trystan only laughs again.

“He’s a paedophile and a murderer.” He shrugs. “The only reason he’s never been caught is because he’s so good at it.”

With a heavy sigh, I raise my head. “I want him to get better.”

My father’s voice rings out, and Trystan turns to leave. As he walks out the door, he looks back over his shoulder at me. “You can’t fix him, sis. Only death can do that. And when good old Daddy is gone, it’s gonna be you and me, baby. We’re going to have so much fun together.”

“He killed her.” I say the words as the realisation dawns on me. “He killed her, and Trystan watched.”

“How do you know?” Eli stands in the doorway.

I swallow hard. “Trystan told me. I just remembered him telling me. But—but... my father isn’t a killer he’s si—he’s sick, that’s all.”

Eli kneels in front of me. “Carlie, you’re right. Your father is sick. Very sick. And what he’s done—what he’s doing to you, and to your sister needs to stop.”

I nod, but my heart is breaking into tiny pieces. I can feel them falling away, exposing my most vulnerable parts. “I want him to love me.” Tears fall from my eyes and I sink down to the floor and curl up in a ball. “I just want him to love me.”

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Life is but
A brilliant battleground
Of shattered hopes
And dreams

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April 29

12.45am

Carlie cried herself to sleep, eventually. I didn't want to bring up her mother, but with the limited time I have to gain information, it was necessary.

This case is unlike any of the others I've been involved in. When the file was dropped on my desk at Hearts of Innocence over five years ago, I thought it would be simple. I assumed we'd get the girls out in a matter of months, but social services always came back empty-handed, and I was never sent in. Over the years, other girls were rescued, but this case was always in the back of my mind.

On Tuesday morning, I was briefed by local authorities and given an hour to prepare before my appointment with Rob Browne. I've seen a lot of girls in my twenty years with Hearts of Innocence, but Carlie is different. She's not ready to run. She's not trying to escape, and she's not fighting back. Carlie truly believes her father loves her, and that his 'sickness' can be cured.

It's after midnight and at the other end of the cabin the bedroom door creaks open. Hopefully, she's in the kitchen getting something to eat. God knows she needs it. I consider getting up to apologise and to try to talk to her, but decide to leave her be until morning.

I close my eyes, and as I'm about to drift off to sleep my door opens and the kitchen light shines through. I blink, then rub my eyes as Carlie walks into my bedroom, naked.

Fuck!

I shuffle up the bed as she pushes the door open wide. Her face is pale and full of innocence. Her body is small, scarred, and malnourished. Of all the girls I've seen her age, she's the smallest. At seventeen she looks like an underweight fifteen-year-old.

I lower my voice. “Carlie, go and put your clothes on and go back to bed.”

She twists her fingers together. “You paid for me. I must do what is expected. I’m good at it, Father taught—”

I cut her off and raise my hand. “No. Don’t.” I swallow down the rage building inside me as I stand and pull the sheet off the bed then drape it over her gaunt, skeletal frame.

She tilts her head, confused. “You paid for sex.”

No! I paid to save you. Still keeping my anger under control, I say, “Go back to bed, okay... We’ll talk in the morning.”

“But... I have to let you... Father said—”

My emotions get the better of me. This poor child doesn’t know anything else, but I shout before I can stop myself. “No! I am not having sex with you. I’m not touching you, AT ALL! You’re a child, damn it.”

She steps back once, clasping the sheet at her breasts. “I—” She closes her mouth then runs back to the other bedroom.

I need to get these girls away from here, and fast.

I run a hand through my hair then dig through the pocket of my jeans for my phone. I need to call Zahra. Zahra and I have been working together for over a decade. She was just one among the first group of girls to be rescued by Hearts of Innocence’s interstate headquarters when she was ten years old.

Years of therapy and counselling helped her gain the confidence she needed to get through school and continue on to university. After passing every class with flying colours, she graduated and signed up to work with Hearts of Innocence. Once she was deemed mentally stable, Zahra was offered a position as my partner. I’ve always been in awe of her determination, and the lengths she will go to, to help the young girls we rescue.

Five years ago, we started dating. After my first marriage, I didn’t think I’d ever find love again, but Zahra showed me it was possible.

Two rings in and she answers. “Eli? It’s after midnight. This better be good, I need my beauty sleep.”

I lie back on my pillow. “Sorry, babe. I got her, Zar. The one from Harrisville. It’s Car—I got Carlie. She’s not in a good way. I think you need

to come see her.”

There’s a long sigh. “Thank goodness. That bad? When’s the return time? Oh, I’ve got some more information on those girls. We can go through it when you get back.”

I scratch my head. “Well... ah, that’s the thing. I think it’s going to take—”

She cuts me off. “Eli Cole, if I have to get out of bed and drive there now, I swear I will—”

“Zahra, the little one, he’s using her too.”

Another sigh. “I’m on my way. I want coffee, lots of coffee.”

“Drive safe, I love you.”

“I will. And you owe me,” she says before she hangs up.

I forget about sleep and get up to shower. When I head into the kitchen and flick on the coffee machine. I decide to call Carlie’s father and organise to pick up her sister as early as possible in the morning.

Having to fake my way through these phone calls, and act as though I genuinely want to purchase young girls for sex, makes me sick to my stomach, but I remind myself every day that this is what I need to do to save them.

“Welcome to Pure. How can I help you?”

“I made a purchase yesterday.”

“Password?” he asks.

I lower my voice. “Tryst.”

“Who am I speaking to?”

“Eli Cole.”

“Not giving you any trouble?”

“None, she’s perfect. Rob, I’m thinking... I want the younger one. And this one for another night.”

He laughs. “Told you she was experienced, didn’t I?”

“Yeah, you sure did. So, what’s the price?”

“Eighty for the young one, plus another sixty for Carlie. You can pick up the other one at the scheduled drop off time. You want a viewing?”

“No viewing necessary. I’ll see you at six.”

“Deal.”

I put my phone on the table and wipe my hands down my pants, feeling filthy. While I wait for Zahra to arrive, I pack my bag and prepare an itinerary for our departure. This needs to be done swiftly, and without error. One mistake could cost us everything.

It's 3.00am, and I'm on my third cup of coffee when Zahra pulls up in the driveway in her red SUV. I open the door as she gets out of the car and rubs her eyes. The sensor light shines down on her. Her long black hair is pulled up into a messy bun on top of her head and she's wearing her pyjamas. I laugh as she heads toward the door. When she wraps her arms around me and kisses my cheek, I thank her for coming.

In the kitchen, she plonks down on the chair and nods toward the coffee machine. "Come on, I thought you'd have it ready and waiting." She taps her foot on the floor.

"It'll only take a minute. You okay?"

"I'm fine, stop worrying." She rolls her eyes, but smiles. "Did you get the other one?"

"Yep. Pick up's at six. You'll be right to watch Carlie while I'm gone?"

Zahra nods and rubs her hands together. "It's chilly out there, you going to stoke that fire before you leave?"

I give her a mock salute. "Yes darling." I hand her the coffee and sit at the table. "So what else did you find out?"

Zahra shuffles through the papers in her overnight bag and pulls out a file. "This has been going on for a hell of a lot longer than we first thought." She slides the file across the table.

"How long?" I ask as I open the folder.

"Years. There are so many reports pointing to abuse, but none have been followed up." Zahra nods toward the folder in my hand as I flick to the next page. "All this time, Eli. He was right under our noses. One of our own..." Tears well in her eyes and she swipes them away with the back of her hand. "That bastard had us all fooled."

I grit my teeth and rub my jaw. On the page is a mugshot of Randall Eastlake, one of our colleagues. He was a friend, or so I thought. We'd meet up once a week after work for dinner and drinks until he resigned and

moved interstate. The phone calls became few and far between—eventually they stopped.

Below the photograph of Eastlake are the details of his arrest. Shock rolls through me. “He used us to—he used his position to get these girls... I told him about—” Realisation dawns on me and I stand and pace the kitchen. “How did we miss this?”

Zahra sighs. “You know what they’re like, Eli. We know. Yes, we should have seen it, but we didn’t.” She hands me another page, and as I read the words, my head throbs and anger builds inside me.

Randall Eastlake was arrested after an internal investigation into the agents at Hearts of Innocence.

I swallow hard. This is a guy I trusted. We drank together, shared stories. “He fucking used us.” I slump down in the seat at the kitchen table. “He used us to get closer to the girls—the kids, Zar...” I drop my head in my hands. This job is my life. Everything I do is to save these girls from the horrendous torture they’re forced to endure. *I failed.* “I failed again.” The words spin in my head.

Zahra places her hand over mine on the table. “No. *You* didn’t fail. You couldn’t have known.”

I raise my voice, “I should—” Realising Carlie is still asleep, I lower it, “I should have seen it. Seen something.”

“Brady spoke to him,” Zahra says quietly. “Drove all the way out to Edgewater Prison to see him.”

Callum Brady is our boss, and the founder of Hearts of Innocence. He’d been working on child trafficking and abuse cases for thirty years before he decided to branch out on his own. With the blessing of the Police Department and other government agencies, he built a team of dedicated men and women to go undercover—all with one goal in mind. To stop children being used and abused by these monsters. Monsters like Randall Eastlake.

“Eli,” Zahra says, “he joined Hearts of Innocence to get closer to these kids. It was all planned. He was setting up the social service visits. Five arrests were made, only one of them talked. Randall. He wanted to make a deal, less prison time for more information.”

“And Brady said no?” I question.

“Of course. He got enough though. The mother of these girls,” she lowers her voice. “She agreed to all of it... until—”

“Until Carlie was born?”

Zahra nods. “I don’t get it, Eli. I’ll never understand how a parent can *want* this for their child.” She shakes her head. “How can money be more important than your own flesh and blood?”

I scrub my hands down my face. “They’re sick. Fucking sick. The only thing that will stop them is a bullet to the head.” I flick through the other pages in the file and pull out the one that has a transcript between Carlie’s mother, Lisa, and her sister, Dianne.

TRANSCRIPT

Lisa Browne: I can’t do it anymore, Di, it’s getting worse.

Dianne Masters: Do something about it. Or I will. I’ll call the police right now.

LB: Don’t. You can’t get involved, he’ll know.

DM: They’re your children damn it. You need to get them out of there.

LB: I have to kill him. I’ll kill him, it’s the only way.

DM: How?

[brief silence]

LB: Oh god, no! He’s following me.

DM: Call the police! [screaming]

LB: [screaming] I’m sorry, I’m sorry. Please don’t take her.

DM: Lisa... Lisa!

[silence]

“Can we talk to the sister?” I ask Zahra.

She sighs. “She’s dead. Hung herself a week after that phone call.”

“So, we’ve still got nothing?”

“We have this. It arrived yesterday,” Zahra says handing me an envelope.

I open it and pull out the letter. In scrawled handwriting it reads,

Rob Browne is a murderer, paedophile, and child abuser. He sells his daughter for sex through his fake business name, Pure. He murdered his wife, Lisa Browne and her sister, Dianne Masters. If you don’t put him away, I’ll make sure he’s buried six feet under. I’m doing this for my daughter, Cathie. I want her back. Please save her before he kills her too.

“Who the hell is this? Did you get a name, an address? Anything?”

“It was hand delivered by a kid who dropped it on the counter and took off before anyone could question him. Callum’s chasing it up, but Eli, we need to get to Rob Browne before this guy does.”

As I’m about to reply the bedroom door creaks open and Carlie peeks out. Her eyes flit between me and Zahra.

“Hot chocolate?” I ask her.

She shakes her head and slowly paces over to the table, still naked. I avert my eyes.

“Did you pay for her too?” Carlie asks.

I don’t reply, I can’t. Instead, I let Zahra do the talking. “I’m Zahra, a friend of Eli’s, and you must be Carlie.”

Carlie nods. “I like your name.”

Zahra thanks her then stands. “How about we get you some clothes? I’ve got just the thing for you.”

Carlie is frozen in place again.

“Go on, you’re allowed to,” I urge.

While they’re in the bedroom, I stoke the fire and fill my briefcase with the cash I need to pay Rob Browne. When I’m ready to leave, they’re still in the bedroom. I knock and open the door a crack to see Carlie sobbing in Zahra’s arms. I give her a wave then leave to head back to Harrisville to pick up Cathie.

* * *

April 29

6.00am

When I arrive at Rob’s house, his son, Trystan, is sitting outside on the veranda smoking a cigarette. When I reach the front door, he stands and extends his hand. “You’re Eli Cole?” I nod and follow him inside. “I saw you here yesterday. One not enough for you?” He laughs as he leads me downstairs to the cellar where I first saw Carlie.

I give him a fake laugh and continue down the stairs. This kid is going to follow in his father’s footsteps if we don’t stop him.

On one side, the cellar—or playroom as Rob Browne calls it—is made up to look like a lavish bedroom any little girl would dream of. A pink four post bed stands against the wall and is covered in pink lace that matches the pillows and blankets. On the end of the bed, sits a doll in a white dress.

It seems relatively normal until you notice the glass wall that splits the room in two.

This side, where I stand, is more like an interrogation room. A single metal table sits in the centre of the room, and in front of it, a large white circle is painted on the floor, with a smaller one painted on the wall. In each corner, surveillance cameras are set up.

On a small steel framed bed is a little girl—it's Cathie. She's asleep.

Rob Browne stands from his chair and greets me. I need to get something out of him.

"Take a seat," he says.

I sit opposite him and slide my briefcase across the table. Behind him, Trystan stands picking at his fingernails.

Rob flicks through the wads of notes in the briefcase before stacking them in a pile on the table, and telling Trystan to put them in the safe.

"She's working well?" he asks me.

I nod. "Like I said, perfect. The young one asleep?" I ask with a nod toward Cathie.

Rob laughs. "Nope. Drugged her up. The brat's a screamer. She'll be nice and docile for you when she wakes up."

Bile rises in my throat, and like every other time, I swallow it down and play along. "She's like her sister then?"

Rob leans back and crosses one leg over his knee. "Not at all. Must be her father's personality shining through." He pours himself a glass of rum and offers me one. I nod as he continues, "Carlie's perfect, she's like me. People pleaser. That's my business, mate. Pleasing the people."

"Cathie's father know about this?"

He huffs, then shrugs. "No idea. The wife took off not long after she revealed the truth. Fucking women. That whore would spread her legs for anyone." He takes a mouthful of rum. "It's why I like 'em young. Easy to train."

Another fake laugh while I imagine putting a bullet through Rob Browne's head. "Got that right, mate. So... drop off at six tomorrow?"

Rob nods. "Trystan will be waiting. I've got some business to take care of in Edgewater."

Edgewater! Edgewater prison. "No worries." I turn my attention to Trystan. "So, I'll see you tomorrow."

He shrugs. "Whatever, man. I'll be here. Still can't believe you want the brat."

Rob closes his eyes for a fraction of a second before he stands and turns to Trystan. "Shut your fucking mouth, son, or I'll shut it for you."

Trystan nods once, then heads back up the stairs.

"Him and Cathie don't get along. He can't stand her. Can't say I blame him."

I take the last mouthful of rum and stand to extend my hand to Rob. When we shake, he winks at me. "I'll carry her up to the car for you."

Rob scoops Cathie into his arms and her head lolls to the side as her blonde curls spill over his arm. Around her neck, there's an impression of a handprint bruised into her pale flesh. The poor kid has no idea where she is, or where she's going. And she's not in a good way.

When I'm on the road again, I give a Zahra a call to let her know I'm on my way back, then I tuck my phone into my pocket and drive. I've got them.

Now, I need to get them to safety.

I walk with gentle feet
Always on the verge of tears
Disenchanted by this world
Crippled by my fears

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CARLIE**April 29***9.00am*

Zahra is so pretty. She has a nice smile and kind eyes. Other than my mother, I haven't seen many women, but I remember one of them. She was kind as well. I was five years old, and she was walking past our house and let me pat her puppy. Its fur was so soft, and its little tongue left wet patches on my hand. She told me the puppy's name was Maxie and that he loved kids. I never saw her again.

When Zahra came in, she handed me a robe and asked me if I was still sad about my mum. I cried and told her I missed her, and that I didn't believe she was dead like Eli had said, but that my memories were telling me it was all true. Zahra said Eli wouldn't lie to me.

When she hugged me, I felt some of my pain and sadness drift away. She didn't talk for a long time, just held me while I cried and somehow, that was all I needed.

While I sit on the bed, Zahra goes to the large chest of drawers and sorts through it for a few minutes. She holds up a white sweater. "You can wear this," she says. "It's a little chilly outside."

I nod and peel off the robe so I can get changed.

Zahra stares at me. "Carlie, honey, do you eat much?"

I shake my head. "Father says they—ah, um... they like small girls."

"Hmm," Zahra comes closer and tells me to turn around. "What happened to your back?" she asks.

"I was punished. Father used the chain. He gets angry if I'm returned early, or if a man refuses to purchase me."

Zahra wipes her eyes with the back of her hand. "Put this on. I'll get you some pants." She goes through the drawer again and this time holds up a pair of black sweat pants.

"I've never worn pants," I admit.

Holding them out, she says, "That's okay, you're allowed to wear them now."

I sit on the bed to pull them onto my legs. It's strange having something covering my legs. When I stand to pull them up, Zahra points to my thighs. "You did those yourself?"

I nod. "I thought they..."

"You thought they wouldn't touch you if you were bleeding?"

I nod again as I tug the pants up. Zahra seems to understand me, and I trust her, but I'm still afraid.

In silence, I help Zahra fold the sheets and blankets, and tidy the room. She leads me to the kitchen where the fire is glowing, and it's cosy and warm.

"Tell me about yourself, Carlie. What do you like to do?"

I shrug. "I'm not allowed to do anything. Except reading and writing, I do that a lot. I teach my little sister to read and write as well. And I have a journal."

"Is your journal here?" she asks.

I drop my gaze, nervous and worried I might be punished. Zahra reaches out and places her hand over mine. "Carlie, it's okay. You can tell me."

"It's in the bedroom, under the mattress. Please don't tell Eli, I don't want to be punished. Were you punished when you were a child?"

Zahra shakes her head and her gaze drops to the floor. For a fleeting moment I wonder if she's sad.

"Carlie, what your father did to you, it's not right. You believe in your heart he loves you, but that's not love. When you love someone, you don't hurt them. You don't whip them or beat them with chains. Would you do those things to your sister?"

I shake my head hard. "Never, I would never hurt Cathie. No, not at all." Tears well in my eyes. I will always protect Cathie.

Zahra rubs my arm then asks me to get my journal.

When I come back into the kitchen, I hand it to her, and she flicks through the pages and sighs. "When did you start this?"

"That one is new, but my old ones I started when I was eight."

"And you write about all the men—"

I shake my head. "Only some of them. Sometimes I write about Cathie and Trystan, and sometimes I write about my mum and dad. I wrote some poems too but they're not good."

"Carlie, if I show you a picture of a man, would you know if you've seen him before?"

I nod. "I know all of them. All the things I don't want to remember are stuck in my head. I want them all to disappear. I wish I could remember my mum more." I sigh and twist my fingers together.

Zahra takes a piece of paper from a folder and shows me a photograph of a man.

"That's Randy. My father's friend."

Zahra's eyes grow wide and she gasps. "You're sure?"

"Yes. Randy purchased me three times. He took me to a motel in Southport, it was called The Retreat. He told the lady at the desk I was his daughter. We stayed in room number twelve."

"And you've seen him at your house?"

"Yes. He used to come once a week. Every Tuesday at three in the afternoon. I haven't seen him for four weeks." I point to another picture in her folder. "That's our neighbour, Leroy, he used to come to our house to use me in the playroom. I haven't seen him for six months."

Zahra sighs and closes the folder. She leans forward to take my hands in hers. "Carlie, Eli and I are going to help you and Cathie start a brand new life. You won't have to do anything you don't want to do anymore. You'll be safe and free from your father—from all those men."

Tears spill down my cheeks and land on my arms. I watch them drip away as I look at Zahra. I want to believe her, but I'm afraid my father will be angry. I'm afraid I'll miss him too much and will want to go home.

When a car pulls up in the driveway, I panic.

Zahra jumps to her feet. "It's okay. It's Eli, you're safe here."

Eli opens the door and in his arms is my little sister, Cathie. She must have fallen asleep in the van. I rush over and run my hand over her thin, silky blonde curls. "Cathie, Cathie are you okay?"

Eli lays her on the sofa, and Zahra covers her with a thick blanket.

"Did she fall asleep? Or did Father give her the drugs?" I ask Eli.

He sounds angry. His forehead creases when he speaks, "She was unconscious when I picked her up. Your father drugged her but assured me

she'd wake up shortly."

"Four hours," I tell Eli. "It lasts four hours. He always makes Cathie have the drugs because she screams when she has to leave."

Eli rubs his hands over his face. "We're leaving at ten," he says to Zahra. "You hungry, Carlie?" he asks.

I nod. "A little. Can you make something for Cathie too? I think she will be hungry when she wakes up."

I follow Eli back to the kitchen and sit at the table to watch him make toasted sandwiches. He puts some apples in a black backpack, then wraps the leftover cupcakes and puts them in too.

While I eat the sandwich, Eli tells me what's going to happen when we leave. "We're heading to a town called Rockburn Grove. I know some people there who will be able to help you and Cathie get back on your feet. You'll be safe there."

"Will you and Zahra be there?"

Eli sighs, and Zahra looks at him over the back of the sofa. "No, Carlie. Remember what I told you about my job?"

"You're going to help other girls, like me."

"I am. But I'll come visit you to see how you are."

"I'm..." I put the sandwich down, no longer hungry, and wrap my arms around myself. Something presses on my chest, a pain that won't go away no matter how many deep breaths I take. I swallow the lump in my throat and choke back tears. My body is telling me to run again, but I don't want to. I want to stay right here where it's warm and safe. I want to stay with Zahra and Eli.

"You're afraid," Eli says. "That's okay. I can promise you, you'll be safe in this new town."

I close my eyes and the tears trickle down my cheeks. I don't want to move, I don't know what to do. I can't run away, not while Cathie is sleeping. Instead, I run to the bedroom and throw myself on the bed to cry into the pillow. Everything is confusing me.

My heart is being crushed in my chest and the memories are back, flickering images of blood-soaked clothes and my mother's face, crying while she begs my father not to kill her.

"Leave me alone!" I scream at the memories, but it's no use. They continue spiralling out of control until my body is weak and my throat is

raw.

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And still you try
To make them see
That sometimes even angels
Can't set your demons free

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ZAHRA**April 29**

9.55am

Eli rushes around the kitchen packing food and preparing backpacks full of clothes for the girls. This is the part he finds difficult. Moving onto the next task. Letting them go again, releasing them into a world that's let them down. A world that doesn't understand the horrific abuse people inflict upon their own children.

Carlie sits on the chair watching him, her eyes—still red from crying—follow his every move. After twenty-four hours, she's already formed an unhealthy attachment. It's to be expected and happens almost every time. The children we come across have never known kindness, compassion, or even love. They've lived sheltered lives, but at the same time have been forced to grow up far too quickly. Their minds and bodies have to play catch up. The scars, both physical and mental, will last for eternity. That's the part I know all too well.

In a way, I was one of the lucky ones. My mind was strong, and even when my body was pushed to the brink of death, I endured the pain because I had to survive.

Seeing Carlie brings back so many memories, most I've locked away, but sometimes when I see girls like this, I remember the little girl they called Twenty-Seven.

*Zahra**9 years old*

"Twenty-Seven." His rough voice sends shivers down my spine. I don't want to be a number. I want to keep my own name. My real name. I want to be

Zahra, but he reminds me I'm not that little girl anymore. I want to cry too, but the last time I cried, I got punished.

I take three little steps forward and stop in front of the huge man with a bald head. He tells me to call him Daddy. But he's not my daddy. He's not anyone I have ever seen before. He's a big scary monster now. Not like he was when I saw him at the playground.

There, he was smiling, and he had a little puppy too. Mummy was at the house next door to the playground visiting her friend Ronnie. When the man asked me if I wanted a lolly, I said yes. He said if I went to his house for a little while, he would let me play with all his puppies, and have even more lollies. He said at ten o'clock he would take me home.

"Take your clothes off, precious," he tells me.

I shake my head. Every time I say no, I get into trouble, but my mouth keeps saying it. The man slaps me across my face, and I fly backwards until I land on the cold concrete floor. I scream. I cry. I beg him to let me go home. I even tell him that it's been past ten o'clock for a long time.

He ignores me and rips off my dress and underwear. When he pushes me down on the dirty bed that has yucky stains all over it, his voice gets scary. "Now I'm gonna fuck you little whore."

I don't know what that means, but I scream and try to get away. After a little while I fall asleep.

18 months later

I'm standing on the red cross on the floor. My hands are shaking because it's so cold, and my head is really sore.

"Twenty-Seven, my precious little princess. Come and show me what you've learned." When the man tells me what to do now, I always do it. I don't like it when he hurts me. I think if I behave and do what I'm told, he will let me go home. But when other men come to the house, and I have to stand in the middle of the room while they shout out lots of numbers, I feel sick in my tummy and I fall down to my knees.

I keep doing the same things all the time.

Walk into the room.

Stand on the red cross.

Smile for the bad men.

So many times, the men take me into the bedrooms and do bad things to me. They touch me all over my body and make me cry and scream, and sometimes I bleed a lot.

One day, I wanted to be brave and run away, but the man I have to call Daddy, caught me. He whipped me with a long black belt. But I wasn't scared anymore, and I tried to run away again and again until a big man with dark brown eyes came to the house.

He paid lots of money for me and took me to another house. But he didn't hurt me at all.

The man said his name was Callum, and he was taking me to a place called Hearts of Innocence where my mum and dad were waiting for me. I was scared I would get into big trouble for going away with the man, and I cried a lot in the car.

When I saw my mummy, I fell into her arms and cried because I missed her so, so much. But when I saw my daddy, I was scared of him, but I didn't know why. I wanted to hug him and tell him that I was sorry for letting the man take me away. And for being so silly and not remembering the rules I'd been told about talking to strangers.

I wanted my daddy. But I didn't want him to touch me.

For a long time after I went home, a lady came to our house every single day to talk to me about the bad men. I didn't like it, but one day I started to feel better and I finally hugged my daddy.

Five years later

The men who hurt me when I was a little girl have been caught. They went to prison, and my dad even said that one of them got killed in there. He said they all need a bullet in their head. Dad told me it means they should be shot and killed with a gun. Sometimes, I get scared that some of the other men might come back and take me again. When that happens, Mum and Dad hug me and remind me how brave I was. Those men can't hurt me anymore.

On the sofa beside me, Cathie stirs. Her eyes, sunken and grey, flicker open before closing again. Every breath she takes is shallow, and

when I give her a little shake, saliva dribbles from the corner of her mouth. Whatever drugs she's been given, have knocked her out and she's in dire need of medical attention.

"Carlie," I whisper over my shoulder. "Come and sit with Cathie a minute."

Carlie paces across the kitchen floor to the living area. She looks down at her little sister and a tiny smile creeps across her lips. I try to hide my frown. This little girl doesn't have long to live.

A wave of emotion rolls over me as I head into the kitchen to help Eli pack the bags.

"She's tiny," he says. "And she's not in a good way. I don't—" he lowers his voice to a whisper. "I don't think she'll make it."

I rub my hand on his shoulder. "She's made it this far, but we need to get to the hospital, ASAP." Eli nods. "She'll be okay." I'm lying to myself. Cathie is the size of a typical eight-year-old. Her skin is thin and pale, and like Carlie's, is littered with scars and bruises, although no care has been taken to keep Cathie's face clean and flawless.

Eli goes to the front window and peers out through the curtains. "What the hell?"

I stand beside him, watching the white ute speed along the gravel driveway toward the cabin. "Who's that?"

He rubs his head. "Their father," he murmurs under his breath. "We need to do something."

Shit! This isn't good, and it means only one thing—Eli was followed back for a reason. "You think he knows?" I ask.

Eli and I both turn to the girls. "Carlie," Eli says, "does your father ever check up on you when you're with the men?"

Her face turns ashen and her eyes widen. "Oh no. Eli, father is—"

My adrenaline kicks in, he's here to take them back. "Is what?" I ask.

She stands and pulls the sleeves of the sweater over her hands and crosses her arms around herself. Her expression is blank. "He's going to kill you."

Eli rushes into the bedroom and comes back with his gun as I take mine from my bag. "Take the girls into the cellar," he says.

"No," Carlie shouts. "Please... not the cellar."

The ute pulls up in the driveway and their father gets out.

I grab Carlie's arm. "Carlie, we need to hide, right now. Do you understand?"

She nods, but when she sees her father out the window, she freezes. The life drains from her face. "Daddy... Dad—no." Carlie's breathing becomes heavier as I rush over and scoop Cathie into my arms. She doesn't flinch. Her eyelids flicker open and her eyes roll back. She's so close to death she may not make it through the next few hours, let alone the trip to Rockburn Grove.

Carlie follows me through to the bedroom and I lay Cathie on the bed, then lock the door behind us. "No matter what you hear, don't make a sound."

I pull back the rug to reveal the trap door that leads to the cellar below the cabin. I whisper, "Go down there, I'll be right behind you."

I pull Cathie into my arms and make my way down the stairs. As I lean down to pass her to Carlie, shouting erupts from the kitchen.

"Shhh," I remind her. "Listen to me... do not come out." Without another word, I head back up the stairs, close the trap door, and pull the carpet back in place.

"Where are they?" the male voice growls.

"Not here. They're down by the river, my wife showed up," Eli lies.

I take a deep breath and when I exhale, I remember what we are here for. We must protect these girls. I open the bedroom door and smile as I enter the living room and walk over to where Eli stands in the kitchen. My heart is racing furiously, but on the outside, I remain calm. "Honey, what's going on? I heard shouting."

Eli runs a hand through his hair and introduces me to Rob.

"Is there a problem?" I ask, giving Eli a kiss on the cheek.

"No, no problem, sweetheart. Rob was stopping by to say hello."

Rob nods and shoves a hand in his pocket, and with his other hand, scratches at the stubble on his chin. "Ah, yeah, I was. I'm going to take a walk down to the river. You don't mind do you, Eli?"

Eli shakes his head. "Of course not, mate. Not at all. We'll be here if you want to drop in before you leave."

Rob walks out the door and heads toward the path leading into the forest. Adrenaline kicks in and I race back to the cellar as Eli grabs his briefcase and the backpacks for the girls.

“We’ve got less than ten minutes,” he rushes out.

Carlie is sobbing as she holds Cathie in her arms. The little girl with her whole life ahead of her, is dead. A stain of deep red blood blooms from between her legs.

“I tried to wake her up,” Carlie cries. “She won’t wake up, she’s dead, isn’t she? It’s all my fault. I dreamed that she died, and I was happy.”

We’re running out of time. I press my fingers to Cathie’s neck waiting for a pulse. There’s nothing. Her pale skin is already turning an awful shade of mottled grey. “Carlie, we need to go,” I say urgently. When I take Cathie from her arms, she covers her face with her hands and cries. This couldn’t have happened at a worse time.

“Carlie, honey, we need to take Cathie to the hospital, right now.”

I wonder if this soul of mine
Can survive another day
So much pain and heartache
Comes from every way

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CARLIE

April 29*10.20am*

Zahra rushes me into the red SUV where my little sister, Cathie, lies on the back seat. She's cold now, and when I ask Zahra for a blanket, she goes around to the other side and lays one over Cathie's little body. When she's tucked it under Cathie's arms, I run my fingers through her soft blonde curls—she can't die. She will be okay. When the sleeping drugs wear off, she'll wake up. I know she will.

Eli gets in the SUV, and Zahra sits in the passenger seat beside him. They whisper quietly before a loud bang shatters the silence. The front windscreen cracks and tiny veins form in the glass.

When I snap my head up, I see him. My father. He shouts my name. Instantly, I grab the door handle and try to get out, terrified he will hurt Eli and Zahra.

The door doesn't open. "Let me out," I scream, tugging on the door handle. I bash my hands on the window. "Daddy!"

Eli takes off. The shiny red SUV slides on the gravel throwing me sideways. My head bangs against the window—I cry out in pain.

"Go, Eli, faster," Zahra shouts.

He speeds along the driveway until we swerve out onto the highway. The outside world flies past us in a blur of greens and blues. I turn around to look out the back window—my father is following us in his white ute.

"Let me go," I scream at Eli. He doesn't listen, so I scream again, hitting him and grabbing at his arm. He doesn't understand what my father is capable of. I want him to let me go so I can make my father happy. I can't let them be hurt because of me.

Zahra turns around and climbs between the front seats so she's sitting beside me. She pulls Cathie's head onto her lap, then grabs me around my

shoulders and holds me tight. I can barely breathe, and the more I struggle to get away from her, the harder she holds on.

I shake my head trying to get the image of my father's furious face out of my mind. The clock on the dashboard reads, 10.31am.

I clamp my eyes shut until I count to one hundred. When I open them, my body sags into Zahra's and she smooths her hand over my hair. "Shhh, it's okay. You're safe now." She presses a gentle kiss to my forehead and I remember my mother.

The memories come flooding back. Wave upon wave of fierce, unrelenting moments of terror. In an instant, I remember it all so clearly.

I was five years old. My mother was lying in a pool of blood. My father, standing over her with a hunting knife in his hand. My brother was laughing. "Daddy, you make a big mess. You kill all the bad girls, yeah Daddy," Trystan said, while I screamed.

In her bedroom, Cathie was screaming too. My father growled at me. "Shut that damn baby up." When I walked through my mother's blood, I slipped and fell to the floor. Blood covered my hands; the smell was so strong it made me vomit.

My father didn't care. "Go," he shouted.

I ran to Cathie and patted her little tummy while I begged her not to cry. With a glance back to my father, I saw him on his knees over my mother's body. He tore her clothes off and threw them in a pile on the floor. His back was to me, but I could see him moving, and I could see the blood... I could see Trystan watching him, pointing to the blood—to our mother. "Dead, dead, dead, Mummy. You be a bad girl you get dead," his voice, so soft and sweet didn't match the words pouring from his mouth.

That was the night we had the fire in the backyard.

"You toasted fucking marshmallows over your mother's burning body." Trystan's words slam into me causing me to suck in a breath of air.

The car is hit from behind pulling me back into reality. We're jolted forward, and I slam into the back of the front seat. Eli swerves across the road into oncoming traffic. Zahra screams. Cathie rolls onto the floor, so I reach down to grab her hand. I catch a glimpse of the bruised handprint

over her throat. The same handprint I've had on my own throat so many times.

As Eli straightens the car, my father's white ute comes up alongside us. "Get down," Eli's voice shouts over the sound of metal scraping on metal.

There's an ear-piercing scream as Zahra pushes my head down onto her lap.

Bang.

Crack.

Glass showers over me.

Through the screaming Eli calls Zahra's name. He swerves again. Another bang. Another window broken. Something warm and wet drips down my cheek and I raise my hand to wipe it away.

Time stands still for a fleeting moment before it speeds up again. With a glance out the window, I catch a glimpse of the outside world still whizzing by us. Eli is driving so fast that my tummy twists and turns.

"Zahra," Eli shouts again. "Zahra answer me!"

"Eli... I've been sho..." Her voice fades away.

Eli looks back. His eyes focus on Zahra first, then on me. "Carlie, don't move. Close your eyes tight, and hold on to Zahra."

The warm, wet drips land on my cheek again. Zahra's crying. *It's my fault.* I don't bother wiping the drips away. I wrap my arms around Zahra's legs and squeeze my eyes shut.

Bang.

Bang.

Bang.

Tyres screech. Horns are blaring in the distance. We spin, and the dizziness in my stomach rises to my throat. I have to force the bile back down as I grit my teeth together. A car slams into us. The sound is like nothing I've heard before.

Still, I don't let go of Zahra. I cling to her as though my life depends on it, counting the seconds as they pass. When I reach six hundred and forty, I inhale, then I exhale slowly. The SUV is still moving, and I'm still holding onto Zahra.

Finally, I peek through one eye to look at the clock on the dash.

11.27am *Why is the time going by so fast? Did I fall asleep?*

“Zahra, talk to me,” Eli says.

Zahra’s voice is barely a whisper, “... kay,” She mumbles something I can’t understand, “Tell... stone... tried. Sorry.”

Eli shouts at her, he sounds angry, and I don’t know why. “Zahra, don’t you dare di—You hold on! We’re almost there.”

The car comes to a halt and the doors open with a creaking sound. “Get her out first,” someone shouts.

“I’ll take this one... I think—It’s too late,” someone else says.

Strong, rough hands grab my waist. I panic. “Zahra, no. Don’t let them take me,” I beg, I plead, and I promise I’ll do anything she says. She doesn’t reply.

Eli’s voice breaks through the screams. It’s only then I realise they’re coming from my own mouth.

“Let me get her,” he says. His hand touches my shoulder. His voice is low and soft. “Carlie, come on, sweetheart. The doctors need to take Zahra now.” My eyes flicker open and I stare down at the floor of the car where my little sister was. She’s gone. All that’s left is the bundled up white blanket Zahra had laid over her.

“Cathie,” I scream.

The begging, the crying, the screaming... none of it works—no one listens. Not even Eli. Something sharp is stuck into my arm. I beg them again, but to no avail. Before my eyes close and dizziness takes me away, I look at the clock one more time.

11.41am

I'd take the stars and crumble them
Then scatter them like sand
And I'd break down heaven's gates
For one more chance to hold your hand

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12

Aftermath

ELI

April 29

Cathie didn't make it. Her tiny body had given up long before I found her. In a way, she's finally found peace. No longer used and abused, no longer suffering in this cruel, unforgiving world. The doctors told me an autopsy would be carried out immediately to ascertain the cause of death. I can only assume it will be due to whatever drugs her bastard father pumped into her.

Zahra is in intensive care. The bullet tore through her shoulder, but she will survive.

Me? I'm fine for the most part. One bullet grazed my arm, another hit the window and showered me in glass. A few scratches and bruises, nothing I can't handle.

As for Rob Browne, I have no idea if he's dead or alive. His ute spun off the road and rolled down an embankment. I didn't stop, I couldn't. Getting Carlie as far away from him as possible, and getting Zahra to the hospital were my priorities.

Now, she's under sedation. When she wakes, I will have to tell her about her sister, and when she's released, we'll continue to Rockburn Grove where she'll be given a place to stay at a local shelter for young women and children.

I've been sitting, pacing, and drinking vending machine coffee for hours, and finally, at 6pm, a doctor calls me in and tells me Zahra is awake, and that I can go in and see her. I follow him along the corridor and into her room. She's propped up on a pillow. Her entire left arm is bandaged and wrapped in a shoulder brace. She's groggy, but she smiles slightly and reaches out to me.

I lean down and kiss her. "Hey you. You're awake. How's the pain?"

“Hmm... drugs are good.” She drops her head back onto the pillow. “Carlie,” she murmurs, “she’s okay?”

I take Zahra’s hand and rub it between mine. “They had to sedate her. She’s sleeping now.” I let out a heavy sigh. “Everything’s okay?” I ask her.

She nods. “It’s all safe for the—You... You need to go. Take her to Rock...” she trails off as her eyes close. “Stone... I called him yess... aday.” She’s asleep again so I get up, kiss her forehead, and leave the room to let her rest.

As I’m closing the door, a doctor stops me. “Ah, Mr Cole, there you are. We have a young lady asking to see you.”

Another walk down a long corridor and I arrive at the Children’s Ward where bright coloured curtains divide the six beds. A little girl smiles and waves as I walk in. Her red curls bounce on top of her head as she bounces on the bed beside a nurse who’s refilling a drip bag.

In the last bed beside the window, is Carlie. She’s wearing a green polka dot hospital gown and is propped up on three large pillows with a blanket covering her legs. In her arm is a thin tube connected to a drip. On the tray in front of her is a plate of untouched sandwiches, and a plastic cup of orange juice.

“You’re awake,” I say.

She stares... seemingly into nothing. “Where’s my sister?”

I sit on the edge of the bed beside her. “Carlie...” I put my hand over hers, but she pulls away. “The doctors did all they could... but—” Guilt eats away at me. If I’d got her when I picked up Carlie, like I’d originally planned to, she would still be alive. I swallow hard. “She—”

“I know she’s dead.” Carlie turns to me; a vacant stare is all I get back. Her mouth moves, but the words don’t make any sense at all. “Shadow told her to fight. I was wrong, she should have listened. That’s why Shadow hated me. She knew this would happen.” She blinks; tears roll down her cheeks. “Why didn’t she listen?”

“Carlie, who’s Shadow?” I ask confused.

She shakes her head and brings her finger to her lips. “Shhh... she’ll find me.”

A doctor walks in, pulls Carlie’s file from the end of the bed, and puts a hand on my shoulder. “May I have a word with you, Mr Cole?”

I tell Carlie I'll be right back, but she doesn't respond, so I leave with the doctor. We sit in the small office and he lets out a heavy sigh.

"She's not good?" I ask.

He shakes his head. "She's not making much sense right now. I'd say most of that is because of shock. But her scars—the bruises. She has a fractured wrist and some nasty bruising on her back. I would expect her to be in a lot of pain. What happened to this girl?"

I explain the story and I tell him how the girls were beaten and abused and sold as sex slaves by their father. I explain how on the day I went to collect Carlie, she looked like a walking zombie, covered in scars and bruises, filthy, and naked.

His eyes well with tears. "Why?"

"I don't have the answers. All I know is, she's free from the physical pain, but psychologically, she will never fully recover."

"She refuses to eat," the doctor says. "Thankfully, we put the drip in while she was sedated."

"How long until she's strong enough to leave?" I ask, knowing we need to keep moving.

The doctor scrubs his hands down his face. "Where will you go?"

"I can't tell you. All I can say is that she will be cared for. There are full-time doctors and nurses on call, and the best psychiatrists and therapists will be available. Our contacts provide the best care for these girls." I hand him my card, and he sighs.

"She needs treatment. She's malnourished and underweight, severely dehydrated, and the fracture needs to be taken care of. I'd like her to remain at least overnight, if not a little longer."

I sigh. "Okay, we can work with that. I just don't want her here... in this town for too long."

"I understand. Ah, Mr Cole, we did some scans."

"And?" *She cannot be pregnant.* Please don't let her be pregnant. I've seen it before. Little girls as young as twelve, pregnant and in constant, excruciating pain. Others having miscarriages or needing terminations because of the severe trauma they've endured.

"She has an IUD. It..." He hesitates, then lowers his voice. "It's not positioned correctly, and I would suggest removing it before it causes any permanent damage. If it hasn't already."

Fuck! That bastard Rob Browne covered all his bases.

She's still a child, and I'm the one responsible for her. *I* have to choose what happens next. The trauma she would face having this procedure done without being put to sleep, weighs heavily on my mind, but it *needs* to be done.

I swallow hard and lean forward with my elbows resting on my knees. "Can it be done under sedation? I don't think she'll cope without it."

He nods once. "Yes, of course. Due to the position I was going to suggest that. I'll get the paperwork ready for you to sign."

"Thank you," I say before shaking his hand then making my way back to Carlie's room where I find her sleeping.

For an hour, I sit and watch her sleep.

"Eli..." she whispers.

"I'm here. How are you feeling?"

She shrugs. "My arm is sore, and my head. My stomach—everything hurts..." She drops her head and cries. "I want to go home now. I miss my dad—my father."

I pull the chair closer to her bed and take her hand. "Carlie, you can't go home. It's not safe for you there anymore. You're seventeen, you're supposed to be living. You should be having fun and making friends, not having—" I hesitate. "It's time for you to live now. To be free."

"Cathie is dead. It's all my fault."

"I'm sorry I couldn't save her too, but this isn't your fault. You didn't hurt her, your father did." I place my hand over hers, this time she doesn't move. "Do you want to talk about her?"

"She was just a little girl." She sobs. "Trystan lied to me. He said he wouldn't use Cathie, but he did. He forced her to—" She chokes on the words as she speaks. "He said she loved it."

I stand and hug her, rubbing her back while she cries against my chest. "I wish I was dead too."

"I don't, Carlie. You deserve to live. You're a strong, courageous and beautiful girl. What your father was doing to you was wrong. Do you understand that?"

She nods, then rolls to her side so her back is to me. "I understand."

After a few minutes of silence, the doctor returns with the paperwork. He explains to Carlie that they'll be putting her to sleep to do some more

scans, and to check she doesn't have any other broken bones. His decision not to tell her what they are doing feels completely wrong. Morally, and ethically.

But to let her know that a male will be putting her to sleep to perform an internal examination, would only cause more trauma. From my years of experience, this is the best way for her to be able to move forward.

Carlie doesn't ask any questions, and when I ask her again if she's sure she's okay with being put to sleep, she says, "Our doctor always put me to sleep when he wanted to do things to me. I'll be okay."

Asshole! I need to find out who this doctor is.

As Carlie is wheeled out of the room, I lean back in the chair and pull out my wallet.

Inside is a photograph of the little girl who made me what I am today. Her smile, her laugh, her complete and unconditional love for everyone is what drives me to save these girls. I trace my finger over the photograph and imagine stroking her soft brown hair one more time.

With a heavy sigh, I close my wallet and shove it back into my pocket. The only things I have left now are memories. Memories of the little girl I couldn't save. The little girl I watched enter this world on a cold Monday morning in the middle of April. The little girl I would find dead three days before her eighth birthday.

My daughter.

My own Carlie.

Eli

20 years earlier

Carlie had been missing for almost nine months, but I wasn't giving up hope. There was not a moment I feared she would be found dead. She was alive, and I was going to find her. My wife, Heather, was distraught. She was with Carlie the day she disappeared without a trace from the local shopping mall. At first, we wrongly assumed her disappearance had something to do with a case I was working on.

A week after Carlie was taken, we received a ransom note telling us to meet an unnamed male at a warehouse an hour away. We were assured our daughter would be returned to us, unharmed. Heather and I arrived

unarmed as requested. I didn't breathe a word of it to my colleagues at the station.

The male never showed.

Three days before Carlie's eighth birthday, I received a call from my Chief, Callum Brady.

A young girl matching Carlie's description had been found dead behind the same disused warehouse Heather and I had gone to almost nine months earlier.

The image of her pale grey face and matted brown hair was, in that moment, scarred into my mind. I spiralled out of control, desperately trying to make sense of what had happened. Where had I gone wrong? Why Carlie? I had so many questions and no answers.

On what would have been our daughter's eighth birthday, Heather—consumed with grief—killed herself. I had nothing left. My family had been obliterated, and I was alone.

But I refused to give up.

One year later, our team busted one of the largest child sex trafficking rings the country had ever seen. When the evidence was brought into the station, I saw the horrific magnitude of abuse human beings were capable of. When I sorted through the images and found my own daughter's terrified eyes staring back at me, I knew I needed to make it my life's work to put an end to anyone who dared believe they could get away with such abhorrent crimes.

Two hours later, Carlie is wheeled back into the room. She's awake, but still a little groggy. While the nurse sets up the drip and gets Carlie comfortable again, the doctor leads me to his office down the hall. He slumps into his chair and crosses his arms over his chest. "I've seen some pretty rough things in my thirty years." He shakes his head. "Rape, murder, suicide. But this..."

"She's not good?" Worry weaves through my chest causing me to inhale and hold my breath momentarily.

"You're sure she's seventeen?"

I nod. "Positive. What's wrong with her? And can it be fixed?"

He opens a folder and looks down at the page in his hand. "There are signs of trauma, including lacerations, severe bruising, and scar tissue and

unhealed wounds in and around the genital area.” He slides the folder across the desk to me. “Her inner thighs have been cut many times, possibly due to self-harm... I can’t be certain, but there are similar scars on her arms and torso.”

I flick through the pages then pass it back. I already know what monsters like Rob Browne are capable of. “But she’s going to be okay? You got it out?”

A nod. “Yes. The IUD was removed successfully. There will be some blood loss for a few days, but I’ve got one of my best nurses talking to her now. She’ll also require an oral contraceptive since it’s unclear when she last had—” He doesn’t say the last word.

“Thank you for doing this. I appreciate it.”

“Ah, Mr Cole, you will find the father... and—”

I cut him off. “Yes. We will find him, and he will pay for what he’s done.”

“If it’s not too much trouble, would you let me know how she gets on? Just a call to say she’s okay.” His eyes well with tears. “She... she’s the same age as my daughter. I can’t—Why?” he asks for the second time today.

“Of course I will. And why? I wish I knew.”

They call me pretty
But I don't see
They tell me to stay
But I want to leave

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CARLIE**April 29***10.20pm*

The bed is soft, but unfamiliar, and the blanket is heavy and warm. I'm uncomfortable and when I try to move, my arms and legs ache.

I trace my finger along the edge of the tray that sits over my legs. On top of it is a white plate stacked with sandwiches. I'm hungry and my tummy rumbles, but I don't want to eat. The thought of putting something in my mouth makes me dizzy.

In my arm is a long needle attached to a clear, thin tube that looks like a straw. It's connected to a bag hanging from a steel pole beside my bed. Every few minutes a rush of cold spreads through my veins causing me to shiver.

Outside, plumes of white clouds hover in the sky. Tiny black specks appear in the distance, as they come closer, I see the wings—blackbirds.

Eli sits beside my bed on a big grey recliner. His face is covered in lots of small cuts that weren't there before. He told me Cathie died. She wasn't strong enough to survive all the pain and suffering my father put her through. He said she must have tried so hard to wait for me; to see me one last time.

But she didn't see me. She didn't open her eyes. She didn't beg me to run away. I'll never see her again, and I'll never get to call her jellybean again. I miss her.

I miss my father, and I miss my brother.

"Carlie, will you eat something?" Eli asks.

"I'm not hungry."

He leans back in the recliner and closes his eyes.

When I close my own eyes, I imagine I'm back home in my bedroom with Cathie sitting on my bed beside me eating a chocolate bar. Then I imagine I'm back in the safety of the cellar where the white spot on the wall

reminds me, I'm alive, and gives me something to focus on while the pain rushes through my body.

Carlie

14 years old

After exactly sixty-three minutes of training with my father, my whole body is sore, and my head is spinning. Father says the drugs he gives me will help with the pain and make me relax so it doesn't hurt so much, but all they do is make me feel sick and dizzy.

Back in my bathroom, I run a warm bath and sink down into the water and cry. Everything feels wrong. I have to protect my little sister, but I can no longer find the strength to keep myself alive.

I reach down between the bathtub and the small cupboard where I find my little packet of razors. I stole them from my brother's bedroom one day while he was out with my father.

The first cut isn't deep, but as the blood seeps to the surface, I watch it in awe. Inside, I am alive. I do bleed, and I can feel pain. I drag the razor across my flesh again, deeper this time. Warm blood trickles down my arm and drips into the bath water floating away into pinkish red swirls.

Another cut, another perfect, thin line of blood. I can't stop. I need to see the life inside me.

Red lines. The thought forces its way into my mind and sticks. Red lines. I need more red lines. Why?

I shake my head hard. I don't know why, all I know is... the red lines that appear on my flesh give me a reason to keep going.

My hands are covered in blood, and when I make the fourth cut in my forearm; it's too deep.

I shut my eyes and take a deep breath before exhaling slowly. Dizziness takes hold, and when I slip back and hit my head on the end of the bathtub, I know I'm going to be in serious trouble. With that thought in mind, I plunge my arm into the water, but at the same time my eyes grow heavy, and the light fades away.

When my eyes open, a bright white light shines above me. Instantly, I panic. "Daddy!" I cry out.

A hand touches my arm, then his voice. "Daddy's here, baby, can you sit up?"

I try to push myself up, but my arm is sore, and it hurts to move it.

Finally, I sit up a little and lean back on the pillow. "Where am I?"

"Hospital, we're leaving shortly. Jeff's going to look after you at home."

Home? Hospital? I remember the razor. I will be punished. Tears fall from my eyes as a lady in a white shirt walks in. "Ah, good morning, Miss Browne. How are you feeling?"

I look at my father first, knowing I should never speak to anyone without his permission. He nods slightly. "It's okay, you can talk, honey." His voice sounds different. He sounds happy; I'm not sure why.

I turn back to the lady. "I'm good, thank you."

She comes closer. "How's your arm? Is it sore?"

I shake my head quickly. I want to go home. I don't like this place full of white walls, and white beds, and people wearing white shirts. "Can I go home now?"

She smiles. "You sure can. Just waiting on your dad to sign the paperwork." She tells my father he can leave the room to sign the papers, but when he leaves, I'm worried he won't come back.

"Can I come with you," I blurt out quickly.

"You stay there, honey. I'll be right back," he says.

When my father leaves, the lady lowers her voice. "Carlie, is there anything you want to tell me? Something you're worried about, or scared of?"

My head is screaming at me to tell her about the men, and how they all have sex with me, and do things to my body that I still don't understand, and that sometimes, it hurts so much I think I am broken inside. Instead, I whisper, "No."

"You sure, darling? You can tell me anything, there's nothing to be afraid of here."

I nod. "I'm okay. I want to go home."

"What school do you go to, Carlie?"

I open my mouth to speak but close it quickly when my father returns with Jeff beside him. Jeff narrows his eyes at the nurse "She's home-schooled. Mr Browne wrote that on her admission form. Remember?"

The nurse drops her head slightly and apologises. “Doctor Northmandy, I’m sorry. I must have missed it.”

“Hmm... thankfully we’re leaving now. “My father’s angry voice is back, and the nurse apologises again and walks away.

Jeff locks the door, then comes to the side of the bed. He puts his stethoscope down the front of the pink hospital gown I’m wearing. It’s cold against my skin, and when his fingers brush across my breast, he murmurs, “Such a good little girl. You remembered all the rules, and that...” His fingers circle around my nipple; he pinches it hard causing me to suck in a breath. “That is why you’ll always be my favourite girl.”

I swallow hard and nod slightly as Jeff steps back and my father pats him on the shoulder. “She’s good to go then?”

Jeff nods. “She’s perfect. I’ll see you tonight.” He laughs and rubs the front of his pants. “I need a release.”

My father laughs with him while I drop my head and cry. I should have said something. I should have been brave.

All I have now, are memories of my father. Memories of the men who told me they loved me—the men who said I was special.

I’m left with nothing else. I am empty.

No one else ever said they loved me.

Now, I am unloved.

* * *

April 30

Eli’s voice draws me from my sleep. “Carlie, you need to wake up now.”

My eyes flicker open, the room is bright, and the sunshine glares through the floor to ceiling window. When I lift my arm, the needle and the thin tube are gone. I run my fingers over the back of my hand where there’s a tiny hole, and a grey bruise blushing beneath my skin.

“You’re going to get some plaster on that arm today,” Eli says.

“Plaster?” I question. “Today? Did I sleep for a long time?” I glance at the clock on the wall. It’s 6.10am.

“All night. Do you feel okay now?”

I shrug. "I'm okay."

Eli stands and rubs his hand over mine. "Carlie, your wrist is fractured. Has it been sore?"

I'm not sure if I'm supposed to tell him the truth. So far, he hasn't lied about anything, and he's been looking after me. "Yes. Since the day you picked me up. That's when Father—"

He cuts me off. "Your father did it?"

"I slipped up the stairs from the cellar, so he grabbed my hand and dragged me up."

"Why didn't you say something to me, or to Zahra?"

"Father said I was not to talk about it. He said you wouldn't pay if I was broken."

The doctor comes in with another lady I notice is a nurse. She has a big smile, and sounds kind, but I still miss Zahra. Eli said I can't see her until it's time to leave. He said Zahra has to stay in the hospital for another week because of the gunshot wound.

I wish my father didn't shoot her. I'm sure it's my fault.

It takes the nurse and the doctor exactly thirty-two minutes to put the plaster cast on my arm. It goes around my hand and up to my elbow. The nurse puts a sling over my head and ties it around my neck, when she's done, I'm allowed to stand up.

When Eli says I can visit Zahra, I smile. My cheeks feel different, and my mouth stretches. It's a strange, unfamiliar feeling that travels through my whole body and warms my heart from the inside.

Eli smiles too and extends his hand. "Ready to see her?"

Zahra is sitting in a hospital bed like I was, but she's not near a window, and she's not sharing a room with anyone. There are two police officers outside her door.

She has a thick blue sling on her arm—it's different to mine. It looks uncomfortable. When she sees me, she smiles. I'm not sure why, but tears drip from my eyes and dribble down my cheeks.

Zahra reaches out to me. "Carlie, honey, you have plaster."

I nod. "It's called a cast, and this is a sling." I tug on the thin white fabric.

She pats the bed beside her and asks me to sit. I look at Eli and hope he says it's okay. When he nods, I climb up beside Zahra. She rubs my back gently.

"Are you in a lot of pain?" I ask her.

She shakes her head. "No, I have some great medicine. The doctors here are wonderful. They're making sure I'm not in any pain. What about you?"

"My wrist is still sore. The doctor said it will get better in a couple of weeks. I had medicine in a needle that went into the back of my hand. It was called a drip."

Eli rubs Zahra's leg, and says, "Carlie, tell Zahra about the view from your room."

I tell Zahra about the birds I saw flying above the clouds, and how the sun shone through my window in the morning and warmed my face with its bright, white light. Then I tell her about the food, and that I didn't eat any of it because it made me feel sick and dizzy.

I spend a lot of time talking to Zahra, and when Eli leaves the room and goes for a walk, she says she has something important to tell me.

I listen intently. I love her voice, it brings a sense of calm I've never felt before.

"Carlie, when you get to Rockburn Grove, you'll be given a new name. It will protect you and help you start a new life. A life where you can be happy. You'll be able to go outside, you'll even get to make friends."

I swallow down the lump that's formed in my throat. "What if I forget my name?"

"Well, you can choose a name. Whatever name you want, something you will never, ever forget.

"Zahra," I say. "I want my new name to be Zahra."

She smiles, and a tear drops from her eye. "Carlie, you are a beautiful girl, and I promise you, one day soon I'm going to visit you in Rockburn Grove. When that day comes, I hope you'll be smiling and happy."

I lean over Zahra and wrap one arm around her neck to hug her. I clamp my eyes shut and commit the moment to my memory. I don't want to forget anything. Not the smell of Zahra's perfume, not her soft, dark hair, not her deep brown eyes. I take it all in and as I sob into her neck, Zahra rubs my back and promises she will visit me as soon as she can.

“Zahra, what if no one wants to be my friend? I don’t know how to —” I clamp my eyes shut and cry into Zahra’s shoulder as she strokes my hair.

“The people you’re going to see, they’re the most wonderful people I’ve ever met. They will help you find friends. They’ll show you how to talk to other boys and girls. You’re going to have a wonderful life, Carlie.”

“And you’ll come and visit me... one day?”

“Yes,” she assures me.

When it’s time to say goodbye to Zahra, I cry harder than I’ve ever cried before. I wish I could stay with her forever, but she reminds me that I need to go to this new town called Rockburn Grove where I’ll be safe, and my father will never find me again.

My heart is broken. I don’t know if, or when the pieces will ever fit back together. All I know is that I’m lost. There’s nothing left for me here.

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I dreamed a dream not long ago
That my life, it would soon end
And now I speak of last goodbyes
And lost forever friends

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April 30

After a six-hour drive, Eli stops the car outside a red brick building in a town called Rockburn Grove. The entire front of the building has big, wide windows and beneath each one is a box filled with flowers. The colours are beautiful, I especially love the pink ones that look like tiny little trumpets hanging upside down. Above the door of the building is a large sign that reads, ***Housing Hope.***

Eli takes my hand and I squeeze his tightly. I'm worried about being here because soon he will leave, and I will be truly alone in the world. When I stop at the front door, Eli reminds me it will be okay, but my legs refuse to move.

"What if they don't like me?" I ask.

"They will like you. There's nothing to be afraid of here." Eli tugs on my hand as he pushes open the door and I reluctantly follow him in. Inside the building there are lots of people walking around, most of them are young girls and women, some are children. I've never seen so many women all at once. My stomach is queasy, and my chest hurts. My heart is beating faster than ever, and when Eli lets go of my hand, I begin to cry. The tears fall from my eyes, rushing down my cheeks like a salty waterfall. By the time he says my name, I'm kneeling on the floor sobbing into my hands and shaking so hard I can't focus on anything but the rapid breaths leaving my lungs.

Eli kneels in front of me. "Hey, shhh.... it's okay. It's safe here." He rubs my back and talks softly, reminding me I'm safe and that no one will hurt me again.

I try to take a deep breath, but it's no use. I can't breathe, and I can't think of anything but the world spinning out of control while I'm stuck in

the middle, clinging to life so I don't fall into the darkness and disappear into oblivion.

By the time Eli lifts me to my feet, I'm breathing a little easier and as he rubs my back, he talks to the lady at the desk. I can't understand what they're saying, though. My mind is foggy, and my heart is still working overtime.

She comes around the counter and leads us through a long corridor with doors on either side, still chatting to Eli as she continues through a red door and walks into another room. I follow her in with Eli beside me and we sit down on a soft brown sofa.

The woman at the desk looks up and smiles. Her bright red lipstick matches the frames of her glasses and the red scarf tied around her neck. "Hello, Zahra, my name is Meg. It's lovely to meet you. I'm going to be looking after you while you're staying with us. We're going to help you find some friends and start a brand new life right here in our beautiful town."

At first, I don't realise she's talking to me. I'm still not used to being called Zahra, and when I hear her name, I instantly search for her face before realising, *I am Zahra*.

Meg tells me about the building, Housing Hope, which is a community centre and home for young girls and women who've had to leave their own homes due to abuse, domestic violence, drug addiction, and teenage pregnancies. She says that once I'm familiar with the town and I've made some friends, I'll be able to come and go as I please, as long as I follow the rules.

Meg continues while I listen carefully, trying to remember every single word she speaks. "Once you've settled in, Zahra, you'll be able to attend our girls group every Thursday. I think you'll love it. All the girls are very welcoming and love meeting new people."

It's all overwhelming and I don't know if I'll be able to do everything Meg says. "Will I be punished if I—What if I can't?"

Meg pushes her red rimmed glasses up on her head and smiles. "Oh, sweetheart, don't you worry about anything. There are no punishments here. You take your time, everything will be at your own pace, okay?"

I nod and Eli and Meg continue talking. A few minutes later, there's a knock on the door. When it opens, a young boy steps into the room. He

might be my age. He's not big like my brother, but he's not small like me. He has shiny blue eyes, and black hair. When he looks at me, he smiles and says hello, but my mouth doesn't move, and the air from my lungs gets stuck in my throat.

I want to look away and close my eyes, but I can't help staring at him.

He turns his attention to Meg. "Sorry to interrupt, Meg, father said you wanted to see me."

I wonder if he's like me. Maybe his father sold him to people for sex, or he was abused. I don't know if that happens to boys. When I was in the hospital, I saw some boys in the other rooms, but I didn't talk to them.

He glances back at me and smiles. It makes my heart flutter. Maybe this is what happiness feels like, but I don't think I would have found it this quickly.

Meg gives him a huge smile. "Declan, darling, yes. Since you're here, this is Zahra, she arrived this afternoon with Eli."

Eli stands and shakes his hand. "I'm from Hearts of Innocence. We've met once before, Declan. You were only about eight or so."

Declan tilts his head and a wave of his black hair falls across his eyes, he flicks his head back and scratches his neck. "Eli... hmm, I'm not sure I remember. I'm sorry."

When Eli sits, Declan extends his hand to me, but I pull my hand into my lap and freeze.

He drops his by his side. "It's lovely to meet you, Zahra. Would you like to come for a walk while Eli and Meg talk business? I can show you around if you like."

I turn to Eli, worried. I don't know Declan. I don't know where I am. I don't even remember the name of this building. My breathing grows heavier and I start to panic all over again.

Declan doesn't walk away. He takes another step toward me and extends his hand again. "Come on, there are fresh cupcakes in the kitchen. Do you want one?"

My mouth waters, and my palms sweat. Then, when my tummy rumbles, Eli rubs my back. "You'll be safe with Declan. He's a great kid. I won't go anywhere until I've said goodbye."

I stand nervously and keep my eyes on the floor as I reach out to Declan. When he takes my hand, he squeezes it softly and gives it a little tug. “Let’s go,” he says, “before they’re all gone.”

I don’t let go of Declan’s hand while we walk through another corridor then down a flight of stairs. When we reach the bottom, he leads me to the end of the hall where the smell of food cooking causes my tummy to rumble again.

“Is your arm sore?” Declan asks looking down at my cast.

“A little,” I admit. “The doctor said it will get better in a couple of weeks.”

“I broke my arm once when I fell off my bike. It hurt so much.”

“You had a bike?” I ask.

He nods, and his eyes light up when he talks. “Yeah, I still do. Mum and dad got it for me for Christmas. It’s a mountain bike. Do you like riding?”

I shake my head. “I can’t—I never had a bike.”

“Well, we have bikes here, so you’ll be able to learn. It’s heaps of fun, especially on the trails around the park and the lake.”

“I’ve never been to a park either.” I drop my head. There are so many things I don’t know. So many places I’ve never seen. My entire life I’ve been trapped inside a house I always thought was a home, but with each minute that passes, I realise I never lived at all. I merely existed.

Declan’s soft voice drags me away from my gloomy thoughts.

“That’s okay. Here in Rockburn Grove you’ll get to do all the things you’ve never done before.”

We enter the kitchen and on the bench is a plate of cupcakes with pink frosting and tiny little roses on top. He picks one up and hands it to me. Sadness washes over me when I have to let go of his hand to hold the cupcake.

Declan takes a big bite of his, and when he finishes chewing, he asks, “Are you going to eat it?”

I put it back on the bench and shake my head, hoping he’ll hold my hand again. “I’m not hungry.” Those words always come so easily.

“You’re allowed to, Zahra.”

My tummy rumbles again as Declan takes another mouthful of his cupcake. “You should probably have one, because I’ll eat them all. Then you’ll have to wait until after dinner for another batch.” He smiles as he shoves another whole cupcake into his mouth. I stare at him again, watching his jaw move as he chews. I wish I could read his mind, or at least ask him what he’s thinking.

He tilts his head then wipes his mouth with his hand.

The cupcake smells so good, and I wish I could put it in my mouth and chew it. But my throat is dry and rough, and my chest hurts when I breathe. “It’s too hard,” I say.

He takes the cupcake then grabs my hand. I pull away quickly, shocked he grabbed me so fast. He gasps and apologises. “I’m so sorry, Zahra, I should have asked first. Can I hold your hand again?”

I nod, and this time he takes it gently. “Do you want to see the attic? There’s an awesome view of the city from the top window.”

I nod again and let this strange boy named Declan lead me up two flights of stairs. There’s not one moment of fear with him. It’s as though *he* is safe, and I’m yet to understand why.

“How old are you,” I ask.

He stops at a large timber door at the end of a narrow hallway. “It was my eighteenth back on the second of April. How old are you?”

“Seventeen.”

Declan drops his hand from mine and pushes the door open. “Wow. Um... I thought you were younger. Like fourteen or fifteen.”

“My father wanted um... he li—he liked me being small.”

“Well, you’re still beautiful,” Declan says, but this time he looks away from me and I notice his cheeks are a little red.

I follow him into the attic where a soft brown sofa and four small armchairs are arranged around the room. On the floor, huge coloured pillows are scattered all around, and a bright yellow rug sits in front of the window. It’s so big I can see the whole city and the mountains far off in the distance.

I sit beside Declan on a pink pillow and cross my legs.

He hands me the cupcake. “No one will see you eating it here. It might make it easier.”

How did he know that would help? I bring the cake to my lips. The scent of strawberries and vanilla lingers under my nose. I take a tiny bite and chew it slowly before finally speaking again. “Declan?”

“Yeah...”

“Did you come here because your father, or someone else hurt you?”

He grabs a pillow and puts it behind his back so he can lean on the sofa. “No. My dad would never hurt me. He’s the best. I love my parents.”

“Why are you here then?”

“I work here. Sometimes, when I’m lucky, like today, I get to show the new people around.”

“Do you like working?” I’m confused. Declan’s only eighteen and he’s already working.

Will I have to work here?

Declan continues, “I love it. I work with my father as well, in that big building you can see at the end of the main street. That’s Foxx and Son. My parents bought the building twenty years ago, we sell and distribute coffee machines, coffee, and coffee related merchandise to local and interstate businesses.”

I look down at the cupcake in my hand, desperately wanting to taste it again. I can’t eat it. I want to talk to Declan some more first. “I was in hospital yesterday. My father was chasing us in his ute, but Eli managed to get away. He protected me, and so did—” I stop, not wanting to say Zahra’s name in case I get confused.

Declan says, “Um... Zahra, I’m not allowed to talk about what happened to you. It’s against the rules. I’m sorry.”

I drop my head. “Oh. Okay.” I put the cupcake on the small table and cross my arms. “Is it because I’m broken?”

He shakes his head. “No, no. Not at all. It’s because the women and children who come here have had things that happened to them in the past, and it’s none of my business. It’s only for the doctors and nurses to talk about with those people.”

I sigh. “What if I don’t want to talk to anyone else?”

Declan shrugs. “I’m not sure. You could ask Meg if you can talk to her, she’s kind and a good listener.”

Nothing makes sense. I want to tell Declan everything about me, and I want him to tell me it will all be okay now. “I’ll go back to Eli... if you

don't want me here."

"Please don't go," Declan says. "Can we talk about something else?"

I pull my knees to my chest and rest my head on them. "I don't know much about real life. I read lots of books and did lots of writing too, but that's all. Do you like books?"

He nods. "I do. There's a library here. It has hundreds of books that have been donated by people who don't need them or want them anymore. You can take as many as you like as long as you return them when you're finished reading."

"Can we go there?" Bubbles of excitement burst in my stomach.

Declan jumps to his feet and extends his hand to me. "Let's go now." He reaches down and takes my hand to help me up, and we head out of the attic.

When we arrive at the library doors, I take a deep breath.

Declan pushes them open and I breathe in the scent of the books that line the shelves on each side of the room. "There are so many," I whisper to myself.

It's not until I'm half way across the room that I realise Declan is no longer beside me. When I turn back to find him, he's talking to a girl with long blonde hair. She hugs him and kisses his cheek. I wonder if she's Declan's girlfriend.

Declan calls me. "Zahra, come and meet Jaymee."

I bite my lip, nervous, and once again unable to move. After a short minute, they both walk toward me.

Jaymee extends her hand. "Hi Zahra, I'm Jaymee. It's so nice to meet you. You're going to love it here, and we're going to be great friends." She talks fast, and her voice is loud, but chirpy.

The only thing I can think of saying is, "Are you Declan's girlfriend?"

Jaymee laughs out loud. "Oh my god, no way. Me and Dec have been friends since we were five years old."

Declan laughs too, and I love the sound of it, but when Jaymee leaps forward and wraps her arms around me, I panic. Every muscle in my body goes stiff. I need to run. I need to get away from her so she can't touch me. Tears spring to my eyes and I try to step back, but she doesn't move.

Finally, Declan says, "Jaymee, let her go now."

Jaymee steps back and rubs my arm. "I'm sorry, sometimes I get a little overexcited. Are you okay?"

I nod as Jaymee waves goodbye and leaves the library.

Eli comes in at the same time. "There you are. You found the books I see."

Without a moment of hesitation, I run to Eli and wrap my arm around his waist before I cry into his chest and beg him to take me home.

"Zahra, I'm sorry about Jaymee," Declan says.

"She'll be okay, mate," Eli tells him. "She needs some time."

* * *

6.00pm

After I've met the doctor and the therapists, Eli tells me it's time for him to leave. How will I survive without him? Eli chased away some of my darkness. He rescued me, and he brought Zahra into my life.

Exhausted, I sit on the side of the bed in a small room Meg says will now be my own. White covers and a thick pink blanket cover the bed. Beside it is a chest of drawers where I can put my journal. Meg even gave me a box filled with brand new pencils, pens, and notebooks. They're all covered in flowers, feathers, and rainbows. I have new clothes, towels, toiletries, and even a closet filled with shoes. I have so many *things*, but somehow, I'm completely empty.

Eli glances around the room before he puts my backpack on the end of my bed. His eyes are glassy and when I see a tear fall, I wonder if he's sad because he had to leave Zahra at the hospital so he could bring me here.

He sits beside me and takes my hand softly between his. "Car—" he hesitates. "Zahra," he says with tears in his eyes. "You're going to be safe now. You're free from all the pain."

"Eli, will I ever see you again?"

He nods. "Yes, of course. But it won't be for a while. I have a lot of other girls to help too."

"Okay." I exhale and drop my head.

"Can I hug you?" he asks.

I nod again, but I can't speak. There's a lump stuck in my throat. Eli puts his arms around me and holds me tight. I put one arm around him. He's warm, and like I did with Zahra, I commit this moment to my memory. I don't want to let him go, not now, not ever.

When Eli stands, he smiles. "You'll be okay now," he says again.

I decide to tell him the truth. "Eli, I'm scared. I'm going to miss you, and I'll be alone. What if he comes here and finds me? What if I forget the rules?"

"He won't. This town is safe, Zahra. The safest in the world. And don't worry about the rules. There are no punishments here, remember?"

At 6.25pm I stand at the door of the Housing Hope building and wave to Eli as he drives away. I wait until his car turns the corner, then I wait for it to come back again. It doesn't. I close the door and turn to walk back to my room. I'm alone again. Still stuck in a world that doesn't understand the thoughts in my head, or the memories stuck in my mind.

I miss the way
It was before
Now there's only me
There's only after

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ZAHRA (*Carlie*)**May 7**

Seven days passed in a blur.

I cried a lot, I screamed, I shouted at people. I told them all to leave me alone and to never speak to me again.

I spent one hour each day inside an office with a female doctor who asked me so many questions I had to scream at her to stop. She never got mad, and it made me furious. I wanted her to tell me I was bad, that I should be punished, and that I deserved everything my father and the men did to me. I wanted to tell her I let them use my body, and I never shouted, or told them to stop. I let it all happen because I was stupid, and I truly believed my father loved me.

She never did. Every single time I saw her, she told me it would get easier. It didn't. She said it wasn't my fault. But it was, I should have said no. I should have tried to run. I should have died.

I haven't seen Declan again, and I wonder if it's because he hates me. Sadness creeps in and brings a fresh round of tears to my eyes. Declan was kind. I still remember the fresh, clean scent of his hair, and his bright blue eyes.

Meg asked me if I wanted to ride the bikes Declan told me about.

I don't want to now. Not without him.

Seven days ago, I found flickering glimpses of hope, but they are no more. There's nothing now but a melancholic wasteland of despair.

I have no one.

She is sparkling stardust
Encased in human skin
But someone put her light out
Now her heart's hidden within

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DECLAN

May 14

No matter how much I try to push her from my mind, she's right there, unmoving. It's as though she's already become a permanent fixture in my life and I only spent two short hours with her. I've never wanted to know someone as much as I want to know Zahra.

There's something unique about her. She's quiet, gentle, innocent. From the outside, I see her as an enigma. A sparkling aura of fragility mixed with the glimpse of light I saw in her eyes when she gave me a tiny, brief smile.

The way she clung to my hand as though no one else in the world existed, gave me goose bumps I was glad were hidden beneath my long sleeve shirt.

I'm disappointed we had to leave for our family trip right after we met. I would have loved to have spent more time with Zahra; I hope she doesn't think I abandoned her just as she was settling in.

"Earth to Declan," Charles' voice rings out across the camp ground.

When I look back over my shoulder, he's walking toward me carrying our fishing rods and the large tackle box. I jump to my feet and jog over to help him. "Sorry, man, I wasn't listening."

He rolls his eyes. "Don't tell me you're still thinking about Zaaahra." My cheeks heat, and Charles' laughs. "Mate, you gotta get that girly blushing under control as soon as possible."

I shove his shoulder as we walk back down to the river bank. According to Charles, I haven't stopped mentioning Zahra's name since we got here. Of course, that's a lie. *I need to find out more about her.* "She's nice, that's all it is. It was fun hanging out with her."

"You were there for two hours. This isn't a fairy tale, Dec. You can't possibly know anything about her in two hours."

I shrug. “I know it’s not a fairy tale. I’m just saying she’s nice. There was something about her, I guess. She’s not like other girls.”

As we bait up our hooks, Charles—as always—continues talking. “Okay. I’ll give you that. I’ve never seen anyone like her. It’s like she has a whole other world inside her head... like she’s not normal, but in a good, kinda weird way.” He shrugs, then laughs. “But she’s beautiful. I’ve never seen a girl that... well, I don’t know—sexy is a stupid word to describe her. She’s gorgeous. Small though. She doesn’t even look like a seventeen-year-old.”

I lean against the trunk of a gum tree and look out across the river that ripples with sunlight. “Yeah she is. But it’s more than that, I can’t explain it. I’m pretty sure she has an eating disorder. Maybe the same as Jaymee had. It seems like she’s had a hard life.”

My thoughts drift to the cupcakes and how Zahra looked at them as though she was starving, but refused to put one anywhere near her mouth until I took her up to the attic. I remember the way her full, pale pink lips looked as she took her first bite. I remember her eyes when she stood in front of the window and saw the city streets. She was in awe, and I was certain she was about to cry when her eyes glistened with unshed tears.

Charles sighs. “Man, that sucks. I hope she’ll be okay. You sure know how to make me feel bad.”

I cast my line out into the middle of the river then sit on the dry ground. “Nah. Don’t feel bad. You didn’t know. *I* don’t even know, I’m only guessing.”

“You and Jaymee are good?” I ask him.

He pokes at the ground with a stick as he talks. “Yeah, she’s amazing. I never thought I’d be in love with anyone, let alone Jaymee.” A smile stretches across his lips. Charles and Jaymee have been a couple for over two years now. We all grew up in Rockburn Grove, and have always been close, but it wasn’t until Jaymee’s sixteenth birthday party that they got together. Since then, they’ve been inseparable.

We spend a few good hours fishing and talking before we pack up the rods and take our catches back to camp to prepare for dinner.

* * *

May 15

In the morning, I wake to the sounds of birds chirping in the trees above my tent. I stretch my arms and roll over to check my phone. *Maybe Zahra*—I laugh when I realise Zahra didn't have a phone and there's no way she'd be texting me. I shake my head hard.

She needs time to come out of her shell. It's not something I can rush her into. *But why can't I stop thinking about her?* Maybe this is some late blooming high school crush type of thing.

"We're leaving at ten, boys," Dad calls out.

Shuffling out of my sleeping bag I think about what Zahra might be doing. Maybe she's made a few friends, or at least had a chance to get outside and explore the walking tracks that lead through the gardens. I consider texting Jaymee to ask if she's seen Zahra, but decide against it. I'll see her soon enough.

Within ten minutes, I'm packed up and ready to go. My dad stands by the trunk of the car watching me load it up while Charles drinks down his second carton of iced coffee for the morning.

"Someone's in a hurry to get home," Dad says.

Charles raises his brow then throws the empty carton at me. I catch it and throw it in the trashcan. "What?" I shrug. "A guy can't help his dad pack the car?"

"This sudden rush to get home wouldn't have anything to do with a certain girl, would it?" Dad asks.

I shake my head, but my damn blushing cheeks give me away.

Charles bursts out laughing. "Declan likes Zahra," he sings.

I leap forward to punch his arm but he jumps back out of the way, then takes off running. I chase him into the forest where he zig zags through the trees and jumps over fallen logs and branches. Puffing, I stop with my hands on my knees and breathe slowly.

Charles walks back with a hand on his hip. "I know you like her." We both laugh through panting breaths. "Why don't you tell her?"

As I straighten, the blush creeps into my cheeks yet again. "Okay... I like her. But the rules. I can't do anything about it. I don't know about her past... her problems. What if she was rape—" I swallow hard not wanting to

say the word, let alone think about something so horrific happening to Zahra.

We head back to the campground. “Do you think she might have been?” Charles asks in a hushed tone.

“I hope not.” I sigh, wishing I could ask her a million questions.

Charles pats my shoulder. “You could make her happy, she’d be safe with you... with us as her friends.”

When we reach the car, we help Dad and William tie down the bicycles.

Dad nods toward me. “Declan, mate, be careful with that girl. She’s got a lot of things going on in her head right now, she needs some time to settle in.”

I nod. “I know. I mean... I don’t, but I understand. I’m not going to do anything stupid. I won’t hurt her, I want her to know she has friends... someone to talk to.”

Dad nods and raises his brow. “So... I’m guessing you’ll be putting in a few hours at Housing Hope when you get home?” He pats my back. “To see if she made friends... you know?”

I can’t hide my smile. “Yeah, I think so, Dad.” If only I hadn’t agreed to work at the bakery for the day.

I want to crawl beneath the earth
In the hope that somehow
I'll find you there
Waiting for me

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ZAHRA (*Carlie*)**May 16**

2.25am

It's so dark outside.

Through my bedroom window twinkling stars surround a silver crescent moon. The sky is beautiful. Up there I imagine my little sister is looking down on me, begging me to save her life and free her from our father. *I should have saved her.* In reality, I didn't kill her, but the way she died will haunt me for eternity.

I pull on my thick sweater that has a fur-lined hood, and I leave my room to head for the front door. Meg said we should never leave without telling someone, but everyone is asleep, and I don't want to go into their rooms and wake them. I always feel like I'm an unwanted intruder in their lives.

I walk out of Housing Hope and head down the street toward the building where Declan told me he works with his father. There are no people around. In the distance, a dog barks. It continues for a few minutes until a blanket of silence hovers like a thick, impenetrable layer of fog.

The street lights appear as small moons stuck on top of tall, twisted green poles. Each one lights up the path and leads me toward the taller buildings. I walk past a row of small houses with no lights on. Perhaps one of them is Declan's house. I wish I had the chance to talk to him again.

I continue along the street, passing by small stores. All of them have lights on, but the signs on the doors say *Closed*.

When I reach the tall buildings at the end of the main street, some of the windows have bright lights shining from them, maybe Declan is working and that's why he hasn't been at Housing Hope.

My heart races with anticipation. I might be able to see him again.

The huge sign at the doors of the building says *Foxx & Son Coffee Company*.

When I push on the doors, they're locked, but there are lights on inside and I can see a long desk and lots of small sofas and chairs all lined up near the wall. Above the desk is a huge round clock, the time is 2.45am.

I walk around the building until I reach the back door. A white police car is parked outside, but there's no one in it. Maybe they're in the building.

I push on the door and it opens slowly, it's heavy and when I make my way through it, it slams closed behind me causing me to jump. In front of me is a staircase.

I start making my way up. At the end of each set of stairs is a doorway with the floor number on a small sign. I don't open them until my legs are too tired to continue.

The sign says, **18th Floor**. I open the door to see a light on. When I walk into the room, the smell of coffee fills my nose. It reminds me of the dining room at Housing Hope where everything smells wonderful.

The room I'm in is clean and bright. On one side, there's a long black desk like the one in the entrance to the building. On the other side there are round tables with four chairs at each one, and in the middle of the tables are coffee machines like the one Meg uses.

"Declan?" I call.

There's no answer.

I pace the floor, running my fingers along the shiny desk and across the back of the chairs. Everything feels so clean, so new. A chill runs down my spine and I hug my arms around myself as I walk to the window.

I can see the entire city from here. I place my hand on the window and my breath causes a little puff of fog to block my vision. I wipe my hand across it, then slide the window open to look outside. A rush of cold air blows past my face and I shiver. The gardens that surround the building appear as tiny, deep green villages dotted with glowing solar lights and winding paths all leading to a central fountain. The window ledge is wide enough for me to sit on, so I lift one leg over, then the other. While looking up at the stars, I whisper, "I'm sorry, Cathie." I don't know if heaven is real. Some days I don't even know if this life I am living is real.

Far off in the distance a single shining star catches my eye as it falls from the sky. It's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen.

With one hand still gripping the open window, I imagine falling to the ground. Nothing about my fall would be beautiful. I'm not a shining

star. I'm not a bright light in this dark, unforgiving world. I am no one. No one will miss me—no one will care.

I close my eyes and recite the poem I wrote in my journal before I left Housing Hope.

“No one will miss me
No one will care
No one remembers
No one was there
My today's are all broken
And no one can see
I will be forgotten
When I'm finally free.”

One day not so long ago, I thought I was unworthy of death. I will prove them wrong. I must be worthy of something.

“No one will miss me,” I remind myself out loud as I take my hand off the window and shuffle forward.

Behind me, there's a creak of the door, then, a flickering light shines into the room. “What the hell?”

A huge man with an angry glare shouts. “Get down from there!”

My body freezes. I want to scream but my lungs won't fill with air and the pressure against my chest is choking me. I squeeze my eyes shut as fear runs through my veins. If I jump now, he won't be able to stop me. *Don't jump.* A voice in my head forces me back.

While I cling to the window with one hand, I lock my knees together. The man talks to someone who isn't there. “There's an intruder,” he says, “I think he's—he's in the window. I need help up here, now!”

He takes a step toward me then extends his hand. “Get back inside. Come on, mate, don't do this.”

He must think I'm a boy. I've never heard anyone call a girl “mate”. I take my hand off the window to push the hood off my head.

“No, no. Don't jump!” the man says. He takes another step toward me and I notice the gun in the holster on his belt. I'm going to be in so much trouble.

The cold breeze has gone, and it's eerily still and quiet. *You're so stupid you can't even kill yourself.* Trystan's words force their way into my mind. "I'm not stupid." Tears well in my eyes.

"What did you say?" The man asks.

"I'm not stupid."

He shakes his head. "No. No... you're not. Come on in from the window and I'll take you home."

"I don't have a home anymore."

The man shines his flashlight in my face causing me to squint. "Where are you from? You from Housing Hope?"

I swallow the lump in my throat. I don't want to talk to him. I don't want to breathe, and I don't want to keep crying. I want everything to stop. Below my feet there's a narrow ledge. I shuffle forward again and extend one foot down to see how far it is. I can't reach it.

I choke back tears as I grip the window and turn sideways so I can lift my leg over the windowsill and get back inside.

"That's it, you can do it," the man says.

When both my feet are on the floor inside the room, the man comes toward me. "Good girl. Now, come to me."

"*Good girl.*" My father's voice returns with a vengeance. "*Always Daddy's good girl.*"

Fear overwhelms me, and I run past the man and pull the door open before I bolt down the stairs. Halfway down I trip over my own feet and fall to my knees. The man grabs my wrist that's covered in plaster and I scramble backwards, crying.

"What have you got?" he shouts.

I shake my head. "No... noth—nothing."

He grabs my arm again and pushes up my sleeve. When he sees my plaster cast, he curses. "Fuck!" He steps toward me again, this time with his hands raised. "I'm not going to hurt you."

I can't talk, the only thing that leaves my mouth is a scream so loud it makes my head spin and my ears ring. He reaches for me again, but I leap forward and run. My legs keep moving until I reach the door and pull on it with one hand as hard as I can. When it finally opens, I run straight into another man. I slam into his big, strong chest and he wraps his arms around me.

“Not so fast,” he says.

I struggle to get out of his grasp, punching and screaming.

When he glares down at me, his eyes change from being filled with anger, to something else. Maybe he’s confused. I can’t stop screaming, and as I fight to get him away from me, I hear a familiar voice.

“Dad, stop. It’s Zahra, the girl I was telling you about.” It’s Declan.

The man drops his hands and releases me, and I drop to the ground hyperventilating.

Declan kneels in front of me. “Zahra, what are you doing here?”

Through panting breaths, I cry. “I was looking for you. I saw the lights on and I thought you were there, but I couldn’t find you and I wanted to—I wanted to sit and look at the stars. But—” My sobbing grows louder.

“It’s okay,” Declan says. “What happened?”

“Then the man came in and he—I was scared, and he told me to come inside. But I was scared, and I ran. He grabbed my arm. It hurts so much, Declan. Please don’t let your father punish me,” I beg.

The man who found me inside, pants as he leans forward with his hands on his knees. “Sorry boss. She was gonna jump. Then she took off.”

Declan puts his hand out to me. “Zahra, can I hold your hand?” I reach out. “She’s hurt, Dad. Can we take her to the hospital?”

“Of course, mate,” he says.

Declan helps me stand and he leads me to a black car where I get in the back seat beside him. He doesn’t let go of my hand while he pulls the seat belt across and buckles me in.

When his father gets in the car, he says, “Eli brought you here, right?”

“Yes,” I whisper. “Please don’t punish me.”

Declan rubs his thumb over the back of my hand. “Zahra, you’re not being punished. Dad’s taking you to the hospital to get your arm checked, that’s all.”

I only nod, hoping it’s not too far. My stomach feels empty, and my head is spinning as the car drives along the dark road.

Ten minutes later I arrive at the hospital with Declan and his father. By the time we see the doctor it’s 5am and Meg has arrived. Her eyes are

red and puffy like she's been crying. She didn't shout at me, and she didn't get mad. I still don't understand why everyone here is so kind.

While the doctor removes my plaster cast, Declan sits beside me on the hospital bed and watches.

"You were gone for a long time," I say.

He smiles. "We went on our family camping trip, just me and Dad, and my best friend Charles and his dad. There's a beach, and a river and heaps of fun water activities."

"I've never seen the beach."

Declan's father leaves with the doctor who says he's going to get an x-ray machine. Meg pats my shoulder and says she'll be back after she's found some coffee.

"Zahra," Declan says, "why were you looking for me?"

"I missed you. You are the only one who listens to me and understands all the things I'm not saying. I'm alone here without Eli—" I sigh wishing I could tell Declan about Zahra. "My little sister is gone too."

"Where's your sister?" Declan asks.

"My father gave her too many drugs. She was too weak and sick to survive. She died..."

He drops his head and runs his fingers over the back of my hand. "I'm sorry that happened, Zahra. I wish I could talk to you about your sister, but I'm not allowed to."

"I know. Declan, will you take me to the beach one day?"

He drops his feet to the floor and stands in front of me before taking my good hand between both of his. "Yes. I will. As soon as you're feeling better, I'll ask my parents if we can go on a day trip."

I can't hide my smile, and I don't want to. I stare at him. His eyelashes are long, and his blue eyes remind me of the sky. In his cheeks, two little dimples appear when he smiles. In all my life I've never wanted to sit and stare at someone's face like I do with Declan.

Part of me is anxious. I'm worried that if I get too close to him, something terrible will happen.

What if my father finds me? I squeeze my eyes shut and drop my head to let the tears fall.

"Zahra, what's wrong?"

I'm silent again. Wishing I could tell him everything. In my heart I imagine there's a wall, and every single time I speak to Declan, pieces of the wall tumble down allowing me to breathe easier—and deeper. With each passing day I'm discovering new emotions. The exquisite taste of happiness lingers above me now, still out of reach, but no longer invisible.

Meg calls it healing. She says it's a journey I need to take. And one day, I'll be able to look back on my past and know what happened to me, wasn't my fault.

I'm ready for the journey to begin, but I want Declan to be a part of it too. Because without him, nothing makes sense.

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She bathes in uncertainty
She dreams in black and white
But she doesn't see the hope I see
Or the stars in her brown eyes

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DECLAN**May 17**

Zahra is so sad. She always looks as though she's about to burst into tears. I've seen so many sad women and children come through Housing Hope, but none as sad and broken as Zahra.

Father told me she was abused by her father. He didn't tell me everything though, he never does. He says there are some things people will never talk about, and some things they will only talk about when they're ready. I can't imagine having so much pain inside me and not being able to tell anyone.

Since I was a child, I've always been close with my parents. They adopted me the day after I was born, and I've always been grateful for the life I have. I've never been worried about talking to them, or afraid to tell them what's on my mind. I wish Zahra had someone like that in her life.

I knock on Zahra's door, but she doesn't answer so I go looking for Meg who runs the house and cares for everyone who comes through the doors. Meg's my best friend, Charles' mother, and has always treated me like her own son, the same way my mum is with Charles.

"Declan," she says when she sees me in the main hall. "You've come to see Zahra, haven't you?"

My cheeks burn. I can't stop it, and I wish it didn't happen. I can't hide anything, from anyone. Sucks to be an eighteen-year-old boy who blushes. "Yeah, she didn't answer the door. Is she outside?"

Meg wipes her brow with her sleeve and pushes the mop bucket across to the wall with her foot. "She might still be asleep after last night. Declan, be careful with this girl, she has a lot to deal with."

I nod. The moment I met Zahra, I could tell she had been through something terrible. At first, I thought she was much younger. She doesn't look at all like any of the seventeen-year-old girls I've seen here before. "I

will be, Meg. I know the rules. I think she's cool..." I shrug. "Or nice, I guess. She's real pretty too."

Meg laughs. "She certainly is beautiful. Now, let's go wake her up, it's about time she gets some food into that belly of hers." We head back down the corridor. "Poor thing's going to waste away if she doesn't eat soon."

Meg knocks on Zahra's door and calls out to her. Again, there's no answer, so she opens the door a crack and peeks in. When she does, there's a muffled cry. It must be horrible to feel like you're totally alone in the world, to have no friends or family. And for her sister to have been killed by their father—Zahra must be devastated.

Meg walks in, and I follow close behind. When I hear the shower running, I stop in my tracks and let Meg go ahead to check the bathroom.

"Oh, my darling girl," Meg cries out as though she's the one in pain, and I'm desperate to see if Zahra's okay.

Zahra's cries grow louder. "Don't touch me," she screams. "Leave me alone."

"Meg?" I call.

Meg calls back from the bathroom, sticking her head around the door. "Declan, go fetch some bandages and gloves, hurry."

I turn on my heels and run to the Medical Room where I tip out the contents of the first aid box and grab a handful of cloths and gauze, and a couple of pairs of gloves.

As I race back to Zahra's room, I think about the other women who have come through Housing Hope. There have been three who have died by suicide. Three too many, my father says. He always worries about them, my mother does too. She says that sometimes people feel so alone and so helpless they lose all the hope they ever had, and believe death is the only way they will be free from their pain.

I've never felt that way, so I can't imagine it. But I wish it never happened to anyone.

"Meg," I call. Zahra is silent. My only hope is that she's not already unconscious.

"You can come in," she calls.

I hesitate, not wanting to upset Zahra. When I walk in, I swallow the lump in my throat.

Zahra is sitting in the bottom of the shower. There's a puddle of blood on the shower base, and more blood covers her legs and hands. Over her shoulders is a thick white towel that Meg must have put over her.

Zahra lifts her head. Her face is blotchy and red, and her eyes are puffy and glistening with tears. Long strands of wet brown hair stick to her face and shoulders, and for reasons I can't explain, she still appears more beautiful than any other female I've seen in my life. But behind that beauty, the unrelenting agony she must be facing, is as clear as day.

"Declan?" she says my name as though she's not sure it's me.

As I hand Meg the gloves and gauze, I can't peel my eyes away from Zahra. It's like a scene from a bad horror movie. I want to switch it off and turn back time to find a place where she was a normal, happy girl surrounded by people who loved her. *Was she ever happy?* The thought tears my heart to shreds. I've always been an empathetic guy, and I probably cry more than the average teenage girl, but I've never felt soul crushing emotional pain like I do right now.

Hold it together.

"Declan..." she says my name again.

"Are you okay?" I ask. I want to punch myself, of course she's not okay. When I glance down at her thighs, it's obvious what she's done. Long, thin lines are cut into her flesh, there must be at least ten or more on each leg. I need to focus. "Can I do something, Meg?"

She puts her hand out for another pack of dressing then presses it against Zahra's thigh.

"Tell Shelly I'm bringing Zahra to the Medical Room," she says.

I turn to walk out the door, and Zahra screams, "No, Declan, don't go." I stop in my tracks. Meg tells her it's okay, but she's hysterical and won't listen. She scrambles back and presses herself into the corner of the small shower while begging me to stay.

Meg gets to her feet and tells me to put on a pair of gloves, then she hands me the bandages. "You remember it all, don't you?"

I nod. Every year since I was thirteen, my parents had me do a first aid course. Since the age of fifteen, I've been working at Housing Hope while I study and help my father run our family business. My parents have always supported me, and I want nothing more than to make them proud.

As Meg leaves, I ask Zahra if she can stand. She pulls one foot back and winces in pain.

When she gets to her knees, she grips the steel handle inside the shower with one hand and gets to her feet. When she's standing, I take her hand and hold it while she steps out of the shower and onto the white towel. Drops of crimson blood trail down her legs and soak into the bath mat.

I pull the small footstool over and sit on it to wrap the bandage around her thigh, focusing only on the cuts. Between the fresh cuts are lots of small scars. It's as though she's done this many times before. She doesn't even seem to be in pain.

I sigh. "Does it hurt?"

"No." She holds the towel to her chest. "Are you going to leave?"

I shake my head. "Why would I leave?"

"Because I'm dirty."

I start wrapping the second bandage around her thigh. "No, you're not dirty. You're bleeding."

Her voice is barely a whisper. "I had to see if I was still alive... inside. I'm still alive—"

I swallow hard. "You'll be fine," I assure her. "These will all heal up." When I'm done, I pull the gloves off and throw them in the trash, then wash my hands.

On the back of the door is Zahra's robe. I take it off the hook and drape it over her shoulders after taking the towel and throwing it in the laundry basket.

She pushes her arms through while I glance at her tiny waist. All her bones are sticking out from beneath her pale, scarred flesh. She's so thin I can see her ribs and it causes me to gasp. Thankfully, I don't think she notices.

I pull the robe closed and tie the belt around her waist, wishing I could make her smile, even for a fleeting moment.

While I tie off the garbage bag, Zahra washes her hands then pulls her hair into a ponytail. She sits on the edge of the bathtub and drops her head into her hands. "I want to die," she cries.

My heart skips a beat. I barely know Zahra, but each time I've seen her a wave of protectiveness washes over me. I want to make sure she's safe

and happy. I want to save her from the horrible thoughts that must be rushing through her mind. She doesn't deserve all this pain and sorrow.

I kneel in front of her and take her hands. "I don't want you to die. You have so many things to do and see. You deserve a beautiful life." Maybe my words are all wrong and they won't comfort her. But I'll be damned if I don't even try to help.

She stares at me for the longest minute before she finally speaks again. "I can't do this anymore. I can't stop thinking about my little sister, and my father, and... and—Declan, it's too hard. I don't know what to do."

I squeeze her hands. "I'll help you. I'll be here for you whenever you need someone to talk to. If you're sad, you can call me. If you're feeling scared, you can call me. I *don't* want you to die, Zahra. I just met you. I want to be your friend." *Don't leave me. Not yet.*

Her eyes well with tears until they begin to overflow and fall down her reddened cheeks. When I stand and gently pull her to her feet, she puts her arms around me and cries against my chest. "Please don't leave me," she begs.

My heart is heavy, and part of me knows this is a huge mistake, but I let the words fall from my lips as though they are a promise I will always keep. And I hate myself for it. "I'll never leave you, Zahra."

* * *

May 18

It's Tuesday afternoon and I'm back at Housing Hope where Zahra's sitting in the library staring out the window. I sit beside her on the sofa and for a long time we don't speak at all. We sit in perfect, blissful silence.

"Are you feeling a bit better now?" I finally ask.

She shrugs. "A little."

When I hear his voice, I smile. My best friend Charles and I, grew up together, went to school together, and now we work together. His dad, William Stone, is the Sheriff of our town and he fully expected Charles to follow in his footsteps and join the police force. Charles wanted to work with my father and me instead. He has a massive fear of blood and doesn't like confrontation of any kind. Although he'd never admit it.

He comes over and plonks himself down on the chair opposite us. I've been talking to him a lot about Zahra, and he knows I like her more now than I did when she arrived. He assumes I want her to be my girlfriend. But it's important for Zahra to be happy and healthy before she considers anything resembling a relationship. All she needs right now are friends, and people she can trust.

"Zahra, this is my friend, Charles."

She says hello, then asks, "Do you have lots of friends, Declan?"

I nod. "Yeah, I do. Me and Charles grew up here, so we have heaps of friends."

"Did you have friends before you moved here?" Charles asks her.

Zahra shakes her head. "I wasn't allowed to. I stayed in my bedroom or the cellar most of the time."

Charles changes the subject. "Have you been out to the lake? Some of the girls go out there to feed the ducks, or just to talk. You could make some friends."

Zahra turns to me. "Am I allowed to do that?"

I nod. "Of course, but Meg said you shouldn't walk around if you're in too much pain."

"I'm not," she says.

I grab a readymade picnic hamper and a few drinks before we head out to the lake. Zahra stands with her hands pulled up inside her sweater sleeves. I've noticed she does that a lot, I've also noticed her hands are always cold, so maybe that's why.

Charles holds out some duck food in a small plastic cup for Zahra. She reaches out and takes it. "What is it?" she asks.

"Seeds and grains and stuff, I guess," Charles says. "The ducks seem to like it. We're not supposed to give them bread, apparently it makes their stomachs puff up." He laughs.

As the ducks swim toward the bank, Zahra throws the food into the water. The ducks start quacking and scooping it up. Charles throws a handful in, and more ducks land on the surface of the water.

"It's so pretty here," Zahra says. "I've never seen a lake."

Charles throws the blanket on the grass and tells us he's going for a walk to find Jaymee.

I sit down on the blanket beside Zahra. "Are you hungry?"

She takes a deep breath, then sighs. "A little."

I dig into the hamper and find pink cupcakes and a container of mixed sandwiches. When Zahra sees the cupcakes, a hint of a smile appears on her lips. I'm waiting in anticipation for her to really smile.

"Are you having one?" she asks.

I hand Zahra one and take a bite of mine. "Of course."

Zahra slouches, leaning forward with her elbows on her knees, staring at the cupcake as though it's going to ruin her life.

I remember back in high school when Jaymee had an eating disorder. She got so thin she ended up in hospital and wasn't allowed to go home until she was eating again and had gained weight. My mum and Meg told Charles and I we should make a point of not talking about how much or how little Jaymee ate, and to focus on her being happy. That was four years ago.

Maybe that's what's wrong with Zahra. "They're good," I say.

"I'm tired, actually. I should go back to my room."

Maybe she's overwhelmed, or afraid of being outside. I want her to stay, but I don't want to force her to eat or pressure her. I place my hand on her back and rub it gently, at first she flinches, then she relaxes. "You can lie down here if you like. It's a beautiful day, and you said you like the sunshine."

"I can?" she asks.

I nod and shuffle across, then pat the blanket beside me. "Of course you can."

She hands me her cupcake and wriggles around until she gets comfortable. When she lays her head on my lap, I instantly want to jump to my feet and say no. I want to tell her to move because this type of contact is surely what my father would say is inappropriate. Getting too close, too comfortable.

While I argue back and forth with myself, Zahra turns so she's facing the lake, and takes a bite of the cupcake.

I decide to stay put and don't move a muscle.

"Declan, can you show me the bikes soon?" she asks.

She's still focused on the lake. "Sure. We could go tomorrow if you like. It's supposed to be a nice day."

“What if I can’t ride?”

“I’ll teach you. It’s easy once you get the hang of it.”

“My brother had a bike when he was little. I watched him sometimes. He was always smiling when he was on it.”

I want to ask her about her brother, but I’m worried he might have been killed by her father as well. “Riding is fun. We can go around the lake and stop at the animal sanctuary if you want to.”

She looks up at me with her eyes wide. “I’m allowed to do that?”

I nod, and get another slight smile from her, and it’s beautiful.

“You’ve never been to one?”

She shakes her head. “I’ve only seen animals in books. Once I saw a puppy, but that was only for a minute.” She extends her hands and cups them together slightly. “He was this big... his name was Maxie.”

“I have a dog at home, I can bring him here if you want to see him. His name’s Peanut.” I laugh. “Mum called him that because he was so small when we got him.”

“Can I meet your mum one day?”

“Yeah, of course. She works at the bakery, we could walk there from here.”

I’m rewarded with yet another smile. Everything amazes her. It sounds like all her knowledge has come from books, and I can’t imagine what the world looks like through her eyes, but I want to. The girl I see right here in front of me is so beautiful on the outside, that I keep forgetting she’s so sad on the inside.

I put my hand on her head and feel her hair, it’s so soft, and I can’t help running my fingers through it. “Zahra, if you don’t want me to touch you, you can tell me to stop.”

She tilts her head back. “I think I like it. It doesn’t hurt when you touch me. Nothing hurts when you’re with me.”

My stomach fills with butterflies and my chest coils with nervous apprehension. I need to talk to my parents, and maybe to Charles, too. I can’t stop thinking about Zahra and wishing I was allowed to see her every day. She doesn’t *need* a boyfriend, but I want to be the one who makes her smile. I want to be the one who causes her eyes to light up in awe.

Slowly, I take her hand in mine and lace my fingers through hers. Hers fit perfectly between mine and I want to stay here like this forever,

even in silence.

“Declan, why are you always nice to me?”

“I like you, Zahra. I think you’re sweet, and beautiful.”

Tears drip from the corners of her eyes.

“What’s wrong?” I ask.

She chokes on a sob. “The men... they always said I was beautiful—they hurt me.”

What men? I want to ask, but I don’t. My imagination is working overtime, and from the things I’ve seen and heard here at Housing Hope, I doubt I want to know. “I won’t hurt you. I don’t ever want to see you sad.”

I wipe her tears away with my thumb and cup her cheek. She leans into me and holds my hand against her face, then closes her eyes. We stay that way for hours, in complete, perfect silence until the sun begins to set in the distance, and Meg calls everyone in for dinner.

Even though I cannot see you
I still feel your storms inside
Remnants of the hope I lost
And a past I left behind

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ZAHRA (*Carlie*)**September 16***122 days later*

Declan is my favourite person in the world. He makes my heart beat faster and harder, and when he talks to me, my tummy twists and turns into coiling knots. When he's working with his father, I miss talking to him, and at night, I imagine Cathie is up in the ebony sky among the stars, and I tell her all about him. I grieve for her every day. And every day brings with it the reminder that I once dreamed—and wished—she would die. That memory haunts my nightmares and never ceases to drag me down into crippling pools of hopelessness and despair.

I'm healing though. Meg was right about this being a journey. My psychiatrist, Doctor Marshall, says it will take a long time for me to heal, but with the right medication and my therapy sessions with the other girls at Housing Hope, I'm finally finding a place where I belong.

Today Declan is taking me to the bike trails again. The first time we went I fell off the bike six times, and when I finally managed to ride along the trail, I cried tears of joy. Everything in Rockburn Grove is beautiful. The trees, the sunshine, the lakes and parks, and the people too. They all love Declan, and when we're together, they love me too. I'm still not used to it, and sometimes when we leave Housing Hope, I panic, and Declan takes me straight back.

During those times, we sit in the library and read books and poetry together and talk about all the places in the world we're going to visit when we're older. Those are the times I feel closest to him, and I remind myself that not all boys and men are like my father and brother. Some, like Declan and Charles and their families, are kind and loving, and will never hurt me.

"You okay?" Declan calls from where he's stopped on his bike.

I put my foot on the peddle and start riding toward him. "I'm okay."

When I catch up to him, we continue along the trail that passes by the wildlife park. Through the fences we manage to catch a glimpse of a mob of kangaroos with two joeys tucked safely in their mother's pouches.

Twenty minutes later, we reach the old oak tree where a thick braided rope hangs from one of the large branches. It's wrapped around an old black tyre, and higher up in the branches is a tree house with a rope ladder dangling from its wooden floor.

Declan says it's been here since he was a child, and that he used to come here with Charles to climb the tree and swing on the rope. He has so many memories from his childhood, and all of them are happy; most of them include Charles.

We lay the bikes on the grass and stand under the branches of the tree. The leaves block out most of the sun allowing only tiny speckled rays of light to scatter across the grass. Birds flit from branch to branch tweeting to one another in their own secret language I never tire of hearing. The world is so beautiful, and I never imagined I'd get to see so much of it from one small town.

Declan leans against the tree trunk with his hands in his pockets. I wish they were out, and that he would ask to hold my hand again. I don't want to ask him myself because when I try, the words get stuck on my tongue and my throat gets dry.

"Did you like it?" he asks about the bike ride.

I nod, and he pulls one hand out of his pocket and extends it to me. When I take it, he tugs me closer so the toes of my shoes are nearly touching his. I've never been this close to anyone I like. My tummy is filled with butterflies and when I breathe, my heart bangs against my chest. A strange feeling coils inside me and sends a warmth through my body that instantly makes me smile.

Everything I want to say is swirling in my head like a storm filled with words I'll never speak. I close my eyes and count to five, hoping that when I open them, this isn't all a dream I made up one night while I was sitting on the cold floor of the cellar.

"You're so beautiful, Zahra," Declan says.

I open my eyes but drop my head. I'm nervous and I'm not sure why. "Zahra," he says my name again.

His eyes are as blue as the ocean and his cheeks are all pinkish coloured. The little dimples that appear when he smiles, make my own smile grow bigger. His lips are slightly parted and I wonder if he would kiss softly; if he would be gentle and kind. I've never *wanted* to kiss anyone before I met Declan.

"What are you thinking," he asks.

I don't want to lie to him. I want to tell him everything. I want him to understand all the things about me that I can never tell anyone. But I want him to stay. "I was thinking about how soft your lips are, and how much I want to look at you. And I was wondering if your lips would be gentle, not rough like the men were."

"Who were the men?" he asks.

I drop my head, ashamed. Tendrils of fear and self-loathing weave through my chest and tear at my throat. They broke me. They took all of my good parts and twisted and turned them into everything I hate.

Declan takes his other hand out of his pocket and puts it on my cheek. "Zahra, I will never hurt you. And you don't have to tell me anything if you don't want to."

"I want to, but I'm scared you'll leave." All the words are on the tip of my tongue, begging to be set free. My psychiatrist, Doctor Marshall, said it was okay if I wanted to start talking about what happened to me, but to remember that some people may not understand, or know what to say.

I'm so afraid that if I let the words out, Declan won't see me the same way anymore. He'll see the dirty, ugly little girl I've tried to hide all my life.

"I won't leave. I'll never leave."

I try to hold them in, but they tumble out anyway. "They were..." I hesitate. Declan's hand slides around my waist. He pulls me close so my chest is against his and I'm certain I can feel his heart beat in time with mine.

"My father sold me to men... so they could have sex with me," I say. "He um... he forced me to do things I didn't want to do. I had no choice, I had to protect my sister. I wanted it to be me, not her. But I didn't like it, I didn't want to—I wanted to save my little sister."

He pulls my head to his shoulder and strokes my hair while I cry. "I won't ever let anyone hurt you again, Zahra, I promise."

I lift my head and Declan stares at me. He inches closer until his lips are almost touching mine. "Can I kiss you? Do you want to kiss me? You can say no."

I can only nod. My words are now a tangled mess of letters I can no longer make sense of.

Declan pulls me closer again until his warm breath tickles my lips. Then... he kisses me. And it's soft, and gentle, and sweet.

While I kiss him, his arms wrap around me and he rubs my back all the way up to my neck where he tangles his fingers through my hair.

I don't ever want to stop, and when Declan takes my hands and laces his fingers through mine, the weight of the entire world is lifted off my shoulders and I can finally breathe.

The sunshine warms my back, and the cool breeze blows through the trees and causes the leaves to rustle, then, there's complete and utter silence as Declan stops kissing me and stares into my eyes.

He smooths his hands up and down my arms, then takes my hands again and brings them to his lips. When he kisses my fingertips one by one, I know I finally belong.

I am free. I am alive. And now, I am loved.

Nothing in the world can ruin this moment.

Declan sits on the grass and pulls me down onto his lap so he can put his arms around my waist. He kisses my head and whispers, "Are you still okay?"

I rest my head on his shoulder and reach my hand up to cup his cheek. "I'm always okay with you."

We sit beneath the oak tree for a long time. There's not a moment I think about counting down the seconds, or wishing it was time to go back to my room. All I feel is complete and utter contentment.

I kissed her
Beneath the old oak tree
My girl forever
The one for me

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DECLAN

September 16

I've wanted to kiss her for so long. I've dreamed about it, I've thought about it, and I've questioned myself over and over again. I had to take it slow, and I was going to wait even longer, but seeing her looking at me nervously, biting her plump pink lip while staring at *my* lips... I had to ask. And I'm so glad I did.

I've only kissed two girls in the past. The first was Macy Plain when I was fifteen. We were at a party playing truth or dare. It was a quick, messy, awkward kiss. The next time I kissed a girl wasn't until my seventeenth birthday when Kenzie Blake and I started dating. That relationship lasted all of two weeks before she decided I was "boring". After Kenzie broke up with me, I decided to stop searching for a girlfriend, and start focusing on my future.

As soon as my lips touched Zahra's, I was done for. I wanted *her* to be my future.

I take Zahra's hand and lace my fingers through hers. "Do you want to come up to the treehouse?"

She looks up, and when she does, I notice the scar on her neck. I've seen it a few times before, but I've never mentioned it. It looks as though she's had a rope tied around her neck. I swallow the lump in my throat wondering how anyone could be so cruel to such a beautiful, innocent girl. *Or... what if she did that herself... like the other scars?*

Her eyes meet mine. "Is it safe up there? I won't fall?"

I trace my fingers up and down her arm as I shake my head. "It's safe. Charles and I still go up there now and then."

"Okay," she says, but she still sounds unsure.

I climb up the wooden ladder we made using planks of timber, and when I reach the top, I look down at Zahra who's smiling up at me. "Come

on up.”

She nods before slowly making her way up. When she reaches the top, I help her onto the floor of the treehouse, and she gets to her knees. “It’s so nice up here.”

Leaning against one of the timber walls, I shove my hand into my pocket and take out the gift I have for her.

When she sits beside me, it takes all the strength I have not to pull her into my arms and kiss her again. *Slow*. I remind myself that Zahra is different, I can’t rush her into anything, or I could lose her. That thought already tears me up inside.

She smooths her hands over her white dress, tugging on the hem to cover her thighs.

“I got you a gift,” I say.

Her eyes grow wide. “I... ah... Why? I didn’t do anything for you.”

“You don’t have to do anything for me. I wanted to give you something. It’s kind of from my parents as well... I guess.”

“But I—” She twists her fingers together in her lap. “I don’t know what to say... or do. I’m sorry.” Tears well in her eyes.

Has no one ever given her a gift in her life? My heart aches at the thought. I place my hand over hers as I tuck a strand of hair behind her ear. “Please don’t cry, Zahra. You don’t need to say anything, I thought you’d like this.” I take the mobile phone from beside my thigh to show her.

“It’s a phone,” she says. Her eyes light up. “You got me a phone? Am I allowed to talk to you on it?”

I smile and let out a quiet laugh. “Of course. That’s what it’s for. I thought we could text each other, or call... or you could even use it to take photos of the things you love here.

When her smile widens, the urge to kiss her overwhelms me again. “Can I hug you?” I ask.

She nods.

I slide my arm around behind her and move closer until her thigh is flush against mine. As she relaxes into me, she asks, “Declan, can you show me how to use it?”

I switch it on and explain the settings and show her how to use the camera and the messages. She takes everything in and listens intently, never asking questions, just nodding and saying she understands. It’s almost

surreal to know that she's never had a phone, or even the same electronics I've always taken for granted.

When I pull my phone from my pocket, Zahra drops her head on my shoulder, watching me.

"I'll send you a text, okay?"

Another nod. This quiet, adorable girl has my heart in her hands. Without words, she manages to give me everything I need and more, and all it takes is a silent nod, or a tiny smile of gratitude.

Me: Hi Zahra

When her phone chimes with a message, she smiles.

My Girl: Hello Declan, thank you for giving me this phone.

Me: You're welcome xxx

My Girl: What does xxx mean?

I can't help laughing.

Zahra bites her lip, then asks, "Should I know? Everything is so different here, I'm sorry if I ask stupid questions."

"It's not stupid at all." The blush creeps into my cheeks, and instead of saying it out loud, I text her back.

Me: They mean kisses.

A smile graces her lips, but her eyes stay fixed to her phone.

My Girl: I like them. xxx

I tighten my arm around her waist as her phone chimes again. This time it's not me.

"Oh, it's Jaymee," she says, "can I write back?"

"Yep, you sure can."

Zahra shows me the message from Jaymee.

Jaymee: OMG you have a phone now we can text each other lol

“What’s OMG and lol?” she asks.

“Oh my god and laugh out loud. You’ll get used to text speak. Jaymee uses it all the time.”

For the first time, I hear her giggle, and it’s a beautiful sound.

Zahra: I’ll text you when I get back to Housing Hope. I’m with Declan in the tree house now.

Jaymee: OMG DID YOU KISS? Tell me everything!!!!!!

Zahra’s cheeks turn pink and when she turns her head to look at me, I shrug and laugh. “Sorry. Jaymee also loves to know everything about everyone. But you don’t have to tell her anything, if you don’t want to.”

“Is it rude to tell her I will talk to her later?”

“Nope. Not at all.”

Zahra texts back Jaymee and tells her she’ll talk to her tonight, then she sits her phone on the timber floor by her legs. “Thank you for the phone, Declan. And for bringing me here today... and for—” She pulls her legs up to cross them, her head still resting on my shoulder. “For kissing me,” she adds.

Kiss her again. My thoughts are in disarray. I’m being careful not to push her away, but I want to feel her lips again one more time before we go back. With a heavy sigh, I make the decision.

“Zahra, can I kiss you again... please?”

Her lips curve into a smile. “Yes.”

As she sits beside me, I slide my hand up to cup her cheek, inching closer with each bated breath. When our lips meet, I hesitate for a long second, breathing in and out, forcing myself to slow down... to make this moment last.

A tiny sigh leaves her lips. It’s enough for me to know she’s ready, and without another moment of hesitation, I swipe my tongue across her lips as she opens her mouth to kiss me back.

The kiss is deep and urgent, and when I tighten my arm around her waist, she moves closer, sliding one leg over mine until I pull her onto me. When she’s straddling my thighs, I run my hands up and down her back before tangling my fingers through her long brown hair.

My jeans become tighter as the bulge in my pants grows. I don't want to stop kissing her. I *can't* stop kissing her. She shuffles closer, her hands gripping my shoulders. Breathless little moans leave her lips.

When she runs her fingers through my hair, I exhale, and our breaths mingle. I kiss her jaw. I kiss her neck, and I continue to pepper soft kisses across her collarbone before I slide my hand up to her neck and rub my thumb over the scar on her throat. "Zahra," my voice is husky.

"Mmm..."

"What happened?" I ask, trailing my fingertip across the raised scar.

She slides her hands down to my chest, but her eyes never leave mine. "A man wanted to tie me up. I couldn't breathe and the more I tried to move, the tighter the rope got." She sighs. "I almost died. My father... he killed—he killed the man, well, he told me he did."

Her father killed a man for hurting her, yet *he* hurt her over and over again. What kind of sick world was she living in? "You don't have to talk about it anymore." Tears fall from her eyes. I cup her cheeks and wipe them away with my thumbs. "You're safe now. If I do anything to hurt you, please tell me, okay?"

She nods before she runs her fingertip across the small scar on my forehead. "I like talking to you... You have a scar too. What happened?"

I pull her into my chest and stroke her hair. Her breath tickles my neck sending goose bumps across my body. My dick is still hard, and she must be able to feel it pressed against the warmth of her own body. I try not to move too much as she wriggles closer. I'd give anything for my hormones to quit working right now. I just want to hold her, right here, forever.

"I fell off my bike when I was fifteen. Charles and I were racing through the park and I hit a rock. Flew right over the handlebars and landed face first in the dirt."

"Did it hurt?"

"Yep. It hurt a lot actually. Thank god I only needed six stitches."

"I've had stitches before," she whispers as she traces her finger over my scar again.

"You have? Where did you have them?"

She extends her arm to show me her wrist. The same scars I've seen many times. I run my finger over the longest one. From her wrist, it's

around five centimetres long. “I had stitches in the back of my head too, but my hair covers it now. And I had some in...” She hesitates, then points down between her legs. “Down there... inside me, it hurt a lot and took a long time to heal.”

No! Why would she ever need stitches down there? Why? It makes me physically ill to consider what could have possibly happened for her to need stitches. She’s seventeen!

I rub my hand over her back. “I’m so sorry, I wish nothing bad ever happened to you.”

She shrugs. “I didn’t listen, and I was punished. It was my fault.”

“Nothing that happened to you was your fault. You were a child.”

“But... if I had done what I was told, I wouldn’t have been punished. My father warned me, he said I had to try harder... but I was so small, and they were... so big.” She sobs into my neck and this time I pull her hard against my chest until there’s no space between us. I rub her back, stroke her hair and tell her that she’s safe now and everything will be okay.

I hope I’m right.

I'd run away with you
Across a thousand miles
But the memories will chase me down
And steal away my smiles

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ZAHRA (*Carlie*)**October 16***1 month later**11.30am*

Freedom is something that still has no meaning to me. While I'm allowed to go out and do things I've never done before, I'm trapped inside my own mind. I miss my sister so much that some days it hurts to even acknowledge she once existed on this earth. I miss my mother, and the memories that led me to believe she was the one who tried to save me. Not the one who deliberately got pregnant with me in the hopes of making money.

I was born for something I should never have known. The realisation my own parents chose that life for me will never leave. I shouldn't have snuck into Meg's office to read my file. I was blissfully unaware of the truth and now, I wish I'd never found out. The report in my file said my mother had been dating my father since they were both fifteen. It went on to say they were involved in crimes such as drug trafficking, prostitution, and theft.

Apparently, after I was born, my mother changed her mind and wanted to leave with me, but it was too late. She was already under my father's control. I want to turn back time and imagine her as the loving, caring mother who kissed away my tears and held me when I was sad. But all those memories are tainted now, like the depths of my soul.

Some days, I wish I was back with my father where I knew everything. I knew what to expect and when, and while I hated every moment of it, it was always familiar.

Here in Rockburn Grove, nothing is.

Everyone has shadows and secrets. People aren't easy to read through their happy painted smiles and beautifully made up faces. Everyone is a stranger. Everyone except Declan.

I close my journal and place my hand on the cover. This journal is filled with happiness. It's every word I remember Declan saying to me from the moment I arrived, to this morning when he told me he was going away with his family and Charles' family for the weekend.

He's leaving me, and I don't understand why. He promised he'd never leave.

I told him I need him to stay. I told him I want him to be right here beside me, every day. And when he told me it was his family tradition to go camping at Greystone during the school holidays, I told him I would run away if he left me alone again.

I tried to make him understand, but he wouldn't listen. He kept saying I'd be okay, and that I could talk to Jaymee or spend some time in the library, reading. I didn't mean to shout at him. I was desperate for him to stay, and in the end, I screamed and told him to leave.

An hour after Declan left, Meg came into my room to talk to me. She said I needed to become independent and that relying on Declan twenty-four-seven was unhealthy. It's the same thing my psychiatrist says, and the same thing we talk about in Girl's Club.

Meg told me that this little break from Declan would be good for me. That it would help me find myself... whatever that means.

All the pieces of myself are gone. They're spread across my old town and the surrounding cities where each man who purchased me took a part of me I will never get back. All my pieces are lying discarded on the floors of dirty hotel rooms and cellars, lavish mansions, and in every room in the house I used to call home. I'll never be able to find myself, and I don't want to.

All I know is that when Declan is gone, everything hurts, and when he's here, everything is perfect.

When I hear his voice, I almost cry. The tears well in my eyes and my throat tightens. I want to run to him and beg him to stay. Instead, I inhale then hold my breath as he sits beside me and apologises.

"I'm sorry I left earlier. I did—I didn't know what to say... or do. I'm not used to having a girl—a girlfriend."

I exhale and close my eyes while I think about the words I want to say. They don't come out, so I open my journal to today's date, and pass it to Declan.

He looks down at the page and for a few minutes, he's silent. Then, a single tear drips onto the page blurring the ink and making a tiny little pattern around his teardrop.

"Please don't cry," I say.

When our eyes finally meet, I find the most beautiful shade of blue staring back at me. "You wrote this to me?" he asks.

I nod. "Sometimes I can't say the words I want to say, so I write them instead. I'm sorry I shouted at you."

He takes my hand. "Zahra, you can talk to me. Even if your words don't make sense, or if you're sad or crying. I will always try to understand."

I swallow the lump in my throat and take my journal back from Declan's hands. "I can try to read it now... unless you don't want me to?"

Declan puts his arm over my shoulder. "I always want to hear you."

I lean against him and look down at the words. *I can do it. It's only Declan and me.*

He runs his fingers through my hair as I read the words I wrote this morning.

"Declan, I don't know how to tell you what it feels like when you talk to me. I can't explain the happiness I feel because it's something I've never felt before. Sometimes I'm not even sure if happiness is the right word. When you look at me, all the pain disappears and floats away as if it never existed in my life at all. When you talk to me, my heart jumps in my chest and my breaths become caught in my throat. I wonder if that's all happiness is. Just a whole lot of feelings that don't make any sense, but help me realise I am alive, and that someone cares about me."

My tears begin to fall and Declan whispers against my ear. "You can stop if you want to."

I shake my head and continue through the tears. "When you told me you were leaving again, all of those feelings disappeared. I tried so hard to find them, but everything was aching, and my lungs weren't working, and with every breath I took, I could only imagine you walking away and never coming back. I'm sorry I need you, and that my need doesn't make sense to anyone but me. And I'm sorry I begged you not to go, then screamed at you to leave. I wanted to tell you that no one has ever stayed with me before,

and I'm afraid I'll lose you. And if I lose you, I won't want to live in this world anymore."

When I close my journal, Declan wraps his arms around me and hugs me. Slowly, I put my arms around him and breathe in his scent. "Please don't go."

He kisses my forehead. "Zahra, I promise you I'll come back. It's three days, I'll be back on Sunday afternoon. I'll take heaps of pictures to show you, too."

I drop my arms from his neck and sit back on the sofa. "Why can't you stay?"

"I want to go. This is something we always do. You're sad, Zahra, and it's okay. Remember, you're safe here."

I stand and look down at Declan. "You don't like me anymore?" I question, confused.

"Of course I do. Every day I like you more than I did the day before."

I shake my head. "Then you would stay. I haven't done anything wrong."

Declan stands and extends his hand, but I can't touch him. It will only remind me of how much I want him to hold me. I have to leave. I can't be here if Declan doesn't want me.

"I'm sorry," I say, before I turn and run out of the Housing Hope building and head toward the city. I need to run. I need to get away.

Declan's voice fades into the background as I continue along the street. When I reach the city centre, I head into the shopping plaza. Everyone is walking by with smiles on their faces and bags filled with things they've bought. I look down at my own hands. They're empty. Like my heart. Like me.

I wish Eli had never brought me to this town, and I wish I'd never met Declan.

* * *

12.15pm

At the park at the end of the main street, I climb up the bright yellow ladder and crawl through the plastic tunnel until I come to the climbing wall that

leads up into the top tower of the playground. From here, I can see all the way down Main Street.

I've been here before with Declan. He wanted to show me what a playground was. I was in awe. There were so many children running around with smiling faces as though their entire worlds were perfect. They wore happiness like I wore scars. It showed on their faces, and in their squeals of delight. I was sure everyone could see it, the same way I'm sure everyone can see right through me until my scars are the only things that exist.

I pull my knees to my chest and drop my head. When I hear a soft, quiet voice, I raise my head. "Are you sad?" A little girl tilts her head and looks down at me. She's wearing a bright yellow dress and matching yellow shoes. She plants her hands on her hips and squints. "I said... Are you sad?"

I nod. "A little."

"Why?"

"Because I miss someone."

"Who do you miss?" The little girl drops to her knees and puts her hand on mine.

"My boyfriend."

Her lips form into an O and she giggles. "You got a boyfriend?"

Another nod.

A voice calls out from the bottom of the playground. "Hallie, what are you doing up there?"

She jumps to her feet and peers over the edge of the platform I'm sitting on. "I'm talking to a sad girl."

"Come back now," the female calls.

Hallie looks down at me and smiles. "Are you coming now too?"

I shake my head as she sits on the edge of the tunnel slide, then disappears with an echo of giggles.

More children come and go. Some of them stop to ask my name or ask me why I'm sitting on the playground. Others run past me as though I'm invisible.

Hallie appears again through the tunnel. "Is your name Zahra?"

"How do you know?" I ask.

"Your boyfriend is down there. He told me to tell you to come back now."

I swallow hard and turn to look down to the ground. Declan is standing by the swings with his hands in his pockets, and Charles is standing beside him.

Hallie points through the little gap between the bright blue barriers. “My brother is down the bottom too. His name is Charles.”

“You’re Charles’ sister?”

She nods and smiles. “Charles is my big, big brother. And Declan is my friend too.”

I sigh and give in. “Okay, I’ll come back down.”

Hallie takes my hand. “Want me to hold your hand?”

“No, I’ll be okay.”

I follow her through the tunnel and back down the red step ladder. At the bottom, she jumps to the ground and runs to Charles and Declan. “I found her!” she squeals, pointing to me.

Declan doesn’t take his eyes off me as I walk toward him. When I’m in front of him and we’re standing toe to toe, he puts his arms around me. “Come on, I want to show you something.”

I don’t say a word as I follow him across the park and into the forest where the giant pine trees remind me of the forest behind Eli’s cabin. We walk in silence for almost ten minutes before Declan stops and tells me to close my eyes.

Reluctantly, I clamp them shut and wait for his next instruction.

“Do you trust me?” he asks.

“Yes.” A warm breath lingers on my lips sending goose bumps all over my body. Butterflies fill my stomach and my breath catches in my throat. I count the seconds in my head as they pass, and exactly fourteen seconds later, Declan’s lips touch mine. It’s a delicate, quick kiss. But it stirs something inside me and leaves me craving more. “Can I open my eyes now?”

He places a small box in my hand, then says, “Now you can open them.”

When I look down at my hands, the small white box is tied with a big pink ribbon. “What is this?”

Declan laughs. “It’s a present, for you. I was going to give it to you when I got back. But I want you to have it now.”

I extend my hand. “I can’t take this. I don’t deserve it.”

He places his hand over mine. “You do deserve this, Zahra. Please open it.”

Carefully, I untie the pink bow, then lift the lid on the box. I gasp when I see what’s inside. A thin, silver ring sits in the box. I take it out and hold it up to see the outside of the band is inscribed with tiny writing that reads, ***I promise you, forever.***

Tears spring to my eyes as I slide the ring onto my finger. “It’s so beautiful, Declan. But I don’t understand... I don’t—”

He presses his finger to my lips. “Shhh... I’m eighteen, and you’re only seventeen, and maybe we won’t be—we might not be boyfriend and girlfriend forever. But no matter what, Zahra, I promise you that whatever happens, I’ll always be your friend.”

“Forever?”

He nods and leans forward to kiss my cheek. “I promise you, forever.”

“And you’ll come back on Sunday?”

“For sure.”

I wrap my arms around Declan and hug him tight. “Thank you... for everything.”

He whispers against my ear, “I like you a lot, Zahra. I want to make you happy, and I’ll keep trying until you’ve got so much happiness that there will be no room left for sadness.”

“Declan...”

“Yeah?”

“Would you kiss me again... please?”

When his lips touch mine, all the warm, fuzzy feelings are back. The sadness that constantly plagues me is washed away with the memories of a little girl who once wished for a fairy tale prince, but got caught in the middle of a tragic nightmare.

Perhaps I have lost
Too much of my soul
So much that I
Will never be whole

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ZAHRA (*Carlie*)**October 20***8.00pm*

Jaymee stands from her seat in the circle and looks down at me before she speaks. She takes my hand and smiles. “It’s not so bad. You’ll see.”

This group is for young girls aged from thirteen to twenty-one who have come to Rockburn Grove to start a new life. Today is my first time here. I didn’t want to come. I’ve been saying no since the week I arrived at Housing Hope.

Meg told me it would be a good way to make some new friends, and to support Jaymee who has become my self-appointed *best* friend. She’s one of the few people my age—other than Declan and Charles—who know a little about my past.

Meg nods toward Jaymee, and she starts speaking. “So, you all heard a lot about me already, but Zahra, she’s my bestie, this is her first time here, so I said I’d go first to show her what it’s all about.”

Everyone smiles, even the girl who twists her hands nervously in her lap when I glance at her. She’s wearing a black hoodie and has the hood pulled down so it almost covers her sad eyes. I’ve seen her a few times at Housing Hope, but I’ve never heard her speak, not even to Meg.

“As you all know, I have an eating disorder, but I’m learning to love food. Cheeseburgers are my absolute favourite right now. But when I was twelve, I started high school, and I was worried about what I looked like. Was I pretty enough? Was I thin enough? Would I get chosen in the sports club? I was afraid I wasn’t perfect, and I started making lists for everything, including what I ate. I cut back on most foods and by the time the year was over, I’d been admitted to the hospital where they told Mum I was anorexic. I didn’t believe them, and when they forced me to eat, I vomited every time.”

Jaymee looks at me again. “So, what I’m trying to say is, you might be sick, or have something wrong with you, or if something terrible happened to you, you can get better. Especially here in Rockburn Grove where we’re lucky enough to have the best hospitals and doctors. Don’t give up.”

Jaymee drops into her seat and lets out a heavy sigh. “See, not so hard,” she says.

“Zahra, would you like to go next?” Meg asks.

I shake my head.

“I will,” a tiny voice pipes up. It’s Natalie. She’s fifteen and has pale blue eyes and blonde hair. Her bedroom is next door to mine at Housing Hope, but like me, she doesn’t talk much. Meg encourages her to speak.

“Hi everyone, and welcome, Zahra, I hope we can be friends because you’re really pretty.”

My cheeks heat and I bite my lip.

Jaymee moves her chair closer and holds my hand as Natalie continues. “It’s been seven days since I last cut.” She tugs on the hem of her long sleeve top and pulls it over her hands as everyone congratulates her. When she slumps back into her seat, she wipes a tear from her eye.

“You don’t want to say anything else?” Meg asks.

Natalie shakes her head. “No thank you, Meg.”

“Zahra?” Meg says.

Jaymee whispers in my ear, “You don’t have to tell them everything. Just say hi if you want to.”

Nervously, I stand. All eyes are on me, waiting for me to say something. I wonder if any of them had the same life as me.

When I start talking, the words come out easier than I anticipated. “Hello, I’m Zahra, and I’m almost eighteen. When I was little my dad, ah—my father sold me to men so they could have sex with me. I was only eight when it started, and I didn’t know it was wrong at first. I only knew I didn’t like it. I wanted to make him happy, so I always did what I was told... for as long as I can remember, my father sexually abused me. When I was seventeen, I was rescued and Eli—he’s my friend now—he brought me here to Rockburn Grove. My little sister, Cathie, she died... Um... my father let men use her too, but she got sick and I—I think the drugs killed her.”

My mouth goes dry and when I swallow, tears well in my eyes. Jaymee tugs on my hand. “You can stop if you want to.”

With an inhale, I shake my head. I *need* to tell them. “Sometimes, I want to go home. The sense of loss is overwhelming. I’m grieving for someone I know I should hate. Then... I remember that fathers aren’t supposed to have sex with their daughters, or sell them to other men for sex. They’re not supposed to keep them locked inside a house so their skin won’t tan, and their bodies won’t grow. Girls are supposed to be outside, having fun, living... laughing.”

Jaymee has tears streaming down her face, and the other girls are staring at me with blank expressions. “I’m sorry if I made you all sad. And I’m sorry if I don’t talk to you or be your friend, but I’m learning all these new things and it’s hard, and sometimes I want to leave everything behind and disappear.”

Jaymee stands and wraps her arms around me. A few seconds later, another pair of arms wraps around my waist. Then another, and suddenly all the girls are hugging me and I’m crying, and I don’t know what to do. *Is this what love feels like?*

Meg’s voice breaks through the crying. “Come on girls, let’s give Zahra a little breathing room.”

Everyone pulls their chairs closer so our little circle is even smaller, and we’re all holding one another’s hands. I’ve never felt like this before, and even though Declan isn’t here, I’m filled to the brim with happiness.

Monsters in the shadows
And hidden in plain sight
Preying on the hopeless
Predators by night

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October 30

It's been six months since Carlie was rescued. Shortly after, her father and brother disappeared without a trace. Usually, once we get the girls out, these cases are wrapped up within eight to twelve weeks. This tells me one thing... someone with contacts in our agency is helping Rob Browne.

Three days after Cathie died, the autopsy report came through. Her tiny body had shut down due to a massive overdose of sedatives and bleeding from her internal organs. Scans showed she had a bruised trachea and a collapsed lung, and X-rays showed three cracked ribs. Numerous burns were present on her stomach, side, and back which the report said were likely caused by cigarettes. To my utter horror, this child—this twelve-year-old little girl—had an IUD recently inserted into her preteen uterus and showed signs of severe sexual trauma.

The pain she would have endured before I found her, sickens me. My suspicion is that Rob Browne planned it all. He knew Cathie was going to die, and he followed me back to the cabin to make sure I took the fall. Of course, there's no proof, but when I think about it, everything adds up.

From what Carlie said, Cathie didn't do what she was told. It was clear Trystan hated her, and her father certainly didn't show the same level of care he showed to Carlie. Even in her weakened state, Cathie was fighting back. She was a risk to him, and to his business.

Callum slams his hand down on the desk, sending a pile of paperwork flying off the edge. "We let that bastard in. He fucking betrayed us. And now he's free from all of it. It's bullshit, Eli."

I take another look at the photographs in my hand. Randall Eastlake lies naked in a prison shower stall with the handle of a shank sticking out of his ass. The gruesome images get worse when I flick through them to see

that each of his fingers have been hacked off by something that was obviously blunt. In another photograph, his face is unrecognisable. One eyeball has popped out of its socket and rests like a blob of sickening goo on his cheekbone.

I've seen some fucked up shit, but these pictures remind me that even the worst criminals are repulsed by paedophiles. The last image shows the shower stall covered in blood, and the words *Rot in Hell*.

"They sure fucked him up," I say, throwing them face down on the desk. While I'm glad the world is rid of yet another perverted creep, I'm frustrated we didn't get all the information we needed. I was positive that if I had the chance to talk to him, he would have told me something.

Callum sighs. "There's been no sign of Browne, or his kid. The house is empty now, and other than the box of journals we found, there was no evidence. The girl's journals had fifteen names of interest in them. Some could be aliases. I've got a few guys still working on it. Three of the fifteen are already in prison and have been for years. Rob Browne definitely has connections, quite a few by the sounds of it. We need to find him before he starts up business again—if he hasn't already."

I sigh into my hands. "You think they'll still help him now he's on the run?"

"I *know* they're helping him. And when I find them, there'll be hell to pay."

I flick through the thin folder of evidence we have. "What about the school? Carlie said Trystan had two girlfriends, and a few friends who visited their house."

He shrugs. "Check it out. Call Beckett and see if you can get one of his men to go with you."

I nod before shaking his hand and leaving the office.

Harrisville High School is within walking distance of Rob Browne's old house. It's a small school with four hundred students. Surely someone here knows something. The principal, Derrick Chamberson, is an older man with greying hair and a thick beard.

After a brief introduction, he sits back in his leather recliner and clicks the top of his ball-point pen.

"Hearts of Innocence? What is it you do there."

I hand him my card over the desk. “Along with the police force, and various community organisations, our agency investigates cases of child sex trafficking, and child sexual abuse.”

He narrows his eyes and cocks his head slightly. “And you think Trystan Browne is at risk?”

“We have reason to believe he could be, yes.”

When I ask him about Trystan, he smiles, nods, and gives me a glowing report of how Trystan was top of his class, and was involved with the junior swimming and cricket teams. He goes on to say he always had time to help the teachers when he wasn’t studying, and that he never got into any type of trouble.

None of it sounds like the same Trystan I met. If I had to take a wild guess, Rob Browne’s paying off the entire school board.

“Must be a shame to lose such a talented, valuable student,” I say.

He scratches his neck where his skin blooms with a red tinge, then loosens his tie. “He’s moving on to bigger and better things.”

“Oh, where’s he headed?”

Chamberson gets up and opens the window before pouring himself a glass of water. He doesn’t look up when he replies, “Can’t for the life of me remember where he was headed.”

Liar. He’s hiding something.

“Did you get the chance to meet Carlie and Cathie?” I ask.

He straightens, then sits back down and clasps his hands together on the desk. “I did.” He nods. “Rob bought them in for academic testing late last year. Lovely, polite young girls the both of them. That Carlie, she’s a bright one. Quite an attractive young girl too.”

I lean back and cross one leg over my knee. “Mr Browne never mentioned them being enrolled in school?”

His knuckles turn white as he clenches. “Ah... no. The girls... they’re um—Since their mother up and left them, they got a bit anxious, you know? Don’t do too well in social environments.”

Knowing I’m not going to get much more out of Derrick Chamberson, I thank him for his time. I don’t want him to get skittish and leave town.

On my way out, my suspicions about Trystan are confirmed when I spot the framed plaque on the wall.

***Senior School Upgrade
made possible by donation of
\$100,000 from Robert Browne***

Standing at the sign, I read it again, knowing exactly where that money came from.

“That guy’s an asshole,” a quiet voice beside me says.

I turn to see a young kid. “You know him?”

He huffs. “I’ve seen him a few times. Tryst used to pay me to copy my homework. If I’d known he had that much money, I would’ve asked for more than fifty bucks.”

“You went to his house?”

The kid looks over his shoulder to the officer who came with me.

“You a cop?”

“Nah, I’m not. He is. You want to talk about something?”

He looks up and down the corridor, then whispers, “Will I get into trouble?”

“Did you do anything wrong?”

He shakes his head, then whispers, “Four-two-eight Ridge Street. Five o’clock.” He walks away without looking back.

Sitting in the car, I text Callum to let him know what’s going on.

Me: The principal knows something. Have him checked out.

Callum: On it. Do you think he’s on the list? An alias?

Me: It’s possible. He talked the boy up as though he was a star student. And you’ll never guess what else I saw...

I send him the image of the plaque in the school corridor.

Callum: You’re fucking kidding me?

Me: I bet this whole town is protecting that bastard!

Callum: I’m calling it in. We need to get a warrant out for his arrest. You headed back?

Me: Meeting with a kid who was friends with the boy at 5pm. We’ll run some checks first and I’ll call you later.

Callum: No worries.

* * *

At 5pm, after checking out the address and the family, I find out the kid's name is Troy, and his parent's own a local hardware store in town. Troy and his sister, Mari both go to the same school.

I drop Officer Brady off at the local café and make my way to the address. It's a small house in a quiet street. When I knock on the door, the kid opens it. "Your parent's home?"

"Nah, they work late." He extends his hand to shake mine. "I'm Troy by the way."

"Eli." I step inside and take a look around, surprised the kid has let me into his home without questioning who I am, or where I'm from. A frame on the wall holds a large photograph of the family. The boy is Troy, beside him, a girl who looks a year or two younger. Their parents stand behind them, their arms wrapped lovingly around their children.

"You have a sister?"

"Yeah, Mari, she's at a friend's place. So, if you're not a cop, what are you? FBI or something?"

I laugh. "Nope. I'm from a private agency. We investigate child abuse cases." After a short silence, Troy speaks up, "That's why you're after Trystan's father? Because of what he did to Carlie?"

"What do you know about Carlie?"

His cheeks redden and he drops his gaze. "Not much. I only saw her a few times. The first time was when Trystan introduced me to his father. He wouldn't let me talk to Carlie, which I thought was kind of weird."

"Did Rob say anything to you?"

He shakes his head. "Not the first time. But I saw something... I um... well..."

"Take your time," I say.

Troy looks up at me. "He had his hands on her... like under her dress. She didn't move or nothin', but when she turned around, I saw she was crying. The next time I went there, Rob was sitting on the sofa, and Trystan's little sister, Cathie, I think her name was, she was on his lap, but she was crying. He grabbed her by her hair and slapped her face."

“Anything else?”

“Ah... I kind of um... well I was hanging around waiting for Trystan one morning, and I saw something through the window. I hopped up on the stack of crates and looked in.” Troy jumps to his feet and paces back and forth in the kitchen. “Her dad was holding her up by her hair... real high too. And she was—” He scrubs his hands down his face. “She was naked, and he was touchin’ her. He’s a fuckin’ psycho. What kind of sick fuck does that to their daughter?”

I lean back and cross my arms over my chest. It’s not common for teenage boys to speak freely about issues such as these. I sense a lot of anger in his tone. “Why are you telling me this? Why didn’t you go to the cops, or at least tell your parents... or someone at school?”

He slumps down in the chair and rubs his head. “Trystan and I were kinda friends. But I hated the way he talked about girls. Especially my sister. She’s only fifteen, but she was obsessed with him.”

Now I’m getting somewhere. “He did something to your sister?”

Troy nods. “Trystan ah—he um, he raped her.”

“She told you?”

He sighs. “Not right away. She came home crying, and Mum was fussing over her and asking her what happened, but she wouldn’t talk. The next day she said she was sick and couldn’t go to school. I heard Trystan and a couple of mates talking, he said something like “she asked for it” then they all laughed.”

Troy slams his fist on the table. “That bastard raped my sister, she begged him to stop, and he told her to shut up.”

“Troy, she needs to file a report.”

He shakes his head hard. “She refuses to. She’s terrified of him. Can you do something?”

“We’re looking for Trystan and his father, so if you hear anything, give me a call, okay?”

Troy drops his head. “What about Carlie? Is she okay?”

I pull a card out of my wallet and slide it across the table. “Sorry, mate, I can’t discuss the details.” I get up to leave.

Troy stands to extend his hand, and we shake. “If my sister wants to talk to you... is that—Can she?”

I nod. “Of course. Twenty-four-seven, on that number.” I point to the card in his hand before I leave.

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Everything is real now
Where once it was a dream
I found my flickering spark of hope
And now I have found me

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CARLIE (*Zahra*)**November 11***18 years old*

I didn't want a party. I was worried about all the things that could go wrong. All the people I could accidentally hurt. Declan's mum, Angela assured me everything would be perfect and that if I needed to, I could stay in Declan's room for a little while to get some space.

The entire living room is filled with pink balloons that float in the air and touch the ceiling. The large dining table is covered in a pink tablecloth and all the plates, bowls and cups are pink too.

I've never seen so much pink in one place. Even the beautifully decorated cake is smothered in thick pink frosting, and tiny pale pink flowers.

The party isn't until 7pm, so I have exactly three hours to get ready. Jaymee is here with her huge case of makeup and something called a curling iron, which she wants to use on my hair. My lack of knowledge is obvious when she shows me her collection of hair accessories, body sprays, and makeup brushes. All I ever had in the way of makeup was lipstick and mascara.

When his hand touches mine, I instantly smile and turn around to see Declan's blue eyes. "This is all so beautiful," I say.

"Like you," he whispers against my ear. My stomach fills with butterflies when Declan kisses my cheek. "Do you want your present now?"

"Um... I—I don't know."

He laughs. "I'll take that as a yes, come on." He tugs on my hand and leads me upstairs to his bedroom. When he opens the door, I drop my hand from his and stand in the doorway. I always feel like I don't belong here. Like this place is all too perfect and beautiful for me. Like I'm an intruder

into Declan's private, perfect world and I don't want to do anything to ruin that.

As always, Declan takes my hand again and reminds me, "You can come in, it's okay."

I take one step, then another. Declan pats the bed for me to sit beside him.

When I sit, he leans across and pushes his hand under his pillow, then he pulls out a small pink box with a white bow wrapped around it. He hands me an envelope first and I slowly open it being careful not to tear the paper.

On the front of the card is a pink heart with "*I love you*" written in the middle of it. I trace my finger over the embellished heart, then open the card. Inside, in neat handwriting it reads,

*Dear Zahra,
I hope this is the happiest birthday you've ever had.
Love Declan.*

I leap across and hug him. I've never had a birthday card. I never celebrated my birthday, and I never imagined I'd ever be lucky enough to have a boyfriend.

"Don't forget this," Declan says, handing me the little pink box.

With shaking hands, I untie the white ribbon, then lift the lid off the box. Inside, there's a beautiful silver bangle with a small, pink heart shaped gemstone dangling off it. I take it out of the box, and while tears stream down my cheeks, I thank Declan for giving me something so beautiful.

He takes the bangle and slips it onto my wrist, then kisses the top of my hand. "Zahra, I want to tell you something, but I don't want to make you cry, or upset you."

I can only nod.

"I... um... well I want to tell you—what I want to say is—" He scrunches his nose and I laugh at the little wrinkles between his eyes. When he smiles, I do too. "I love you, Zahra."

He loves me? Declan loves me.

Suddenly, voices spin through my mind making me dizzy. *He loves you, Carlie. No one else.*

“No, no no no.” This can’t happen, not now. I shake my head hard, but the dizziness won’t go away. Declan takes my hands again, but when he touches me, everything disappears and I’m pulled back into the past. *Your head’s fucked up. You want it. You love it.* “No!” I scream, but nothing comes from my mouth, and when I hear Declan, I beg him to help me. But his voice is replaced by my brother’s... *He loves you, Carlisle.* And my father’s... *Daddy loves you, baby.*

I try to stand up, but when I do, my legs give way and I land on the floor. I can’t breathe. I can’t think, and I can’t see anything but my father’s face, and the faces of the men who said they loved me.

* * *

When I open my eyes, Angela is sitting beside me. I turn my head to her and notice I’m still in Declan’s bedroom. I’m lying on his bed, and he’s sitting at the end near my feet. Angela strokes my hair. “How are you feeling, darling?”

I blink a few times, then look at Declan again. His eyes are covered in clouds of sadness. Sadness I put there—again.

“I’m sorry,” I say to them both.

“No, darling, no. Don’t you apologise for something you have no control over,” Angela says. She leans down and kisses my forehead.

“Remember, you’re safe here. You’ll always be safe here.”

When she leaves, there’s a long, lingering silence between me and Declan. I lift my hand to rub my eyes, and the silver bangle catches my eye. *I love you, Zahra.* Declan’s words fill my mind. Declan loves me. He’s never hurt me. That’s what love is supposed to be. *Right?*

Slowly, he lies beside me and turns to his side, taking my hand in his. He laces our fingers together as I turn to my side and stare into his beautiful blue eyes. “I’m sorry,” he whispers.

He traces his finger over the back of my hand and shuffles closer. “I...” he hesitates and takes a deep breath. “I wanted... I *want* you to know how much I like you. And I wanted it to be special, for your birthday. I’m sorry.”

“Please don’t say sorry. It’s my fault. Sometimes the memories come back so fast and I forget that that’s all they are, and it’s hard to breathe.”

Declan brings my hand to his lips and kisses it. “Do you know what love feels like?” he asks.

My stomach twists in knots. I thought I knew what love was when my mother was alive. I thought I loved my little sister. But there was still so much pain that I was never sure what it really was.

“I think so. At therapy the other day when all the girls hugged me, I thought that was love. But it’s different to what I feel with you, and I want this to be love, too. I want to love you, Declan, but how do I know if I do?”

“What do you feel, right now?”

“Safe. Warm. Like I belong here, with you. Like the past doesn’t matter anymore, as long as you’re holding my hand, as long as you’re with me. I love—Declan, I love you!”

I cannot hide my smile. And when Declan smiles too, I snuggle into him and lay my head on his chest where I can hear his heart beating. “I love you, Declan.”

He twists his fingers through my hair and kisses my head. “I love you, Zahra.” This time, there’s only happiness. And for the first time in my life, I finally know what love is.

* * *

At 6.55pm there’s a knock on the bedroom door and when it opens, Jaymee is smiling. “Oh my god, Zahra you are gorgeous.” She looks me up and down as she comes closer and tilts her head. “Do you like the dress? You don’t look happy?”

Angela comes out of the bathroom. “Overwhelmed,” she tells Jaymee.

I nod. “I’m okay now, I think. Do you think Declan will like this dress?” I glance at myself in the mirror again. The pale pink dress sits above my knees and has a delicate lace trim. It’s flowy and soft and I love the colour.

“He will love it,” Jaymee says. “Because you’re wearing it.” She giggles but when Angela shushes her, she bites her lip and extends her hand. “Come on, let’s go downstairs and show you off to everyone.”

I turn back to Angela who nods in encouragement, but before I take Jaymee’s hand, I hug Angela and thank her for the dress, and for letting me

have a party.

At the bottom of the stairs, I freeze when I see everyone. All the girls from my therapy group are here, as well as Declan's best friend, Charles, and his little sister, Hallie. Jaymee tugs on my hand again. "Come on, let's go say hi."

I shake my head. "I can't... I don't know what to say, or what to do."

"Be yourself. Everything else will be perfect."

With another tug of my hand, I let Jaymee lead me across the dining room to where Declan and Charles are talking. Jaymee taps Declan's shoulder. "Your girlfriend is here." She giggles.

Declan turns around and looks right into my eyes, then down at my dress, and again at me. "You're so beautiful, Zahra."

"Um..." I can't speak.

"Say thank you," Jaymee whispers.

"Thank you," I say quickly.

Jaymee stays with Charles, while Declan takes my hand. He leads me across the room to where his father is talking to another man I've never met before.

When they see us, they stop talking and Ryan, Declan's father, introduces us to Erik, a police officer who has started working in Rockburn Grove. "How are you, sweetheart?" Ryan asks.

"I'm okay now."

Before I can say another word, a familiar voice floats through the room. My head turns to find him before my mind can catch up. "Eli!" I scream when I see him. And when he smiles, my whole world lights up. I run to Eli and he wraps me in a hug and kisses my head. "Look at you. You're so grown up, and this smile..." he steps back, still holding my hands. "This smile suits you. You're happy?"

I nod and tell him about my panic attack earlier, and he rubs my back and reminds me that the memories are only that... just memories. "I have a surprise for you," he says.

I lift my arm and show him my bangle as Declan appears beside me. "Declan got me this, it was a surprise too. And he got me a card, and he told me he loves me, that was the best surprise of all."

Eli shakes Declan's hand and gives him a hug. Then, he asks if I want my surprise in here with everyone around, or if I want to go out into the

back garden where it's quiet. Of course, I choose the garden, since it's my favourite place in Rockburn Grove, and it's the second place that Declan kissed me.

I wait in the back garden on the wooden swing seat with Declan sitting beside me. "I love seeing you smiling and happy," he says.

"It feels nice. I love it too."

He tucks a long strand behind my ear and tells me how much he loves my hair when it's curled in long ringlets, but he's distracted when there's a tiny cry of a baby.

The woman walking toward me has the biggest, brightest smile I've ever seen. In her arms, wrapped in a pink blanket, is a tiny baby.

"Zahra." Her name leaves my lips with barely a whisper.

"That's Zahra?" Declan asks.

I swallow the lump in my throat and nod. My eyes well with tears as she comes closer. "Zahra." I say her name again. And this time I stand, but my knees shake.

"Hi beautiful," she says as she walks toward me.

"Zahra... I missed you." The weight of everything surrounding me comes crashing down and I fall to my knees.

"No, Zahra," Declan says.

I hear Eli's voice. "She's okay, give her a minute."

I take a deep breath and count to ten before I look up at Zahra again. She's here. She's alive. And she has a baby.

Declan helps me to my feet. "Are you okay?"

I nod, not taking my eyes off Zahra. "You're here."

She smiles. "I am. And did I say you look absolutely beautiful, and so, so happy."

"You have a baby... is she—did someone hurt her?" Panic takes hold and Eli reminds me to breathe.

"She's perfect. No one will ever hurt her, not when she has the best Daddy in the whole world."

I peek over Zahra's arm to see bright blue eyes, and tiny bowed pink lips. "She's your baby?"

She nods. "She sure is."

"Who's her father?"

"That would be me," Eli says proudly.

My eyes flit between Eli and Zahra. I had no idea they were together. “You love Zahra?” I ask Eli.

He smiles and kisses her cheek. “I’ve loved her for a long time.”

“What’s her name?” Declan asks.

“Grace,” Zahra says. “Would you like to hold her?” she asks me.

I shake my head hard and step back. The only baby I ever held was my little sister, Cathie, and she died. “I can’t... I might hurt her.”

“You won’t hurt her,” Eli tells me. “But if you don’t want to hold her, it’s okay.”

Eli asks Declan to show him where the bathroom is, and when they leave, Zahra sits beside me on the swing seat and Grace starts to cry. “Is she okay?” I ask looking down at her little face.

“She’s perfect. A little cranky because we woke her up. Tell me, Zahra, what have you been doing here? Have you made friends?”

I nod and tell her everything, even the parts about kissing Declan, and going to group therapy with the other girls. I tell her about the times I ran away, and about all the times I forgot what it was like to have people care about me.

“So Declan is your boyfriend?”

I nod and smile. “I told him I love him. But I’m still confused because I don’t think it’s supposed to hurt when he’s not here. Is that still love?”

She nods and rubs my back. “Honey, it’s going to take you a long time to get used to being loved. And sometimes when people have other things to do, your mind will play tricks on you and make you believe they don’t love you anymore. But that’s not true. Love is a million different things, and people can love you from far away. Like Eli and I love you. And you love us even though we’re not here.”

“Zahra, sometimes I want to go home. I miss my fath—”

She starts to answer me when Eli and Declan come back, but Eli takes baby Grace and says Declan’s mum wants to meet her, and they leave again.

She pulls me into her arms and rubs my back. “I know, honey. But remember what I told you? That wasn’t love. That was abuse, and it was wrong. What your father did, what your brother did. It was all wrong, and it

was all to hurt you. They did it to use you, and to make sure you were too afraid to leave.”

“Everything is confusing here. I don’t understand all the things the girls talk about, and sometimes I cry and get sad, and I don’t know why.”

“You’re healing. You’re leaving Carlie behind. You’re growing and living as Zahra now. It’s a journey. I know it’s all confusing, but one day soon you’ll wake up and you’ll realise you’re finally home.”

“Will you visit again?”

She nods. “Of course. Eli’s thinking of moving, actually. He wants to talk to William about working from the station.”

“You’ll live in Rockburn Grove?”

“I hope so. We’d love Grace to grow up here.”

“Would you let me see her sometimes? I promise I’ll never hurt her.”

Zahra hugs me again. “Of course. Come on, let’s get something to eat, I’m starved.”

Back inside we spend lots of time talking and laughing, and I even eat some party food which I’ve never had before. Everything is perfect and when it’s finally time for them to sing Happy Birthday, I’m worried I might panic again. But with Declan holding my hand, and Eli and Zahra right here beside me, I am *finally* home. And for the first time, I think about my little sister, Cathie, and I smile.

“I love you, jellybean,” I whisper as I blow out the candles on my birthday cake and wish for a world where little girls are loved the right way.

FOUR YEARS LATER

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They see her as a whisper
On a gentle summer breeze
But her love for me is like a hurricane
That brings me to my knees

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DECLAN**November 11***23 years old*

“I can’t explain it, Mum. I love her more than I ever thought it was possible to love someone.”

Mum pats my knee. “Well, tell her that. You don’t need to have a long list of reasons, darling, I’m sure Zahra knows how you feel about her.”

Dad chuckles as he raises his brow. “He wants it to be memorable, love. You know, like the way I proposed to you.”

Mum’s laughing now. “Yes, that night was certainly memorable.” She lifts her leg to show off the ten-centimetre scar she received when dad took her horse riding at sunset. He had planned to propose at the top of Mount Blessing. Half way up the mountain, mum’s horse, Abby, got spooked and reared up, sending Mum to the ground. She landed with her leg twisted and a piece of bone sticking out through her flesh. Dad proposed to her then and there.

“And you still said yes,” Dad reminds her.

“I was in shock, honey.” Mum leans across and kisses his cheek.

“And I didn’t get to see that sunset until six months later. Definitely memorable.”

Mum and dad exchange loving glances and I roll my eyes in mock disgust. “You’re supposed to be helping me.”

“Tell her what you told me.”

Dad shakes his head. “Write her a poem, son. Do something romantic. Take her horse ridi—”

“NO!” Mum and I both shout in unison.

Dad gets up from the sofa. “Look mate, you love her, and you’ve already given her more than she’s ever had in her short life. Tell her how

you feel, in your heart.” He extends his hand. “Now, give your old man a hug.”

I get to my feet and hug my dad before he pats my back. “We’re mighty proud of you, Declan. You’ve grown into a loving young man, and you’re going to make that girl happier than she’s ever been.”

“I hope so, Dad,” I say, “I just want to see her smile.”

* * *

My palms sweat as I drive toward Housing Hope. Today, I’m going to ask Zahra to marry me. I wanted to ask her on her nineteenth birthday, but my parents talked me out of it. They told me to wait a few more years and let Zahra settle into her new life. Now, I’m glad I waited.

The past few years have been a roller coaster of ups and downs. Zahra’s run away from Housing Hope no less than eight times. She’s had emotional breakdowns that leave her almost comatose for days on end, and she regularly has flashbacks so intense they cause her to faint.

The doctors have run scans, and she’s had plenty of tests done, but they always lead to the same conclusion. The psychological abuse she endured has taken its toll on her mentally and emotionally, and it’s something she may never heal from.

The anger and hatred I feel toward her father and brother, and the men who willingly paid to have sex with her when she was a child, is something I’ve never felt before. Sure, I’ve been angry, and I’ve been in my fair share of arguments. But this is something else entirely. Zahra was ruined. Even now, I can look at her, and in her eyes I see a glimmer of a little girl who wants nothing more than to be loved. Knowing what happened to her has helped me be more understanding.

While Charles and Jaymee are expecting their first—completely unplanned—baby any day now, Zahra and I haven’t done anything more than share a few breathtaking kisses and talk about our plans for the future. I never complain.

Since meeting Zahra, I haven’t even thought about half the things boys my age should or would think about. Her happiness is all that matters to me right now. Everything else will come when the time is right. We can spend hours sitting together and talking and there are never any awkward

silences. Everything feels right when she's with me. Six months ago, we discussed moving into my parent's cottage together. It backs onto a small manmade lake and is surrounded by flowers in every colour of the rainbow. She was so excited, and I promised I'd take her there today. She has no idea what else I have planned.

I pull up outside the building and cut the engine. I shove my hand into my pocket to take another look at the silver ring. Since I bought her the bracelet, silver is her favourite colour for jewellery. A single pink diamond sits in a clasp. Around the inside of the band is today's date—Zahra's 23rd birthday. Charles laughed when I told him I got it engraved, as if he doubted she would say yes.

She will say yes. I've told myself the same thing over and over for the past six months.

I snap the lid of the box closed and push it back into my pocket before I head inside.

Meg's at the desk tapping away on the computer and I say a quick hello before I head to Zahra's room. When I knock on the door, it opens immediately. She would have been waiting on the other side, counting down the seconds to 9am.

She bites her lip and smiles.

"Happy Birthday," I say.

Her cheeks blush pink and her voice is soft—quiet. "Thank you."

"You ready to go?"

She nods and I pull her in for a hug before I kick the door closed behind me with my foot. When our lips meet, pulses of electricity surge through my veins reminding me that I'm more in love with her than I was yesterday.

"Declan," she whispers against my lips.

I kiss her cheek, then trail soft, gentle kisses along her jaw. "You okay?"

"Yes. I'm okay. Are you still going to show me the cottage today?"

"Of course." I tuck a loose strand of hair behind her ear, then lace my fingers through hers. "Let's go. I have heaps of plans and only one day."

As we drive through the city and toward the highway, I hold Zahra's hand in mine.

"Have you heard from Charles or Jaymee?" she asks.

"Last night Charles called. He said she could go into labour any day now." I still can't believe my best friend is about to become a father. "I'm sure he'll call as soon as something happens."

"Do you want a baby one day?" Her voice quivers as though the mere thought of it is terrifying.

"One day. But I only want children with you, and only if and when you're ready."

For a few minutes she doesn't talk, only stares blankly out the front window. Something is bothering her, and I need to know what it is.

"Are you okay?" I ask.

"I um... I want to—Don't worry, it's stupid. Everything I think is stupid."

"Hey, babe, no it's not. What's wrong?" I ask as I pull over to the side of the road. When I turn to her, tears are already welling in her eyes.

"Zahra, talk to me." I take her hand and kiss her fingertips.

She inhales and holds her breath for a short second before exhaling. Another inhale. Another exhale. I'm thankful for the breathing exercises her psychiatrist suggested. They work well for the most part unless she has a flashback. Then, there's nothing anyone can do but wait until she rides it out and finds herself safe in reality again.

"I had a dream... about my father. He—he found me, Declan. He—" She sobs as big heavy tears fall from her eyes. "He made me do things, horrible things. And I couldn't get away and I called for you and... and... an —"

I lean across the console and pull her into my arms so I can rub her back. She sobs into my shoulder.

"Shhh... he's gone. You're safe here," I remind her. "You're safe with me. I'm not going to let anyone hurt you again."

"What if he finds me?" she cries.

I shake my head and cup her cheeks with my hands. "Remember what William said? He's got his best officers watching you. If something happens, we've got plans. Remember our plans?"

A year after Zahra arrived in Rockburn Grove, some guy turned up asking around for a young girl named Carlie. In our town, word gets around fast. There are only a select few people who know about Zahra's past, and when the guy dropped into the bakery, Mum called William right away. By the next day he'd arranged a place interstate, a kind of safe house where I could take Zahra if anyone discovered who she really was.

After some investigating, it turned out the guy was the father of Zahra's little sister, Cathie, who died shortly after Eli rescued her. When William found out, he had him taken to the police station where Eli met him and explained what had happened. The poor guy was devastated and blamed himself for not protecting his own daughter, but he was glad Zahra was free. After a few hours, he left town, only leaving behind a letter he asked Eli to give to Zahra in the future.

I agreed with Eli and William that it would be best not to tell Zahra, and even though I feel horrible about it, I think it was the right decision. Every time her little sister is mentioned, Zahra's thrust into the pits of despair all over again. The letter is in a sealed envelope at Mum and Dad's house where it will stay for a while longer.

Zahra nods. "We have to leave."

"That's right. We. You and me. I won't leave you, Zahra, ever. And Jaymee and Charles will come too, you'll never be alone again."

"Did I ruin this day?" She blinks back tears.

"This day is only going to get better."

I'm rewarded with a smile. Finally. And as I take off back along the highway, Zahra thanks me—as always—for listening to her.

The day flies by bike riding along the beach trail before we spend an hour collecting shells and drift wood. We walk through the national park, and hike to the top of Mount Blessing where I tell her the story of Dad's proposal to mum. She laughs, and she talks, and she tells me about the time Eli showed her a waterfall, and how afraid she was back then. She never told me about her fear of water until the day we went to the beach. She said she couldn't talk about it, but as we walk to the top of the trail toward the scenic lookout, Zahra tells me about the times her father plunged her

beneath the bath water until she was fighting for each breath. And while my hatred for him grows stronger, my love for Zahra does too.

After everything she's endured, she still treats the world, and the people around her as though they are fragile when she herself is the most fragile thing I've ever laid hands upon. The heaviness in my heart is lifted when we reach the top of the mountain and Zahra gasps. "Oh, Declan. I can see the whole world from up here."

I snake an arm around her waist. "Isn't it beautiful? The view at sunrise and sunset is magnificent."

"I've never seen anything like this." There's a happiness in her voice I can't get enough of.

I lead her to the barrier where we can look down to the rivers winding through the valleys below. "You know what's amazing here?"

"What?" she asks with excitement.

"You can scream as loud as you want to. Wanna try it?"

"Scream? I'm allowed to?"

I nod. "I'll go first."

She grins, then covers her ears with her hands.

I inhale, and when I scream, I imagine my voice is the only thing I need to destroy her father. To obliterate him, and every single one of the memories she carries like poison in her veins.

When I stop, her eyes are wide. "You were loud. I don't think I can scream that loud."

"Think about something you're angry about. And scream until it's gone."

She takes a breath and holds it for a second before letting out an ear-piercing scream so loud I have to cover my ears, but I still smile.

For a full minute after she screams, Zahra is silent. I imagine she's counting like she always does when she's trying to focus and calm herself down. She turns to me, then leaps into my arms and wraps hers around my neck. "Thank you for letting me do that."

I stroke her hair. "Today is all about you. As long as you're happy, I'm happy."

"I'm happy," she says. "Are we staying until sunset?"

"Not this time. We're going to the cottage now, you ready?"

Her smile lights up, and even her eyes seem brighter.

Hand in hand we race down the mountain in fits of laughter I've only dreamed of hearing spill from her lips. By the time we reach the parking lot, we're both puffing as we get into the car.

* * *

As the sun sets behind the backdrop of the mountain ranges, I pull up in the winding driveway in front of the cottage. It's not the best word to describe a six-bedroom, two storey farm house with a wraparound porch, but my parents insist on calling it a cottage.

Zahra peers out the window, unmoving... silent. When she leans back into the seat, she clamps her eyes shut. Instantly, I'm worried this house could resemble one of the houses she was taken to when she was younger. Panic coils in my chest as Zahra breathes slowly, counting each breath until she reaches ten. I slide my hand gently over hers and squeeze it. "Zahra, are you okay?"

She nods once but doesn't turn to me or open her eyes. When she squeezes my hand, her lip quivers. "It's... so—Declan..."

"Beautiful?" I question.

She nods again and a tear dribbles down her cheek. "I'm afraid if I open my eyes it won't be real."

Smiling, I let go of her hand. "Stay right there." I get out of the car and go around to her side to open her door. Then, I take her hand. "Keep your eyes closed, okay?"

She doesn't say a word as she gets out of the car with her hands trembling.

Slowly, I lead her up the narrow, gravel path and up the steps that lead to the white French doors. When I open the door, I wrap my arm around her waist. "Open your eyes."

After a few deep breaths, she opens them. "It's real," her voice is barely a whisper.

"It's all real."

Once inside, I lead Zahra through the cottage, stopping at each room on the lower floor. We make our way up the stairs to the second floor where

the master bedroom looks out across five hundred acres of farmland and forest.

In the distance, the sky is alight with shades of pink and orange as the sunset dips below the horizon. When I draw the curtains closed, Zahra turns to the king size bed and runs her fingers along the soft, white cotton cover.

“It’s beautiful, Declan.”

“Let’s go downstairs, I want to show you something.”

She reaches out for my hand, then drops hers and holds it tight against her thigh.

I take a step toward her, lace my fingers through hers, and whisper against her ear, “You never have to ask to hold my hand.”

She squeezes my hand tight as I lead her back down the stairs and toward the back doors where all my plans will be put into motion.

Thick, heavy drapes hang over the backdoor, blocking the view to the garden and the manmade lake meters from the house. I flick on the light switches, and without a word I pull the drapes across and open the door revealing the surprise.

“Oh wow... Declan. What is all this?”

I tug on her hand and lead her out to the gazebo I decorated yesterday with over one thousand fairy lights, and five hundred pink silk roses. From the centre of the gazebo a circular light hangs like a full moon, and on the grass, a trail of pink rose petals leads toward the lake.

Zahra is silent. Her eyes are focused on the rose petal path, then, she turns her attention to the gazebo before turning to me. “You did all this... for me?”

“Everything I do is for you. Come on.” I lead her to the gazebo where we sit together on the soft woollen blanket before I light the candles and stand them near the side rails.

My heart races wildly, and there’s a lump in my throat that won’t budge no matter how hard I swallow.

Zahra pulls her legs to the side and twists her fingers through the blanket, her eyes are wide as she looks up at the fairy lights.

“Zahra,” I can barely say her name without blubbering like a fool. This girl... this woman is everything to me. *Tell her how you feel.*

When she looks at me and bites her lip, I shuffle closer. “I want to tell you something...”

“Um... okay.” She crosses her legs and twists her fingers together in her lap. “Did I do something wrong?”

“No.” I take her hands and lean forward to kiss her lips. “You never do anything wrong.”

“What I want to say... what I’m trying to say is...” I exhale. I inhale. I try counting to five, then ten. Nothing helps. I need to say it, out loud.

“What I want to say is, I love you. You know that, right?”

She nods, and a smile spreads across her beautiful pink lips.

“I love you so much that I never want to live without you. When I met you, right away I wanted to know more about you. I wanted to hear your voice and listen to you talk all day long. As we became closer, I saw you. I saw the gentleness in your eyes and heard the fragility in your voice.”

I hesitate, trying not to let my own emotions consume me.

“Everyone sees you as a whisper, so soft and so gentle. But when I’m with you, it’s like I’m caught in the middle of a raging hurricane. The world whizzes by and everything surrounding me blurs into the background. And you’re right here, holding me, loving me, trusting me. You have every reason to push me away. You have every reason not to trust, but you do. And every day my heart grows with love for you, and for the strength you show.”

Tears fall from her eyes, but she doesn’t speak.

“I’m almost done,” I say.

She only nods.

I get to my feet and take her hands until she’s standing, then, I drop to one knee and pull the ring from my pocket. “I love you, Zahra, and I don’t want to spend one more minute of my life without you. I will give you my heart, and my promise that our love will be forever. It will be infinite. Zahra Grace Harper, will you marry me?”

Her mouth gapes open. More tears. More crying. Although this time, I expected it. She drops to her knees and wraps her arms around my neck, sobbing into my shoulder. “Yes, Declan. Yes, I will marry you. I love you... oh Declan, I love you so, so much.”

As I fall back onto the blanket, Zahra falls on top of me and we erupt into fits of laughter. “You forgot the ring,” I say holding it up.

Her eyes grow wide as I take her hand and slide the ring onto her finger. She twists her hand, watching the pink diamond sparkle as the fairy

lights shine off it. "I'm going to be your wife..."

I twist my fingers through her hair and bring her lips to mine. "Forever," I say, before we fall into a decadent kiss.

A distant whistle travels across the lake. Charles helped me plan the night and assured me this would be the perfect finishing touch to my proposal. When the second whistle fills the air, I sit up with Zahra still in my arms and dig my hand into my pocket to retrieve my whistle.

"Have you ever seen fireworks?" I ask her.

She shakes her head and smiles. Her eyes are wide. "I've read about them."

"You might want to block your ears."

She presses her hands over her ears as I stand and inhale before blowing the whistle.

Exactly ten seconds later, Zahra stands beside me in awe as the night time sky fills with explosions of colour. Each burst causes her to gasp, but she's no longer covering her ears. She stares up at the sky, her hand gripping mine tight.

One bright, sparkling burst after another, the fireworks explode, then rain down like showers of glittering light. "They're beautiful," she says in awe. "I've never seen anything so beautiful."

My arm snakes around her waist and I kiss her cheek. "Nothing is as beautiful as you."

* * *

Zahra hasn't stopped talking all night, and I never want her to. After a dinner of Chinese takeout—her favourite—we shared a tub of chocolate ice cream and I told her stories from my childhood. She laughed when I told her about the time Charles and I went swimming in the lake and forgot to check the time, and his dad sent out a major search party. She smiled when I told her about our Christmas lunches and how she'd be there for all of them from now on. And she cried tears of joy when I told her the cottage would be our home.

Lying on the king size bed, I turn to kiss her cheek. "There's one more thing I want to show you," I say as I reach over behind the bed head

and flick the switch.

First, she covers her face with her hands and begins to cry. When I pull her hands away, I remind her, “It’s all real. You and me. This cottage. Our lives. It’s real.”

She blinks as she stares up at the ceiling where I had an electrician install tiny lights that look like stars in the sky. “You do so much for me, I don’t know what to do for you.”

“Love me, like you do right now. I promise you it’s enough.”

“You gave me the stars. Now I’ll never be in the dark again.” She wriggles closer and I slide my arm under her so she can rest her head on my chest. “Thank you for loving me, Declan,” she whispers as I stroke her hair and watch her fall asleep.

PART TWO

THE BOY WHO SAVED HER LIFE

I painted stars upon the ceiling
Because you couldn't see the sky
I took a thousand photographs
I was so afraid you'd die
I walked with you in sunsets
On golden grains of sand
I ran with you through forests
And all across the land
I held you in my heart
And wished on dandelion fields
But one day I opened up my eyes
And you were gone
And none of it was real

Julie Anne Addicott

YOU ARE INVITED TO THE WEDDING OF

ZAHRA GRACE HARPER

AND

DECLAN RYAN FOXX

NOVEMBER 11

AT TWO O'CLOCK IN THE AFTERNOON

ROCKBURN BOTANIC GARDENS

27 HIGHLANDER TERRACE

ROCKBURN GROVE

OceanofPDF.com

Everything I do now
Will always be for you
The one who opened up my eyes
To a love I never knew

OceanofPDF.com

26

I do

ZAHRA
ONE YEAR LATER

November 11

23 years old

1 year later

1.58pm

I'm standing beside a breathtaking Cinderella carriage adorned with delicate pink and white roses. The filigree patterns twist and twirl creating a perfect circle where pretty vines with deep green leaves wind up to its pointed top. I've never seen anything like it. Not even in books. Inside, plush pink cushions lined with tiny crystals sit on the decorative wrought iron seats that are covered in a thin veil of ruffled white fabric.

Leading the carriage are two magnificent white horses with braided manes and feathered plumes upon their heads. The driver, whose name is John, wears a black tuxedo with a bow tie and top hat. He was so kind, and even made time for Grace and Maggie to have some photographs taken with the horses before we left for the wedding ceremony.

I had no idea I would arrive at my own wedding in a horse-drawn carriage. I was waiting at Declan's parents' house expecting the white limousine we'd looked at a month ago, but when Declan's mum, Angela, led me outside and I saw the horses trotting along the street toward us, it brought tears to my eyes.

My life has changed drastically. Although melancholy seeps from my soul, and the darkness of my past lingers above my head like a constant cloud of despair, I've learned that the happiness that eluded me for so long, is finally within my grasp. With Declan beside me, I can breathe in the beauty of life while I take one step at a time into a reality where my dreams are real, and I'm filled to the brim with the love I once lost.

I'm so excited, but I've never been so nervous. I still can't believe it. I'm finally the fairy tale princess I never got to be when I was growing up. *You deserve this.* The little voice in my head that urges me on is becoming stronger than the haunting whisper of the voice that serves to drag me into depression and self-loathing. Slowly but surely, I'm winning against the darkness in my soul.

I'm dressed in a stunning, pale pink silk wedding gown that flows around my feet. The train trails along behind me, covered in one hundred silk roses, and three hundred tiny, glass crystals that sparkle when they catch the light.

Jaymee said it was traditional to wear a white wedding gown, but when Declan's mum, Angela took me to the store and I saw the pink dress on the mannequin in the window, I knew it was the one I wanted to wear. Everything else, Angela and Jaymee helped me choose, including my lingerie which was a feat in itself. After six stores and two panic attacks, I was exhausted.

Jaymee promised she'd find me something while Angela took me home to rest. Beneath my dress, I'm now wearing a strapless, white satin bra and matching underwear that Jaymee calls, "Comfortable and practical." She's certainly right about that.

On my left, Eli stands with his arm linked through mine. He's wearing a black suit, and pale pink tie that matches my dress. On my right, Jaymee is beside me wearing a long flowing pink dress covered in sparkles. She's holding a bunch of pink and white roses that match my bouquet.

Charles and Jaymee's daughter—Maggie—is almost one. She was totally unexpected, but they've made the most of it, and are amazing parents, and I'm grateful to be a part of their lives.

Grace is five years old now, and from the moment we started organising our wedding, I wanted her to be my flower girl. She giggles as she spins around blowing bubbles. Her pink satin dress is identical to mine, and on her head, she wears a silver crown dotted with crystals. She's the most beautiful little girl I've ever seen, and I love watching her play and seeing her smile.

"Gracie, honey," Eli says, "you need to save the bubbles for everyone to see."

Grace turns around and looks up at Eli with a cheeky grin. “But Daddy, they’re sooo pretty, I can’t stop making them.”

Before Eli can reply, Meg rushes toward us. “It’s time.”

“Don’t forget to breathe,” Eli reminds me.

As the music starts, I take the first step toward the white carpet that’s been rolled out on the grass. Grace rushes ahead throwing rose petals on the carpet and stopping to show everyone her dress as Jaymee ushers her along.

Eli and I continue close behind her. As I walk down the aisle, the faces of the people who love me come into view. Everyone is looking back over their shoulders, looking back... at me. Me. The girl who—more than once—begged death to take her from this world. The same girl who found hope in a town called Rockburn Grove, with a boy who would ultimately save her life.

At the altar, is the same boy who has grown into the most handsome, loving man I’ve ever known. Declan’s back is to me, but beside him, Charles is watching me and smiling.

Declan said he didn’t want to see me until the moment I was right there in front of him.

“This is it,” Eli whispers as he walks me down the aisle toward Declan.

When I reach the end, Eli kisses my cheek and goes to sit with Zahra and Grace. Declan turns to me, and when our eyes meet, his well with tears.

I take his hands, and he whispers, “You are the most beautiful woman I’ve ever seen.”

I bite my lip, too nervous to speak. Too worried that if I open my mouth, the words will come out too fast and my tears will follow.

Declan leans forward. “I love you.” He leaves a delicate kiss on my cheek before stepping back to hold my hands.

The ceremony flies by quicker than I can blink, and when the time finally comes to read our vows, Declan reads his first.

“Fate brought us together
One sunny April day
One look into your eyes
And I couldn’t turn away

I promised you my heart and soul
I promised you a life
Today we finally make our vows
As husband, and as wife.”

Declan slides the beautiful pink diamond ring onto my finger before I say my vows.

“With every heartbeat, I will breathe
With every breath, I will believe
With every touch, I promise you
With honesty, our love is true
With all the love we have today
I know I’ll never lose my way.”

When the celebrant speaks, my tears are finally released. “Declan and Zahra, I now pronounce you husband and wife. Declan, you may kiss your bride.”

I swallow the lump in my throat as Declan asks, “May I?”

I nod, my cheeks stained with tears, and my heart filled with immense happiness. “Yes. Yes, you can kiss me.”

The clapping that surrounds us dies down as I lose myself in the kiss. There’s no place I’d rather be than wrapped safely in Declan’s arms. When our lips part, he presses his forehead to mine. “Are you okay?”

I smile. “Yes. Thank you for the carriage, and the horses... and De— Declan, it was so beautiful.”

He cups my cheeks with both hands. “*You* are so beautiful.”

* * *

After the ceremony, we wave goodbye to our guests before we follow the photographer through the botanic gardens. We’re having our photographs taken here before we head back into the city for our wedding reception.

The photographer, Leo, sets up his camera on a tall tripod and tells Declan and I where to stand and what to do. It’s awkward at first, and it

isn't until twenty minutes into our photo shoot that I'm comfortable enough to let a real smile spread across my lips.

After each set of photos are taken, Leo calls us over to look at the images on the small screen on the side of his camera. It's surreal seeing myself dressed like a princess and smiling as though happiness was there in the palms of my own hands all along.

For seventeen years, I was trapped inside a home that became nothing more than a house. A shell surrounding a secret world where my life took a turn for the worst, and I had no control, over anything. Although I can still smell my father's cologne, and feel his hands on my skin, sometimes—only sometimes—I find hope in the form of a boy who grew into a man, who promised me a lifetime of blissful happiness when he asked me to marry him.

Leo scratches his chin with one hand as he points to the flower bed in the centre of the garden. "Do you think you could stand there in the flowers, Zahra?" he asks.

I notice a few people have stopped walking through the gardens and are now staring at me. I drop my head as Declan's fingers lace through mine. "Hey, it's okay. Everyone loves a bride. And you're the most beautiful one this town has ever seen."

My cheeks heat, and Leo's nodding in agreement. "You sure are, Zahra. So, what do you think about the flowers?"

"Am I allowed to stand there?" I ask.

He nods and points to the flower bed. "Walk between the flowers, see those little stepping stones, you can walk on those. It's all good, this town loves a wedding." He glances to the gathering crowd. "Obviously," he adds with a chuckle.

"Let's do it, sweetheart," Declan says with a smile. He tugs my hand and I follow him into the garden bed where beautiful pink and white daisies grow, a delicate carpet of pristine petals. The sun shines down warming my bare shoulders and catching on the crystals sewn onto my dress. I keep my eyes down, careful not to crush the flowers as I step across the stone. When I catch a glimpse of tiny rainbow shards of light from my dress, each crystal reminds me of the first three hundred days I spent in Rockburn Grove.

The first journal Meg gave me when I arrived, had three hundred pages, and I wrote on each one. From every moment with Declan, to my therapy group with the girls, and the words I wish I'd had the chance to say to my little sister before she tragically passed away. It's all there, still bound inside the pages of my new world. A world I've come to love.

"Is here okay?" Declan's voice draws me from my thoughts.

Leo replies, "Perfect, Declan. Now, see if you can kneel slightly, and Zahra, you put your foot on Declan's knee."

Declan kneels, and I awkwardly lift my foot while trying to hold my balance. While Declan smiles up at me, all I can think about is falling to the ground and ruining my dress or making a fool of myself.

"Lift your dress a little at the front," Leo calls from outside the circle of flowers. When I reach down, a familiar voice tears me from reality and thrusts me back to a place I wish I'd never known.

Carlie

8 years old.

The cellar is cold. I don't like it down here, but Daddy says it's a special playroom. A place that's safe for me. It has one table, two chairs, and one bed with a pink frilly blanket and a special dolly that I can only play with sometimes. In the cellar, I have to wear the clothes daddy gets for me, and I even get to have piggy tails and ribbons in my hair.

Today the photographer is coming.

Daddy says he wants pictures of me because I am so, so beautiful and lots of people in the world want to see me. Daddy says one day I will be allowed to do videos too because everyone will love me.

I looked in my bathroom mirror one day and I thought I was beautiful. It makes me smile when daddy says that. But sometimes it makes me feel sick, too. I'm bigger now so I don't throw up a lot anymore. Only when I get scared, or if I have lots of pain in my tummy and in my head.

The pain is bad when daddy wants to do things with his fingers and hands. But I'm brave now, and I don't cry anymore because that makes daddy angry.

Daddy helps me put the new underwear on. It's pink and soft and has lots of frilly bits on it around the top, and around my legs where Daddy has

to fix all the frilly bits so they don't look bad. The little bra is very small and has frilly bits too, but it's itchy and when I tell Daddy, he says I have to be quiet and not talk, then, when the photographer is here, I can take it off for a little while.

Daddy puts his black jacket on, and his red tie, then he puts some pieces of paper on the table, and a bottle of his special drink called rum.

While daddy is getting the table ready for the photographer, I play with my dolly. She has long blonde hair and big blue eyes. Her dress is short like the dresses Daddy buys for me, and when I peek under her dress, she has white underwear on. I'm not allowed to wear underwear with dresses, so I take dolly's underwear off and hide it under the pillow on the bed.

The photographer is very tall and has a black camera.

He talks to Daddy for a little while, then he tells me to sit and stand in funny places on the bed while I hold my dolly. When he tells me to put my legs and arms in all different directions, it makes me laugh because it feels silly.

When he's taken lots of photos, Daddy helps me take off all the itchy underwear so the man can take even more photos. Something in my tummy starts to feel sick and I tell my head I'm not allowed to throw up anymore. I have to be very brave.

The photographer comes closer to me and tells me to lay down on the bed. He takes so many photos, and I ask him why he needs to take lots of them.

"Because you are the sweetest little girl I've ever seen." He has a big smile, but I don't like him. He puts his camera on the bed and sits next to me, but when he puts his hand on my leg, I forget about Daddy's rules and I jump backwards very quickly. Tears appear in my eyes and I rub them away, hoping Daddy doesn't see them.

When he turns around, he has his angry look, and asks me, "Did he touch you, baby?"

I know I'm not allowed to lie to Daddy, but the man is looking at me with a mean face, and my words don't work.

Daddy uses his angry voice to tell the man it's time to leave, and that makes me happy again.

When the photographer is gone, Daddy gives me my favourite nighty. It goes to my knees and has a pretty pink flower on the front.

“Lift up your dress a little,” Daddy says. “Show me what you’ve got under there.”

When I lift it up, I think Daddy is checking to make sure I don’t have underwear on. And when Daddy picks me up and tells me I was a very good girl, I smile a lot because now I can have ice cream and strawberry topping, and pink sprinkles. Pink is my favourite colour.

In the kitchen, I sit at the table next to my brother, and my little sister, Cathie. She’s three now, but she still can’t talk properly, so Daddy says I have to start being a teacher for her. We are not allowed to go to school. Daddy says there are lots of bad people who hurt little girls, and if we stay home, he can make sure we are safe.

I’m very lucky because I have lots and lots of books and paper and pencils to write and draw with. When I was five, Mummy showed me how to read and write and now I will get to show Cathie too. Mummy still isn’t home yet. She went away when I was five, and now I am eight. That’s three whole years. Daddy said she has gone on a long holiday until she feels better and stops crying. Sometimes I miss her, and sometimes I want to go on a holiday too, but I would miss my daddy.

“Zahra, it’s okay. Listen to my voice. You’re safe. No one is going to hurt you.”

I blink once, and again. Above, Declan’s looking down at me. “Declan?”

“You’re okay now,” he whispers.

When I reach out my hand, delicate petals beneath my fingers remind me where I am. Tears spring to my eyes. “My dress,” I cry. “I ruined it.”

Declan shakes his head and a slight, gorgeous smile tugs at the corner of his lips. “I caught you. Your dress is perfect. You are perfect. And Jaymee’s on her way to fix your makeup.”

In the distance, Leo’s voice rings out. “Ahh, sleeping beauty has awoken.”

Declan laughs, but his face quickly turns solemn. “Flashback?”

I swallow the lump in my throat, then nod. “I’m so sorry. I’ve ruined everything.”

He lifts me up and kisses my cheek before Leo extends his hand. “Need some help?”

I take his hand and he pulls me to my feet as Declan stands and brushes off his pants.

Jaymee’s voice floats on the breeze, a chirpy sound that instantly puts me at ease. She runs to me, then slams against me, hugging the life out of me before dabbing at my eyes with a bunch of tissues. “It’s all going to be fine. Ten minutes, and I’ll have you all fixed up.”

While Declan talks to Leo and goes through the photos, Jaymee drops her bag off her shoulder and rummages through it for the things she needs.

“You’re okay?” she asks concerned.

I nod but lose my composure when I choke on a sob. “Everything is ruined.” I can’t stop crying. “I should be over it by now. I’m not a child anymore.”

Jaymee pulls me into her arms. “Hey, hey, Zar, remember what the psychiatrist said? They are always going to be there. It’s not ruined. You *can’t* control the flashbacks.”

“I wanted this day to be perfect.” I sniffle as she hands me a bunch of tissues and twists my loose curls around her finger before pinning them back up.

When my tears have dried up, she dabs a brush in some powder and brushes it over my face. “You’re making new memories every day, and we can only hope that in the future, all these moments of happiness will soon drown out the pain.”

I sigh, but in a way, she’s right. I have hope now. I have love, and I have Declan. The all-consuming darkness scares me though, it weaves its way through my veins and into my heart.

“I want them all gone. The memories, the flashbacks, the words that send me crashing to the ground. I want to be normal, but I—”

Jaymee brings a finger to her lips. “Shhh. Focus on today. You are the beautiful bride. And Declan Foxx, the single most gorgeous guy in Rockburn Grove, is your new husband. So, Mrs Zahra Foxx, let’s get this party started.”

I can’t wipe the smile off my face. *Mrs Zahra Foxx*. It’s all real. I’m no longer Carlie Browne. I’m not Zahra Harper. I am Zahra Foxx, and my

life—no matter how difficult it was before—will be perfect... *I hope.*

* * *

November 12

1am

It's been hours since our wedding ceremony and I can't bring myself to take off my wedding dress. I've never had such a wonderful day. Standing at the window of the penthouse suite at The Palace Hotel, I can see the city in the distance, and the crystalline stars dotted across the midnight sky. All day I wished for rain. Just a little because I'd read it was good luck for it to rain on your wedding day. It never came, and our day was still a picture of perfection.

A gentle hand on my shoulder brings a smile to my lips. "Hey, what are you doing?"

"Looking at the stars," I say.

Declan wraps his arms around my waist from behind me and kisses my shoulder. "Not ready for the night to end?"

I shake my head. "It was more beautiful than I could have ever imagined." I lean back to kiss his cheek. "You smell so good," I tell him as I take in his musky, delicious scent.

"Thanks. The shower's amazing." I turn around to see Declan's wearing one of the hotel's fluffy white robes.

I run my hands down the front of my dress feeling the cool silk beneath my fingertips. "Would you help me with the ribbons?" I ask Declan.

He plants a gentle kiss on my lips, then turns me around to untie the back of my dress. Before he finishes, he draws the curtains closed and flicks on the lamp, filling the room with a soft, warm, golden glow.

His fingertips trace down my spine before he unlaces my wedding dress and lets it fall to the floor at my feet. It puffs out around my knees in a puddle of pale pink silk. Tonight is the first time Declan will see me naked since the day he patched up my wounds at Housing Hope.

I want tonight to be perfect, and I'm hoping and praying to whatever gods reside in the world, that nothing will ruin my wedding night.

The years that have passed have been filled with countless, wonderful moments.

For my nineteenth birthday, Declan took me to the beach. I sat on the sand, wrapped in his arms as we listened to the roar of the waves on the ocean, and watched the golden sunset across the horizon. I'd never seen anything so magnificent. Hues of pink, purple, and blue were painted across the sky, a masterpiece of beauty that brought tears to my eyes.

Until I was seventeen, I'd spent so many long, lonely days and nights trapped inside my house. Even through my bedroom window, I'd never seen the sky so breathtakingly beautiful.

Declan cried too that day. He said he'd always taken everything for granted, and that he'd never bothered to notice the sky and its glorious palette of colours that changed moment by precious moment. Now, he says I've shown him the importance of stopping to breathe, of stopping to notice the world around us, and taking it all in.

The following year, I turned twenty. Charles and Jaymee decided it was time for me to see a nightclub. I spent two hours with Jaymee fussing over my hair and makeup while making me try on every slinky dress she owned. I finally settled on a skin-tight red dress and matching stilettos. What started out as an exciting night, ended with Declan in the emergency room. He had to be treated for a black eye after he punched another guy who grabbed me on the backside while I was standing at the bar. I was overwhelmed with guilt, and I didn't understand why. That night, I told Declan about my brother, and the torture I endured at his hands.

There have been many times when I've expected Declan to walk away. But he always stays. When I told him about the men who forced themselves upon me when I was barely a teenager, he stayed. When I told him about our doctor, Jeff, who would use his sex toys on me before I even knew what they were, he stayed. And when I spilled every single, sordid detail of my past, including the parts where I wished I was home with my father again, he reminded me of all the reasons he loves me, and he stayed.

Delicate, lingering kisses along my shoulder bring me back to Declan. My heart is so full of love for him it's already beating faster and forcing me to take in long, deep breaths. As Declan removes the pins from

my hair, it falls down, covering my arms in long, spiralling ringlets. When his hands smooth down my arms, goose bumps appear on my skin and my stomach coils in knots. But it's not fear, and it's not apprehension. It's something I can't quite explain. It causes my body to shiver, and my heart beat to quicken.

Every muscle in my body relaxes as he laces his fingers through mine and continues his divine exploration of my shoulders and neck with his soft lips. "Dec..." I can't catch my breath long enough to say his name, and when I try again, all that comes out is a breathless sigh.

His lips pepper kisses up my neck before stopping by my ear where his words are barely a whisper. "Turn around, beautiful."

I inhale. I count to five in my head. I exhale.

Then, I turn to face my husband.

My chest heaves with each breath as anxiety begins to take over. I know everything there is to know about having sex. But nothing about making love. *Something is wrong with me.* My heart and mind are at war. I'm trying to hold on to reality, desperate for time to stand still and not let the past come crashing down around me to ruin this precious moment.

"I... Declan... I don't—"

He takes my hand and leads me to the bed before he shrugs his robe off, then slips under the covers. "Lay with me. We don't have to do anything."

I bite my lip and nod as I slide under the sheet and turn to face Declan.

He runs his fingers through my hair, then shuffles closer so our bodies are touching. His satin boxers cool against my thigh. I want him to kiss me again, but I can't ask. I can't do anything but stare into the deep blue eyes of the man I love.

I trace my fingertip across Declan's lips remembering all the times he's kissed me, and as though he's read my mind, he asks, "Can I kiss you?"

My smile is all he needs to know I want to say yes, but I don't get a chance.

He puts an arm around me and twists his fingers through my hair as he kisses my cheek and slowly moves along my jaw until his lips meet mine. When his tongue glides into my mouth, I swipe mine back over his

causing him to let out a groan. It's a beautiful sound I want to hear again, so I raise my hands and knot my fingers through his hair as I kiss him harder.

He smells like the ocean on a warm summer night, mixed with the decadence of the fine red wine we shared at our wedding reception.

When his hand glides down my arm and comes to rest on my waist, I momentarily freeze, and Declan stops kissing me.

He pushes the covers off us and traces his fingers along the edge of my white satin underwear. "You're so beautiful, Zahra." His fingers trace across the scars on my stomach before he lowers his head and kisses them one by one.

When he lifts his head, I swallow the lump in my throat, worried he'll be disgusted when he finds they're not the only scars I have. *I have to trust him. I do trust him.* Declan loves me.

He blazes a warm trail of kisses up my stomach and between my breasts until he reaches my neck. "Want me to stop?"

"No... please don't," I beg, relishing in his gentle touch and the way he treats my body like it's fragile... and precious.

When his hand slides under my back and he unclips the clasp on my bra, I suck in a breath, but I don't stop him. When he takes my bra and drops it on the floor beside the bed, my hands instinctively cover my breasts, but he doesn't pull them away. He continues to kiss me all over, sliding down the length of my body until his thumbs are tucked over the hem of my underwear and he tugs them down.

I squeeze my thighs together, but he only stops to kiss my scars and tell me again how beautiful I am. When I'm completely naked, Declan kneels over my legs and looks down at me. I search his eyes for any flash of disgust... I don't find it. All I see is love and a cross between something that looks a little like desperation mixed with fervid desire.

Slowly, I let my hands fall from my breasts and I drop them by my sides, not knowing what to do with them now. Declan tilts his head, still staring at me, while I stare back at him.

I've never wanted to look at a male's body the way I want to look at Declan. His shoulders and arms are all muscle, and his smooth, tanned chest and abs are glorious. He is a work of art. A masterpiece I never imagined I'd see.

As I chew on my bottom lip, I let my gaze wander to the tattoo on Declan's chest, right above his heart. He got it a few weeks ago on the spur of the moment when we went for a day trip into the Castletown, a large city a few hours drive from Rockburn Grove. The beautifully detailed heart surrounds my name in a pretty cursive script. I was so worried about him being in pain, but he said it was completely worth it.

When he stands to take his boxers off, I clamp my eyes shut, and he laughs. "Are you still okay?"

I nod, my eyes still closed.

The bed dips with his weight. "You can open your eyes now." As he pulls me across, he glides his hand down my side until it rests on my thigh. "You can say no anytime. I don't want to do anything you're not ready for."

I nod again.

Anticipation washes over me. My chest tightens, and my palms sweat as Declan's hand slides between my legs where he stops to rub it over my scars.

Inhale.

Exhale.

Breathe.

I am safe. Declan loves me.

I promised her serenity
And true love without sin
Now she's locked inside my heart
And tattooed upon my skin

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DECLAN

November 12

Her skin is smooth and soft but for the scars scattered across her pale flesh. Each one reminds me of what she's endured—of what she's survived. As I smooth my hand over the inside of her thigh, I close my eyes and imagine taking away every ounce of her pain.

When I lean down to press another kiss to her lips, she opens her mouth slightly, allowing my tongue to swipe across hers. Her lip quivers as I glide my hand up higher, letting it rest between her legs.

While we kiss, she sucks in a breath and I stop right away. I want her in every way possible, but I refuse to force her into anything. She needs slow and gentle, and that's what I will give her. I search her eyes for any indication of fear, but all I find is uncertainty and longing.

She looks as though she's caught between what she wants, and what she needs and the only way I can figure it out, is to ask her.

"What do you want, Zar?"

Her eyes don't leave mine. "I want... um... I want—I want you to touch me... please."

Please? This girl... this woman, is heaven. Not a second goes by that I don't thank the world for bringing us together. "I love you, Zahra."

Her smile says it all. She loves me just as much.

Cautiously, I move my hand against her soft, warm flesh. At first, she tenses up and squeezes her thighs together.

I stop. She relaxes.

I move, she tenses.

I stop.

"Please... don't stop," she begs in a whisper. "I don't want you to stop."

I swallow hard, worried she's letting me touch her out of guilt, or fear, or even anxiety. My mind swarms with thoughts.

I had a rather awkward conversation with Eli about Zahra and how I should handle our wedding night. It was strange asking for his advice on sex, but in the end, I was glad I made the effort. Knowing what could trigger Zahra, and what could send her spiralling into the abysmal pits of darkness and despair, has certainly helped me, and not only in the bedroom.

I lie beside her and stare into her eyes as I move my hand ever so slightly again. This time, her legs fall to the sides and rather than move faster, which my body is desperate to do, I take it slowly. Soft, gentle movements that cause her to move her hips and close her eyes as her breasts rise and fall with each heavy breath.

When a quiet, feminine moan of pleasure leaves her lips, I circle one finger around the delicate softness of her flesh before sliding it gently inside her.

My heart is near bursting out of my chest. She is so soft, so hot... so... precious. My dick throbs as her hips rise again and her tiny moans turn into breathless pants. *How could anyone hurt her?* I push the anger away and focus only on her.

I can't get enough. The scent of her perfume, the supple flesh of her breasts, and the heavenly sighs escaping her lips threaten to send me over the edge of reason, and into a cloud of decadent debauchery. *I can't go there.* I need to stay focused, stay in control.

Trying to hold on and stop myself from devouring her glorious body. I slide my finger out and circle it around her thigh. She gasps as though she's just discovered she's in reality and not trapped inside a beautiful daydream.

"Declan," desire fills each word, "please, make love to me."

For exactly five seconds, I hold my breath and squeeze my eyes shut. I've dreamed about this since the night I asked Zahra to marry me.

I lie back with my head on the pillow and reach out to her. "Come over here."

She gets to her knees and shuffles closer.

A tingling sensations spreads through my body. *I need her. I want her.*

Zahra's past was fraught with pain and suffering, and all of it revolved around sex. From the time she was a child, she was groomed by

her prick of a father to believe it was all okay. To believe it was normal.

I reach out for her hand and tug her closer.

When she's lying over me, she presses her lips to my cheek and breathes against my ear. "I'll be okay." I don't know if she's saying it out loud to tell herself, or if she's assuring me, this is what she wants. Whatever it is, I promised her love, and I will do anything to give it to her.

I cup her cheeks, press my lips to hers, and move beneath her, testing her reaction. When she slides back over my dick, I almost lose every ounce of willpower I have.

She feels so damn good.

As our lips clash with furious passion, she slides forward... and back. And forward again.

I've never felt anything like this. My body is a live wire of electrical currents. Each nerve ending setting off charges that blaze like tiny infernos beneath my flesh.

When she moans into my mouth, I slide my hands down and grip her ass, careful not to be too rough. Less than three seconds later, my dick slides inside her and I'm enveloped in a glorious heat I never knew existed.

She freezes.

I freeze.

We both breathe heavily. Our chests heaving against one another's. Not a word is spoken until a single salted tear lands on my lip. I swipe my tongue across it and look up at the woman I love, terrified I've ruined her.

"Zahra?" there's a panic in my voice I can't hide.

"Declan... it—it doesn't..." she presses her lips to mine as a waterfall of tears drip onto my face. "It doesn't hurt," she murmurs.

I breathe a sigh of relief as I wrap my arms around her shoulders and hold her tight against my body. "I love you, Zahra Foxx."

She smiles, then circles her hips. "I love you, Declan." My dick throbs inside her as I thrust forward.

For the next two hours I explore her body, stopping to kiss every single scar. I smother her in kisses and trace my tongue around her nipples as she begs me to continue. She takes her time to trace every curve of my body with her fingertips, before planting a gentle kiss on my chest and thanking me for showing her pleasure where only pain once lived.

* * *

9.00am

Room service knocks on our door. I pull on the hotel robe and open the curtains to reveal a glorious, sunny day without a cloud in the sky. Today, we leave for our honeymoon. Although I haven't told Zahra where we are going yet. I promised her it would be a surprise trip.

When I've wheeled in the room service cart, I check under the lids to find a full buffet breakfast, including pancakes with strawberries and ice-cream, and croissants with ham and cheese, as well as an assortment of fresh fruit, juice, and coffee and tea.

Zahra comes out of the bathroom with her hair wrapped in a towel. She's wearing a robe, like me, and her eyes are brighter than I've ever seen.

"Good morning, gorgeous," I say extending my hands toward the breakfast I've laid out on the table.

"That's all for us?"

I nod. "You must be hungry, you barely ate last night."

"I am. But that's a lot of food." She comes to the table and lifts one of the lids. The buttery scent of croissants causes my stomach to rumble.

"What if we don't eat it all?"

I wrap an arm around her waist. "I'll eat it all," I say, and Zahra laughs.

Beneath the next lid she lifts, are the pancakes smothered in strawberries and ice cream. Her body tenses, she clamps her eyes shut, and she whispers to herself as she breathes. "Safe. Safe. Safe. Safe." But everything unravels like a fraying thread when she drops the lid and steps back, covering her face with her hands.

A second later, she's on her knees crying and shouting, "No. Please no..."

I drop to the floor beside her and pull her into my arms. "Shhh.... it's okay. You're safe here. Remember to breathe. In... out... in... out."

When she's breathing slowly, I stroke her hair and grip her hands. "You're safe, Zar. It's me and you. No one can hurt you," I remind her.

When she opens her eyes, they're already red and puffy from crying. She falls into a heap between my legs and begs me to forgive her.

"Do you want to talk about it?" I take the towel from her head and hang it over the chair.

Usually she says no, and she'll wait until we're in bed to talk. But this time, I'm surprised when she nods, but still clings to me as though I'm about to run away.

"When I was little my fath—he used to let me sleep in his bed. He said I was his favourite." Her eyes dart around the room as though she's searching for something, and I'm reminded of the time she told me about the spot on the wall she would focus on when she was punished.

I wrap my arms tighter around her and press my lips against her damp hair as she continues. "He said if I loved him, I would sleep with him, and I would—I... I." She hesitates, and I remind her she doesn't have to tell me anything.

"I want you to know... everything," she says. "He made me touch him. His body, his di—" As she sobs, rage builds inside me. Knowing he's still out there somewhere, makes me want to search the world so I can find him and destroy his life like he has destroyed Zahra's.

Through sobs, she continues, "He touched me... he hurt me. I tried so hard not to cry, but it hurt so much. In the morning he would bring me pancakes with strawberries and ice cream and tell me he was sorry, and that if I tried harder, he would love me even more."

Goddamn pancakes. I curse under my breath, thankful she doesn't hear me. Guilt eats away at me. I know about her issues with food. I should have been more careful. I should have asked her what she wanted first.

"No!" I shout at myself. There is no way to know anything unless she tells me. I'm still learning about her, and she's learning to trust.

When Zahra jumps, I kiss her cheek. "Sorry... I'm sorry I shouted, babe."

"Are you mad at me?"

"No. Never. I'm mad at myself. I should have asked what you wanted for breakfast."

"I like croissants," she says with a half-smile.

I jump to my feet and pull Zahra to hers. "Then croissants it is," I say, offering her a seat at the table.

She sits on my lap instead, and when I wrap my arms around her thin waist, I know without a shred of doubt that I will make it my mission to ensure her life is filled with nothing but sweet serenity.

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A journey to salvation
It is my time to shine
I once thought hope was all but lost
Now the stars have realigned

OceanofPDF.com

ZAHRA**December 2**

We arrived home from our honeymoon a week ago. Declan and I spent almost the entire time in each other's arms. It was pure bliss. Every day was like a dream come true. At sunset, we rode horses on the beach and watched dolphins play in the ocean before retreating to the privacy of our suite where we spent hours talking, laughing, and making love through the nights and into the mornings.

On the last day of our honeymoon, while it was still dark, we took to the sky on a hot air balloon ride where we watched the sun rise on the horizon before a buffet breakfast at Bella, the only glass bottom restaurant in the world.

Tomorrow, Declan goes back to work, and I'll be home alone, except for the times when my psychiatrist visits, or Jaymee comes around to visit me with Maggie. I never imagined I'd enjoy being alone. It's surreal to be able to walk around the cottage and do anything I want to do. I no longer have to answer to anyone. I can eat if and when I feel like it. I can shower or bathe at any time of the day, and—not that I do—I can come and go as I please.

Since we arrived home, I've spent countless hours on the computer Declan bought for me. Declan's mother, Angela, said she has a friend out of town who owns Foxxstone Publishing Company. She said they're always looking for autobiographies, and even though I'm not famous or well known, there's a chance they could be interested in my story.

It sounds strange to hear my life called a story. No matter how many days pass, I still remember it as if it were yesterday. So many times, I've wished, hoped, and even prayed for the slate to be wiped clean so I can start my life over and live my dreams. No matter how small they may be.

I'm no longer a naïve child, or a clueless teenager. I know better now than to believe my memories will magically disappear from my mind. Day after day, they haunt me and threaten to tear me from this beautiful existence. Perhaps that's why my fear of leaving the house is so strong. Inside the safety of our cottage, no one can touch me. No one can break through the walls I've built around myself. The only one who truly reaches me now, is Declan.

I don't want it any other way, but apparently, it's not healthy to rely solely on one person. Even if that person is the love of your entire life.

My appointments with my psychiatrist, Doctor Marshall, are now fortnightly, but occasionally I'll see her more often, especially if something has triggered my memory. Today, Declan is here. He was apprehensive, as usual, but he says he'd never forgive himself if he didn't try to understand the trauma I endured, and how it still affects me now.

He doesn't like hearing the details, but afterwards, it's as though everything he's heard makes him understand why I am the way I am. He says all he feels for my father and brother is immense hatred and anger. I don't quite understand it because I've never had those emotions before. I was always so sure my father loved me... so sure my brother loved me. Even now, all I feel is an overwhelming sense of grief and loss. The weight of my past is the heaviest burden I carry.

Doctor Marshall sits on our small leather sofa with one leg crossed over the other. She's always smiling when she arrives, but her smile never lasts for the entire hour. She said my case is one that's reminded her of the beauty of life, but also of the horrific abuse some people inflict upon others. She says my way to healing is to talk about what happened as much as I am able to. Some days, I find it hard to breathe, and the memories literally knock the wind out of me. Doctor Marshall says it's okay to have bad days, and to remember they don't last forever.

Declan sits beside me on our white two-seater sofa holding my hand tight in his.

Doctor Marshall begins by asking how our wedding and honeymoon was, and how I felt about having so many people around me. She checks that I've been taking my medications correctly and reminds me to call our doctor if I have any side effects.

Declan squeezes my hand, encouraging me to speak.

“The wedding and honeymoon were beautiful. It’s still a little strange having so many people recognise me if we go out. It makes me anxious, and some days, I want to run away and hide. Declan reminds me to breathe.”

Doctor Marshall explains that my social anxiety is something that will take time to recover from. She says I might always be this way, but with continued therapy, I will be able to go out more. All my goals are “small and achievable”. My list is on our note board beside a photograph of me and Declan.

*Go to the bakery on Sundays
Meet Jaymee on Wednesdays
Call Declan at work at midday*

When I read my tiny list out loud, it seems silly and immature. The things I should be able to do are limited by my anxiety and the triggering symptoms of post-traumatic stress. Every day, I battle against my mind and struggle to put my racing heart at ease.

Doctor Marshall focuses on Declan next. She’s been helping us with couples therapy, and once every three months we have a family session with Declan’s parents as well. Knowing they all love me, and care about my past, gives me hope for the future.

“How is your relationship going, Declan?”

He nods. “It’s amazing. I’m learning more about what triggers Zahra, and I’m able to notice when she’s starting to panic. Sometimes, I’m able to stop it. Other times, she falls apart. It’s hard to see her like that. To know there’s nothing I can do to take away the pain she’s endured. But I stay with her, and I remind her that she’s safe and that I’ll love her forever, no matter what.”

“You’re doing all the right things, Declan. One day at a time, that’s all we can do.” After making some notes, she looks up at me. “Zahra?”

I squeeze Declan’s hand. “I’m so happy with Declan. I love him, I trust him. But sometimes, it’s hard to talk about it. The words get caught in my throat, and when they finally come out, I can’t stop them. Some days, it feels as though all the darkness from my past will seep from my veins and

poison everyone around me. I don't want to hurt Declan. That's what I'm most afraid of. I wish I could get rid of all the memories."

She clasps her hands together on her lap. "Do you honestly *believe* Declan will be poisoned by your past? How would that happen?"

She always asks questions I don't have answers to. I bite my lip as silence lingers. When I don't reply, she says, "Zahra?"

I shrug. "I don't know."

"Okay, let's think about this," Doctor Marshall says. "Your past is in the past. Right?"

I nod.

"And you've opened up to Declan about a lot of it, almost all of it?"

Another nod.

"And he's okay?"

I shrug. My darkness could ruin him. It could take away the beautiful light in his deep blue eyes, or the love in his heart.

She continues. "Well, look at Declan, he's right here beside you. He's happy, healthy, safe. There's no reason to believe he's hurt, or *poisoned* by your past, is there?"

"I guess not... but—"

She lets out a chuckle, then shakes her head. "No buts. Look at your husband, Zahra. He's been with you since you were rescued. He's stayed through the nightmares, the self-harming, the suicide attempts. He's been by your side through everything. You're not going to hurt him. You're not capable of inflicting that type of pain on another person. Do you know why?"

I shake my head.

"Because you have empathy. You know how it feels to be abused and tortured, and you don't want to inflict that type of pain on anyone else."

"So... Declan won't end up like me?" *He could.*

Declan puts his arm around my waist and pulls me closer to kiss my cheek. "Babe, you worry too much."

"Okay," I say, but deep in my chest, anxiety weaves its way through my body and into my mind where the voices from my past clash with the present. *You'll ruin him.*

"What about the compulsions?" Doctor Marshall asks.

I twist my fingers nervously in my lap. “I can’t stop them. I can’t sit down until everything is clean and back in its place. I can’t focus on anything except keeping the house tidy and making sure it’s all perfect. It has to be perfect, for Declan. I want him to be happy.”

She scribbles down some notes, then tilts her head. “And what about you? What do you want?”

I narrow my eyes. “I said I want Declan to be happy.”

Doctor Marshall smiles. “Okay, let me reword this. What does Zahra Foxx want for herself that doesn’t involve Declan?”

I freeze. *What do I want?* I shake my head. “Nothing.”

“Okay, let me ask Declan the same question. Declan, what do you want?” She watches him intently, smiling as he speaks.

“I want to be someone who has integrity, compassion, honesty. I want to know that everything I do is important, and worthy, and that my family—Zahra—are healthy and happy.” Declan rubs his hand on my knee, but I grab it and lace my fingers tight through his, hoping to calm the swell churning in my stomach.

She turns her attention back to me. “Zahra?” she asks.

“I... I want—I don’t know. I just want to be happy...” When I cry, Declan rubs my back and hands me the box of tissues while Doctor Marshall continues.

“Zahra, what’s on your mind right now? Talk to me about it.”

“I’m afraid. I’m afraid that if I don’t do everything right, Declan might leave. I’m afraid that if I can’t be a perfect wife, people will hate me for hurting him. I want to be perfect. I want Declan to love me, even when —”

“When what, Zar?” Declan asks.

Doctor Marshall nods toward me. “Can you continue?”

I shake my head knowing if I say the words, I could lose Declan. I can’t let that happen. I can’t lose the only love I’ve ever known.

“Zar, want me to go for a bit?” Declan asks.

I swallow the lump in my throat, and even when Declan stands, I don’t speak. He presses a gentle kiss to my head. “I’ll never stop loving you, ever.” Then, he leaves.

“Tell me what’s going on, Zahra.”

“Doctor Phillips called yesterday while Declan was at the store.”

Her eyes grow wide and she smiles. “You answered the phone?”

“Jaymee was here. She helped me.”

She smiles. “Well done. That’s a big step, you should be proud of yourself.”

I only nod.

“What did he have to say?”

With a heavy sigh, I cross my arms around myself. “He said... he said I might not ever be able to have children. Because of—because of what they did to me.”

“You haven’t told Declan yet?”

“No.” I shake my head. “I’m afraid if I tell him, he will leave me. He loves Grace and Maggie, and he said he’d love to have children with me one day. But I’m broken inside. They broke me, and now I’ll never be perfect. I *need* to be perfect.”

“Zahra, Declan loves you the way you are. This perfection you always talk about is not achievable. No one can attain it. Perfection is an illusion you’ve come to expect from yourself. You’re beautiful because of your flaws. All your scars, your memories, your pain, all of that makes you truly unique. You’ve faced horrific abuse. You almost died. Those things make you the person you are today. The person Declan Foxx fell in love with.”

My shoulders drop. “But what if this is too much for him?”

She leans back and takes a sip of water from the glass on the side table before she continues, “Why don’t you tell him. Let him make that choice. Don’t make it for him.”

* * *

6.15pm

After Doctor Marshall leaves, I sit on our bed while Declan is in the shower. When he comes out with a towel around his hips, he smells wonderful, and it makes me smile.

He runs a hand through his damp hair and watches me. “Are you feeling better now?”

I nod, but what I want is to tell him the truth about what Doctor Phillips said. “Declan, I didn’t tell you everything about the phone call with Doctor Phillips.”

I stand, and he puts his hands on my hips. “That’s okay, you can tell me now.”

“Doctor Phillips said...” I inhale, then exhale slowly before I admit the truth. “He said I might not be able to have children...” I wait for Declan’s reaction. He steps forward until his toes are touching mine, and he presses a soft kiss to my cheek. “Is he sure?”

I shrug. “He said he’s ninety percent certain. Because of what my fath—”

Declan presses his finger to my lips. “Zahra, it’s okay. There is nothing stopping us from adopting a baby, or a child. Nothing at all. But none of that matters if you’re not ready.” He slides his hands around to my back and pulls me into him. His freshly washed hair smells like the ocean breeze on our honeymoon.

“You’re not mad at me?”

“Of course not. I don’t want you to make babies for me. I don’t want you for your body. I want you because without you, my life is incomplete. Nothing matters to me unless you are here by my side. I love you, Zahra. No matter how many things life throws at us, I will be here for you through everything.”

“Would you be mad if I wanted to wait a long time? Until I’m better?”

He presses his forehead to mine. “We have forever, and if that’s how long you want to wait, then we will wait forever.”

My smile widens as Declan slowly pushes me back until I’m sitting on the bed again. He lays me back, then climbs over me and kisses my jaw and my neck sending goose bumps across my body. It’s a feeling I’ll never get used to. Having someone—anyone—this close to me used to cause physical pain, but with Declan it’s different. Everything is soft and slow.

As Declan lifts my t-shirt, he trails gentle kisses across my stomach and up between my breasts, stopping to kiss each scar and remind me how beautiful I am to him. When our lips meet, he pulls me onto him, and our breaths mingle as we kiss. His hands caress my back before they tangle through my hair and he pulls me closer to kiss me harder. My heart races

with anticipation, and my body begins to move in all the ways I never imagined it could... or would.

When Declan slides my underwear down, I kick them off and they land on the floor.

Declan hovers over me, his elbows on either side of my shoulders. I spread my legs until he stops between them to ask, "You sure?"

I nod. He's always so patient. He never rushes me or forces me to move faster than my own pace.

As he trails soft kisses across my collarbone, he breathes against my pale flesh causing goose bumps to ripple across my skin. He kisses between my breasts, then lower, and lower until he circles his tongue around my navel. Without looking up, he laces his fingers through mine.

Another kiss. Another swipe of his velvet soft tongue. Lower, and lower, until he presses gentle kisses to my thighs, one after the other. He releases his hands from mine, and at the same time my back arches and my breath catches in my throat. *Please, never stop.*

His hands slide up and down my thighs before he pushes them apart ever so slowly. Another kiss, another lick. From between my legs—a place I once believed only caused pain—a groan of pure pleasure leaves Declan's lips. He raises his head slightly, looking up at me. When our eyes meet, he murmurs, "Want me to stop?"

I shake my head hard. "Never. Please..."

A smile dances across his lips. I let out a quiet giggle before he drops his head and his tongue swirls around the most sensitive parts of my flesh.

I thread my fingers through his hair, praying this moment of bliss will never end. It doesn't. For long minutes, Declan's tongue sends me spiralling into a lust filled cloud of pleasure. His fingers glide in and out of me, a steady rhythm I never want to end, but it does, too soon.

When I reach the climax, my body shudders and breaks out in a sweat that covers me from head to toe. Dizziness takes over, but it passes quickly when Declan's warm, wet lips find mine. As we kiss, he moves inside me until every breath I take belongs only to him. With every touch, with every sweet, sensual moment, Declan breathes life into my veins, and love into my heart.

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She finally found her place here
Where love is all around
But one moment in the darkness
Sent her crashing to the ground

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CHARLES

March 1

“Daddy... no go,” Maggie screams from her highchair at kitchen table. As I turn to blow her another kiss, she knocks her bowl of cereal off the tray, sending the milk splashing across the hardwood floor and up the side of the refrigerator. Tiny coloured circles of sugar called Little-Os, stick to the table, the chair, and every other surface within a two-metre radius.

I slap my palm to my forehead. *Shit!*

“Maggie!” An exasperated sigh comes from the other side of the kitchen where Jaymee’s stacking the dishwasher.

After lifting the highchair tray, and plonking Maggie in a clean seat, I tell her to stay put while I grab the mop and start cleaning. Maggie peers down at the floor, pointing. “Pinky lil lil Os, Daddy.”

Cursing the cereal under my breath, I turn to see Jaymee grabbing a handful of paper towels. She rubs her head. “Charles, go. Get to work, I’ll clean this up.”

When I put the mop back into the bucket, another scream pierces the air. “No, Daddy!” I’m sure our daughter inherited the lungs of a banshee.

I press a kiss to her forehead, promising I’ll be home at five. I give Jaymee a quick kiss and a hug before I rush out the door.

By the time I reach the tenth floor of Foxx & Son, I’m twenty minutes late.

At the door to my office, Declan is standing with his arms crossed over his chest while he taps his foot and smirks. “You’re late... again.”

I roll my eyes in mock disgust and give his shoulder a playful shove as I walk into my office.

“Everything okay?” he asks. There’s genuine concern in his voice.

Jaymee's struggling with Maggie's behaviour. She can be the most carefree, lovable little girl in the world, but she can also have intense tantrums that last for hours on end. It's not unusual for her to storm through the house like a mini, crawling wrecking ball, leaving a trail of destruction in her wake. My mother tells me I was the same, not that it helps our situation any, but it's good to know Maggie's behaviour is relatively "normal."

"Yeah, it's all good. Maggie spilled her cereal. I was helping Jaymee clean up the mess. Those damn Little-Os will be the death of me, man." I shake my head hard.

"That bad?"

I nod, then laugh. "Want her?"

Declan scratches his head. "Nah. We love her though, Charles, and anytime you and Jaymee need a break, we'll take her for a few days." He sits in the chair opposite me. Declan's one of the nicest guys I've ever met. He'll go out of his way to help anyone, no matter what. And the way he treats Zahra... the guy deserves a medal. He's so patient with her, and always mindful of her feelings.

We go through the paperwork for the day, and I organise Declan's meeting schedule. Our first call out is at the local café, Latté Art. Ryan decided a few years back that Declan and I weren't going to be stuck inside an office all our working lives. So, as well as taking care of the business side of Foxx & Son, we also do call outs.

Working quickly, we rush in and out of Latté Art restocking the coffee supplies. After three more stops at other local businesses, including Housing Hope, where we get stuck for an hour listening to my mum gossip about Trudi Baker's alleged affair with her gardener, we head back to the office for lunch.

Most days, Declan will meet Zahra for lunch at the park, or at a café in town, but today she's working with Declan's mum at the bakery. It's good to see her getting out more and living her life.

When our lunch is delivered to the office, we tuck into take-out containers of fried rice and lemon chicken. "How's Zahra enjoying the bakery?" I ask Declan.

"She loves it. She's still a bit anxious, but Mum said she's getting better at taking orders, and greeting people. She's trying, that's all we can

ask for.

“You’ve done so much for her, Dec. Good on you, mate.”

He shrugs. “I love her. I’d do anything for her.” He opens his can of cola and takes a mouthful. “So, when’s our next camping trip? I thought we could take the girls, I think Zahra would love it.”

I lean back in my chair and raise my brow. “Man, I need a break. I’ll ask Mum and Dad if they can take Maggie for a few days, maybe we can go next month?” Camping is something Declan and I have been doing together since we were kids. Our Dads used to take us once a month and we’d go fishing, hiking, and mountain bike riding. When Maggie’s a little older, I hope to be able to take her to the same camping ground. With a contented sigh, I shovel in the last mouthful of fried rice. “I’ve missed it,” I admit.

Declan nods. “Me too. It’s been too long.”

We finish lunch, then tidy up the office before getting back to work. Declan’s about to walk out when Ryan walks in, his face ashen. Declan jumps to his feet. “Dad, what’s wrong? Is Mum okay?”

Ryan blinks, then raises his hand that’s holding the cordless phone with a death grip.

“It’s Zahra,” is all he says.

For long, silent minutes, Declan and his father stare at one another as though everything they’re saying is right there in their eyes.

I push my chair out and grab the phone from Ryan’s hand. It’s only then that Declan snaps out of his trance and turns to me.

“This is Charles Stone, who am I speaking to?”

It’s my father. “Charles? Where’s Declan?”

“He’s right here, what’s going on?”

“He needs to come down to the station, Zahra’s here. She’s pretty shaken up. Ah, Charles, someone recognised her.”

I hang up without answering him.

“Dec, we need to go to the station, now. I’ll drive.” Declan stands in silence. I’ve never seen him like this. Usually, he’s the one who’s calm and collected. Right now, it looks as though he’s completely checked out of reality. “Declan!”

He shakes his head, then nods before following me down to the parking garage.

As we drive toward the police station, Declan stares out the front window.

I put my hand on his shoulder. “Dec, talk to me, man.”

His voice is low, but there’s no mistaking the deadly intent behind it. “I’ll kill him.”

I swallow hard. “You’re not killing anyone. We’re getting Zahra, then we’re leaving.”

He punches the dash. “Fuck it, Charles. I was supposed to protect her. I promised her. And I can’t do that while the bastard is still alive. While any of those bastards are still alive.” After another five punches to the dash of my car, he scrubs his hands down his face and sighs. “I want them dead. There must be something your father can do.”

This isn’t the Declan I know. This Declan is someone else entirely. This Declan is the one I saw for a split second when some random asshole at the local nightclub grabbed Zahra on the ass. I’d never seen him so furious. Poor Zahra was beside herself, terrified Declan was going to end up in prison.

I pull over to the side of the road. “Dec, if Zahra sees you like this, she’ll freak out. Unless you calm down, we’re not going anywhere.”

He inhales. He exhales. “I’m fine.” His tone says otherwise, so I give him a minute to breathe before I take off again.

When I pull up at the police station, Declan races in with me trailing on his heels. Zahra’s nowhere to be seen, so we head straight to my father’s office on the second floor.

I knock, but don’t wait for a reply before I barge in with Declan. When Zahra sees him, she cries and throws herself into his arms, but not before I notice the blush of a purple bruise across her cheekbone.

“What the fuck?” I lower my voice as I stand to one side of the room with my father.

He rubs his chin. “Some guy was passing through, stopped at the bakery. Zahra was there with Angela, and she started panicking. Angela said she went outside for some air, then she heard a scream. The guy took off, but Greg from the hardware store stopped him.”

“Who’s the guy?” I ask.

My father shakes his head, then nods toward Zahra.

On the other side of the room, Declan's arms are wrapped tight around Zahra as she cries into his chest. "I'll cancel your schedule for today," I tell Declan.

He only nods.

"We'll leave you two alone. Take all the time you need, Dec," Dad says before he leads me out of his office and down the stairs.

In the file room, Dad locks the door and slumps down into the chair.

I lean on the bench opposite him. "Who the fuck is this guy, and what did he do to her?"

My father scratches his chin. "He's a paedophile and a drug dealer. He's been wanted for a while."

I look down at the piece of paper with the guy's mugshot on it. His name is Rick Wolls.

"So... you've got him here? Where is he?"

My father crosses his arms. "Yes. And no way."

I raise my brow. "Come on, let me hit him..."

My father doesn't budge. He doesn't even pull a smile. "Don't worry. With the evidence we've got, Zahra won't even have to talk for us to put him away."

Realisation dawns on me. "Wait... Zahra? He was one of them... one of the men who paid for her?"

My father nods.

Now I know how Declan feels when the rage takes over. This pathetic piece of shit paid to have sex with a child. It's things like this that make me question my career choice. Deep down though, I could never be a police officer. "What did he do to her?"

"From what I managed to get out of Zahra, he pushed her against the wall. When she struggled to get away, he hit her. She screamed, and he ran. Zahra knew who he was. I called Eli and he came in and confirmed he was on their list as well." He lets out a heavy sigh, then shakes his head. "Charles, the things he did to her when she was a child, I've never heard anything like it."

"But he's going away, right? For good?"

"Yeah, mate. Eli will make sure of it, he's got plenty of evidence."

* * *

By the time I get home, I'm exhausted, both physically and mentally, and after filling Jaymee in on the day's events, all I want is to relax. When the phone rings, I sigh.

Jaymee's lying on the sofa with her head on my lap, and Maggie's already in bed. I grab the phone and lower my voice, "Hey, this is Charles."

"Hey, man. I want to thank you for today. Sorry I kind of went a bit... well crazy."

It's Declan. I huff. "Man, you were a little past crazy. On the verge of insane... but no harm done. What's up? How's Zahra?"

"She's not good. Not at all. That guy... he was one of them."

"Yeah, Dad told me. He said he's going away though. He won't be back."

"He ruined her, Charles," a sob breaks through his voice. "She was doing so well. Getting out of the house, starting to feel good about being outside. Now she's terrified, and I don't know if I can fix it again."

Jaymee looks up at me and mouths, "Is she okay?" I shake my head, and she sighs. "Give her time, Dec. She'll come 'round."

"She was fifteen. Fifteen years old when that bastard bought her, and forced himself on her. She was a child. You know what he called her today?"

I don't know. And by the way Declan sounds as though he's trying to hold back his tears, and his anger, I don't think I want to know. "I'm sorry, mate." It's all I can say.

"He called her a whore. He assaulted her right there on the street outside the fucking bakery. Thank God Greg got there in time."

"Bastard," I say.

There's a long silence before Declan continues. "Charles, I want you to promise me something."

"Of course. As long as it doesn't involve you killing anyone."

He huffs. "If something happens to me, I'm begging you, please take care of Zahra. Protect her with your life. She's my whole world..." he breaks down and sobs over the phone.

"Declan... I promise I'll look after her. You have my word."

"Please, Charles. She'll die without me, you can't let her down."

“Mate, calm down. Nothing is going to happen to you, or Zahra. Why don’t you come around, it’s not too late. I’m sure Jaymee wouldn’t mind.” I look over the back of the sofa to the kitchen where Jaymee’s making a cup of tea. She smiles and nods. “Come over,” I repeat.

After a heavy sigh, he says, “Nah. Thanks for the offer, but we’re good. I’ll see you tomorrow, okay?”

“No worries, Dec. Take it easy, hey.”

“Sure thing.”

“Are they coming?” Jaymee asks, hopeful.

“Nope. This messed her up, babe. Fuck that guy!”

She hands me a cup of tea and sits beside me. “How did she survive it all, Charles? She was a little girl.”

“No idea. Has she talked to you about any of it?” I ask.

Jaymee nods, she takes a sip of her tea. She leans back on the sofa and pulls her legs up. “She told me about her brother. She said he started *using her* when she was fifteen. She let it happen to save her little sister from the pain. Can you imagine that?” She shivers. “God, I’m so thankful for my life.”

I nod in agreement. Jaymee had a pretty tough upbringing. Her mother was an addict, and her father left when she was twelve. She’s made it through anorexia and survived a suicide attempt at sixteen. She’s one of the strongest, bravest women I know, and she never complains or wants people to feel sorry for her.

“I wish there was something more we could do,” I say honestly.

“Me too, babe.” She drops her head to my shoulder.

When her eyes close and she’s snoring quietly, I pick her up and carry her to bed before checking on Maggie. She’s curled up under her blankets with her favourite soft toy in her arms, a plush pink pig Declan and Zahra bought for her.

When I finally doze off, I remind myself how lucky I am to have a family.

Her screams, they shatter the silence
Her cries drown all that remains
Her secrets, they're out in the open
But her heart still breaks when it rains

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DECLAN**April 2**

With one hand, I fumble with the front door key, while in my other hand, I hold a bunch of pink roses. When I finally open the door, Zahra jumps up from the sofa and into my arms. “I missed you so much,” she says as I kick the door closed with my foot and wrap an arm around her waist. “Happy Birthday again.”

I hold out the roses. “Thanks, babe. How was your day?”

She takes the roses and sniffs them before smiling and heading to the kitchen to put them in a vase. On the kitchen counter is a chocolate cake decorated with chocolate curls. “It was good. I made you a cake. Jaymee and Charles are coming over after dinner, remember.”

I nod and watch her flit back and forth in the kitchen as she positions the vase just right before washing her hands and making me a coffee. It doesn’t matter how many times I tell her she doesn’t have to do it, she still does.

She dries her hands, then spins around so she’s in front of the sink again. When she reaches for the tap, I grab her hand and pull her into me. “You already washed them. It’s time to kiss me.”

Her face lights up. “What about your coff—”

I cut her off with a deep kiss. A sigh of pleasure leaves her lips as her hands find my biceps and she squeezes them tight. “I love you,” she breathes the words against my mouth.

“Forever,” I say.

With a spring in her step now, she rushes into the bedroom and comes back with a large box wrapped in white paper and tied with a black ribbon. When she places it carefully on the kitchen bench, she steps back. “Told you I had something else,” she says. The excitement in her voice

makes me want to carry her off to bed right now, but there'll be time for that later.

I place a hand over the expensive new watch on my wrist. "You already got me the watch, Zar, you shouldn't have got anything else."

She smiles and kisses my cheek. "But I love you, and I want you to have everything you've ever dreamed of."

I wrap my arms around her waist, and with a squeal of delight, she wraps her legs around me. "Open it," she says.

With Zahra still in my arms I carry her over and sit her on the bench before I untie the ribbon on the box. I unwrap the paper slowly, watching her eyes light up and the smile play across her lips. Seeing her happy fills me with joy. The paper is gone, revealing a plain white box with a flat lid.

"Keep going," she urges.

I lift the lid, and inside is my present. I gasp, then step back and turn to her. "Babe, you shouldn't have." Since we got married, I've wanted to buy myself a good quality camera. I'm certainly not a professional photographer, but now that I have Zahra, I don't want to miss a single moment.

When it's out the box and set up, I focus the lens on Zahra, but she covers her face. "No, not me."

"Please, sweetheart? I want to remember every single moment with you."

She gives me a slight, adorable smile, and I snap a picture. I turn it around to show her. "This is how I see you. You're perfect for me, babe."

She drops her feet to the floor and hugs me. "I'm so happy you like it. Can I take a picture of you?"

I hand the camera over and smile as Zahra takes pictures. She continues snapping away while I drink my coffee, make faces at her, and when I head into the bedroom. While I'm getting changed, I hear the camera clicking from the living room. *Damn, I love her.*

* * *

My birthday dinner consists of homemade pizza and garlic bread which we devour in front of the TV as we watch a movie and talk about our day. This

is my favourite place in all the world. Right here beside Zahra where no one can hurt her, and all her smiles are made for me.

She's been on my mind so much lately that Dad's given me the month off work to stay home with her. Since the incident with that bastard Rick Wolls, she's gone back into her shell and has been avoiding going out as much as possible.

I'd planned to tell Zahra about my own secret from my past a while ago, but I never got the chance. Tonight, with everything being perfect, I'm positive she'll take the news well.

"Zahra, before Charles and Jaymee get here, I want to tell you something."

She puts her glass of cola on the side table and crosses her legs on the sofa.

"First of all, I'm having a month off. So we can do whatever you want to do. I thought we could go hiking again, up to Mount Blessing, or we could go camping... if you want to."

Her eyes light up, and she covers her mouth with her hands so all I hear is a muffled, "Really?" When she drops her hands, she continues, "I would love to do that with you, Declan."

I nod. "You're happy?"

"Yes. But your job is important, and I don't want your father to be mad at me."

"The time off was Dad's idea. So don't worry, okay."

"Okay. What else are you going to tell me?" She twists her fingers together.

I reach down beside the sofa to lift the small wooden box onto my lap.

Zahra shuffles closer, watching me as I open the lid. "Remember when I told you I was adopted... well, there's more to the story. And I feel like this is the right time to tell you about it."

Another nod. She's silent, but her face is a picture of curiosity.

I take out the photograph and hand it to Zahra. She looks down at it, traces her finger over the image, then looks up at me. "You were a twin?"

I nod. "Yep. My brother and I were separated at birth. William and my mum and dad have searched everywhere for him. There are no records, and nothing to say he survived passed infancy."

“You were both so tiny. Didn’t your mother want you?”

“She was only fifteen, and left the hospital the day after we were born. She didn’t even name us. When my parents adopted me, they were given this box and told that my twin brother wasn’t suitable for adoption. They tried a few more times to find him, but it seems like he disappeared.”

She tilts her head. “Are you sad?”

I shrug. “I’m not sure. I’ve always felt like a part of me was missing, but when Charles and I became friends, it was as though he filled that place. And when I met you, everything was perfect. Sometimes I wonder if he is alive, and if he knows I exist. When I look at this photo, I imagine what it would have been like to grow up with a twin brother.”

“Can we keep looking for him?” She places the photograph in the box. “I would help you, Declan, like you’ve always helped me.”

“It’s okay. My parents have tried for years. There’s not much else we can do now.”

She sighs. “Me and my brother are twins.”

I swallow hard. Zahra’s told me a lot about her brother, but she never mentioned they were twins. I assumed he was older, and that’s why he took advantage of her. Somehow, knowing he is her twin, makes what he did to her even worse. Twins are supposed to have a loving bond. At least that’s what I’ve found out through my research. “I’m so sorry, sweetheart.”

“He always said he loved me. It wasn’t love though.” She drops her head. “I’m okay.” The memories must be bubbling close to the surface of her mind. As if she’s trying to distract herself, she looks over the lid into the box. “What else do you have in there?”

I take out my birth certificate and hand it to her.

“Mum and Dad got a new one when they adopted me.”

“Your middle name is Jacob... Why did your parents choose that?” she asks.

“It’s after my grandfather, his name is Jacob Ryan Foxx.”

She smiles. “I like it, it’s a nice name. Did you have a grandmother too?”

“Yep, still do. They live a long way from here, so I don’t see them much. My grandmother’s name is Abigail, but Mum calls her Abby. They’re my dad’s parents. Mum’s parents are gone. Her dad passed away when she was a teenager, and her mum died of a heart attack when I was a baby. I

don't remember her." I lean back, watching Zahra, worried that talking about death, and family might cause her to remember her past.

"I'm sorry they died. What were their names?"

"Donna and Michael. Does it make you sad to talk about my family?"

She shakes her head. "I love hearing you talk about them. I wish I'd known what a real family was like. I'm glad I have you now, Declan, and your parents. Maybe one day I'll meet your grandparents too."

"And they will love you."

A knock at the door causes Zahra to jump, then she laughs. "Do Charles and Jaymee know about your brother?"

I nod. "Quite a few people in town know, but they don't talk about it."

I close the box, then get up to open the door while Zahra clears the table and tidies the kitchen.

"Hey, Happy Birthday, bro," Charles says, patting my back. Jaymee gives me a hug, wishes me a happy birthday, then heads into the kitchen to see Zahra.

"How did she take it?" Charles asks.

"Ah, good actually. Her brother is her twin," I whisper.

"What the..." Charles lowers his voice. "You're serious?"

"Yeah. I was shocked too."

We sit on the sofa and Charles hands me a beer. "How's Maggie tonight?"

"She's good. Mum and dad are having her for the weekend, I'm sure they'll pump her full of sugar before they bring her home though." We both laugh.

In the kitchen, Zahra and Jaymee are sitting on the bar stools talking.

"So, tell us what you got for your birthday," Charles urges.

I extend my hand to show him my watch. "Whoa! Man, that's one nice watch. You're a lucky guy."

"Zahra got me that camera I wanted."

Charles raises his brow. "Sounds like your night's only going to get better." He gives me a wink before he calls out to Zahra. "Zar, take a photo of us with the new camera."

She takes a few photographs, then hands the camera over to Charles who takes a few pictures of Zahra and I together before we sit down at the table to play a game of cards. The night continues on with drinks, birthday cake, silly board games, and lots of talking before Jaymee and Charles call it a night.

By the time they leave, it's well after 1am when I strip off my clothes and fall into bed beside Zahra. She snuggles up beside me with one arm over my chest. "I had so much fun tonight, Declan. Thank you."

I turn to kiss her. "I should be thanking you, sweetheart. You are the best thing that's ever happened to me."

With a satisfied sigh, she closes her eyes. Within minutes she's fast asleep, but I lie awake thinking about my twin brother, and wondering if it's time to start searching again. Outside, rain patters against the window. Thunder brews in the clouds, an ominous reminder that no matter how perfect our life is right now, the storms of the past will always be on the horizon, ready to ravage us.

Even if you wander
As far and wide as you can see
You'll find the memories chase you
And you'll never be set free

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DECLAN**July 11**

The Foxx & Son Annual Charity Ball is something I've always looked forward to. For five years—while Zahra was settling into Rockburn Grove—I didn't attend. Tonight though, for the first time, Zahra and I are going together.

She stands in the middle of our living room in a stunning, pale pink ballgown while Jaymee sprays her hair with a can and a half of hairspray.

Charles nudges my shoulder. "Mate, we have the best looking wives in this town, right?"

I smile and nod in agreement. Not a day goes by that my heart doesn't swell with love for my wife. "You okay?" I ask.

With a nod, she smiles, but I can see the apprehension in her eyes. For the past two weeks, she's been worried about this event, and try as I might, I can't put her mind at ease.

The beep of a car horn outside sends Charles to the door. "Limousine is here, girls. Are you ready?"

Jaymee jumps up and down clapping her hands and squealing. She yanks on Zahra's hand and drags her toward the door. As they pass me, I take Zahra's hand and spin her around to plant a kiss on her soft, pink lips. "It's going to be fun," I remind her. "Mum will be there too." In the past couple of years, Zahra's become closer than ever with my mum, and I couldn't be happier. Mum always has the uncanny ability to calm Zahra down when she begins to panic. Sometimes, she copes with it better than I do. Dad says I'm so in love with Zahra that I lose focus, making it harder to help her. I guess he could be right.

"Don't ruin her makeup, Dec," Jaymee chides.

"You look gorgeous," I whisper as we make our way to the limousine.

“I’m nervous. What if I do something wrong?”

“You won’t. Everything will be perfect as long as we’re together.”

Inside the limousine, neon pink and blue lights shine from the roof and along the bottom of the seats. It’s big enough for ten people, but Zahra sits right beside me, and Charles and Jaymee sit opposite us. On the way to the venue, we sip on champagne and take in the opulence of the limousine which seems to have hidden compartments everywhere. There’s even a mini refrigerator, and a set up for chocolate fondue which Charles forbids Jaymee from using. It earns him a pout, and a playful slap on his thigh. “You know I can’t resist chocoooooolate,” Jaymee sings.

Charles laughs. “Yeah, you also can’t resist dropping it on your clothes... and that dress cost a fortune.”

Zahra covers her mouth to stifle a laugh as Jaymee and Charles argue back and forth about chocolate. “I’ve never seen anything like this before,” she says.

Jaymee’s voice goes up an octave. “Oh... me either! This is the first time I’ve ever been inside a limousine. We need to do this more often.”

Charles nods in agreement.

Five minutes later, we pull up in the driveway of Crown Reception Centre. Fairy lights and paper lanterns hang from the trees that line the circular driveway. This event brings in hundreds of thousands of dollars for our town, with a percentage of the proceeds going to Housing Hope and the other charities our company supports.

At the entrance, the limousine stops. Charles and I get out first. Jaymee gets out next and straightens her dress as local television and newspaper reporters take photographs. The flashes of their cameras are almost blinding, and when they shout out my name for an interview, or information on the event, I cringe. I don’t mind public speaking. I don’t even mind the attention, but Zahra doesn’t like it one bit, and she is my first priority.

“Oh no,” Jaymee says. “This isn’t good.” She plasters an entirely fake smile on her face and waves to the gathering crowd.

I lean into the car and take Zahra’s hand, but she freezes. “I can’t... I —There are so many people.”

I curse that bastard, Rick Wolls for ruining her progress and sending her back into the darkness. “Come on, sweetheart, once we’re inside, it’ll all die down.”

She drops her feet to the ground and takes my hand as William comes out the entrance with two security guards. He raises his hands. “Back away people, there will be time for photographs and interviews at 9pm.”

Charles shoves his phone into his pocket and I thank him with a wink. “Perks,” he says, winking back at me.

When the crowd dissipates, Zahra stands, and I wrap an arm around her waist as we head inside. When my mother sees her, she leaps from her seat and rushes toward Zahra. “Oh, darling, look at you.” She wraps her in a hug then cups her cheeks. “Are you okay?”

Zahra nods, but remains silent.

We take our seats at the circular table with my parents, and William and Meg. My father takes to the stage first to welcome everyone, and to talk about the night’s events including the auctions, and the charities the money will be donated to.

While he speaks, I pour Zahra a glass of wine. She takes a sip, then returns her hand to mine, holding it tight.

“Welcome ladies and gentlemen to the twentieth annual Foxx and Son Charity Ball. Tonight, we welcome a new charity organisation to our community.”

My father scans the room and when he finds the person he’s looking for, he motions for them to go up to the stage. “Tomorrow, work will start on a new venture. Rockburn Grove will be home to Beneath The Stars, a camp for underprivileged young people to learn valuable life skills in the safety of our beautiful town. To tell you more about this exciting new development, is the founder of Beneath the Stars, Jayden Kellerman.”

“Declan,” Zahra’s voice is barely a whisper.

I squeeze her hand and turn to ask her what’s wrong, but she’s already counting, already has her eyes clamped shut, and her breathing is heavy.

Charles and I exchange knowing glances before I lead Zahra out of the ballroom. In the foyer, she falls to the floor at my feet, sobbing uncontrollably.

I kneel in front of her. “Zar, sweetheart, what’s wrong?”

“It’s him... it’s him. He’s the one—” She begins to hyperventilate and I try to calm her down, but it’s not working. My mind goes into overdrive. If someone in that room has hurt Zahra, I *will* destroy them.

Jaymee rushes out with Zahra’s purse and fumbles with the clasp to get her medication out. Then, she calls out to a nearby waiter and asks for a glass of water.

Almost ten minutes pass before Zahra’s finally calmed down enough to sit beside me on the small, velvet sofa. “Can you talk?” I whisper.

“He’s the one, Declan.” She lets out a heavy sigh. “He’s the only one who ever saw me. Who ever spoke to me. The bath, the water... it was so cold...” She hesitates. “I thought my father killed him because I never saw him again.”

“Who, sweetheart?”

“Jay—Jayden... I was seven years old, and he was the first person to see me. I wasn’t invisible.”

“Did he hurt you?” I clench my fists.

She shakes her head. “No, no. Never.”

I breathe a sigh of relief as William comes out of the ballroom toward us. “Everything okay?” he asks, concerned.

I nod, then stand and tell him what Zahra said while she sits with Jaymee who hands her a bunch of tissues and tells her everything will be okay.

“He’s been thoroughly checked out, Dec. He passed all the background tests, and there’s nothing in his records or personal history to indicate anything suspicious. Honestly, mate, it’s a coincidence. A shitty one, I know, but a coincidence nonetheless.”

I nod and he gives me a hug. “Take your time. And have a chat to Jayden if you like, he’s a good guy, Dec.”

I shove my hands into my pockets and turn back to where Zahra’s sitting with Jaymee. “Declan, am I allowed to talk to him? Is it safe?”

I swallow hard. “If you want to, babe. I’ll have a talk to him first though, is that okay?”

Zahra nods.

I’ve always been the one Zahra wants and needs, and maybe that’s not a good thing. Tendrils of anxiety swarm in my chest mixed with

jealously and anger. Did Jayden know what was happening to her? Did he ever think to tell his parents? To tell anyone?

I shake my head hard. I have no right to judge him. He would have been a child too and probably had no idea. With a glance back to Jaymee and Zahra, I head back in to talk to Jayden before he gets anywhere near my wife.

The crowd is mingling and quiet music plays in the background as I head to Jayden's table. He looks up when he sees me. "You're Ryan Foxx's son, Declan?" He stands to shake my hand.

"Nice to meet you. I dropped in late last year, but you were on your honeymoon. Congratulations."

"Thanks, Jayden. Ah... do you mind if we talk... privately?"

He excuses himself from the table and we head out to the balcony that overlooks the gardens.

"So," Jayden says, "what can I help you with?"

"Well..." I sigh. "This is going to sound all kinds of weird, okay?"

He laughs and leans back against the railing. "Okay..." he says slowly.

"When you were young... do you remember a little girl named Carlie?"

He swallows and his face drops. "What's this about?" There's no hiding the suspicion in his tone. "Who are you...? What's this about?"

I run a hand through my hair. "Carlie... she's my wife. Her name is Zahra now."

"What? Bullshit! I don't believe you." He cocks his head, his eyes narrowed as he stares at me with his arms crossed over his chest.

I pull out my phone and text Charles to bring Zahra out to the balcony.

"How old are you?" I ask.

"Twenty-three, why?"

"The same age as Zahra."

Jayden takes a step forward to leave, but when Charles walks in with Zahra beside him, Jayden freezes on the spot. "Car—it's you. Oh my god!"

Zahra bites her lip and I pull her to my side when Charles leaves. She laces her fingers through mine and squeezes my hand. "Hi Jayden."

"You're Carlie..." his eyes are wide.

“I’m Zahra now.”

“But you... what happened to you? How did you get away?” He covers his face with his hands and leans against the wall. When he drops them, his face is pale and his mouth gapes open. “I thought about you every day. Every day since then, I wondered if you were okay. You were so... so sad, and so small. And your brother...”

Zahra cuts him off. “I’m okay now, most of the time anyway.”

“Why didn’t you tell someone?” I ask, wondering if he ever thought about it.

“I did. I told my mum.” He begins pacing back and forth. “I told her about everything I’d heard and seen. The screaming, the bruises on your skin, the cuts on your arms and legs. She went to your house, but your dad got mad and told her to leave, so she called the police instead.”

“Did they do anything?” I ask.

Jayden shrugs. “I don’t know. They went there, then they left. I thought, Car—” He shakes his head. “I thought she’d be okay. About a year later, my mum was killed in a car accident, and we moved into a smaller house a few blocks away.”

“I’m sorry about your mum,” I say.

“I’m okay. Me and Dad are really close, always have. We’ve got each other now. Zahra, I’m sorry I didn’t do more. I was scared of your father. All the kids were. And even your brother, he was always beating one of us up, or trying to hurt us.”

Feeling a little more at ease, I ask Zahra if she wants to talk to Jayden alone. I expect her to say no, and when she says yes, there’s a lump in my throat I can’t swallow down. *She’s my girl.*

* * *

JAYDEN

Looking into the eyes of the little girl I used to know, is surreal. Since the day I met her when I was seven years old, I could never get her out of my mind. She had the deepest brown eyes I’d ever seen, but in them, I felt like the whole world was right there, waiting to be discovered.

I imagined she had stories in her head, and she wanted to tell me all of them. She became the only thing I would dream about, and until I was ten years old, I told everyone the sad little girl across the street, was my girlfriend. I lied for years, and no one ever questioned me.

After we moved away, I would get on my bike and tell Dad I was going to visit my friend, Mason, who still lived a couple of streets away from where I used to live. The truth was, I was desperate to catch a glimpse of Carlie, to see if she was okay. I'd stop by the green letter box and wait for hours on end, pretending I was playing catch, or that my ball had accidentally rolled into their front yard.

Sometimes, Trystan would tell me to go away. Other times he'd ask to play catch with me. Those were the times I'd find some way of asking him about Carlie, but he never answered any of my questions.

She's even more beautiful than I remember. There's a sparkle in her eyes now, but beneath that sparkle, I still see the same sad little girl.

"Are you okay now?" she asks. Her voice is soft and sweet, the way I remember it.

I smile. "I should be asking you that, right?"

She drops her head slightly, her long dark lashes leave tiny shadows on her cheekbones. "I'm okay. Thank you for talking to me that day, Jayden. I'm sorry if I made you sad, or angry..."

She's sorry? This sad beautiful girl makes no sense to me, but I need to know everything about her. "What happened to you?"

For a long minute she doesn't say a word, she only stares at me. Then, with a whisper, she tells me, "My father abused me. He had sex with me when I was a child and sold me to men who had sex with me too. When I was seventeen, I was rescued."

My eyes are wide, and my mouth is gaping open. I hate myself for not saying more or doing more to help her. Even as a child, I knew something was wrong. "I—I don't even know what to say... I'm so, so sorry."

"I'll be okay now. I have Declan, he's loved me since I was seventeen and he's never given up on me."

I gave up on her. The pain is almost too much to bear. I consider getting up, walking out and never looking back. But the truth is, that little girl I met when I was seven, is the reason I am sitting here today.

Her eyes scan the room, and when they stop, she smiles, and it's beautiful. I look over my shoulder to see Declan walking toward us. He sits on the chair beside Zahra and laces his fingers through hers before kissing the back of her hand. "You okay, sweetheart?" he asks.

She nods.

"Can I tell you something about my charity?" I ask, hoping not to upset her, or Declan.

"Of course," Declan says.

"Ever since I met Carl—you, Zahra, I always thought about how sad you were. I used to see you outside sometimes; you always looked lonely. None of the other kids ever wanted to talk to you because of your dad and Trystan. But I always did. As I grew up, I kept thinking about you and wondering if you were okay, and if you'd made friends. I wanted you to be happy."

I run a hand through my hair. "When I left school, I didn't know what I wanted to do with my life. I'd drive around all day; go past your house to see if you still lived there. One night, I drove past and saw a car in the driveway."

"You were stalking her?" Declan asks.

I shake my head. "No. I mean, I couldn't forget... you know? So, I waited, and I watched you get out of a car with a man. I wanted to shout out to you, to tell you I still remembered, and to ask if you were still sad. But..." I sigh. "I—I was still afraid, I guess. I went to the park and laid on the grass looking up at the stars. I wondered if you'd ever seen the stars, or if you'd been stuck inside that house all your life. And that's when it came to me. I couldn't help you, but I could help other kids see the stars. I could make sure I spoke up and helped them find some happiness in their dark worlds."

Tears well in Zahra's eyes and when she blinks, they roll down her cheeks.

"Want me to stop?" I ask.

She shakes her head. "Please keep going."

I glance at Declan, and he nods, so I continue, "That's where Beneath the Stars was born. I went to university, got my degree in social work and children's services, and I spent two more years studying and travelling. Then, last month I found out the land behind the park here was for sale, so I spoke to my father and he helped me put down a deposit."

“You did that for Zahra?” Declan asks.

I nod. “I guess I did. I mean, because of her I got the idea.”

Zahra’s eyes light up. “Jayden, would I be able to see it when it’s all set up?”

“Of course. I would love for you both to be there.”

Declan stands and shakes my hand, then offers me a drink. When he leaves, I watch Zahra watch him walk away. “Are you safe from him now? Your father?”

She nods. “I’m safe here. I’m safe with Declan.”

“I’m happy for you, Zahra. I’m glad you have a wonderful life now.”

“Do you have a wife or a girlfriend? Are you happy?”

I smile. “No girlfriend. No wife. But yeah, I’m happy. Even more now that I’ve found you again. I hope we can be friends.”

“I’m still... um... I’m learning how to make friends, and trust people, but I’d like that.”

Before I can reply, Declan returns with a glass of wine for Zahra, and a beer for me. Zahra stands and kisses his cheek. When I stand, Declan extends his hand. “It was good to meet you, Jayden, and thank you... for being there for Zahra when she was a child.”

I nod and shake his hand. Obviously, I’ve spent enough time with his wife tonight. Reluctantly, I say goodbye to Zahra and watch her walk away, her fingers laced together with her husband’s as they head to the other side of the room.

Through silent tears I wait for you
Though I know you'll never come
And even dandelion wishes
Won't undo what has been done

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ZAHRA

July 18

9.45am

It's been eight months and eight days since Declan and I became husband and wife. Every day, I mark a pink heart on the calendar in our office. Every day, I try with all the strength I have to remember that Declan loves me. Out of all the girls in the world, he *chose* me.

Today, happiness slipped through my fingers. The hope I've been clinging to for so long, has dwindled away to a dull whisper I cannot seem to find, no matter how hard I search.

This morning, Eli dropped off a box he was given to by the police officers who cleared out my old house. Eli said my father and Trystan are long gone and they're currently on numerous wanted lists. I'm terrified they'll find me and drag me back into their world.

Declan tried to help me, he tried to explain that I'm safe here, and that Charles' father and his officers will protect me, but I couldn't focus on anything but the terror coiling in my chest and clenching around my heart and soul. When I opened the box, all the memories I thought I'd tucked into the back of my mind were released into the atmosphere like a dark, haunted Pandora's Box.

Now, the lid won't close.

I begged Declan to stay home from work today, but he said he had an important meeting with a new client who has a restaurant opening in town this weekend. When I cried, he told me I would be okay, and that he'd call as soon as he got out of the meeting. I begged him a second time, and he reminded me again that I was safe, and no one would hurt me anymore.

The words spilled from my mouth before I had a chance to stop them.

“You don’t understand! You never understand me. You don’t know what it’s like to live in my body. To hate myself every single day because of what they did to me.”

He didn’t move. Just stared at me as though I was someone else entirely, someone he didn’t know at all.

“You weren’t there, Declan! You don’t know how it felt to be raped over and over again by my father, my brother, the school principal... by every single man who entered our house. I need you, and you don’t care. You care more about your stupid job than you do about me.”

Even while I shouted, he remained calm.

“Do you know what it feels like to have men force their fingers inside you when you’re a little girl? Do you know how much pain it causes when you can’t scream, and you can’t cry, because if you make even one tiny sound, the punishment will be so much more painful than you can ever imagine.”

The words continued to pour out, filled with rage and unexplained hatred. A switch in my brain clicked off, logic was whisked away with reason, and replaced with envy and rage.

“You’ll never understand, because your life has always been perfect. All I’ll ever be is a dirty whore.”

Now, while I sit on the floor of our bedroom with the box beside me, all I can think about is the look on Declan’s face while I screamed at him. His eyes glistened with unshed tears, and his lip trembled, but he didn’t say a single word. He took a deep breath, exhaled, then turned and walked out the door.

I clamp my eyes shut and let my tears fall. I’ve ruined everything. I can’t take back the words I said to Declan, and he’s going to hate me for the rest of his life, I’m sure of it.

As I reach into the box, I exhale. Without looking, I let my fingers trace over the stack of books, then down to the bottom of the box where the cool silver reminds me of my mother. For a fleeting moment, I recall the day she took me to the park. I was five years old and my father and Trystan had gone into town. Cathie was still a tiny baby, wrapped up like a jellybean in her pink blanket, and tucked into her stroller. I stood at the top of the bright blue slide and waved to my mother before I dropped to my bottom and slid down with a squeal of delight.

I drop my head back against the bed as I take the silver locket from the box. Clutched in my hand, the cool silver holds no warmth. No love. Nothing good at all. Inside, there's a picture of me smiling, on the other side, there's a picture of my brother. A lump forms in my throat and I can barely swallow it down as the bile rises.

I drop the locket on the floor and crawl to the bathroom, sobbing and choking on tears. My heart beats against my chest so hard I'm sure it's about to explode. I can't breathe. *No. No. No.* I have to breathe. Breathe! *Keep breathing. It's only a panic attack. I'm not going to die.*

Each breath is heavier than the last. I search the wall for a spot to focus on, but all I find are pale pink tiles with swirling filigree patterns that make me dizzy. *Get up!* I shake my head hard. Voices fade in and out of my mind.

"You love sucking daddy's big cock, you'll love sucking mine too."

"Tell Daddy what you want..."

"You should see her with my cock in her mouth."

"It's okay, sis, I've had heaps of practice..."

I press my hands over my ears to drown out the voices while I scream and beg them to stop. "Please, leave me alone."

"Shadow doesn't like you today..."

"You toasted fucking marshmallows over your mother's burning body."

"If I wanted to use you right now, you'd let me..."

"We're all sick..."

I rock back and forth, slamming the back of my head against the tiles, trying in vain to make the voices stop. Nothing helps. They won't leave me alone.

Beneath the bathroom sink, I catch a glimpse of my razor. My fingers move quickly to take it from its hiding place. It's been hidden there since Declan and I moved into the cottage. *Just one cut. Only one.*

I need to make sure I'm still alive. To make sure this isn't a vivid hallucination, or a nightmare I can't wake up from. My phone chimes, distracting me momentarily. I shake my head again to focus on the shiny razor clamped firmly between my thumb and forefinger.

When I press it into my forearm, the relief is instant. I drag it across slowly, watching my crimson blood seep to the surface. One thin red line. I'm alive.

I inhale.

I exhale.

I let my eyes close as I cut another thin red line into my arm. Then another. And one more.

Eight months. Eight days. Eight thin red lines. I drop my head back and sigh with relief. *I am alive.*

My phone chimes again, and exactly three seconds later, it begins to ring. I tilt my head, listening to the bird chirping ringtone Declan added for me. A smile tugs at the corner of my lips, but it doesn't last long. I'm too tired to smile. Too tired to answer the phone or reply to a message. With the razor still tight in my grasp, I drop my head to the bathtub, it's cold against my cheek, but somehow, comforting. My eyes close and my thoughts carry me away to a place where all I hear are birds chirping.

* * *

DECLAN

11.45am

I've tried calling Zahra eight times since I got out of the meeting. I've texted her ten times, and still she's not replying. It's not like her at all, but

she was so upset this morning that she's probably fallen asleep. I feel horrible for walking out on her.

My heart was in turmoil as she screamed at me, her voice filled with pain and rage, and desperation. I knew she wanted me to stay home, but I've taken so much time off lately, and with Dad being unwell, he hasn't been able to come in as much as he'd like to.

With a heavy sigh, I try calling Zahra again, and again, there's no answer. Damn Eli for bringing that box in this morning. The one morning I needed to leave on time. I begged Zahra to leave it closed until I got home, but I doubt she would have.

I check my watch, fifteen minutes until lunch, then, I can go home and check on her. I'm sure I'll find her curled up on the bed, hugging my pillow while she sleeps.

Fifteen minutes drags on forever until finally, Charles arrives back at the office, and I can leave. I rush home with a twinge of panic in the back of my mind. *What if something is wrong?*

When I open the front door, I call out to Zahra. There's no answer.

I head straight to the bedroom. The bathroom door is open, and when my eyes lock onto her, it takes all the strength I have not to drop to my knees and scream. Pulling my phone out of my pocket, I dial the emergency number then drop it on the bathroom floor beside my feet. Blood is smeared across the tiles on the side of the bathtub. In her left hand, resting between her fingers, is a razor.

"Sweetheart, what have you done?" A sob breaks through my voice as I pull her into my arms, begging her to wake up. When I press my fingers to her neck, her pulse is steady, but slow. She's unconscious. "No, please no." Holding Zahra against me, I tap the speaker on my phone to hear a concerned voice.

"Hello...? Is someone there? I can hear you, I've traced the address. What's your emergency?"

"Help! My wife, she's..." I take a few deep breaths, still begging Zahra to wake up. "She's unconscious. Please, hurry."

As I remind myself to stay calm, the panic subsides slightly, and I lay Zahra on the bathroom floor, carefully cradling her head before I move her

to her side.

I tear my jacket off and rummage through the bathroom cupboard for the first aid kit while telling Zahra to hold on.

“Hello?”

Shit! The operator. “I’m sorry. I’m here. My wife... she... she cut herself.”

“An ambulance is on its way. Is she breathing?”

“Um... no, yes. I don’t know. Wait, there are more cuts...” My thoughts turn to shit when I count the cuts on Zahra’s forearm.

“Today is eight months and eight days since we got married.”

It was 8am when she kissed my cheek and pointed at the calendar, a glittery pink pen in her hand.

“Are you there? The ambulance has arrived, please stay on the line.”

Ignoring the operator, I slump to the floor and pull Zahra up so her head is resting in my lap. My tears fall onto her cheek as I look down at the eight deep cuts in her arm. “I’m so sorry, sweetheart. Please forgive me.”

A knock at the front door startles me. “It’s unlocked,” I shout.

I’m not letting Zahra go.

I can’t.

This is all my fault.

* * *

The paramedics load Zahra into the ambulance, and I watch in shock as they drive away. My hands are trembling, and my head is spinning. *She’s going to be okay.* Back inside, I pace the bedroom as I wait for my mum to arrive to drive me to the hospital. There’s no way I’ll be able to drive in this state.

As I pace, I look down at the box Eli brought around this morning. I pick it up to put it in the robe when I notice a silver locket attached to a chain, lying on the floor. The oval shaped locket is open and inside are two children around three or four years old. On one side, a little girl smiles, but

it doesn't reach her big, dark brown eyes. On the other side, a little boy with the same dark eyes wears an angry scowl.

With a heavy sigh, I close the locket and turn it over. On the back, it's engraved.

Carlie and Trystan. Four years old

Is this what caused Zahra to cut herself again? I hold the locket with a closed fist and walk to the kitchen to throw it in the trash, but I stop myself.

No. This has to be her choice. Sighing, I pace back to the bedroom to drop it into the box.

Five minutes later, my mum arrives in tears. "Oh, Declan, darling is she okay? What happened?" She pulls me in for a hug before I rush to grab my keys and wallet then we head out the door.

On the drive to the hospital I tell Mum how I found her, and that I don't know much of anything yet. "She was slumped in the corner against the wall, her head resting on the bathtub. But Mum..." I watch the trees as she drives along. "She was covered in blood and the razor was right there in her hand. I... I thought she was—she could have died."

Mum pats my leg. "She'll be okay, let's get there and figure out how we can help her."

"It's my fault," I say to myself.

"No. It's not your fault, darling. The poor girl has an ocean of memories to swim through. You can't possibly know what will drag her down, you're doing your best. You're doing more for her than anyone else can."

I lean my head back against the headrest and close my eyes. "I guess."

As Mum drives, I twist my wedding band around my finger. *I promise you, forever.* "I'm sorry," I whisper.

When we finally reach the hospital, I rush in through the emergency entrance with my mum following close behind. Doctor Phillips, our family doctor, barges through the emergency room doors, and I call out to him. "Doctor Phillips!"

He turns, and when he sees me, he stops. “Declan, Angela. Zahra’s in room eight, go right through.” He points to the double doors. “I’ll be there in five.”

I nod and thank him before rushing through the doors.

Of all the rooms they could put her in, they chose room eight. Before I push the door open, Mum grabs my hand. “Declan, you need to calm down. Try to stop for a minute and breathe.” She takes a deep breath, staring at me until I do the same.

Inhale.

Exhale.

I can breathe. “I’m fine,” I assure her.

“Calm,” she reminds me. “You know how she gets when you’re worried.”

“Thank you, Mum,” I say as I wrap my arms around her. “Can you give me a minute with her first?”

“Of course, darling. I’ll call your father.”

Inside the small, private room, Zahra lies in a hospital bed with her arm bandaged up. There’s an oxygen mask over her face, and her eyes are closed. I take her hand and rub my finger across the back of it. “Zahra, babe, I’m here,” I say before leaning down to kiss her forehead. “I love you.”

There’s no response, so I drop down into the leather chair and wait for Doctor Phillips to arrive.

My mum comes in first, followed by the doctor who shakes my hand and tells me everything will be okay. Mum sits beside me as he explains, “Zahra started to wake when she arrived in emergency, but was quite drowsy and disoriented, so we’re giving her some oxygen. She’s stable, and all her vital signs are normal. We’re taking her up for scans in about ten minutes, it’s all procedure. We’ll keep the drip in until she’s awake.”

“Will she need stitches?” I ask.

He shakes his head. “The cuts look a lot worse than they are, medically speaking of course. They should do well with some medical glue and a light bandage.” He lowers his voice, “Declan, has she been talking about suicide, or wanting to die?”

“Not at all. As you know, she hasn’t done this for so, so long.” I swallow hard and choke back tears. “Today...”

“Take your time,” he urges.

Mum rubs my back. “It’s okay, Declan.”

I sigh. “Eli brought a box around this morning, it was from her house. The house she lived in with... with them. I had a meeting and I asked her to wait until I got home to open it. But when I got home, there was a necklace—a locket on the floor. It was a picture of Zahra and her brother.” I scrub my hands down my face. “Could that cause her this much pain?”

Doctor Phillips nods. “Her past is—well, it’s horrific. Her brother caused her a lot of pain, she felt threatened by him, and admitted she was terrified of him. I’m only assuming, but I would say seeing that picture brought up a lot of unwanted memories.”

I drop my shoulders. “Damn it, Eli,” I mutter under my breath. *He should have known.* But maybe he didn’t check the box. I make a mental note to give him a call.

I turn my attention back to Zahra and squeeze her hand. When she squeezes mine back, I jump to my feet. “Zahra!” She shakes her head then pulls at the oxygen mask on her face.

Doctor Phillips flicks a few switches, then removes the mask and presses his stethoscope to her chest. “Zahra, can you hear me? It’s Doctor Phillips.”

She nods. “Declan...” A tear slides from the corner of her eye.

“I’m here, sweetheart. I’m here.” I kiss her cheek, lingering for a moment. “You’re okay now.”

Mum pats her leg. “Hey there, beautiful girl, you’re finally back with us.”

“Where am I?” Her eyes dart around the room.

“Hospital. You fainted,” I say. “Zar... do you remember what happened?”

She clamps her eyes shut and shakes her head. “The—locket... Tryst—I wanted to make sure I wasn’t dreaming. I thought I was dreaming,” she sobs through the words.

“You’re okay now... You’re not alone.”

She takes a deep breath and lets it out slowly before looking up at me. “I—I said such horrible things to you, Declan. I’m so sorry.” Tears

stream down her cheeks and when she lifts her hand to wipe them away, she winces in pain. Doctor Phillips reminds her to keep her arm still, and Mum grabs a bunch of tissues to dab at her face.

“Shhh... it’s okay. I’m okay. Let’s just worry about getting you home, hey?”

“When can I go home?” she asks Doctor Phillips.

He stands by the side of the bed. “First of all, you’ll need a scan done because you were unconscious. Then, we’ll give Doctor Marshall a call and she’ll come in and have a chat to you. Depending on how your feeling, you could go home tonight, or, we may keep you in until tomorrow morning. How does that sound?”

“I want to go home,” she cries. “Please, let me go home.”

I stroke her hair. “Sweetheart, if you can’t come home tonight, I’ll stay right here beside your bed.” I glance at the doctor and he gives me a nod. “We need to make sure you’re okay.”

“Declan?” Mum whispers from behind me.

I tell Zahra I’m saying goodbye to Mum, and she nods while we leave the room.

“Declan, honey, I think it would be a good idea for her to stay overnight. Let me go back and clean your bathroom, get it all tidied up—make sure there are no...” she sighs, then drops her head.

“No what, Mum?”

“Sharp objects...” Tears well in her eyes. “I’m sorry. I can’t bear the thought of her doing something like this again.”

I give her a hug. “Thanks, Mum. I appreciate it.” I hand her my keys, and after a quick goodbye, I head back into the room with Zahra.

My love for her
Is written in the stars
She is the one I fell for
Now the future is ours

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DECLAN**July 27***25 years old*

Every time I learn something new about Zahra, it's like falling in love all over again.

In Zahra's eyes, the world is a magnificent sphere of beauty, magic, and new beginnings. She finds joy in the simple things most people take for granted. A tiny buzzing bee on a flower, wishing on dandelions, walking barefoot on the grass, and sitting by the lake behind our house, throwing pebbles into the water.

It's been a week since I brought Zahra home from the hospital. Today, she wants to go through the box from Eli, with me. I told her it wasn't necessary, and that whatever was in there didn't matter anymore, but she's determined to do it.

Zahra sits beside me on our bed with her legs crossed and her hands in her lap, twisting her fingers together. The box sits in front of her, closed. After ten minutes of complete silence, she reaches out and places her hand on top of the box.

"Are you sure?" I ask again.

She nods, then opens the box before leaning forward to look into it. The first thing she takes out is the silver locket which she holds tight in her hand. "I miss..." She sighs. "I miss something, but I'm not sure what it is. Is it possible to miss the things you never had?" Her soft voice questions.

"I guess so. I miss my twin brother sometimes, even though I've never met him."

She drops the locket on the bed beside her thigh. "How can I grieve for a loss I don't even understand?"

"Maybe you're grieving for the loss of what could have been. In a different world, or in a different life, happiness could have been yours."

She shrugs before taking a book from the box. "This is one of my journals."

I've only heard about them. Zahra said they were hidden in the floor beneath her bed where she found a few loose floorboards under the carpet. She didn't think she'd ever see them again.

After taking out three more journals, she turns to me. "Do you want to read them? You can."

A voice in my head screams "yes". I've heard so much through her sessions with Doctor Marshall, I can't imagine there being more. But, by the way Zahra stares at me with her eyes wide, I wonder if she *needs* to share what she's written as a way of healing. I never want her to resort to cutting because she thinks she's alone in this world. I can't lose her.

"Do you want me to?" I ask.

She nods and I shuffle back on the bed so she can sit between my legs. When she's comfortable, I kiss her head then whisper beside her ear, "I'm here for you. You'll never be alone again."

She leans back to kiss my cheek before she flicks through the pages of one journal and holds it in front of us so I can read it.

Today Father went into town and Jeff stayed with me and Trystan. Cathie was in the cellar. She's been in there for two days this time because she bit Father when he was training her. I should be upset and worried about her, but I'm only relieved I wasn't punished as well.

Trystan was in the backyard with his friends, Luke and Glen, and when they came inside, Trystan told Jeff he wanted to take me into his bedroom. I was caught between wanting to stay in the living room with Jeff where I knew what was going to happen. Or, going with Trystan, where I knew whatever happened would be worse.

It was a choice I knew I wouldn't get to make myself, and when Jeff said yes, my body trembled and bile rose in my throat.

"Don't make her bleed this time, Tryst," Jeff said with a smirk.

In Trystan's bedroom, Luke and Glen sat on his bed with a stack of pornographic magazines. They looked up at me, and Glen laughed. "She won't do it, Tryst, no way."

Trystan pointed to the other side of his room. "Go stand over there." I swallowed the lump in my throat and stood in front of the mirrored doors

on the robe. Trystan paced toward me, and when he stopped just inches from me, he whispered, "Do what you're told." His eyes were dark, and his smile sent a shiver of fear down my spine.

I only nodded before he said, "Take your dress off."

I slipped off my dress and let it fall to the floor, keeping my eyes on Trystan the whole time. Waiting for him to hurt me, to do something. He turned back to his friends. "Told you she'd do it. She'll do anything I tell her to."

Luke's eyes widened, he stared at me as though he'd never seen a girl naked before, but the magazines on his lap proved he had. While I stood frozen, Trystan sat on his bed and flicked through one of the magazines. He stopped on a page, then lifted it to show Luke and Glen. "Want her to do this?" he asked them.

Luke shrugged, and his cheeks turned red. Glen nodded. "Fuck yeah, I do."

"Wait," Luke said, "what if your dad comes home, won't he be pissed? And what if Jeff comes in?"

Trystan slapped his shoulder. "They don't give a shit. She's here to be used, you don't wanna be here, go home."

"Pussy," Glen muttered under his breath.

Luke raised his hands in defence. "Nah, I'm not. I don't wanna get beat to shit by your dad again, Tryst."

Trystan ignored him and turned his attention back to me. "Get on the bed and spread your legs."

I wanted to say no. I wanted to scream, knowing Jeff would come in, but then I'd be moved from one horrible situation to another. I was stuck, and I knew there was no way out.

When Trystan stood and grabbed my wrist, he lowered his voice. "On the fucking bed, now."

I nodded and did what I was told, as usual. I am a whore. I found out what that word meant not long after my thirteenth birthday.

In scribbled handwriting and circled with a red pen, it says,

WHORE: a woman who engages in sexual intercourse for money

I grind my teeth to stop myself saying anything as I continue reading.

While technically I wasn't a woman, and I wasn't getting any money, I was smart enough to realise that the dictionary was still right. I was a whore. I am a whore.

The boys only stared at me at first. No one, not even Trystan, touched me. I clamped my eyes shut, trying to focus on a dream I'd once had about a castle built on fluffy white clouds, and surrounded by a moat filled with glittering water and rainbow coloured fish. I never found that dream again.

Silence lingered for exactly forty-three seconds before a hand flattened against my breast, then squeezed. I held my eyes closed, not wanting to know who was touching me. Heavy breathing quickly replaced the silence, then, more hands. All over me. Touching, pinching, groping.

When rough fingers moved inside me, there was a laugh, followed by Trystan's voice. "See, she won't move. She loves it. Do whatever you want to her." He lowered his voice. "No blood though, Father will be pissed if she bleeds."

"You always do this with her?" Luke asked. "She's your sister."

"So fucking what..." Trystan replied. "She does what I tell her to do. Watch this..."

"Get up," Trystan said.

I sat on my knees on the bed while Glen and Luke continued to touch my breasts as though I was nothing more than a naked doll for them to use as they pleased. "She's got nice tits," Glen said.

Luke nodded. "Have you fucked her?"

Trystan laughed. "All the time. She doesn't care, do ya' Carlie?"

I bit my lip, too afraid to speak. Tears welled in my eyes and when I blinked, they dripped down onto my cheeks. Trystan grabbed my face in his hand. "You don't care, do you?"

I shook my head. "No, Trystan."

When he dropped his pants and told me to suck, I did it.

When he told me to do the same for Luke, I did it. And again, for Glen.

When they were done, they moved on to using their fingers, then the fake rubber dicks Trystan had in his drawer. Over the next hour they took turns using my body, forcing themselves into me even when I cried out in pain. When Trystan wrapped his hand around my throat, I prayed I would run out of oxygen and die. I wasn't that lucky. All I could focus on was the pain coursing through my veins.

A knock at the door stopped them all.

"Tryst, time's up, bring her out." It was Jeff.

I thought I would be sent to my room to get cleaned up... I was so wrong.

Jeff wanted to use me too. And while I was face down on my bed, he thrust inside me, harder and faster with each movement. He moaned and groaned while his sweat dripped onto my back and neck and I cried into the sheet. "Such a tight little pussy... gonna fuck you hard this time." His voice caused bile to rise in my throat. I was sore, tired, sick... I buried my face into the sheet and held my breath, hoping I would be able to suffocate myself, but my body betrayed me and when I gasped for air, Jeff merely turned me over and slapped my face. "Ah, ah... don't be fuckin' around. Just 'cause your daddy's not here, don't think you can get out of this." He licked my neck and shoulder. "While your daddy's away, I'm in charge. We need you to keep the dough rollin' in." He shoved his fingers inside me. "This tight little pussy's a money maker."

Two hours later, Father came home and I was taken to the cellar where it started all over again.

I take the book from Zahra's hands and slam it closed before throwing it at the wall. "Fucking bastards!" I shout.

Still sitting between my legs, Zahra gets to her knees and turns around to face me. She laces her fingers through mine. "It was my fault. I didn't stop them. I was a whore. I am—"

"NO!" I shout and pull my hands from hers so I can get off the bed. Pacing back and forth, I scrub my hands down my face before I pick up the journal again. Anger builds in my chest and heat crawls up my neck; spiralling veins of hatred threatening to consume me.

"This wasn't your fault, damn it..." I flick through the journal, searching for words of happiness, words of hope. There's nothing there.

Every page is filled with sentences, paragraphs... pages that make my skin crawl.

On Thursday, Father punished me. I can't sit down, and the bleeding won't stop. It hurts so much.

Today, Trystan's friends came over again. They took turns using me before Trystan tied me to a chair so I couldn't move while they made me suck their dicks.

Cathie is bleeding. Father says she won't be used for a few days because Jeff needs to come over and put an end to it. I don't know what he means, but I'm scared.

I throw the journal back on the floor and pick up another one. The first page causes me to drop to my knees.

For the third time, I tried to kill myself. I was under the water for seventy-three seconds, but Father dragged me out by my hair and forced me to the floor. After he used me, I was whipped five times before he lifted me to my feet and made me watch while he used Cathie, then let Trystan beat her. When Trystan punched her, her front tooth fell out. I couldn't take my eyes off it. A little white tooth, all alone on the tiles of my bathroom floor. I wish I was alone. I wish they would let me die. Tonight, I will try again. I hope Father doesn't want me to sleep with him. He always seems to know when I've given up.

Furiously, I swipe through the pages, there has to be something good. I look up at Zahra. She's sitting on the side of the bed, her hands clasped together so tight her knuckles are white. "Nothing good ever happened to you?" It's a question I already know the answer to, but I need to be sure.

She shakes her head. "I'm sorry."

She's sorry.

She. Is. Sorry.

SHE IS SORRY!!!

Fuck those bastards!

I drop the journal and move across the room to kneel between her legs. With my hands flat on her thighs, I look into her eyes.

“Zahra, sweetheart. No more saying sorry. None of that...” I point to the journal on the floor. “None of it is your fault. You were a little girl who was terrified. You were a little girl who wanted to be loved. *You* wanted happiness, and they used you. *They* are the ones who should be sorry. They broke you, and it started when you were too young to understand that it was wrong. Now, you still believe it’s your fault.”

“But I—”

I press my finger to her lips and shake my head. “No buts. Just because you didn’t stop them or say no, it *does not* mean you wanted it or deserved it. It’s *not* your fault.”

She opens her mouth to say something, then closes it.

I take her hands and kiss her fingertips before I wrap my arms around her waist. While she strokes my hair, she whispers, “I’m sorry for making you sad... and mad.”

When I stand, I tug on her hands so she’s standing toe to toe with me. “I love you. *You* don’t make me sad... or mad. What happened to you does, and if I could take all those memories away, I would.” I place my hand over the bandage still wrapped around her forearm. “I want to help you believe in yourself, sweetheart. You are beautiful, and strong, and you’ve endured so, so much pain. I want to help you stop cutting your skin to find the life inside you.” I pull her close and wrap my arms around her before I twist my fingers through her hair. “Zahra, you are alive. You are free. It’s you and me now, and we’re going to survive, together.”

She sobs against my chest. “Dec—Declan, I want to be better now. I want you to help me. Please... pl—please help me.”

For the next three hours, I hold Zahra while she tells me more about her brother and the torture he inflicted upon her. I’d thought she’d told me everything, but it turns out he had no limits. If her father was a monster, her brother was pure evil. Eventually, Zahra decided she wanted to burn everything in the box, except—to my surprise—the silver locket that belonged to her mother and held the pictures of Zahra and her brother inside.

She didn’t say it, but I have a feeling part of her is still the same little girl who believed in hope and craved their loved. They ruined her life, and I

will help her get it back.

After a call to Eli and William to ensure Zahra's journals won't be needed for further evidence, we head outside. Twenty minutes later, the fire pit is dancing with flames. Tendrils of grey smoke rise into the air. With a journal in her hand, she opens the cover and places her hand flat on the first page.

"Declan, I..."

I tighten my arm around her waist. "You don't have to do this."

She inhales, then on an exhale she tears the first page from the journal, scrunches it in her hand, then throws it into the flames. The paper ignites within seconds; it's nothing more than ash. Another tear of paper, another page in the fire.

Together we stand, tearing page after page from Zahra's journals, then watching them go up in smoke. If only getting rid of her memories was so simple.

When there's one journal left, she opens it to a random page and reads the words out loud.

"Dear Daddy, today is my tenth birthday. You promised you would buy me a pink cake. I hope you do because I'm making a special wish for you today. It's a big secret so I'm not going to tell you, but I'm writing it in my journal and one day I will show you." Unshed tears line her eyes before she blinks, sending them dripping onto the pages. I rub her back as she continues, "Today I'm going to make the biggest wish ever. I'm going to wish for you to get better. You've been sick for a long time, Daddy, and it's my fault. From now on, I'm going to be very good, and I'm going to do all the things you want me to do, because it makes me sad when you're not happy with me. I love you the most, Daddy, and I hope you love me too."

Zahra tears out the page then drops to her knees, sobbing. "Why, Declan? Why did he do this to me?"

I kneel and pull her close, before whispering, "Sweetheart, I don't know. I don't have the answers, I'm sorry." *God, I wish I had the answers.*

"I loved him so much, he was my dad—my father. But now—now... I hate him." She sobs the last words into her hands. "There's nothing good in

here. I thought it was all okay. I believed he loved me so, so much.” She tears out another page, and another until scattered pages surround us. “I wanted someone to love me...” Unblinking, she stares into the fire as I gather up the pages. One by one, I scrunch them into balls before dropping them into the flames.

As the paper goes up in smoke, I sit on the ground and pull Zahra into my lap. Her head rests on my shoulder and her warm breath tickles my neck. “Do you think he ever loved me? Like fathers are supposed to love their daughters?”

I tuck a loose strand of hair behind her ear and kiss her forehead. “At one time, maybe he did love you. But somewhere along the way it turned into something ugly and depraved, and that *wasn't* love.”

Looking up, I notice the first star shining in the sky, and I make a wish.

Please, let her be happy now.

Unravelling at the seams
What does this all mean
Has no one ever seen
The nightmare inside my dream

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ZAHRA

August 25

9.15am

24 years old

One, single, odd-shaped piece of disposable plastic is all that stands in my way. A piece of plastic signalling the beginning of a journey I never intended to take. I stare down at the two thin, blue lines. *Irreversible*. When guilt coils in my stomach like tendrils of poison ivy, intent on clawing their way through my subconscious and into reality, I suck in a breath. While exhaling slowly, I allow my shaking hands to come to rest on the pale pink porcelain basin.

My second thought comes one minute later when my reflection in the mirror appears as a distorted face. Remnants of my past breach the surface to remind me of the scars still etched into my flesh. A lightbulb flashes in my mind. *The past*. What I could become lingers like a thick smog filled with malevolence. What I never want to become pierces my veins like a toxic poison with no cure. I can't be like him... like them. *Don't let me be like them*.

Unconditional. That's what love is supposed to be. If only I knew *how* to love properly. If only I wasn't so obsessive. If only I... my thoughts trail off as I recall the moment I met Declan at Housing Hope.

He was taller than me. He had perfect, thick, dark hair and piercing blue eyes. I knew instantly, Declan was different. I gave my trust to him in the form of a thousand tiny butterflies fluttering in the pit of my stomach. In return, he showed me hope. He calmed me, and he never once looked at me with anything but love and adoration.

How I long to see those blue eyes right now.

I clamp my eyes shut for a fraction of a second before opening them again.

The thin blue lines stare up at me as a shock wave tears through my body. It's too much to bear. I'm balancing precariously—on those lines—somewhere between hope and uncertainty.

Placing the plastic stick on the bathroom counter, I lean down and squint to ensure the lines are really there. To ensure they're not a figment of my often over active imagination.

I pace the bathroom, straighten the towels, then pace the living room and the kitchen. The house is spotless, but in my mind, every corner and every shadow hides a secret I've kept hidden. Under every rug is a memory I long to forget. They float in the air waiting for the moment I lose my composure and fall to my knees.

I sit.

I cry.

I pace again.

I spend two hours scrubbing the kitchen before I vacuum the house for the second time.

Five hours later, at precisely 5.05pm, Declan arrives home. Through the stained-glass panel of the front door, I watch him fumble with his keys. In his other arm, I spy a bunch of flowers.

My smile is short-lived. Those tendrils of poison ivy are already weaving their way through my heart, grasping at my chest and winding intricate little paths through my lungs.

I can't breathe. The air grows thick and my legs shake, but when the front door opens, the waft of Declan's cologne smothers the anxiety, and calms me for a fleeting moment.

Declan is home, and finally, I am home too.

"Hey, babe," his voice, like him, is filled with the promise of unending happiness.

I leap from the comfort of the sofa into Declan's arms.

One strong arm snakes around my waist and holds me against the warmth of his chest. Feather soft kisses trail my neck and jaw until our lips collide with furious passion.

In this moment, with my arms wrapped around my husband, my world is perfect. Nothing else matters. Declan is my saviour. But will he forgive me for feeling the way I had earlier? The way I still feel now?

I will tell Declan about my thoughts. If not, they will eat me up inside until a breakdown of epic proportions thrusts me into a darkness from which I always struggle to escape. A darkness that has lived inside me since I was a child and still terrifies me.

For a while, I was happier than I'd ever been. The ups were giving me hope, and the downs were few and far between. Then Rick Wolls showed up at the bakery. With him came the reminder, I'll always be the same scared little girl I was when my father controlled me.

Tears spring to my eyes. My grip around Declan's neck tightens as thoughts of despair and self-loathing break through my fragile mind. *I will destroy everything I touch.*

Uncontrollable sobs cause salted tears to spill from my eyes and trickle down my cheeks to the corners of my lips. I'm a little girl again, being plunged violently into the crystal-clear water that had the power to drown me.

I purse my lips into a tight line and press my face against Declan's shoulder where the tears soak into his shirt. They no longer taint my skin. They're gone.

His hand massages my back in long, slow circles as he whispers in my ear, "Hey... hey, babe. What's wrong?"

I swallow down the lump in my throat and force the words out, "I... I'm... I'm so sorry..."

Declan leads me to the plush, white sofa where pale pink and white scatter cushions are perfectly lined up. A white fleece throw rug is folded over the back of the sofa. My arms never leave his neck as he pulls me onto his lap. He strokes my hair, rubs my back again, and kisses my forehead.

"Zahra, talk to me."

Deep breaths. Tell him.

Declan loves me. He makes a point of telling me every single day. Of showing me, every day. Never once have I doubted him. Though I do doubt my ability to be loved, to be lovable. My mind constantly plays tricks on me. It reminds me of the past I long to forget, and the voices I pray will never return.

His fingers lift my chin, and when I look into his deep blue eyes, the words fall from my lips in a waterfall of heartache and despair. "Declan, I... I'm pregnant."

I search his face for a sign he feels the way I did earlier. All I find are his own tears welling in his eyes. Drop by watery drop they fall down his cheeks and land in silence on the bare flesh of my arm. I cannot bear the thought of Declan being in pain, and I can't read his face until finally, a smile creeps upon his lips and as it grows bigger, his eyes grow brighter.

I cup his cheek. "Dec, please say something."

"I love you, Zar."

Dropping my hands, I twist my fingers together. *Tell him, Zahra.* The voice in my head urges. *He'll hate you.* Another voice warns.

I clamp my eyes shut and try to block the voices out. *I am in control.*

Declan takes my hands in his. "You're not happy?"

His concern is genuine. As genuine as the fear coursing through my body, forcing me to point out my flaws, my inabilities.

We had discussed children. We agreed to wait, at least until I'd settled into a routine, and I'm able to get through the day without debilitating anxiety creeping in and destroying my happiness. Our happiness.

Honesty was what I promised in our wedding vows. Most people promised for better or for worse. Declan was there, for better, and has always been there for the worst.

He never gives up on me. Not when I threatened to leave him. Not when he found me on the floor of the bathroom, covered in blood from wounds I had inflicted upon myself. And not when I begged him to let me die so I could be free of the turmoil raging inside my head.

Declan was there for all of it.

I wanted our wedding vows to reflect our love, and a new chapter in our life. With my eyes closed, I think back to the day I became, Mrs Zahra Foxx.

*With every heartbeat, I will breathe
With every breath, I will believe
With every touch, I promise you
With honesty, our love is true*

Honesty.

It has always been the glue that has held us together. I've never once lied to him, and I won't start now.

When I open my eyes, I admit, "I'm scared. What if I'm like him, like them? What if I do something terrible, or say something I can never take back? It's irreversible."

Declan's strong hands cup my tear-stained cheeks before a lingering kiss meets my lips.

"Zahra, you are not like that. You will never be like that."

I stand and fluff up the cushion before pacing the living room.

"I'm not good enough. I can't even get through a day without breaking down in tears, Dec. I can't leave the house unless you're with me. I'm going to ruin everything." I make my way into the bathroom where the ominous plastic stick still sits on the corner of the counter. The blue lines are still there. *Of course they're still there.*

I reach out to take it, but something stops me. An invisible hand holds mine back.

Declan appears in the doorway. A second later, he glances down at the plastic stick and smiles before turning his attention to me.

He runs a hand through his hair. "Zahra, babe, talk to me."

I point to the test and its tiny blue lines that seem to be laughing at me. "Those two blue lines will change our lives."

Declan pulls me into his arms and kisses my cheek. "It will be okay. We will be okay. I'll take time off work so you won't be alone. Zar, I would never let you do this by yourself, you know that, right?"

I nod, but my heart is heavy. It's aching for someone who is yet to exist in the real world. Someone I alone have the power to destroy.

Declan will never let me do that. *With Declan, I will be okay.*

I promise her the world
And hope she understands
I'm not here for this moment
I'll forever hold her hand

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DECLAN**September 8***2 weeks later*

It's been two weeks since I discovered I'm going to be a father and I couldn't be happier.

I walk into the Foxx & Son building on Main Street with a smile I can't wipe off my face. Zahra is the love of my life. There is nothing I wouldn't do for her, and though our relationship hasn't been easy, I've never given up on her. I never will.

I make my way across the hardwood floor and shrug my coat off before hanging it neatly over the back of the leather recliner. With a heavy, contented sigh, I sit down and pick up the silver-framed photograph off my desk. Behind the spotless glass is a picture of me and Zahra on our wedding day. One of those photos the photographer calls "quirky" and "fun."

At first, Zahra was nervous. She was worried about smiling, worried she might look stupid, or fall over while trying to balance in her strappy white heels that were dusted in a thin layer of sparkling glitter.

I remember kneeling in the flower bed as Zahra balanced on one foot. Her other foot balanced on my knee. Only seconds later, she fainted. The flashbacks haven't stopped, and I try not to let them ruin anything for her.

The photographer had no idea why she fainted, he wrongly assumed it was nerves and lack of food and water. Either way, it is my favourite photograph because in that moment of uncertainty, I reminded Zahra that I loved her.

A knock at my door pulls me from my thoughts. I place the frame on the side of my desk, and when I glance up, my eyes meet with Charles. He unbuttons the cuffs of his shirt and rolls up the sleeves. "You coming to The Crown tonight?"

I scratch my chin and flick through the ever-growing pile of paperwork on my desk. As the new CEO for Foxx & Son coffee company, I have no shortage of work, and I always make a point of not taking it home. Home is my haven. My place of rest and relaxation. Home is Zahra.

I pull my mobile phone from my pocket. "I'll call Zahra and see what she wants to do."

I swipe across the screen to find her face. My beautiful wife. Her long, brown hair frames her face and flows down over her shoulders in thick waves. Her brown eyes are staring into the camera. She wasn't smiling, but she wasn't sad. Pondering, I thought. It's my favourite photo of her. A rare photo she let me take.

I bring the phone to my ear as Charles takes a seat opposite me.

Her sweet, quiet voice flows into my ear. "Declan..."

I smile, she sounds good, *and* she answered the phone. "Hey, sweetheart, how are you feeling?"

"I'm okay, a little tired. I made muffins for you."

"You're the best, Zar."

I glance at Charles who gives me a thumbs up and a nod, then mouths, "Six o'clock."

I nod.

"You're already at work?" Zahra asks.

"Yeah, not much traffic today. Hey, you want to go to The Crown tonight with Charles and Jaymee?"

"Oh, um... The Crown? I don't..."

Charles calls out, "Come on, Zahra, Jaymee is dying to see you."

On the other end of the phone there's a quiet laugh. "Um... okay, I guess so."

Charles nods, eagerly awaiting an answer.

"You really want to?"

"I do, Dec. I want to, and I want so much for you to be happy."

My smile grows as I nod to Charles and he punches the air.

Zahra's *issues* aren't a secret. Growing up here, everyone knows who I am. When Zahra and I became an item, the entire town welcomed her with open arms, and open hearts.

They don't know the truth, though, or the secrets we have to keep to ensure Zahra's safety.

In the past five years, I've helped my father grow this company and we've turned Foxx & Son into one of the most iconic brands of our time. We've created hundreds of jobs and regularly donate money to local charities and schools. Twenty percent of all our profits go to Housing Hope. Everyone loves me—Declan Foxx. It's surreal, and sometimes I wish I were invisible, especially for Zahra's sake, but given my time over, I wouldn't change a thing.

"I love you, Zar," I say, before I hang up.

Charles mocks me, making kissing sounds, and I laugh. "Okay, we'll meet you there at six."

Charles gets up to leave. "By the way, why are you so happy lately? I mean more than usual anyhow."

I shrug and raise a brow. "You'll find out soon enough. Now get to work, or we'll both still be here at six."

* * *

She twirls in front of the full-length bathroom mirror. "This is so pretty, Declan. You didn't have to buy me another dress."

My heart swells when I watch her smiling and twirling like a ballerina.

When I was young, my mother told me about her days in the theatre, and how they practiced so much their feet would be bruised and bloody by the end of the performance. She said some ballerinas even danced with broken toes. *Zahra would love the ballet.* I make a mental note to purchase tickets for her next birthday.

Zahra stops and takes a step toward the mirror. She tilts her head and turns slightly, looking at herself from every angle. She leans forward and peers into the mirror as though she's searching for someone through its reflective surface. After blinking, she steps back quickly then smooths her hands over the black satin dress.

"I should wear a coat," she says into the mirror.

I take two steps forward and stand behind her with my hands on her bare shoulders. I smooth them down her arms and stop at her fingers where I lace mine through hers.

“You’re perfect like this. And it’s warm out tonight, you won’t need a coat.”

“But...”

I put my finger to her lips and kiss her neck. She lets her head fall back to my shoulder and my lips trace her neck before I nibble at her earlobe.

“No buts. You are perfect, Zahra.”

When she closes her eyes, I let my hands wander over the small swell of her hips, up to her breasts and back down to her tummy where I stop and flatten my hands.

“I love you... so much.”

“Declan...” she breathes my name with pleasure.

The bathroom is filled with the heady scent of my cologne mixed with the fruity scent of her perfume and body wash.

My hands slide down to her thighs and up under the silky fabric of her dress.

“Declan,” she whispers as my hands find her warm and wet and aching for my gentle touch.

Slowly, I push her underwear aside and slide a finger in, followed by another. Her body relaxes against mine, held up only by my arm coiled around her waist.

I flatten my hand and rub my palm against her, easily finding the place where she turns to putty in my hands.

Her breaths turn to shallow pants as her lips part and I spread her legs with my knee. Propping myself against the counter allows Zahra to spread her legs wider, giving me more room to delve deeper into her warmth.

“Oh god, Zar,” I breathe against her cheek and whisper in her ear, reminding her how beautiful she is to me.

As her body shudders with pleasure, she moans my name until finally, she stills.

I turn her around. The pink blush in her cheeks is reminiscent of our wedding night, and the first time we made love.

Every time after that night only confirmed what I already knew. Zahra is perfect for me. We are two parts of a whole. Two beating hearts brought together by fate. We were made for each other.

I smooth out her dress and cup her cheeks. “Ready to go?”

She nods.

She smiles.

Then she whispers, "Thank you for loving me, Declan."

* * *

The Crown is the most luxurious restaurant in Rockburn Grove. The opulent dining room is fitted with high end leather sofas and mahogany tables with matching leather topped chairs. Each table is decorated in crisp white table cloths embroidered with gold thread and topped with crystal vases overflowing with deep red roses.

Zahra's death grip on my hand tells me she's already anxious. The Crown is her favourite restaurant in town, and is usually quiet. But tonight, there's a function involving a rowdy group of females I recognise from high school.

One of them is Macy Plain, who is anything but *plain*. The hot pink sash over her shoulder reads *Bridesmaid*. It's going to be a night filled with alcohol, and a lot of partying.

Macy catches my eye and rushes over. Her stiletto heels are at least six-inches high and make her walk like a baby calf. I resist the urge to laugh at her stumbling between the tables. When she reaches us, she throws her arms around my neck and plants a pink lipstick kiss on my cheek.

I place my hands on her shoulders and step back to put my arm around Zahra's waist.

Macy shakes her head and places a hand to her cheeks; her glassy eyes tell me she's already drunk.

"Deccy, what you doin' 'ere," she slurs.

"Dinner. You're here for a Hen's night?" I ask trying to be polite, but desperate to get away from Macy before the entire group of rowdy clucking hens appear.

She nods quickly. "Heyyyy.... Zar... you wanna join us for drinks?" Macy asks.

Zahra shakes her head. "No thanks, Macy, we're meeting Charles and Jaymee. You look good."

Macy wiggles her hips where a wide, hot pink ribbon is tied around her waist inches above her tiny black hot pants. "I know, right? These hot

pants are sooo cute.”

For a moment, I imagine Zahra dressed like Macy, out on the town having a girl’s night out, partying, drinking—carefree.

Guilt hits me like a punch to the stomach. Zahra will never be able to do such a thing. But I wish she could.

Macy gives us a wave and blows a kiss before sauntering off toward the group of females. They’re leaning over a table, taking turns downing shots of vodka while cheering one another on.

“Looks like they’re having fun,” Zahra says. “Do you ever wish she was still your girlfriend, Declan?”

Her words cut me to the core. Zahra’s questions are always so honest, and so sudden. I’ve told her a hundred times there’s no one else in this world I want other than her. But anxiety causes her to question everything. I tighten my arm around her waist. “Never. You’re the only one I want, forever.” When she smiles, I change the subject. “Do you wish you had a Hen’s night?”

“Oh god, no way,” Zahra says. “I’d never be able to do that.”

I kiss her cheek. “You can do anything, Zar. Anything your heart desires. We just need to give it time.”

She smiles but doesn’t answer me as we head toward the table where Charles and Jaymee are waiting. Zahra slides into the seat beside Jaymee and they hug.

“Wow, Zar, you look gorgeous,” Jaymee says with her eyes wide. “Please don’t tell me Declan bought you another dress. I swear he has better taste in clothes than half the women in this town.”

Zahra smiles and her cheeks blush pink. “He did, I love it.”

I’ve always loved that about her. The pink in her cheeks never ceases to stir my emotions in the best way possible.

“So,” Charles says. “You two have been more than a little happy lately, what’s going on?”

I take a sip of beer after thanking Charles for ordering our drinks. Zahra takes her glass and stirs the water with the straw, ice cubes clink against the side of the glass.

“Do you want to tell them?” I ask her.

She shakes her head and sips on her drink, then places it back on the table.

Jaymee nudges her arm. "Come on, tell us."

"Declan can tell you," Zahra says.

I exhale slowly and scan the room. This news is going to be the talk of the town for a lot longer than the next nine months. "Zahra's pregnant. We're having a baby."

The squeal from Jaymee causes the entire restaurant to look up and fall silent. At the exact same time, Charles jumps from his seat and shouts, "You're having a baby!"

I grab his arm and pull him down. "Seriously, keep it down," I remind Charles with a glance and nod toward Zahra who's nervously chewing the inside of her mouth.

Jaymee grabs Zahra and pulls her in for a hug. "Congratulations, Zar, you're going to be a perfect mother."

The sadness in Zahra's eyes is overwhelming, and the blush in her cheeks is gone. It's been replaced with a blank stare and a pale complexion.

I reach across the table and put my hand over hers. "You okay?"

She nods, but she's not okay. *If only she could see herself the way I see her.*

Our meals come out, and by the time dessert is served, Zahra has finally relaxed.

"Have you picked names yet?" Jaymee asks

Zahra shakes her head. "Oh no, it's too early. Isn't it? Should we pick names now? Oh no, I'm so stupid. I don't know anything about babies." She drops her head into her hands.

Jaymee smiles and continues. "You're not stupid, Zar. I can help you, don't worry, okay. What about colours for the nursery?"

Zahra shakes her head again. "Not yet. I've only known for two weeks. Will you help me with that too, Jaymee?"

Jaymee nods. "We could go to Hues, they have colour samples."

"Ah... I guess so," Zahra says nervously.

Charles stands to go to the bar and pats my back. "Coming, mate?"

I lean down to kiss Zahra's cheek. "Drink?"

She nods, and we leave the girls to head to the bar.

At the bar, Charles sits on the stool beside me. He lowers his voice, “She’s not happy, Dec?”

I sigh. “She’s scared, mate. This isn’t what we planned, you know? I mean, we thought there was only a slim chance of her being able to get pregnant.”

He orders another round of drinks before turning back to me. “I bet. Do you think she’ll be able to cope with a baby?”

I shrug while drumming my fingers on the bar. “Mate, I don’t know if *I* can cope with a baby.”

Charles pats my back. “We’ll help you out, Dec, with anything. We’ve got so much of Maggie’s old stuff, so don’t you go buying up big. I wish...” his voice trails off.

I take a mouthful of beer. “I know, mate, and I appreciate it. She’s getting better, though. A year ago, she couldn’t walk in the door here. Six months ago, we didn’t make it to the main course, and now look at her.”

“It’s because of that bastard, Ric—”

I shake my head. “Don’t mention him. She’ll be good again, it’s going to take time.”

I look over to Zahra where she’s chatting and smiling with Jaymee. I give her a wave and the pink in her cheeks returns.

Charles follows my gaze. “Mate, I wish she could see herself the way other people see her.”

“It’s all I want for her,” I say honestly. “It’s all I want.”

I hold on to the memories
Even though I don't want to
If you promise to stay forever
I'll try harder just for you

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ZAHRA**November 3***12 midday*

I press my hands over my already swelling belly. “It’s not normal, Declan, what if something is wrong?”

Declan places his hands over mine. It’s growing fast. Too fast, our local doctor thinks. So, at twelve weeks, we’re headed for an ultrasound in the city. The doctor suggested it could be twins, but when I panicked, he said it was all fine. Of course, I don’t believe him.

At twelve midday, we sit in the waiting room at Sundowner Memorial Hospital. I take Declan’s hand and hold it between mine. “Dec,” I whisper. “I can’t do this without you. Please, please don’t let me do this alone.” On the verge of tears, I beg him to never leave me.

Declan drops his arm over my shoulder and pulls me closer. “I’m not going anywhere. I’ll be here, for you and for our baby. I promised you forever, remember?”

While I sit, I think about Declan’s birth mother and how she left her tiny babies in a hospital. Does she know Declan is alive? Does she care? “Do you ever wonder how she did it? How she gave you up and never came back?” I ask.

He sighs as a cloud of sadness shrouds his face. “I guess she had her reasons. We’ll never know. But our baby is going to know it’s loved by both its parents. Its real, birth parents.”

“I’m sorry if I made you sad.”

Declan shakes his head. “Zar, you never make me sad. I don’t remember my real mother, or my brother. I can’t be sad over someone I didn’t know, right?”

I nod, guessing he’s right.

But I still wonder. If I'd been adopted, like Declan was, perhaps I would have had a better life. An exciting, brilliant life, full of wonder and happiness. Maybe I would have had the chance to make friends, and to go to parties. But no, I wasn't lucky, not at all. All I got was a life of abuse, torture, and pain at the hands of those who were supposed to love and protect me.

My past is tip toeing precariously close to the forefront of my mind. Everything is reminding me I'm not worthy, nor am I ready to become a mother.

Most days I feel as though I'm still a child in a grown woman's body, playing house with a husband who worships me, and friends I never see because I'm too afraid to step outside my own front door.

They could come back. And if they come back, I will die.

I am a mess of anxiety wrapped in a cloak of nightmares. I need to pull myself out of the prison I've created and move forward. This baby could be the answer. Or, this baby will be the beginning of my undoing. I tighten my arms around Declan and kiss his cheek, lingering for a moment to take in the scent of his cologne.

"I love you, Declan," I say as the sonographer arrives.

The room is small and claustrophobic. It reeks of disinfectant and bleach. I gasp and step back out of the doorway, unable to force my feet to move forward. *Please. Not now.* I beg myself to move.

Inside my head, I'm screaming *it's just a room*. But on the outside, I'm shaking uncontrollably. *You'll die in there*. A voice echoes through my mind. My hands fall like dead weights by my sides. My palms are sweating, and my stupid heart is racing in my chest.

"Zahra, breathe." His voice cuts through the confusion, but still, I cannot move.

A gentle hand touches my shoulder and causes me to jump.

"Mrs Foxx, I'm sorry. We have a larger room available, dear."

The words start to make sense, voices clear and his cologne lingers.

"Declan." I say his name louder than I want to, and when his hand squeezes mine, I know I'm going to be okay.

The next room I'm led into is larger than our bedroom. Two beds sit side by side, in between them, a monitor. And either side, more monitors.

It's all unfamiliar and overwhelming. "Is someone else going to be in here?" I ask.

The nurse shakes her head. "Nope, only you, my dear. Now, let's get you ready." She hands me a blue gown and I reluctantly let go of Declan's hand to head into the small change room.

When I peel off my long sleeve t-shirt and catch a glimpse of myself in the mirror. Disgust coils in the pit of my stomach. My too-pale skin is littered with scars.

Do this again, and I'll use Cathie instead. The words float through my mind without a care. They bring with them more words. Words I desperately want to erase from my memory.

I shake my head and clamp my eyes shut, and instead, I focus on my ever-swelling belly. I smooth my hands over it and stop, imagining Declan's gentle hands over mine. His touch, his kiss, his everything.

It doesn't work, and my voice trembles. "Declan, help me."

By the time he arrives, I'm already on the floor in the corner of the change room, sobbing.

He kneels beside me as the nurse's voice calls from the room. "Take your time, sweetheart."

Why is she so kind?

Declan helps me to my feet and pulls me into his strong, loving arms. "Zahra, listen to me, okay. We can do this, together. Our baby is going to have the most amazing life, and the most beautiful Mummy the world has ever seen. I've got you, Zar. I'm never letting you go."

Tears stream down my face as the panic that took hold flows slowly into the background and my breathing returns to normal. "Declan," I cry.

There's no reply, no questions. His name alone is enough to calm me.

"I love you so damn much, babe," he whispers. And after the shortest, sweetest kiss, we walk out of the change room to find the nurse smiling.

I lie on the bed with my belly exposed. Will the nurse ask about my scars? Will she care? What if she laughs or says I deserved it?

You deserved it. A voice taunts, but another gentle voice reminds me, *it's not your fault.*

Before the nurse—whose name tag says Mary—presses the probe against my belly, Declan places his hand over it. "You're so beautiful."

Mary sighs and smiles. “Well, Mrs Foxx, if you can tell me where you found this catch of a hubby, I’d much appreciate it.”

I smile brighter, and Declan laughs. “She didn’t find me. I found her. In fact, I think I was searching for Zahra all along.”

“Aww, you two are too much,” Mary says. “Now, let’s see what’s going on with this little baby.” The blue gel is warm on my skin, but I still gasp when she spreads it across my belly and begins to move the probe across my flesh. A light flickers on the monitor, and orange lines appear before something pops up on the screen.

A little bean shaped something.

Inside the bean shaped something, is a tiny, flashing glimpse of what I know without a doubt is our baby’s heartbeat. *It’s real. It’s all real.*

My own heart swells with pride. For twelve weeks, I’ve protected the tiny being growing inside me. I’m yet to know anything about it, but I’ve kept it safe. So far.

What if something is wrong? What if that tiny beating heart suddenly stops? It will be my fault. My responsibility. I will be to blame.

The nurse flicks a switch and a whooshing sound fills the room. It’s followed quickly by a strange thumping echo.

“That’s our baby?” Declan asks as his hand tightens around mine.

Mary smiles, still looking at the screen. “It is. Looks like you’re right around twelve weeks along. Give me a minute, my dears, and I’ll explain everything.”

I watch between the probe on my belly and the image on the screen. Then, I watch Mary’s brow crease. She squares her shoulders and tilts her head. But she’s silent.

Something is wrong.

She zooms into the image, then clicks. Click, click, and click again. *Is she measuring something?* The probe moves, and the echoing beat of our baby’s heart suddenly changes from bom, bom, bom, to an erratic thumping that makes no sense.

Something is wrong.

My head is spinning with thoughts. My breath is caught in my throat, and the words I want to say will not come out. *Broken inside.* I’m broken inside. All my broken parts will destroy any chance our baby has of breathing life into this world. It’s all my fault.

“Is everything okay?” Declan’s trembling voice says everything I can’t.

“Do twins run in your family, Zahra?” Mary asks with barely a glance at us.

When I turn to Declan, the sadness in his eyes breaks my heart. Will he tell the nurse everything? Or will he deny all knowledge?

He gulps a breath of air. “Ah... I was. I am a twin,” Declan finally admits.

I exhale, relieved he left it at that.

“Oh lovely, identical?” Mary asks.

Declan shrugs. “I don’t know, actually. We were separated at birth. I don’t know what happened to my brother.” His tone is sombre. Declan told me he’s always felt like a part of him was missing, and we’ve been talking more and more about trying again to find his twin.

Mary continues, “What about you, Zahra?”

“No,” I lie.

“Well, I think congratulations are in order. It looks like you’re going to have your very own set of twins.”

“No.” I cover my mouth with my hands and tears spring to my eyes. No.

Guilt replaces happiness.

Fear replaces hope.

Two babies? I can’t do it. *And not twins*. I am devastated.

Declan stands, never letting go of my hand as his other hand rubs over his face. “You’re sure?” he asks.

Mary points to the screen, now frozen in time. On the left, a tiny bean. Beside it, another identical bean. Or peas. Two peas in a pod. Two lives we are now responsible for. Two babies I helped create. *Two babies* I am capable of hurting.

“I can’t,” I cry. “I—Not twins... please no.”

Mary rubs my arm. “Darling, this will be okay. I’m going to call your doctor in to go through a few things with you.”

Declan cups my cheek and leans down to my ear. “We can,” he reminds me. “You are not alone, Zar. Never alone again. I promise you, forever.”

I swallow the hard lump in my throat like it's poison. "Not twins," I cry once more.

The nurse continues her clicking, while in the background, the thumping heartbeats of two unborn babies reverberate off the walls, reminding me that two lives are now in my care.

Two tiny beings who could grow up to love one another. Or, they could grow up like my brother and me. And that would destroy me in every way possible. I would rather die.

Please don't let this destroy me.

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We'll hold their hands
For a little while
But we'll forever
Hold their smiles

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DECLAN

1.45pm

Zahra is overwhelmed and terrified. The news we were having a baby was enough to send her spiralling into anxiety and fear. But the knowledge we are having twins, is destroying her. In truth, we both should have seen this coming. We're both twins, so our chances were high to begin with.

When we left the hospital, we sat in the car for ten minutes. Zahra cried into her hands, begging me to never leave her. I promised her I'd always be here, but fear has replaced rational thought.

I've made an appointment with Doctor Marshall for the end of the week so we can spend some time talking about the future, and what this pregnancy means for Zahra and the issues she's faced in the past.

Walking into the shopping centre, Zahra grips my hand and squeezes it. "I'm so scared," she says again.

I wrap an arm around her waist and stop between two stores to pull her into me. "Zar, babe, we can do this. Let's take it one day at a time, okay? Baby steps."

She smiles, then rests her head on my shoulder. "Don't let me ruin them."

I kiss her cheek. "Let's go to the baby store," I suggest.

"It's not too soon?"

"Of course not." I rub my hand over her tummy and she smiles brighter than she has all day. "We can buy our babies their first presents."

Her shoulders relax and she breathes out a sigh. "I would like to do that."

Before we head off, my phone rings, it's Mum.

"Hey Mum."

"Well... how did it go? Good news?"

Zahra holds my hand between both of hers as I talk. "It's all good. Everything is perfect."

There's a sigh of relief, then quiet laughter. "That's all you're going to tell me? Did you get pictures?"

"Yep, we sure did. We'll stop by on our way home and show you."

"Aww, honey, I'm so happy for you both. How's Zahra handling it? Is she okay?"

"She's perfect," I say with a wink at Zahra. "We're both nervous, I guess. It's all so real now."

"Oooh... I can't wait to hear all about it. You drive safe, and we'll see you later today. Love you both, so much, darling. And your father says hurry home, he wants to see pictures of his grandchild."

I laugh. "We will. We love you both too. See you soon."

"Bye, honey."

I push my phone into my back pocket.

"You didn't tell her it's twins," Zahra says.

I shake my head. "Nope, we're going to surprise them. Like we were surprised."

Her smile is beautiful, and with a spring our steps, Zahra and I head to Baby Lane & Co.

Every aisle is filled with baby clothes, furniture, toys, bedding, and dinner sets, bottles and cups made for babies and children. Zahra stands in awe staring at everything, then she bursts into tears.

Before I can comfort her, a sales assistant rushes over and pats Zahra on the back. "Oh, honey. It's all overwhelming but go slow. You've got months to prepare."

"Thank you," I say, hoping she'll back off a little.

She doesn't. "When are you due?" she asks. There's no mistaking her excitement. She's certainly chosen the right job.

"April thirtieth," Zahra says, wiping her tears away. "We're having twins."

The sales assistant whose name is Tally, presses her hands to her mouth, but it doesn't muffle the scream that echoes through the entire store. She jumps up and down, squealing, "Oh my god, I love twins! Follow me," she says, running to the end of the aisle.

Zahra and I exchange glances, and at the same time, we laugh. The sound of her laughing sends waves of hope through my veins. She's getting better. Maybe these babies will bring her out of her shell and show her she's capable, beautiful, and worthy of all the happiness in the world.

I take my wife's hand. "Well, you heard the lady, let's go."

Standing in front of the display, my head spins. The prices are ridiculously high, but according to Tally, "It's totally worth paying extra for quality."

With that in mind, Zahra and I spend the next hour looking at tiny baby clothes. Not knowing if we're having boys, girls, or one of each, we decide on white for everything and end up purchasing a twin bassinet, white cotton bedding, six sets of white newborn clothes, and two pairs of white booties. On our way to the register, strategically placed soft toys are on sale, and of course we need those too. Zahra chooses two, soft, white teddy bears with rattles inside them. Tally assures us they are suitable for newborn babies.

As we're loading everything into the back of the car, Zahra laughs again. "Oh my gosh, Declan. What did we just do? Do we need all this yet? Should we take it back?"

I hand her the teddy bears. "We bought things for *our* babies. We're not taking anything back. We can start setting up the nursery as soon as we get home."

She closes her eyes for a second and sighs with happiness. "I love you so much, Declan."

I push the back door closed, then wrap an arm around her waist, the two teddy bears squished between us. With one hand on her belly, I tangle my fingers through her hair and press my lips to hers. The kiss is soft and her lips taste like cherry gloss. When she lets out a feminine sigh of pleasure, I whisper, "I promise you, forever."

She leans into me and the world around us stops as we hold one another in perfect, blissful silence until the honk of a car horn startles us.

"Hey, you leavin'?" a guy calls from the window of his car.

"Yeah, we're leaving." I give him a wave as we get into the car.

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I made a secret promise
To keep them safe and sound
One plus one, two tiny hearts
Forever to me bound

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ZAHRA

3.30pm

Café Braziia is a lovely little café nestled among gum trees and overlooking a small park and a duck pond. From our seats in the rear garden of the café, I watch families strolling through the park and children playing on the swing sets and slides. Soon, we will have our own family. *It will be okay.*

I sip my hot chocolate as Declan stares down at the black and white ultrasound pictures of our babies.

“Dec, I’m still scared,” I admit. “What if something happens to them?”

“They’re safe,” he assures me. “While they’re inside you, growing, they’re safe. Remember what Doctor Phillips said. Healthy eating, lots of rest, and plenty of water. He’s going to be with us every step of the way, babe. He’s the best doctor around.”

Declan slides the pretty china plate toward me. On it sits two mini cupcakes. One pink, and one blue. “Do you think they’ll be boys, or girls?” he asks.

His voice is so full of happiness. I need to push away my sadness and fear and focus on Declan and the journey we’re about to take together.

“Maybe boys, like you and your brother.”

His smile grows bigger. “That would be cool. Should we pick names?”

“Already?”

He nods. “Come on, it’ll be fun. This whole day is about us, Zar, us and our babies.”

“What names do you like?” I ask.

“I have an idea!” He calls a waitress over and asks her for a pen and two pieces of paper. “I’ll pick two boy names, and two girl names, and you do the same. Then, we swap.”

I nod in agreement. While Declan writes the names down, I pick up the ultrasound picture and trace my finger over the little beans. *I'll keep you safe, I promise.* A tear drips from my eye and I swipe it away as Declan hands me the pen. "You okay?"

I nod. "Happy... and still nervous. But I'm so happy right now." I write down the names I love and pass the paper to Declan.

"First, eat your cupcake." He stuffs the pink one into his mouth. "On three?"

I nod, and after eating my cupcake and waiting for Declan to count to three, I look down at the names on the page, and more tears spring to my eyes. In Declan's neat, perfect handwriting it says,

Boy—Xavier, Jacob
Girl—Abigail, Grace

As my smile grows, Declan's does too. "I can't believe this. I guess our babies are named..." He sits the two pieces of paper together and we both smile wide. On mine, I chose,

Boy—Jacob, Ryan
Girl—Abigail, Angela

"It's still so long until we can find out what they are," I say.

"Eight weeks will fly by, sweetheart, you'll see. So, are we decided on Jacob and Abigail?"

I nod. "What if it's two the same?"

"We'll work it out, together."

I take another sip of hot chocolate and watch a father pushing his daughter on the swing. "I missed out on so much..." I whisper the words more to myself.

"And our children won't miss out on anything," Declan promises. "They'll be so loved they won't know what sadness feels like."

I smile, but I can't shake the feeling of concern. Even when Declan takes my hand and twists my wedding band around my finger. "I made you a promise. I will be here for you, always and forever," he reminds me. "This journey has just begun, and we've got so much more to do."

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Thunderstorms are coming
November rain is falling down
The roads, they are all flooding
Please don't let me drown

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ZAHRA

4.45pm

The drive home is unusually quiet, and slower than usual due to the rain that seems to have come from nowhere. It's spring, and the sky is clear and blue, not a cloud in sight. Heavy raindrops hit the car, a lively symphony playing an unknown tune.

The weather reports come across the radio calling it a freak phenomenon of nature. People are calling in saying this is unlike any sun shower they've ever seen. Then, a woman calls in to the radio station and says it's a sign from God. She says he's crying for the destruction and death that plagues the world.

I've never believed in God, but for a brief moment, I imagine an old man with a bushy white beard looking down upon an earth he created, wondering how and where it all went wrong. Did *He* choose my childhood? Was I punished for something?

No.

I didn't do anything wrong.

Declan flicks the radio off. "When we get to Mum and Dad's house, you can sit on the porch and watch the rain," he says. "I'm sure Mum will go crazy over everything we bought today." He reaches across and squeezes my hand. "And she's going to love those little pictures."

"I would love to." I run my fingers through his hair at the back of his neck. I do love the rain. On our wedding day, I prayed for rain, knowing that rain on your wedding day meant good luck. It never came. Today is my second chance. The day we discovered we're having twins. I place one hand over my belly and rub it gently. I can't wait to tell Jaymee about our babies. She'll be over the moon.

As Declan drives, I watch the road. It's slick and shiny and the sun belts down upon the bitumen creating a rippling mirror on the road's

surface. A sheen of slippery water that reflects the sunlight making it appear as a sheet of glass.

Declan comes to a stop at the traffic lights. Cars speed past from left and right. Water sprays from their tyres and splashes against our windscreen. The rain comes down with such force that the gutters and drains struggle to swallow it up, leaving rushing rivers along the sides of the road.

The lights turn green, and as Declan accelerates, he squeezes my hand again.

“Zahra, I love you so much. Our lives are only going to get better from now on.” His voice is full of hope and happiness.

I smile and turn to him. “You are my everything, Declan.”

My heart is caught in my throat. The scream comes from deep in my lungs, a place I never knew existed.

It’s too late.

The red jeep barrels toward our mini with its horn blaring. With a glance, I see fear in the driver’s eyes.

Why isn’t he stopping?

“Declan!” My scream is masked by the violence of the crash that pushes me against the car door. My head hits the window and I’m thrown around like a rag doll. My vision blurs with a haze of red. I reach out to Declan and managed to grip his arm, but our little car throws me into the door again.

“Declan!” I scream until my throat is raw and I cannot form another word.

“Zah—Zahra,” his voice is barely a whisper. A strangled, gurgling sound I instantly hate on him. For the first time since we met, I wish I hadn’t heard his voice.

Silence lingers for a long moment before sirens wail and screaming takes over.

But it’s not mine. And it’s not Declan.

A crack.

A crunch.

Metal being torn apart.

Glass breaking.

Voices.

“What’s your name?”

“Are you okay?”

“Can you hear me?”

I open my mouth. “Declan,” is all I can say.

My vision is still blurry, but when it clears, I see it. The image that will be burned into my mind for the rest of my days. The ultrasound picture of our babies is stuck to the dash and splattered in blood.

It’s a sign.

Instinctively, I attempt to wrap my hands around my belly, but I can’t move.

I try to turn my head away, but a forced hand splays across my forehead. “Don’t move.”

Something hard is clipped around my neck and I struggle to free myself. *Let me go! Please, let me go.* “Declan!” I scream.

“They won’t make it.”

Who won’t make it?

My body doesn’t react the way I want it to. I extend my hand, searching for Declan, needing him. Wanting to hear his voice, no matter what it sounds like now.

I push at the hands trying to hold me down. I scream. I wail. I curse.

“Put her out!” a voice calls.

Something presses against my belly. *My babies.*

Another voice shouts, “There’s... no—I can’t find... heartbeat...”

I force my eyes open but the entire world is filled only with blurs of black and white. “No!” I beg. “Please...”

When silence takes hold and my eyes grow heavy, I know with certainty, I am alone.

Only blackness remains, and my world is dark.

Years of fun and laughter
Happiness and friends
Torn right from her grasp
This curse will never end

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CHARLES

5.58pm

I shove my hand into my pocket to retrieve my phone. The damn thing has been vibrating non-stop since the start of Maggie's Teeny Tots dance recital. No one is ever this determined to talk to me.

I stand and apologise profusely to each person as I shuffle, bump and push my way through the narrow gap where people sit, eagerly waiting for their children to take the stage. I head out to the foyer and of course, the call ends.

With a sigh, I look down at the screen. An unknown number has called seven times.

What the hell? It could be a customer. Some have been known to call on weekends, even though Declan made it clear, weekends were off limits for call outs or business. Some don't care though, and Declan rarely says no.

I lean against the wall in the foyer, tapping my foot, staring down at my phone knowing the mysterious caller will call again. And they do.

The male on the other end of the line sounds relieved. *Damn customers.*

"Hello, is this Charles Stone?"

I roll my eyes. "It is. This better be important. I'm at my daughter's recital and we have a strict, no weekend calls policy. Mr Foxx made that clear in every contract."

There's some commotion in the background. A beep, then an alarm, followed by a scream. *What the hell?*

I run my hand through my hair, confused. "Who is this?"

Tapping on a keyboard, voices in the background seem to be shouting commands. Something about blood and oxygen.

The male exhales, then continues, "I'm sorry, Mr Stone, we have your name here as a contact person for Declan Foxx."

Suspicion is creeping in. There are people trying to get money out of Declan and his father's business. Especially since he started giving it away to charities. Scammers call every other day with their fake sob stories. Now, everyone is thoroughly checked out before any donations are considered.

On the other hand, there's also the possibility this person could be looking for Zahra. Ready myself for a confrontation, I take another step toward the door of the foyer.

"And?" I ask.

"This is Doctor Lachlan Roberts at Sundowner Memorial Hospital. I'm sorry to tell you this, but... ah, Mr Foxx was involved in a motor vehicle accident."

I swallow hard against the acrid taste at the back of my throat. I pace the floor of the foyer trying to make sense of the words. Doctor. Hospital.

Declan.

Accident.

Where's Zahra? Did they find her?

I place a hand against the wall to steady myself. "What happened? Where's Zahra?"

Jaymee peeks through the doorway with a scowl on her face. Her blonde hair is tied into a neat bun with thick white ribbon. Her white, lace covered dress flows around her thighs, and on her wrist, she's wearing the diamond and pearl bracelet I gave her for our first anniversary. Before we married, we both agreed we would devote as much time as humanly possible to Maggie. This is her first dance recital, and she's been practicing for months.

Tears come to my eyes at the realisation, Declan and Zahra could be in danger. Declan's been my best mate since we were kids. Our own fathers are best friends. *Nothing can happen to him.*

Jaymee's face softens and concern etches her features.

I whisper, "It's Dec, he's been in an accident. I don't know where Zahra is."

Jaymee covers her mouth with her hands. Her tears come quickly, but she blinks them away before nodding and heading back into the concert hall.

“Mr Stone?” the doctor sounds irritated now.

“I’m still here.”

“Mr Stone, Declan and his wife Zahra were both involved in the accident. We’ve had to sedate Mrs Foxx. We’ve called your father, and Declan’s, but they haven’t answered. Doctor Phillips is on his way, but asked me to call you. I’m sorry, are you able to come in?”

Sedate Zahra? She’s alive though.

“I’m on my way,” is all I say before I shove my phone into my back pocket.

Jaymee comes back into the foyer with Maggie who has tears streaming down her own little face. Her pink tutu is spread around her tiny waist and the ribbons of her ballet shoes are tied in perfect pink bows. She’s devastated, but this is something I have to do. I’ll make it up to Maggie a thousand times over.

I kneel and take her little hands in mine.

“Maggie, honey, Uncle Declan and Aunty Zahra were in a car accident. Mummy and I need to go and see if they’re okay. Do you understand?”

Maggie rubs her eyes and nods. “I come wif you... dey die, Daddy?” she asks.

“No!” I say adamantly. “They won’t die.” But anything is possible.

* * *

The sterile smell of the hospital is one I detest. It lingers. It burns my nose and reminds me of death. Hospitals are the one place I avoid like the plague. My aversion to blood is another reason I stay well away. It was also the reason I chose to work for Declan and his father rather than follow in my own father’s footsteps.

As Jaymee carries Maggie into the emergency waiting room, I make another call. I can’t get through to my parents, or Declan’s, so instead, I call Eli and fill him in on what I know before I ask him to meet us at the hospital to watch Maggie while we wait for my parents to arrive.

I wonder for a moment if my father knows about the accident, he could have been on the scene. Could still be there, waiting for the okay to leave. I’ll call him again as soon as I’ve seen Declan and Zahra. There’s a

line in the Emergency Department's waiting room. People are crying, babies are screaming, and others are complaining about the wait.

I'm growing more irate by the second. I can't handle the waiting and not knowing. I march up to the desk and lean in close to the glass window.

"Hey, we were here first," a young guy says as he cradles a pale baby in his arms.

"I need to get in. I was called a few minutes ago," I say urgently.

The woman at the desk sighs and points to the back of the line. "There's a line. You're not in it."

"Please," I beg. "I'm here to see Declan Foxx, he was in a car accident. Doctor..." I can't remember his damn name. "Ugh... a doctor called me."

The woman rolls her eyes and taps on a computer screen before she points to the large double doors. "Through that way. Next," she calls.

Jaymee grabs my hand as we rush through the emergency cubicles searching for Declan and Zahra.

They're not here.

I stop a doctor and beg him to help, "Please, my best friend is here. Declan Foxx, and his wife Zahra."

The doctor's face is pale, his brow creases and he pulls off a pair of blood covered latex gloves. My stomach turns at the sight of them.

The doctor nods. "Ah... sorry, Mr Foxx is in surgery. Mrs Foxx is in intensive care. Doctor Roberts is with her now, perhaps he can tell you more." The doctor takes off and Jaymee rushes over to the nurse's station where people are busily answering phone calls and shuffling paperwork.

An older lady looks up at her through thin, brown rimmed glasses. "Can I help you, dear?"

"We're looking for Zahra Foxx, the doctor said she is in intensive care."

She taps on a computer then points in the direction of the corridor.

"Head straight down to the end. It's the last door on the right."

Jaymee nods and I take her hand before we run down the corridor with Maggie screaming. Our poor daughter has no idea what's going on, and we can't stop to comfort her. Not until we find Zahra.

* * *

I can't breathe. The air has been sucked from my lungs and the world is spinning around me while I stand helpless, staring down at Zahra. She looks positively dead.

Her head is bandaged and blood stains her white bra and covers her chest, arms, and face. A bandage is wrapped securely around her left thigh where blood seeps through.

My gaze stops on the myriad of scars scattered across Zahra's thighs.

Of course, I know a lot about the horrors Zahra endured as a child, and then later in her teen years, but I never imagined I'd see her scars or feel such anger and hatred toward those who inflicted the pain upon her.

"Oh my god." Jaymee gasps and covers her mouth with her hands. "Do they know she's pregnant? What if the drugs they gave her harm the baby?"

"Fuck!" Charles curses.

A doctor walks in and stops in his tracks. "Malcolm Roberts. You must be Charles Stone?"

I nod and extend my hand to shake Doctor Roberts', then I introduce him to Jaymee.

"She's pregnant," I say nodding toward Zahra's lifeless body. "Um... Doctor Phillips... he's their doctor."

"What?" The doctor is clearly shocked and removes his stethoscope to hold it against Zahra's chest. He presses a button on the wall, and a minute later a nurse rushes in. He orders her to bring in an ultrasound machine and to page Doctor Phillips.

"Can I touch her?" Jaymee asks.

The doctor nods. "We had to sedate her, she was hysterical."

Maggie's eyes are wide as she climbs up on the chair to look at Zahra. "Za za, wake up now," she says, her little hands resting on the side of the bed.

Zahra will never survive without Declan. He is *her* lifeline, and although I also know enough about Zahra to help her, I can never replace my best friend.

As though Jaymee senses my thoughts, she puts a hand on my shoulder. "They will *both* be fine."

Jaymee takes Zahra's hand and sits on the small chair, pulling Maggie onto her lap. "You'll be okay, Zar, we love you."

"What about Declan?" I ask the doctor.

"He was pretty bad when he came in. We couldn't get him breathing on his own and he has suffered some serious internal injuries. We've got the best surgeons here at Sundowner, he's in good hands."

"How long until we can see him?"

The doctor sighs heavily. "Not sure, I'm sorry." He walks out without another word, leaving me and Jaymee in silence.

"She won't be able to cope without Declan," I say.

Jaymee lowers her voice, holding Maggie against her chest as she whispers, "She's strong, Charles. Don't talk like he's not coming back. He'll be okay."

I slump into the uncomfortable, squeaky recliner and rub my hands over my head as my mum and dad rush in with Angela. I jump to my feet and my parents hug me while Angela goes to Zahra's bedside and cries.

"Where's Ryan?" I ask my dad.

"He's trying to get in to see Declan, but they're making him wait..." He scrubs his hands down his face. "How is she?" he whispers.

I shrug. "She's been sedated, we don't know anything yet."

Angela looks up at me, tears streaming down her face. "Do they know she's..." she sobs and my mum pulls her into her arms. "The baby..."

I pace back and forth. "Yeah, the other doctor paged Doctor Phillips."

Angela and mum sit with Jaymee, the three of them cry but don't say a word. Maggie sits on the end of Zahra's hospital bed, whispering, "Wake up now, Za za." After ten minutes of pacing, and still no sign of the doctor, my father storms out of the room in search of answers.

Five hours later, an ear-piercing scream tears through the room. Maggie covers her ears and cries before my mum picks her up and carries her out of the room and into the corridor.

I leap to my feet to find Zahra tearing off the tubes and bandages. Blood seeps from the wound on her head and her eyes are wide with horror. "Declan!" she screams.

Angela tries to calm her, but it's no use, and when Doctor Phillips rushes in with a syringe, I extend my hand, stopping him. "No. Don't. Do

you have to put her out again?”

“Please, Doctor Phillips,” Angela says.

He steps back. “She won’t heal if she tears out the tubes and bandages,” his voice is panicked.

I rush to Zahra’s side, and on the other side, Jaymee takes her hand. “Please, please let me speak to her first,” I beg.

He steps back and nods. “Two minutes.”

Ignoring the blood, I put my hand gently on Zahra’s shoulder. “Zahra, calm down. It’s okay. You’re safe here and if you pull out the tubes, they’re going to put you to sleep again. Stay with us, focus and breathe, okay?”

She clamps her eyes shut. “Declan,” she cries.

I look over my shoulder at the doctor.

“He’s just come out of surgery, as soon as I find out more, I’ll let you know.”

Zahra’s breathing slows and she turns to me. “I need him. I need to see him, Charles.”

Jaymee sobs as she holds Zahra’s hand and begs her to listen to me and to stay calm. With a heavy, defeated sigh, Zahra drops her head back on the pillow and stares up at the ceiling. “Angela...” she calls.

Angela leans down to Zahra’s ear and whispers something I can’t hear, but Zahra nods, then closes her eyes as Angela sits beside the bed.

Two hours later, Zahra falls asleep of her own accord. At the same time, the doctor arrives to say that Ryan’s just left Declan’s bedside, but that only one of us can see Declan at a time. I extend my hand to Angela, but she decides to stay with Zahra and tells me to go first.

I follow the doctor to a larger room in the intensive care unit.

When I walk through the double doors, I freeze. My best friend is lying prone on a hospital stretcher covered in blood. A thin blue sheet barely covers him from his hips to his thighs. There’s a metal brace on his left leg, held together with long silver screws. Down the centre of his chest a large wound is covered loosely in a clear plastic dressing. Another wound slices across his abdomen where his skin is a horrible shade of mottled purple and blue. Declan’s right arm must have been sliced open too. It’s now held together with hundreds of silver staples.

A breathing tube extends from his mouth to a machine. Another larger machine has thin tubes extending from two different bags, one is filled with a watery liquid, the other is filled with blood. They both lead down to Declan's arms where the tubes lead straight into his veins.

The constant beeping is already drilling through my mind, but I continue forward, walking slowly, each step taking me closer to the male who has always been my very best friend.

"Ah, Declan, mate. What the hell happened?"

I don't expect a reply, instead, I turn to the doctor who shakes his head.

"The police were here earlier. If you're listed as immediate family, they'll tell you what happened."

I only nod. My heart hammers inside my chest. My ribcage feels like it's crushing me, and my head is spinning with thoughts. How will Zahra react to seeing him like this? How long will it take Declan to recover? *Will he recover?*

I ask the doctor, "When will he wake up?"

He looks up from his notes. "There's some swelling on his brain. We managed to stop the internal bleeding, but he lost a lot of blood. His body needs time to heal. He's still unconscious, but if he wakes of his own accord, we'll call Mr Foxx immediately."

"But he will recover, right?"

"There's a chance he will regain consciousness."

I scrub my hands down my face. *This should never have happened.* "There's a chance?"

"Mr Foxx suffered serious internal and external injuries, right now, he has a good chance of survival."

I pace the room. "A good chance? What the hell does that mean?"

"Mr Stone, I can't tell you if and when he'll wake up, we need to take it minute by minute, for now."

I'm furious. I want details. How did this happen... and why? I pull my phone from my pocket and dial my father's number, hoping he's found out something... anything.

"No mobile phones," the doctor says, pointing to the sign on the door.

I sigh and shove my phone back into my pocket as the doors open and Ryan walks in. “Only one at a time,” the doctor reminds us.

Shut the fuck up!

Punching the doors, I head back out the room with Ryan. His eyes are red and swollen from crying.

“What happened?” I ask.

Ryan rubs his head. “The other car... its brakes failed. Because of the rain... he couldn’t slow down... he hit—The driver’s side, he crashed right into Declan.” Ryan breaks down and I help him to a seat and rub my hand over his back.

He sobs into his hands. “This... It’s ruined my son’s life. My daughter-in-law’s life. They were on their way to see us. He can’t di—God, don’t let him die.”

Unable to hold back my own tears, I let them fall. “He’ll be okay,” I say. “He has to be. He’s Declan Foxx.”

Footsteps pace toward us, but I don’t look up until I hear his voice. “Charles...” It’s my father. I stand and he gives me a quick hug before he sits beside Ryan.

With a frustrated sigh, I walk back down the white corridor.

My phone rings in my pocket and I pull it out quickly.

“Eli!”

He sounds like he’s running. “I’m just coming up from the carpark, everything okay?”

“It’s Dec—Declan, he’s not good.” A sob breaks through my voice.

“Ahh fuck! I’m sorry, mate. Is Ryan there?”

I lean against the wall and rub a hand over my head. “Ah... Yeah. We’re all here.” The reality of what’s happened consumes me and I break down, sobbing as I drop to the floor and pull my knees to my chest. “It’s bad... he has swelling on his brain and he’s cut up and... he’s a mess.”

“Hey, Charles, stay calm. Breathe, mate. How’s Zahra doing?”

“Um... she’s—we’re in the ICU. Zahra’s sleeping now, but they had to sedate her earlier.”

“I’m heading in now,” he says before the call ends.

I lean my head against the wall and stare at the lock screen on my phone. It's a picture of Declan and Zahra, and me and Jaymee on Zahra's birthday. We were sitting on the top deck of a yacht, drinking cocktails and watching the sunset over the ocean. It was the same day Declan bought the pink Mini for Zahra. I teased him about it relentlessly for months, telling him I wouldn't be caught dead driving a pink Mini.

He won't die.

He can't die.

He can't.

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When the lights are fading
And heaven calls your name
Please don't let them take you
I won't cope with the pain

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DECLAN**November 11***2.15pm*

When I open my mouth to call her, pain shoots through my head like it's being split in half. When I try to open my eyes, there's nothing but bright white light, or complete darkness. There's no in between.

I swallow, but something catches in my throat and I can't get rid of it. Nothing works the way it should. I'm trapped inside my body, screaming, shouting, cursing... but silent. Voices come and go, words float above me in clouds of confusion.

The last thing I remember is a flash of red, then Zahra screaming. I called her, over and over I called her name begging her to answer me.

When my eyes flickered open for a split second, I saw the ultrasound picture I knew Zahra was holding. It was splattered in blood.

Silence took over and everything went dark. I haven't heard her voice since. I haven't seen her, haven't felt her. She's been torn away from me and I'll never be the same again.

She's gone.

The thought is agonising. There are no words to describe the pain. Nothing makes sense. Without Zahra in my world... I can't go on. I promised her forever, and I failed.

When my veins turn cold, the sensation spreads through my body and into my heart where it skips a beat, causing me to gasp.

A quiet voice lingers, "Declan, can you hear me?" It's unfamiliar. I say "yes" but I don't hear my own words, only beep, beep, beep.

What's happening to me?

Did I faint?

I let my mind carry me back, searching for the moment I knew with certainty Zahra was gone. Only her scream remains.

I picture her face. The first time I saw her deep brown eyes and soft, pink lips. I think back to the moments we held hands, our fingers laced together, our perfect silences, our first kiss beneath the oak tree. Her eighteenth birthday when I told her I loved her for the first time.

I follow the memories along the path beside the lake, up to the mountain where we screamed at the top of our lungs before sharing another breathtaking kiss. Images of Zahra form a cyclone in my mind... *No!* It's a hurricane. Again, I'm on my knees watching every second of our lives together pass me by, but this time, she's not here. The scent of her perfume floats on the breeze. Her eyes light up as she watches fireworks explode into the sky.

She twirls in her wedding dress and laughs when she throws the bouquet.

The weight on my chest is unbearable as I recall the moment she discovered we were having twins and she begged me to stay, forever.

It's all gone now.

My beautiful Zahra. My unborn babies. My entire life is ruined.

I can't go on. I can't live in a world where Zahra no longer exists.

I inhale, I exhale. Cold air rushes through my nose, but I fight it.

A surge of adrenaline courses through my veins, shocking my body and forcing my eyes to open. I blink, only to see the same bright, white light.

"It hurts," I say the words out loud, and this time, there's a reply.

"We've given you something to help with the pain, try to relax." The voice fades away.

"Zahra," I say her name, desperate to hear her voice.

There's a commotion, words cloud my mind all over again.

"Gone..."

"Not yet..."

"She... it's almost time—"

She's gone.

The light appears again. This time, I reach for it. If Zahra is gone, I'm going too. When an aura of warmth surrounds me, I find Zahra standing in front of me.

She reaches out, I take her hand. She smiles... I ask her, "Can I kiss you?"

She nods, then, she's gone.

"Come back to me," I whisper.

But she's gone.

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Forever is a long time
To promise you will stay
I believed your words
So please don't go away

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CHARLES**November 11***2.35pm*

I stand beside Zahra's bed with Jaymee, as Zahra attempts to stand. I reach out to help her by putting my hand under her elbow.

She stands.

She cries.

She falls.

I help her up again as the doctor calls for a wheelchair to be brought in, but Zahra refuses.

So, with the help of me and Jaymee, Zahra makes her way along the corridor dressed only in a hospital gown, down to the room where Declan lies.

He's woken from his coma. The doctors are saying it's a miracle. Though he still hasn't spoken, and they have no idea as to the extent of the damage to his brain, or his body. He reacts to light; he reacts to noise. But so far, he hasn't reacted to any one person.

Zahra is desperate to see him, and the doctors agreed it wouldn't help to put it off any longer.

Jaymee and I hold her hands as we enter Declan's room.

Her tears pour down her cheeks as she makes her way to the bed where Declan lies covered to his chest in a white sheet. Tubes are still connected to his arms, and his braced leg is now slightly raised and connected to a strange looking contraption that reminds me of a crane.

Zahra takes his hand and squeezes it hard. She leans down and kisses his cheek. "Declan, please wake up, I need you. I can't do this alone. You promised. You said you wouldn't leave me alone." She cries onto his chest.

The beeping becomes erratic, and the doctor rushes over. Zahra sits on the chair beside his bed and leans into Declan's ear.

“Please, Declan, please wake up,” she begs.

His eyes flicker open. A gasp comes from his mouth. The beeping slows.

The doctor presses a stethoscope to his chest, removes the oxygen mask, then steps back.

I stand on the opposite side of the bed and look down at Declan. He’s staring at the ceiling as the doctor checks his eyes with a pen light. When he squints, I smile, and I’m filled with hope. He can make it through this. No matter what happens, I refuse to give up on him.

“Declan,” Zahra says again.

Declan’s mouth opens. “Zahra,” his voice is barely a whisper. But he spoke. I smile again. Jaymee smiles too.

Zahra sobs. “Declan, please I need you. I love you so much, please get better.”

“Come back... to me.” His eyelids flicker as he whispers.

“I’m here, I’m okay,” Zahra says.

His eyes close, but Zahra continues to sob over him as she leans down to Declan’s lips and kisses him softly.

His eyes flicker open again. “Babies... don’t let... go...” his voice trails off.

“No, no you promised, Declan. You promised you would never leave me,” Zahra cries.

“Zar... I love you... Zar always... promise me, forever...”

“Declan!” she screams over the beeping machines. “NO! No, don’t leave me. Not today... I’ll die without you.”

I cock my head and lean in close to my best friend. I take his hand and squeeze it hard, but he doesn’t react.

“Dec, what are you saying?” I raise my voice. “Declan?!” I know him so well I can read between the lines. I can hear the words he’s not saying. He was never going to survive. He was waiting for Zahra.

No, you’re wrong. My head and heart are in turmoil. Logic tells me this is it, but I want him to fight. To fight for every moment he’s going to miss. To fight for the girl he loved from the second he laid eyes on her. *It was a fairy tale.* I wish I could tell him I was wrong. Tell him to fight for his children who will now grow up never knowing their father.

The beeps quicken, then slow. And slower again until there's a lingering deathly silence between each beep.

"Zahra... forever... love you..." His words leave his lips as a final declaration of the love he had for his wife.

"Fuck it, Dec. No!" I shout. My chest tightens and I'm certain I'm about to have a heart attack. This can't be happening.

One single long beep is all it takes for Zahra to fall to the floor of the intensive care unit and scream until every ounce of air is released from her body and she's hyperventilating. Cradling her stomach with both hands, she's reduced to nothing more than a shell of the woman she once was.

"NO!" An agonising shriek of pain is torn from Zahra's throat.

Doctors and nurses rush in, but not one of them attempts to comfort her. They swarm around Declan, pressing buttons, shouting commands, and shocking his body back into the reality I don't want to believe exists.

Jaymee kneels and pulls Zahra into her arms as she continues to scream for her husband and beg him to wake up.

When the doctors step back, I go straight to Declan. I lean down and press my forehead to his. "I love you, mate," are the last words I'll ever speak to my best friend.

The darkness is still calling me
I cannot find the light
Free me from this agony
I'm giving up this fight

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ZAHRA**November 17***1 week later*

I sit in Doctor Phillips' office twisting my wedding ring around my finger. I've been doing it so much lately, my skin is red raw, but I refuse to take it off. I refuse to let the pain heal. I'm out of options. Nothing will bring Declan back. Nothing will ever be the same again.

It's time for me to let them go.

"Zahra, I think you should reconsider," Doctor Phillips says. "All your family and friends are here. Everyone who loves and supports you."

I don't react. "I can't do it." There's no emotion in my voice. There's nothing left *of* me, or *for* me. I'm empty and will be forever. After a week of sheer hell, I've resigned myself to the fact that I cannot and will not bring up these babies alone. I would rather be taken back to my childhood and live it a hundred times over than live with the pain I'm feeling right now.

I look Doctor Phillips in the eyes and repeat the words I spoke only minutes before.

"I *don't* want them." The words cut me to the core. I hate myself. I loathe every single thing about me. I want to die, but no one will leave me alone long enough to consider the options.

Even now, Jaymee sits outside the doctor's office oblivious to what I'm doing. She's been treating me like a child, never leaving me alone, not even to shower. They all say they love me, they say they care.

They don't.

They can't.

They shouldn't.

I need to go back to my father, back to the life I was born for. Back to being tortured for my thoughts, my actions, my words. I deserve that pain, I

need that pain. Anything would be better than this. If I go back, maybe he will kill me... put me out of my misery and end my life once and for all.

I can't live like this any longer. I'm dying inside, and every breath I take drags me one step further away from Declan. The pain in my heart is unbearable; the weight on my chest is consuming me minute by horrific minute. *Why won't they let me die?* It's the only thing I truly want.

Doctor Phillips refuses to listen. "You're already fourteen weeks along, Zahra. Your husband just died. His funeral is tomorrow. You're still in shock. This is not a decision you should be making right now."

I stand, my voice filled with venom. It doesn't sound like me at all, it sounds like someone else. There's nothing but a gaping hole, a blackened void where my heart once beat so passionately with love for my husband. I refuse to believe he's gone.

"This is my life!" I scream. "This is my body! I can't do this without Declan. I won't do it. You have to help me." I pace across the room and cross my arms over my chest. "If you don't help me, I will find someone who will. And if I can't, I will make sure *I* die instead. And it will be *your* fault!"

Who am I? I am the filthy, ugly little girl who was born to be used.

Doctor Phillips sighs. He reaches out to put a hand on my shoulder, but I shrug him off and step back. "Zahra, what you are going through right now is an overwhelming reaction to grief. A decision like this cannot be made when you're in such pain. *Please*, take some time to think about it. There are other options. You have a brilliant team of doctors; we want what is best for you, Zahra."

I shake my head adamantly. "I won't change my mind. I don't want children. I never did. I was born to be a whore, not a mother."

When I open the door to leave, Jaymee's standing on the other side with tears in her eyes. No doubt she heard me screaming. I no longer care. I have nothing to live for, nothing to fight for.

Inside my belly two babies are growing. Two babies who will grow up without a father, without someone who loves them unconditionally.

I did exactly what I knew I would do.

I destroyed myself, and in the process, I destroyed them too.

Irreversible.

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When will I see you
Where have you gone
I'm lost and I'm broken
Forever I'll mourn

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ZAHRA**November 17**

I sit on the sofa and stare out the window. The leaves on the trees sway gently in the wind. Birds flit from branch to branch, and in the garden, two ducks are waddling around the fish pond. Everything around me is alive and flourishing.

Everything inside me, is dead.

I turn to the front door and imagine Declan's face through the stained glass. Handsome, smiling, beautiful. I picture him walking in with a bunch of fresh flowers, and the smile he always saved for me.

I'll never see him again.

I'll never smell him again.

I'll never hear his voice whisper my name.

And tomorrow, they will bury him beneath the cold hard ground in a cemetery only a minute's drive from our house. He will be removed from the world as though he never existed.

People will talk about him as though they know him, they'll cry for him and tell me I'll be okay. All I want, is to lie inside the coffin beside my husband, and die with him.

The pain is so raw.

The ache is unrelenting.

The sorrow is all consuming.

Jaymee walks into the living room holding two mugs of hot chocolate. She places one on the coffee table and takes a sip of her own. She sits beside me in silence for a long time. Maybe minutes, maybe hours. I don't know, and I don't care.

"Zahra, honey, how are you feeling now?"

"I don't want them," I remind her for the tenth time.

Her voice is too soft, too sweet. It's smothered in a sickening layer of empathy.

"Zar, this isn't what you want to hear, but think about Declan, what he wanted. What *you* promised him."

"He's dead." *Is she stupid?*

"I know, sweetheart, but soon you'll have two beautiful little babies to remind you of the love you and Declan shared."

My eyes narrow as I turn to Jaymee. "He. Is. Dead. He doesn't know, and he doesn't care. He left me... He promised he'd never leave. If he can't keep his promise to me, I'm not keeping mine. I DON'T WANT THEM!" *Why doesn't she understand?*

I kick my shoes off and pull my legs up on the sofa, still twisting my wedding band around my finger. Behind it sits Declan's wedding band. "He promised me forever."

* * *

JAYMEE

I'm struggling with the words coming from Zahra's lips. My own heart is breaking for my husband who has lost his best friend, and for Maggie who has, for the first time in her short life, seen death so close. Declan was always the perfect one. The polite one. The one we all looked up to. He had all the good qualities of a kind, loving guy. He was a friend to everyone who needed one. The *best* friend.

Declan wouldn't want Zahra to terminate her pregnancy. He would be devastated. My heart is breaking for Zahra, the woman I love like a sister, but can barely look at right now. She's turned into a hollow shell. Every word that spills from her lips is filled with spite, anger, and hatred.

Doctor Phillips says it will take her a long time to come to terms with Declan's death. He even suggested she be admitted to the Mental Wellness Centre, but Charles and I assured him we wouldn't leave her alone, and that we'd call him if we were worried.

I try to sound upbeat. "Zahra, why don't you come stay with us for a while? Charles can help you. Maggie would love to see you."

She doesn't reply. Instead, she pushes her mug of hot chocolate off the coffee table. It spills across the beige carpet leaving a dirty brown stain. Zahra looks down at it as though it's nothing more than a speck of dust. Any other spill like that would send her into a frenzied cleaning spree.

"Leave me alone, Jaymee," she says as she pulls a cushion to her chest and stares blankly at the front door.

When the phone rings, Zahra's head snaps up, then she sighs and resumes her staring.

I grab the cordless phone from the coffee table.

"Hello, this is Jaymee."

"Jaymee, darling, it's Angela. How is she?"

I let out a heavy sigh and lean back on the sofa. "Nothing's changed."

Angela cries as she speaks. "I'll be there shortly. I'm going to talk to her again."

"Are you okay to drive? You can call Charles to pick you up?"

"That would be... good, thank you." She sobs. "I—I can't believe he's gone... I wish this was all a bad dream."

"I'm so, so sorry, Angela. God, I wish it was too."

"I'll be there soon, darling. Please, look after her until I get there."

"Of course."

"Who was that?" Zahra asks, her eyes still on the front door.

"Angela, she'll be here shortly."

Zahra turns to me and tilts her head. "I don't need you here, or her.... Leave me alone. I want everyone to leave me alone."

I stand from the sofa and pick up the coffee mug off the floor, then head to the kitchen to get some paper towels. When I come back, Zahra's looking down at the scars on her forearm, counting them. "One, two, three, four... eight months. Eight days. You promised me forever."

I watch her trace her finger over each scar as she continues talking to herself... or me? "Eight months is not forever. Twelve months is not forever. There's no such thing as forever. I couldn't even keep my own name forever." She lets out a quiet laugh. "You should let me die now."

I drop down on the sofa and take her hand. She doesn't stop me or pull away. She stares into my eyes. "Please, Jaymee, let me die," she begs as though I am the one who can end her pain.

The devastation she must be feeling in her heart is clearly taking its toll.

I shake my head. “No. I love you. Charles loves you. Angela and Ryan love you. I won’t let you die, Zahra. We just lost Declan, we can’t lose you as well.”

Tears stream down her reddened cheeks. “Please...” She sobs, each breath causing her chest to rise and fall rapidly. “Please... I can’t do it. I can’t without... I want him back,” she cries before she falls into me and I pull her into my arms, holding her against me as we cry together.

Twenty minutes later, Angela arrives. Her red-rimmed eyes wet with fresh tears. When she sees Zahra still crying on the sofa, she rushes over to her and sits down while I go to the kitchen to make some tea.

* * *

ZAHRA

Angela rubs my back, but I can’t stop crying. I can barely breathe through each round of fresh tears. My world is falling apart around me, and my hands are no longer strong enough to hold the pieces. I shuffle up on the sofa and Angela snuggles up beside me, then pulls my head to her shoulder. “Zahra, darling, we can do this... we’ll be okay. One day at a time.”

“It’s too hard,” I say. “It hurts so much.” Of all the pain I’ve endured, this is the worst. “Angela, I want him back... please bring him back...”

Angela whispers against my ear as she sobs. “I know, sweetheart. I’m here for you... please don’t give up... please... We will survive this, we have to.”

But I can’t.

And I won’t.

They speak as if they know you
They speak as if they see
You were more than just a person
You were every part of me

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ZAHRA**November 18***11.45am*

I sit in the back of the black limousine. The same limousine that drove us to the Foxx & Son Charity Ball. The coloured lights have been switched off and there's a dim white glow that highlights the sorrow on the faces surrounding me. Opposite me, Charles and Ryan whisper to one another, then share a quiet laugh. *There's nothing to laugh about anymore.* I want to scream at them, and remind them that in less than ten minutes, we will be sitting in a church full of people staring at the coffin that holds Declan's body.

Tears stream down my face at the thought. Angela takes my hand and squeezes it tight. I rest my head on her shoulder and close my eyes, wishing it was all a bad dream.

The funeral procession is huge. The entire town has come out, the shops are closed and the Mayor, Michael Holsten, has declared it a day of mourning.

Declan had made an impact on everyone in Rockburn Grove. I hate it though. I hate that the entire day will forever be dedicated to remembering the moment I spoke my last goodbye to my husband.

He belonged to me; I don't want the world to own his memories.

In the front row of the chapel, Angela grips my hand while on my other side, Declan's grandmother, Abigail, sobs into a handkerchief. Jaymee is on the other side of the church with Maggie, and Charles' family. There are people here I've never seen before, and for the first time ever, there's no anxiety. I'm not afraid of who might see me. I'm completely and utterly numb.

When *The Last Day on Earth* by Kate Miller-Heidke begins to play on the overhead speakers, everyone stands. Angela tugs on my hand and when I stand, I lean against her, not trusting my legs to hold me up. With a

glance to my left, my eyes well with tears as Declan's coffin is carried into the church. His father and Charles are at the front. Behind them are William, and Declan's grandfather, Jacob. And at the back are Declan's uncles—Braden and Marc, who I met in the hospital.

My eyes follow the coffin to the front of the church. It's placed down among tearful sobs before the men head to their seats. Not one of them is free from tears of sorrow. *Declan was so, so loved.*

One by one people take to the lectern to speak about Declan. They tell stories of his childhood, share memories of his school days and sporting achievements, and speak about the money and time he so generously donated to the town of Rockburn Grove and its people.

All the while, I sit motionless as tears fall from my eyes and soak my face in the salty water I despise. When it's my turn to stand at the altar, Angela helps me to my feet, but I can't stop sobbing.

"Darling, you have to do this, remember?"

I nod. "I begged Angela to help me. I wrote down what I wanted to say, and I have to say it. I *need* to say it."

I finally reach the altar, and when I look out to the pews, hundreds of unfamiliar faces stare back at me, waiting for me to talk. I spot Zahra a few rows from the front, her eyes red and puffy from crying. Beside her, Grace and Eli sit in silence. The sorrow on their faces is obvious.

I swallow the lump in my throat and watch as Jaymee rushes up to the altar, then wraps her arms around me. "You can do it, Zar. You can do it," she reminds me.

Inhale.

Exhale.

Inhale.

Exhale.

I unfold the piece of paper and smooth it out with my hand before I begin.

"Dec—Declan..." I choke on a sob and for a few minutes there's only silence before I gain the strength to say more than his name. "Declan, I love you. I miss you... I miss you so much I don't know how to cope with this pain. I wrote this for you because... because I know how much you love—you loved hearing me read to you."

Angela rubs my back as she cries. “It’s okay, take your time,” she whispers.

I stare at the now tear stained page that holds the words I long to say. *I can do it.*

“You promised me... forever. You promised me forever and I know you didn’t want to break that promise. It wasn’t your fault. That day started with fear... for both of us, but it turned into something beautiful, something I will cling to forever—until the day I die.”

I take a deep breath and exhale slowly. Jaymee rubs my arm.

“The day of the accident was... it was almost perfect. You reminded me you’d always love me, and that no matter what happened, our babies would grow up knowing they were loved. I will make sure that happens, somehow. That day, we sat at the café and chose baby names while we ate tiny cupcakes and talked about our future. We bought gifts for our babies, and you put your hands over my belly and promised you’d be here... always.”

When my heart starts to race, I close my eyes and count to ten before I open them again and look up at the mourners. They’re all crying. Even little Maggie who sits beside Charles, has tears streaming down her pink cheeks as I continue, “I keep thinking about that man in the parking lot. If he didn’t want our spot, would that minute have made a difference? If we hadn’t stopped to get the white teddy bears, would someone else have died? If it didn’t rain... would you still be alive? I have so many questions, and no answers. I love you, Declan. I think I loved you the moment I saw you. You gave my life meaning and filled it with love. I’ll never forget you. I’ll never forget the kisses we shared, the vows we took, the words we spoke... the fireworks, the mountain tops, the island... the stars you brought into my darkness. I’ll never, ever forget.”

I turn to the coffin, barely able to breathe through the pain that’s crushing my heart and causing my legs to shake. “I promise you, forever. Declan, I promise... I will love you, forever.”

The rest of the funeral passes by in a blur of tears and uncontrollable sobs. Everywhere I turn, someone wants to offer their condolences and tell me it will all be okay. That once the babies are born, I’ll have “two precious children to remind me of Declan”. After two hours, I’m tired of hearing it.

Tired of pretending that two little lives are all it will take for my life to be okay again. Tired of lying.

I leave the church and wander through the cemetery until I find a quiet spot beneath a beautiful oak tree like the one Declan kissed me under for the first time.

Sitting on the grass, I look down at my empty hands wishing Declan was here to fill the spaces between my fingers. I twist my wedding ring around, then close my hand into a fist. "I miss you so much."

For ten minutes, I watch a young couple clean a headstone then put a bunch of white roses in a little vase. The male sits a blue teddy bear beside it as they both cry over the grave. When they turn to walk away, the female looks back over her shoulder and gives a little wave before they continue on.

With a heavy sigh, I lean back against the tree trunk.

"Zahra," the quiet voice calls my name.

"Hi Jayden."

Jayden scratches his head and digs the toe of his black shoe into the grass. "Are you... ah.." He sighs. "I mean, do you need me to go get Angela... or Jaymee?"

I shake my head. "I'm okay." Of course, it's a lie. I will never be okay again. Not without Declan.

"It was a beautiful funeral... um... damn. I'm sorry, Zahra. I don't mean it's beautiful." He scrubs his hands down his face. "I'm sorry. Declan was a great guy, I wish he was still here."

"Me too," I whisper.

He looks back to the church, then down at me. "Do you want me to walk you back? Are you going back?"

With a glance over to where the couple put flowers on the grave, I make a decision. "I want to go over there for a minute," I say. I'm not sure why, but something is pulling me toward the headstone.

Jayden doesn't say a word, but he walks beside me until I stop and kneel in front of the headstone. On the plaque, the engraving reads,

Our precious babies, taken too soon.

Rest in Love

Daniel and Catherine

3 days old

They lost their twins. A fresh round of tears fall from my eyes as I place my hand on the headstone and cry for the two, tiny babies. I place my other hand on my belly and make a promise. “You will be loved.” And it’s a promise I have to keep. For me, and for Declan.

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DECEMBER

Your heart was an ocean
Filled with everything I loved
The day it stopped beating
Was the day I gave up

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JANUARY

For Declan,

Take me back to the days
Where our hearts were intertwined
Where endless summer sunsets
Held the stories of our time
Promises had not been broken
The stars were yet to fall
Between us nothing
Was left unspoken
Back then we had it all
Take me back to jewelled blue seas
Where we danced on golden sands
Back to a time where we were free
And love was right there
Safe inside unbroken hearts
Held together by our own hands

Love, Zahra.

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FEBRUARY

No one knows or understands
And I can't quite explain
They're all standing in the sunshine
While I'm always in the rain

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Will this torment last forever
Will agony tear out my soul
Will I fall into the abyss
To be swallowed by a gaping black hole

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ZAHRA**March 26***25 years old**8.30am*

One hundred and twenty-nine days have passed since Declan's funeral. For one hundred and twenty-nine days, I've cried every night before I've fallen asleep, and every morning when I've woken alone. Declan should be here. He should be looking up at the stars when we fall asleep in one another's arms. He should be pulling the drapes open each morning and reminding me what a beautiful day it will be.

He should be here.

But he's gone.

Lying in bed, I rub my hand over my belly that's grown so much I can barely roll over or move without a tiny hand or foot pressing against my bladder. Doctor Phillips says the babies are small but growing well, and there shouldn't be any issues with a natural delivery.

But... I am terrified.

Every day, I'm thankful I didn't go through with the decision to terminate my pregnancy. Angela and Meg have done so much for me, and I even had the chance to meet the couple who will be fostering the babies after they're born.

Martha and Joel are friends of Declan and Charles' parents and have been fostering babies and children for over thirty years. They're kind and loving and have assured me I'll be able to visit as often as I want to. I still haven't decided if that's something I want to do. I can't imagine looking at them and seeing Declan in their eyes.

"Zahra?" There's a light knock on my bedroom door.

"I'm awake, Jaymee."

She pushes the door open and walks in with a mug of hot chocolate which she hands to me before sitting on the side of the bed. Her eyes drop

to my belly that's covered by the sheet. She tilts her head and smiles. "You okay today?"

I nod. "Yes, I'm okay." It's the same lie I've told every day since Jaymee's been staying overnight to take care of me, in case the babies arrive early.

"Only a few more weeks to go," she reminds me. "I can't wait to see them." A smile lights up her face, but I see the sadness in her eyes. Jaymee wants me to keep the babies and even said I could move in with her and Charles until I can cope on my own. But I can't do it. This is my home. The home Declan chose for us. This is where I belong.

With a squeal of delight, Maggie runs into the bedroom and jumps onto my bed. She wriggles closer to me and puts her hand on my belly. "Helloooo widdle babies," she says. "You not kicking you mummy?"

I sigh and rub Maggie's back. "They're being good," I tell her. "I think they're sleeping now."

"You keep dem if dey not kicking you, Za za?"

Tears well in my eyes. Jaymee and Charles explained to Maggie what was going to happen to the babies. They told her she would still be able to see them sometimes, but they wouldn't live here. She didn't understand and still believes the babies are getting sent away because they're hurting me. I wish I could help her understand.

Jaymee comes to my rescue. "Maggie, honey, remember what I told you? The babies are going to live with someone else for a while so Auntie Zahra can get better. Then they'll come home."

Maggie nods but drops her head onto my belly and wraps her arms around me. "Want Declan come home now." She pats my tummy. "You be good babies for you mummy. I wuv yooo." When she cries, I stroke her hair, desperate to tell her I'm sorry and that I don't want to hurt her, but all I can do is let my own tears fall as Jaymee wraps us both in a hug.

* * *

2.00pm

The afternoon sun shines down on the lake behind our house. Silver ripples travel across the water and a warm breeze blows through the trees. A twinge

of pain pierces my stomach and causes me to wince. When I rub my hands over my belly, one of the babies kicks. For a moment, I smile, but it's quickly replaced with the tears that fall relentlessly whenever the reality of life crashes down upon me.

"Zahra, are you okay?"

Jayden stands in front of me with the garden rake in one hand as he wipes the sweat from his brow with the back of his other hand. He's been helping around the house and taking care of the gardens for the past three months.

I wipe the tears from my eyes and nod. "I miss him. The babies... They'll never know him. It's not fair." My crying turns to sobbing as Jayden drops the rake and kneels in front of me.

With his hands clasped together, he lowers his voice. "Zahra, I can't take away your pain, but if you want to talk, I'm here. Anytime."

With a heavy sigh, I close my eyes and raise my head to feel the sun on my face. Blinking back tears, I turn my attention to Jayden. "I wish I'd done more, you know? I spent so much time at home, afraid of what might happen to me; I missed out on so much. Declan missed out on things because of me."

Jayden sits back on his heels and runs a hand through his thick blond hair. "He loved you, Zar, he would have done anything for you."

My tummy tightens again, and I rub it to relieve the pain. "Do you think he knew how much I loved him?" I ask Jayden.

He smiles and nods. "Absolutely. I have no doubt about it."

A hint of a smile tugs at the corner of my lips, but pain spreads across my belly and through to my back, causing me to gasp.

Jayden stands. "Zahra, are you okay?"

Standing, I plant one hand on my lower back and try in vain to breathe through the pain that comes in waves. *Am I in labour?* It's too early. I can't possibly be in labour yet. Rubbing one hand over my belly, I pace back and forth.

"Zahra?" Jayden's voice distracts me from my pacing.

"I think... I don't know, Jayden, it hurts..."

He scrubs his hands down his face and rubs my back. "Want me to call Jaymee or Angela?"

I shake my head. I don't want to worry them. "Please, take me to the hospital?"

Jayden steps back and shoves his hands into his pockets. "I ah... I think I should call..."

As pain shoots through my body, I double over. "Please... can you take me? I don't want to bother them."

"Yeah... okay, um... let's go then..."

Jayden rushes into the house and grabs my purse and phone before he helps me into his car and buckles me in. "Drive carefully... please," I beg.

He starts the car then takes off down the driveway and heads toward the hospital. While he drives, I concentrate on counting, remembering what Jaymee told me about contractions. There's nothing regular about the pain. It comes in waves, then disappears. By the time we arrive at the hospital fifteen minutes later, the pain has stopped. "I'm so sorry, Jayden. I think I'm okay now."

He shakes his head and gets out of the car before he comes around to my side and opens the door. "Let's go in and make sure everything is okay, hey?"

Reluctantly, I agree, and we head into the hospital's maternity ward. At the desk, Janet, one of the nurses jumps to her feet when she sees me. "Zahra, darling. What's going on? Is everything okay?"

I nod. "I was having some pain, but by the time we got here it stopped. I'm sorry."

"No apologies necessary. Come on, I'll call Doctor Phillips and get you set up in the room." She turns to Jayden, her brows raised. "Are you coming in too?"

He looks between me and the nurse. "I um... I can wait out here."

"You can come in," I tell him. "If you want to."

He stutters. "O—okay... sure."

The room is quiet with dim lights and soft music playing from the speakers in the ceiling. A calming sensation washes over me as Janet leads me to the double bed and fluffs up the pillows.

"Lie down and put your feet up." She rushes around the room preparing towels and a small cot before she stops, her attention focused on Jayden. "Sit down, dear. And no need to panic, this is all procedure." She

rubs his arm, but he doesn't react. His face is pale, and he looks like he's about to vomit.

I sit up slightly and rub my belly. "Jayden, it's okay, you can leave if you want to."

He shakes his head and blinks a few times, snapping out of his trance. "I'm fine... I ah... I'm okay."

Janet laughs as she leaves the room, promising she'll be back shortly.

"You're not scared?" Jayden asks.

I exhale slowly while trying to calm my racing heart. "Terrified," I admit. "I'm not ready... I—I don't know what will happen when they're born..."

He sits on the bed beside me and takes my hand. "You're so brave. I'm freaking out and I'm not even the father."

I smile, but drop my head wishing that Declan was here instead of Jayden. I should be thankful I'm not alone; thankful I was able to get pregnant in the first place. Thankful I'm alive.

My whole world has been flipped upside down and nothing makes sense anymore. All the dreams Declan and I had, are no longer viable. They are nothing more than scattered ashes, unrecoverable remnants of a life that was lost before we had the chance to live it.

"Thank you, Jayden," I finally say as Doctor Phillips walks in with a folder tucked under his arm.

After a quick hello and loads of questions, he hooks me up to a monitor and attaches two sets of round probes to my belly, one for each baby. When the sound of their heartbeats fills the room, Jayden gasps.

"That's the babies?" he asks.

Doctor Phillips watches the screen as he speaks. "It certainly is. They're both strong and healthy. I'd say space is getting a little tight in there now though."

"But they're okay?" I ask.

"They seem to be doing fine, Zahra. We'll keep you here for an hour or so, and if there are no more pains, we'll let you go home. Do you need me to call Angela?"

"Thank you, Doctor Phillips. And yes, it would be good if you could call Angela."

When he leaves, Jayden leans back on the bed beside me. “Do they hurt?” he asks nodding toward the probes on my belly.

“Not at all. It’s just uncomfortable.”

Jayden sits in silence, while I lie back on the soft pillows listening to the heartbeats echo around the room. There are a few kicks, but no more pain. When Doctor Phillips comes back an hour later with Angela right behind him, I breathe a sigh of relief. Angela leans down and kisses my head. “Darling, you should have called.”

“I didn’t want to bother you. Jayden was doing the garden, so I asked him to bring me here.”

Jayden gets up to leave. “I’ll wait outside.”

Angela takes his place on the bed beside me and places one hand gently on my belly. “No more pain?” she asks.

I shake my head as Doctor Phillips removes the probes. “Well, it looks like you had a few mild contractions. It’s to be expected at this stage, especially with twins. Remember we talked about the possibility of them arriving early?”

I nod. “Yes, I know. I want them to be healthy, and safe. I’m doing everything you said.” At seven months, Doctor Phillips is surprised that given the stress and grief I’ve experienced, that the babies haven’t arrived much earlier than expected. Two months ago, he gave me a strict routine and diet plan and told me to avoid as many strenuous activities as possible. My goal is to bring the babies into the world and say my final goodbye before I hand them over to the foster carers. It’s the only thing that makes sense. I’m not capable of being a mother, let alone a single mother.

They need a life, without me to bring them down.

They tell me it's okay to cry
But it hurts just being me
They tell me I am stronger now
But the strength I cannot see

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ZAHRA**March 30**

Days pass by in a blur now, each one blending into the next. There's no morning, no night time, and nothing in between. Only dark and light. Even when I close my eyes, there's no relief from the torment. I continue though, smiling, crying... pretending.

My stomach swells with life where two tiny beings are waiting to leave my body and enter the world, and I... I have nothing to offer them but sorrow and pain.

Tiny faces bring the sunlight
Back into my heart
But I have to let them go
Right from the very start

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ZAHRA**April 2***7.00am*

Today is Declan's 26th birthday and I'm pacing the labour ward at Sundowner Hospital with Jaymee by my side. Charles is sitting by the door of my room watching us pace back and forth. My contractions started shortly after midnight, and two hours later I knocked on the spare bedroom door to wake Jaymee and Charles.

Last night, we had a quiet birthday party for Declan. We sat at the kitchen table with a chocolate cake, we sang happy birthday through streams of tears, and we used Declan's camera to take pictures of one another. The ache in my heart hasn't lessened, if anything, it's grown stronger.

I often wonder if I was cursed. If somehow, I was destined for a life filled with pain and sorrow. There's a constant veil of darkness that follows me now, dragging me into its path and reminding me that the hope I once held with an iron grasp, is slowly trickling away.

Inside me, two tiny babies are relying on me to bring them into this world. Two gifts I won't be able to keep. Angela and I went to meet with Martha and Joel a few days ago to confirm the arrangements for the babies. The papers I signed say I can change my mind at any time and bring my children home.

As I walk down the corridor again, Jaymee squeezes my hand. "Declan would be so proud of you, Zar."

My lip quivers and a sob breaks through my calm façade. Jaymee rubs my back before I stop to lean against the wall. "It hurts," I cry as another contraction spreads across my belly.

From the corner of my eye, I see Charles walking toward me. “Do you want to lie down now?”

The contractions have been coming and going for seven hours now and I’m exhausted. “Please... Charles, I think I need the pain relief—now...” my voice trails off as another contraction tightens my belly and forces me onto the floor.

“Help!” Charles shouts.

A flurry of activity surrounds me as Charles and Jaymee lead me back to my room before a drip is attached to my arm and a burst of cold rushes through my veins. I lie on the bed and close my eyes.

“Try to relax now, you need the rest,” a nurse says.

The lights are dimmed down.

Soft music lingers as darkness envelops me.

Their voices grow softer as my breathing slows and I finally find some relief.

Everything surrounding me blurs into a seamless mass of pulsating white light. I’m positive I’m dreaming because I’m calm, and everywhere I look there is nothing but white. Making my way forward through a thick, wispy cloud, I hear his voice. My eyes search for him, and when he appears, he’s smiling, and my heart beats harder and faster.

“Declan.” When I say his name, his smile grows wider.

“You look so beautiful, sweetheart,” he says before his eyes drop down lower. “Are the babies okay?”

I nod and place my hands over my belly. “They’re okay. They’ll be born soon... I wish...” I stop myself saying the words. *This is a dream.* While I’m dreaming, Declan is alive. I need to hold on to this for as long as I can.

He moves forward, his feet never touching the cloud below. His blue eyes shine brighter than I remember, and his skin is clearer and more radiant. “You won’t let them go, will you?”

A lump forms in my throat. I am going to deny him his dying wish. The one thing we talked about. I take a step forward but something stops me. When I raise my hand, there’s a barrier between us. I can’t reach him, I can’t hold him; I can’t touch him.

He tilts his head. “Don’t let them go... sweetheart.”

Tears pool in my eyes before I blink, allowing them to escape and roll down my cheeks. “Declan... I can’t do it. I’m not strong like you.”

He shakes his head, still smiling. “You’re stronger than you believe. Don’t let them go, please...” Slowly, he moves backwards as though he’s being pulled away from me.

I bash my hands against the invisible barrier, begging him not to go. “Come back, Declan, please. Come back!”

His smile never fades, not until he disappears into a haze of white, leaving behind only his soft, gentle voice. “Don’t let them go...” is the last thing I hear before I’m jolted back into reality.

I scream for him. “Declan, please come back!”

“Zahra, Zahra...” Jaymee pats my shoulder. “You’re okay, Zar. You’re okay.”

I shake my head hard and blink a few times, my face wet with tears. “I saw him,” I cry. “I saw Declan. He said...” I clamp my eyes shut and count to ten.

“You saw him?” Charles asks when I open my eyes.

“A dream... something... he was right there, and it was so—He was there, Charles. I saw him.” I fall into Charles’ arms as Jaymee rubs my back, but suddenly, a fierce pain tears through my body and I cry out in agony.

Pressure builds between my legs and something warm and wet smothers the bed. Charles jumps to his feet as Jaymee presses the buzzer.

I can’t do it. “Oh my god, no... Jaymee, I can’t do it.”

Charles stands at the door calling for Doctor Phillips while Jaymee strokes my hair. “Zar, I’m here. I’m not leaving you, you can do this.”

I shake my head again. “No. I don’t want to, it hurts so...”

Another contraction.

Another scream of agony.

I can’t control anything, not my breathing, not the pressure, not the tears streaming down my cheeks. “Declan,” I cry his name as my body takes over.

Voices come and go. Finally, I find Angela beside me. Her hand squeezes mine as she speaks. “Zahra, honey, try to breathe... you can do

this. Breathe with me... in... out... in... out.” As her voice fades, Doctor Phillips’ replaces it.

“Okay, Zahra, I need you to push. Can you do that for me?”

I shake my head, but Jaymee and Angela encourage me by breathing with me and counting as I push. Finally, after long, drawn out minutes, and what feels like a hundred excruciating contractions, there’s a moment of relief. Doctor Phillips is talking to the nurse beside him, but I can’t focus on what they’re saying.

My body is trembling and the cold face cloth Jaymee put over my forehead now feels like a lead weight holding me down. I swipe it away and shake my head before I catch a fleeting glimpse of the nurse. In her arms, tiny feet appear before she turns away.

“My babies...” I cry.

Doctor Phillips lowers his voice. “Baby one is out, Zahra, now. Give yourself a minute to breathe, then another few pushes, and hopefully we’ll have baby two.”

My rapid breaths turn to pants as I close my eyes and focus on Jaymee’s voice.

Time passes by in a blur until Doctor Phillips encourages me to push again. With another round of agonizing pain, I finally bring baby two into the world. This one arrives with a scream and Angela laughs quietly.

“Someone’s not happy...”

“Zar, you did it. You brought two babies into the world,” Jaymee’s voice trembles.

“I did it...” I drop my head back and inhale slowly before I close my eyes and think about Declan. “I did it. They’re safe,” I whisper only to him.

Thirty minutes later, after being given some oxygen, and being wrapped in soft white blankets, my babies are placed in my arms. I look from one to the other, there’s no difference. I can’t tell if they’re boys or girls. *Should I know?* What kind of mother doesn’t know what sex her babies are?

The nurse comes over to my bedside and opens the blanket to pull out their tiny hands. Each little finger is perfect and so, so tiny, and on their wrists, tiny plastic bands. One is pink, and one is blue.

The nurse steps back. “Your son, and your daughter,” she says. “Congratulations, Zahra, they’re just perfect.”

Angela’s hands shoot up to her mouth and she begins to cry. Jaymee starts too. “Oh my god, they are so beautiful,” she says.

I look down at their little faces and their tiny, pink rosebud lips. They have Declan’s nose, and his lips. They’re so beautiful that I can’t imagine ever living without them. But I have to. I’m not good enough. Not strong enough. They need a perfect life and I can’t give them that.

“I’m sorry.” I cry over them, letting my tears fall onto their tiny cheeks. *Declan, why did you have to leave?*

I drop my head and sob into their little blankets as I cuddle them close. Their tiny hands touch my cheeks.

“What are you going to name them?” Angela asks with tears in her eyes.

I stroke my finger across my daughter’s cheek. “This is Abigail Grace. We were going to—” I choke back tears. “We were going to call her Abby.”

“Oh, Zahra,” Angela tucks a strand of hair behind my ear. “It’s perfect.”

I place my hand gently on my son’s head. His soft black hair is silky smooth beneath my palm. “Our son... His name is Jacob Declan...”

Angela sobs into her hands as Jaymee makes her way around the bed to hug her. The three of us sit together and cry as I hold my babies for the first and last time.

Alone again
Forever lost
Love, I've learned
Comes with great cost

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ZAHRA**May 2***1 month later*

My body yearns for the babies I gave up. My heart yearns for Declan. My soul yearns for peace.

For nine months I protected my babies, carrying them safely in my womb. Now, I am empty and everything hurts. My breasts are full and heavy, my stomach still clenches in knots, and the exhaustion I felt after the delivery hasn't disappeared. Feelings of pregnancy linger. During the night when I'm alone and crying into my pillow, I place my hands over the small swell of my belly and imagine tiny feet kicking me from the inside.

I imagine Declan is home and his gentle whisper is all I need to fall asleep, wrapped in the embrace of his loving arms. I imagine a life where death does not exist, and babies are born into a world filled with nothing but love.

I imagine now, because reality is no longer a place I want to be.

People come and go. They bring food I don't eat and say words I don't hear. They talk about their day as though I care, and they reminisce about Declan as though he's merely gone away and will return when they least expect it.

Doctor Phillips visits every week to check on how I'm healing, and Eli and Zahra have visited a few times as well.

I don't smile anymore.

I don't wait for the sunrise or gaze up at the stars above my bed. My life—what's left of it—consists of fleeting moments I wish would end, followed by long nights of darkness where I pray for death to take me, like I did when I lived with my father.

I am surrounded.

But I am alone.

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This torment will last forever
This agony will tear out my soul
All I want now is to fall into the abyss
To be swallowed by a gaping black hole

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June 18

7 months since Declan died

There's a never-ending pit of despair surrounding me. Smothering me in the acrid stench of death while I sit, screaming on the inside, begging the world to let me go. To free me from this overwhelming pain that presses down upon my chest, crushing me in grief and untold sorrow.

The air in my lungs is thick and stagnant, drowning me with the promise of death's darkest touch. Choking me from within. This abyss of nothingness is tearing my soul apart with the weight of more than a thousand memories I lost while sifting through the remnants of a life I once—for a fleeting moment—believed was worth living.

I am no more.

I pull open the bathroom cupboard and take out the small, sharp scissors. I hold them in my hand and the silver catches the light from the bathroom window above my head. *Light*. Light like I always saw in Declan's eyes. I'll never see it again. He'll never walk out the bathroom with a towel around his waist. I'll never smell the scent of his cologne after he showers. He's gone.

He is no more.

I cross my legs, then pull my sleeve up to look down at the scars scattered along my forearm. It's been so long since I've seen the blood seep from my skin. I'm dead inside all over again. Declan saved me from that pain. He reminded me nothing in this world was worth more than my life—my happiness. He promised me forever.

He is no more.

The first slice of the scissors is painless. There's nothing but crimson blood seeping to the surface of my pale skin. As it begins to drip down my arm, I exhale and relief washes over me.

Have I become completely numb to physical pain?

I drag the sharp edge of the scissors across my flesh again... still no pain. Deep in my lungs, a strangled breath catches me off guard. It's not until tears wet my cheeks that I realise I'm sobbing. My heart is shattered. There's nothing left for me now—only death.

I did what I needed to do. I brought my babies safely into the world, but I cannot keep my promise to Declan. The only way out now, is to let death take me once and for all.

I am no more.

Another slice.

Then another.

And one more.

I cut into my flesh, watching the blood pool in my lap. It soaks into my white t-shirt and sticks to my belly where two, tiny babies once lived and grew inside me. Two parts of a whole. Half of me, and half of Declan. *But how?* I am dead inside. I was always dead inside.

Dead and broken.

I am no more.

Swapping hands, I cut into the flesh of my other arm. There's no pain.

Perhaps I'm already dead. A walking corpse. Another thing I can't do properly.

Another failure on my part.

I extend my legs and let my head fall to the edge of the bathtub beside me. Déjà Vu washes over me like a tsunami raining down destruction and swallowing up everything in its path.

Birds chirping.

Blood pooling.

Breaths fading.

I'm caught in this moment, spinning in a vicious circle. The entire world is laughing at me, finding joy in my sorrow. They don't know how I feel, but their voices...

Over.

And over.

And over.

And over again.

Their voices chant, "I know how you feel." "You will be okay."

"You don't know!" I shout. "I'm not okay."

A rush of memories plays through my mind; each one contains an image of Declan. Each one is a reminder of his smile, his eyes, his face. With another deep breath, I press the scissors into my wrist and drag them along my skin. At the same time, there's a frantic knock at the front door.

I close my eyes and let my tears fall with my blood.

"Let me die." No one will hear me, and I don't care.

I can't go on.

I tried so, so hard.

I lied to everyone.

I am nothing. I am no one. I am no more.

"Zahra! NO!" The scream is so loud I attempt to lift my hands to cover my ears, but I can't move.

"Zahra, can you hear me?"

I open my mouth to speak. Nothing comes out.

"Sweetie, please, open your eyes."

"Oh god, what have you done?"

"Charles!"

"Charles, come quickly... SHE'S DYING!"

"Zahra, please... we can't lose you too."

No. I can't open them. I can't look at a world where Declan no longer exists.

A peaceful tranquillity finally smothers me as silence takes hold and I find myself walking toward our tree.

The tree where Declan and I first kissed.

He takes my hands and laces his fingers through mine. He breathes against my lips.

He whispers, "Can I kiss you?"

I nod.

But we are no more.

Remnants of my heart
Are scattered far and wide
I lost all my pieces
When I lost you from my side

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ZAHRA

September 18*3 months later*

I'm tired of these white walls. I'm tired of this bed. I'm tired of being stuck in this place away from my friends and family.

Once again freedom was taken from me. This time, it was my own fault. I need to take responsibility for my actions. I *need* to live. Today, I will finally get my freedom back.

My nurse, Vivienne, stands beside my bed where I sit with my legs crossed. "Morning, sweetheart, how are you today?"

"I'm okay, I guess." My reply is honest, I've learned that lying to the nurses here doesn't help me at all. Honesty is always better. *With honesty our love is true.* I swallow hard, forcing myself not to speak while blinking back the tears I thought would have dried up by now.

"Home today, I bet you're happy about that."

I want to go home but everything there reminds me of Declan. Everything smells like him, feels like him. "I am. I'm... it's so hard without him," I admit.

Vivienne sits on the edge of the bed and pulls me in for a hug. Of all the nurses here, she's my favourite, and she's a friend of Angela's, so she knows everything about me, and of course, about Declan too.

"I've got you down for home visits so you won't be alone, unless you want to be. Okay?"

Another nod. "Will this pain ever go away?"

She strokes my hair. "I'd be lying if I told you it will get better. You and Declan were in love, you two were made for one another. A love like that can never be forgotten. But in time, it will become bearable. And one day soon, you'll smile at the memories."

"Vivienne..." I choke back tears, but they fall relentlessly. "He saved me... He loved me through everything, all the awful things I said, the times

I ran away... he never stopped loving me... I want him back,” I cry.

She snuffles and hugs me tighter. “I know, sweetheart. That’s just how love works. She comes into your life and fills it with everything good and pure. But sometimes, she loses her way, and we spend the rest of our lives trying to find her again. Trying to fill the void she left behind.”

After a long hug, and a mug of hot chocolate, I get up and shower.

I’m starting my life all over again. The first time was filled with abuse, torture and horrifying moments I’ll never forget. The second time was filled with love, adoration, and blissful serenity that smothered the darkness in my soul and brought me into the light.

I don’t know what this next journey will bring, but this time, I’m going to try harder than I ever have. This time, when I find hope, I won’t let it slip through my fingers or fade away into the abyss of despair. This time, I will hold on as though my life depends on it.

Because this time, it does.

The look on Declan’s parents’ faces when I woke in the hospital, scarred me. I put them through so much pain. They lost their son and watched me give away their grandchildren; I almost ruined them. It caused me to question everything I’d ever known. I didn’t realise their love for me was so strong, and now, the thought of hurting them kills me.

In one moment of utter hopelessness, I truly believed death was the only way to be free from the unrelenting pain coursing through my veins. Declan was gone. My babies were gone; my life was spiralling out of control. I was in turmoil. I’d lied to everyone around me for weeks. I told them all I was okay and that once the babies were born, I’d be able to focus on getting better, on living again.

All the while I was preparing for what was coming.

I bought the small nail scissors one day when Jayden took me to the store to buy groceries. I slipped them into the pocket of my jeans and when I got home, I hid them under the bathroom sink inside a jar of cotton balls. I planned everything right down to the note I left on the kitchen table beside a photograph of Declan and I from our wedding.

I wanted them to know it wasn’t their fault, that it was all me.

In the bottom of the bag containing my clothes and a few photographs—the only things I was allowed to bring—is the letter. Sitting

on the edge of the bed, I lean down and reach into the bag to retrieve it. When I smooth it out, I notice the tear stains that blur some of the letters. With a silent thank you to the universe for another chance at life, I read over the words...

I lied to you all.

I'm not okay. I will never be okay again. Perhaps I was born into tragedy and meant to be nothing more than a silent shadow lurking in the background of someone else's beautiful story. I deserved everything I was given. I didn't stop them when they raped me. I didn't say no when they wanted to use my body. I didn't push them away. I stayed. Even when I was old enough to understand, I stayed.

I deserved all of it.

But I didn't deserve Declan. If I had never walked into Housing Hope, he would still be alive. If I hadn't told him my secrets and shared my memories with him, he would still be alive. If my body had done one thing right and not got pregnant, Declan would still be alive. I will never forgive myself for that. But I promise you, Angela and Ryan, I loved him beyond anything you could possibly imagine. I loved him more than life itself, and when he died, a part of me died with him. A part I will never be able to replace.

I'm not sorry for what I need to do. This was always going to happen, it was only a matter of time. With me in your lives, you will never be free... I will always be a reminder of what tore your beautiful son from your arms. Without me, you will all be happier, and that is all I want for you.

Please tell my babies their daddy loved them.

I can't live a moment longer without him. I have to go. Declan's up there somewhere, waiting for me. In death we will be together again.

I lied to you all.

I'm sorry.

Guilt, remorse, and shame smothers me. I hurt everyone I loved. Reading those words causes bile to rise in my throat and tendrils of guilt to wind their way around my neck, choking me and making it harder to breathe. *Who was that girl... that woman?* Twelve short weeks later, I don't

recognise the words. Of course, I know I wrote them, and I understand why. But... I sigh. Serenity settles on my chest. A weight has been lifted and finally, I can breathe again. My new life starts today.

I scrunch the paper in my hand then shove it down to the bottom of the bag. *I'm stronger now.*

The past twelve weeks I've spent here at Housing Hope's Mental Wellness Centre have made me realise that even without Declan, I *can* breathe. And although every breath hurts, I owe it to him to try. He never gave up on me, and giving up on myself now, feels wrong. I want to make him proud. I wish he was here to see it happen.

I drop my feet to the floor and slip on my shoes before I braid my hair.

Vivienne comes back in with my file and some paperwork for me to sign as well as my medication. Doctor Marshall has visited me every day of my stay here, and Doctor Phillips has come in once a week. The classes have been wonderful, and although I loathed everything for the first couple of weeks, I was able to make a few friends and attend art therapy and writing classes. Each day new activities were offered. I was encouraged to take a walk in the gardens, cycle around the park, or swim in the indoor heated pool. My favourite part was relaxing in the library where I read every single book available on parenting, babies, and children.

During my fourth week, I was allowed visitors. Eli and Zahra came in with Grace who's grown so much. She's even started school and didn't come up for a breath of air while telling me all about her teacher, Mrs Thompson, who has a pet frog she keeps in the classroom.

The next day, Jayden came in. He said he felt guilty for not noticing how far down into the darkness I had slipped. After an hour of talking, and me listening to him tell me about Beneath the Stars, he was happier than he was when he arrived. He left with a smile, and a promise to take me to lunch as soon as I'm home. I didn't have the heart to tell him no.

My reminiscing is put on hold when Vivienne sits beside me. "Now, you remember everything we talked about?"

I reel off my list for the next four weeks. "Medication after breakfast, lunch, and dinner. At least an hour outside every day. Write in my journal and make sure I'm eating properly."

She raises her brow and gives me a knowing smile. "And?"

I throw myself into her arms. “Don’t forget to be thankful.”

She rubs my back and kisses my cheek. “Right, I think you’re all set. I’ll miss you, Zahra.”

“I’ll miss you too, you’ll visit me though, right?”

“Of course!” With one last hug, Vivienne leads me out of my room and toward the foyer.

* * *

2.00pm

Angela and Ryan arrive to pick me up from the centre. The nurses and doctors are all here, and so emotional that everyone ends up crying. It’s overwhelming to know the extent of the love they had for Declan and for me; I wish I’d been able to get out more and see it for myself.

On the drive back home, Angela sits beside me in the back seat, while Ryan drives. For the first ten minutes there’s nothing but complete silence.

“I’m so sorry,” I say to them. “I never meant to hurt you or scare you. I was—”

Angela takes my hand. “Zahra, sweetheart, we understand. We lost our only child, our son. The baby we chose. Our pain is beyond words. I can’t imagine how it must feel for you.”

Ryan glances at me through the rear-view mirror. “Zahra, you’re our family, you have been since you and Declan got together. You’re like—No, you are a daughter to us, and if anything ever happened to you, we’d be devastated.”

Tears well in my eyes. *A daughter to them?*

Angela nods in agreement. “Please, if you ever feel that way again, please come to us. Let us know. Tell us what’s going on. No matter what, we will help you.”

“Thank you... thank you both so, so much.” I drop my shoulders and sigh. “Have you heard from Martha and Joel? Are the babies okay?”

Angela smiles. “They’re perfect. Both healthy and happy... do you want to see them?”

My heart is caught in my throat. I haven't seen them since they were born, and I'm still not sure I'm ready, but part of me is yearning for them, to see if they resemble Declan as much as I believed they did when they were born.

“Am I allowed to?”

“Of course,” Angela says. “We can stop by on our way home... if you want to.”

Before I can think about it for too long, I reply, “Yes, please.”

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I fell apart and lost it all
Now it's twice as hard to breathe
But deep inside I know the truth
You didn't want to leave

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ZAHRA**September 18***5.15pm*

From where I sit in the living room, I hear a tiny cry. My chest constricts, and my heart races with trepidation. Fear and sorrow weave through my veins reminding me of what I gave up, of what I lost, and of what I've gained in the past three months.

Angela sits beside me, her hand tight around mine while Ryan leans back on the sofa and talks casually to Joel. His smile is wide, and his eyes sparkle with light. Grey hair is slicked back neatly, and he's dressed as though he's about to go out. A deep blue suit, blue tie, and shiny black shoes. In his hand is a glass of gin and tonic he tells me is his "afternoon pick-me-up".

When Martha comes back from the bedroom, she's holding a baby in each arm. *My babies*. They're both wearing little white jumpsuits, their dark hair a stark contrast to their pale skin. When she leans down in front of me and attempts to hand me one of the babies, I freeze. My entire body hums with nervous apprehension. What if I hurt them? What if I drop them? *What if...?*

"It's okay, sweetheart," Martha whispers. "You won't hurt him."

Him. My son. My Jacob.

I shuffle back on the sofa and exhale as Martha places my son in my arms reminding me to support his head. Angela takes my daughter, but try as I might, I can't look at either of them. Instead, I close my eyes and cry. Tears fall for the choices I've made, the love I've lost, the friends I've found, and the moments I've missed with my babies because of the way grief stole my heart and forced me into the depths of utter despair and chaos.

I could have died and never seen them again. I could have ruined their lives. My babies could have grown up never knowing how much they were loved and wanted even before they were born. They could have discovered that at my lowest point, I was willing to sacrifice their tiny heartbeats and force them from this world because I wasn't strong enough to carry the weight of their father's death.

I can't take them back. Not yet. But they have to know... they *must* know I love them... that Declan loved them.

I blink.

More tears fall.

A baby cries.

I open my eyes and peer down at the perfect little face of my son. *He is beautiful.* His eyes are as blue as Declan's were. As blue as the sky I screamed into at the top of Mount Blessing. As blue as the ocean that surrounded the island on our honeymoon. His tiny nose and baby pink lips remind me of Declan. His black hair reminds me of Declan, too. "Jacob..." His name leaves my lips and everything about it feels right. It belongs to him. *He belongs to me.* I snuggle him closer, bringing his tiny face to my lips where I press a gentle kiss to his chubby cheek. "I love you my precious little boy."

When my tears fall, I don't blink them away. I stare into his eyes, wondering how something so perfect came from someone so... imperfect... so broken. "Your daddy loved you, Jacob... so, so much."

He blinks.

He wriggles in my arms.

Then, *he* cries.

I gasp, instantly worried I hurt him.

"He's hungry," Martha says with a chuckle. "They have their bottles when they wake up. Would you like to feed him?" Her smile is genuine, and her voice is soft and gentle.

"Am I allowed to? Is that okay?"

She nods. "Of course it is. You're his mummy, Zahra."

A couple of minutes later, Martha returns with two bottles. She hands one to me and explains how to hold it properly. When I press the teat to Jacob's lips, he opens his mouth and a second later, sucks furiously. Once he's calm, I lean back a little and watch him drink.

“I wish Declan was here.” I don’t realise I’ve said the words out loud until Angela replies, “He would love them with all his heart.”

While she feeds Abby, I watch her. She looks like Declan too, but her eyes—although still blue—are much darker than Jacob’s, and her lips remind me of my own. *She’s perfect.*

The overwhelming urge to pull them both into my arms and run away with them forever, almost consumes me. Perhaps it’s a mother’s instinct... or maybe it’s a dire need to have them back. *They’re safe here.* I remind myself they’re still mine. I haven’t lost them.

When they’ve finished their bottles, Angela and I swap, and for the first time I hold my daughter in my arms. She opens her eyes and stares up at me, blinking, yawning, scrunching up her cute button nose. “No one will ever hurt you,” I promise her. Memories of my little sister appear in my mind. Her tiny feet, blonde curls, and the pink blanket I wrapped her in before handing her to my mother. *My little jellybean.*

For a fleeting moment, panic takes hold. My babies... my son, and my daughter. The fear I tried to fight the day Declan and I discovered we were having twins, and there was a possibility they could be a boy and a girl, unravelled my world in the worst way possible. I glance at my son. *No. He’s perfect.* He will be kind, loving, and caring. He will love his sister the right way, and she will love him the same. Their relationship will grow into something beautiful, the type of bond siblings should have. It won’t be filled with darkness, debauchery, or terrifying nights of torture and pain.

They will be okay.

Abby wriggles in my arms before her little face turns red and she screams. I rock her gently, trying to calm her, but it’s no use, and the louder she cries, the more my heart breaks.

When my own tears fall, Angela pats my knee. “It’s okay... she’s okay.”

Martha nods in agreement. “Take her for a walk, she loves being outside.”

“Like her daddy,” Angela adds, sadness layers each word.

“Will you come with me?” I ask Angela.

She nods and gets to her feet, cradling a sleeping Jacob in her arms. I follow her through the house and out into the back garden where flowers

grow in large stone pots, and bluebirds flit between the branches of giant, leafy green trees.

I rock Abby in my arms, gently patting her bottom as I pace the garden. “Shhh... you’re okay, Mummy is here.” I look up at Angela. “Do you think they know I’m their mother?”

“Of course,” she says taking a seat at the wrought iron outdoor setting. “Babies are clever. When we brought Declan home, he stared up at us as though we were the ones who gave him life. Even when he was old enough to understand, and we told him we weren’t his real parents, he refused to listen. He said that no matter who was responsible for bringing him into this world, I was his mother.”

“I wish they had the chance to know him...” I trail off as another thought comes to mind. “Angela, I’d like to look for Declan’s brother.”

She tilts her head. “Are you sure?”

I nod. “Declan and I talked about it... he was ready to start looking again.”

She kisses the top of Jacob’s head. “Well, I’ll call William and have him bring the files over. Maybe you can find something we missed.”

A smile tugs at the corners of my mouth. “If he’s still alive, I would love for him to meet his niece and nephew. He deserves that, don’t you think?”

Angela lets out a contented sigh. “He does, Zahra, absolutely.”

Hope spreads through my veins like wildfire. I have something to look forward to, a purpose, a reason to keep going. If I can find Declan’s twin brother, it will be one more thing I’ve done... for Declan, and for my children.

The first time I saw you
I knew I had to know
The last time I saw you
I didn't want to let you go

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ZAHRA**October 20th***11 months since Declan died*

For months my life has been a series of firsts and lasts.

The lasts are all about Declan.

The last time we went to the café.

The last time we went grocery shopping together.

The last time we laid on our bed and looked up at the stars on our ceiling.

The last time we held hands and kissed.

The last time we touched.

The last thing he made me promise.

And the last time he placed his hands on my swollen belly and whispered to his babies, "I love you both so much."

The firsts are about life *after* Declan. A life I didn't want to live but was thrust into by a cruel twist of fate that would seek to destroy me.

The first time I walked along the street alone.

The first time I saw my babies.

The first time I sat on the edge of the lake and dangled my feet in the water.

The first time I fell asleep and didn't wish my life would end.

The first time I called Angela for help, because the nightmares were too real, and it was all too hard.

I'm learning to live this life without Declan, without my babies, without the support and love I had before. I'm learning to live alone, minute by minute sometimes, other times, it's day by day. But *I am* living.

I am alive.

Since I arrived home from the hospital, I've been writing in my journals again. My words pour out now, and I leave nothing unwritten. The hurt, the pain, the hope, it's all there between the pages. Writing stops me cutting and helps me find slivers of hope in each day.

I lean back on the sofa and pull up my feet. With my journal and a pen in my hand, I begin to write.

October 20th

The blanket of sorrow that's covered me from head to toe is finally beginning to lift. Life is harder than it has ever been, but I've found something in the wreckage of what was once my beautiful fairy tale. I am strong... God; I am stronger than I ever imagined I could be.

I wake each day with Declan's picture on my bedside table. His smiling face reminds me, I must go on. He saved me and he stayed by my side through some of the most difficult times. I want to make him proud. I want to continue this journey and prove to everyone that Declan was the best part of me, and that his love is what made me what I am today.

One day, I want to bring my babies home and tell them about their daddy and how much he loved and adored them. I want them to grow up knowing he wanted them. That their lives were the last thing he thought about before he took his final breath.

This ache in my heart may never fade, but in time I hope it will lessen.

A knock at the door startles me. I close my journal and slide it into the drawer on the side table. Through the stained-glass window of the front door, I see Jayden.

When I open the door, he's smiling.

I haven't smiled for so long. The last time was when I saw my babies. It still feels wrong to smile, at anyone... for anything.

"Hi Zahra, I wanted to come around and see how you were... um... I thought I could do the gardens, or something..." He shuffles from foot to foot as though he doesn't quite know what to say.

I extend my hand and welcome him in before asking if he'd like a coffee or a cold drink.

Jayden sits at the kitchen bench on a barstool while I make his coffee. "Have you been busy?" I ask.

He nods. "Yeah, got another group of kids coming tomorrow. Five teenagers. Hopefully they settle in well."

"Are they local?" I ask.

"Nah. Two of the girls are from Hearts of Innocence, and the other three are from Banksia Park, it's about six hours away."

There's a lump in my throat when Jayden mentions Hearts of Innocence. It hurts to hear that young girls are still being hurt by monsters like my father and brother. Although, I'm relieved that Eli and his team at Hearts of Innocence are working hard to stop it happening.

"Ah, Zahra..." Jayden hesitates and runs a hand through his hair. "I was wondering if you... would you like to come to the camp tomorrow, have a look around and maybe meet the kids? I thought we could go out for lunch afterwards."

I sigh. I haven't been out much, and apart from Angela and Ryan, and Charles and Jaymee, I rarely see anyone. Jayden's been trying to get me to leave the house, and is always encouraging, but sometimes I get a niggling feeling that he wants more than just a simple friendship.

The positivity I felt when I left the Wellness Centre has waned, and I'm trying my hardest not to let the abyss swallow me up and drag me back into a deep, dark hole.

I place the coffee mug on the bench in front of Jayden and he thanks me. "Um, I'm not sure if I'm ready for that. I... I ah..." I swallow the lump in my throat. "I'm sorry."

He raises a hand but his eyes are clouded with disappointment. "No, no don't be sorry. I understand. It's all good. I just thought if you wanted to get out of the house for a bit."

I nod. "Thank you... I do want to see what you've done with the camp. But right now, I'm trying to get back to being me again."

He nods in agreement, then takes a sip of coffee. "How are the babies doing?"

"They're beautiful. I've fed them a couple of times and bathed and changed them. I can't believe how much they look like Declan with their blue eyes and dark hair."

I pull up a bar stool to sit beside him. Jayden's been so kind to me since Declan died, and he's been doing all he can to help around the house and keep the gardens neat and tidy. I offered to pay him, but he refused.

"Have you had any luck with Declan's brother yet?" he asks.

I shake my head. "William is going to send some flyers out to police stations and community centres. Eli is going to see what he can find out about Declan's mother. Hopefully I'll hear something soon."

Jayden takes a mouthful of coffee, then scratches his head. "Do you think he's still al—" He stops before he says it.

"Alive? I don't know. I hope so." *He has to be.*

"Well, if you need help, or you need to go anywhere, I don't mind driving you."

I give him a small smile. "Thank you, Jayden, that would mean a lot to me."

Where has he gone
What lies has he told
How long before he shatters
Beneath a heart that's so cold

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ELI

November 1

I slam my hand down on the desk. “We lost them again!” My anger grows as I flick through the folder containing the photographs of six young girls aged between ten and fifteen. Each one—without hesitation—pointed to the pictures of Rob and Trystan Browne. Each girl said they were the men who had abused them. They’re still out there and getting better at hiding.

Fourteen months ago, we almost had him. He was right there in front of us, walking down the street as though he hadn’t ruined the lives of so many young girls. It took all of thirty seconds for him to get into the passenger seat of a red sports car, and disappear. Barely a week later, we discovered an undercover police officer was helping him. That bastard is in prison now, rotting away like the rest of those mongrels.

Callum crosses his arms. “Go back to Edgewater Prison. Talk to Anderson.”

I roll my eyes. “Been there, done that. No one’s talking. We need to change our tactic. Let me go undercover again.” It’s a big ask, and my bet is he’ll say no.

He shakes his head. *No surprise there.* “No. You’ve got a daughter now, I’m not putting her in danger... I’m not putting *you* in danger. It’s too risky. Too many people know about you now.”

“Fuck!” I curse under my breath. Our guy on the inside is the only option, for now.

I shove the paperwork into my bag and stand to shake Callum’s hand. “I’ll call when I get out.”

He gives me a nod and I head out but not before I hear him call me, “Eli... don’t do it.”

I give him a mock salute. “Not doing it,” I assure him, but damn, I want to. *Maybe I could get a disguise.* I roll my eyes and laugh at myself.

As I take off along the highway, I call Zahra on my car phone. “Hey honey, everything okay?” she asks.

“All good. I’m heading to Edgewater. I might be home late, give Gracie a kiss for me.”

“Of course. Eli, please be careful.”

“I will. Love you.”

“Love you too.”

When the call ends, I make another call to Edgewater to let them know I’m on my way.

By the time I arrive at Edgewater a few hours later, my mind is whirling with thoughts. I need to find Rob Browne and his son. No one’s this good at evading the law. No one. I check in and show my badge and ID before I’m led through to the visitation room where Joe Anderson is waiting.

The guard stands by the door and nods as I walk in. When I take a seat at the table opposite Joe, he leans back in his chair and raises a brow. “Eli. You’re back... again.”

“I need information.”

He laughs and lifts his cuffed hands to rub his brow. “I told you last time what I want.” He shrugs.

I scratch my neck. Last time I spoke to him, he upped the ante. He wants the man who raped and killed his daughter, dead. There’s one problem, I don’t know who that guy is. While Joe sits in prison for killing the wrong man, the real murderer of his daughter is out there somewhere, a free man. “I can’t help you with that. Is there...” I lower my voice.

“Something else I can do for you?”

He cocks his head and narrows his eyes. When he leans forward across the table, the guard clears his throat. “Back, Anderson.”

Joe slides back slightly, but still rests his elbows on the table. “Find him. Don’t give me that bullshit, you’ve got contacts.”

I cross my arms over my chest. “I’ll look into it, but like I said last time, I can’t promise you anything. I’ll go over the files again, call in some favours if I have to. But Joe, I need information.”

He grunts. “You still looking for that filthy scum? Taking your sweet time about it.”

“You heard anything?”

“Some stuff. You got a smoke?”

I turn back to the guard and wave the pack of cigarettes in his direction. He gives me a curt nod and I hand one to Joe then light it up for him. He takes a long drag and blows the smoke toward the ceiling. “I hate those maggots. Fucking scum of the earth.” His jaw clenches. “Apparently, there’s a place outside Braemar, some kind of holding area where they take the kids before they’re sold off to Libertine.”

Libertine. A group of sick, twisted paedophiles who prey on young children and will stop at nothing to feed their vile needs. Originally, I was positive Rob Browne was part of their secret society, but there was nothing to lead us to that conclusion. “Names?” I ask.

“Browne was never mentioned. I only got one name, Tryst. Same name keeps coming up every time.”

“Fuck!”

Joe’s brows bunch together. “You know him?”

“He’s Rob Browne’s boy. Unless there’s another sick fucker named Trystan.”

The guard calls out from the door. “Five minutes.”

I look back over my shoulder and nod toward him.

When I return my attention to Joe, he lowers his voice. “How are your girls going?”

I swallow hard. Prison is the last place I want to be talking about my wife and daughter, but I trust Joe. Yes, he’s a murderer, and he killed an innocent man—by mistake. He was one of us, until his fourteen-year-old daughter, Taylah, was raped and murdered. While his world spun out of control, we tried to help him, but grief is a bitch, and his thirst for vengeance ruled his every waking moment. After his wife left him, he was determined to find the man responsible for Taylah’s death.

Two weeks after her murder, a man was arrested, and Joe walked into the police station and shot him point blank in the head. A few hours later, he found out it was the wrong guy. His sentence—15 years in prison.

“They’re good. Safe, happy, perfect.”

He nods slightly. “You keep it that way, hey.” He stands from his seat and nods toward the guard before looking down at me again. “Find him, Eli, find them all...”

“That’s my plan,” I say before I leave.

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They see me as their saviour
I'm their happy ending
Until the truth appears
And their pain is never ending

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TRYSTAN

November 4

The door slams closed behind me followed by a scream. When one starts, they all start. Dirty little whores can't keep their mouths shut. None of them are like my sister was. None of them submit, and none of them stay quiet.

"Rob! Where the fuck are you?" A groan of satisfaction follows a scream of pain, then, a quiet plea. "Let me go home now, please..."

I roll my eyes. Constant whining, that's all I ever fucking hear. This being on the run bullshit is getting old. I've got things to do, people to see. Places to go. *Rockburn Grove*. They thought we'd never find her, they were so wrong. All in time, I remind myself. This isn't something I can rush into. Everything must be perfect, and it is... almost. Now that I've taken over my father's business, I answer to no one.

My father stumbles out from behind a sheet hanging from a rope that stretches across the warehouse from one side to the other. Behind the sheet, ten girls wait on single bed mattresses where they'll stay until the next lot of buyers arrive.

He tugs on his pants and pulls up the zipper. "What's going on?" he slurs then reaches behind the sheet for his bottle of rum.

I slap the bottle out of his hand and it shatters on the concrete causing yet another round of screaming. "Shut the fuck up!"

Luke's standing at the top of the stairs near the office on the second floor. "Luke, get down here and shut these bitches up." He races down the stairs and heads behind the curtain.

One slap, one scream.

Another slap, a cry.

Another slap.

Dead silence.

"Fucking finally! You heard from Lionel?" I ask my father.

He narrows his eyes as though he doesn't know what—or who—I'm talking about. The loser hit the bottle hard after Carlie was taken, didn't give a shit about Cathie though... no surprise there.

"Tonight... ahhh... fuck—Nine... n—no, ten." He rubs his head, then laughs. "Nine ten."

I let my eyelids close as I count to ten in my head. It doesn't help. When I reach six, I clench my fist, open my eyes, and knock my father out. He lands on the floor with a thud. He's out cold and he'll stay there until I'm ready to move him.

I stretch my arms and crack my neck. It's almost eight which means the buyers will arrive in a little over an hour. I need to sell four of these girls to meet our quota.

Luke comes out from behind the sheet and scratches at the scabs on his arm. Another loser. A year with Libertine and he decided he had conscience, too bad things don't work that way around here. After trying to run off with fifty grand of my money, Glen caught him and dragged his ass back here. Now, he's like an obedient dog—doesn't help that he's an addict too. I made sure I was the only one he can get his drugs from. Loyal now, but still dumb as fuck. "They're all quiet. Want 'em cleaned up?" he mumbles.

I nod and wave him away before I head up to the office where Glen sits in a recliner with a cigarette between his lips. "She's ready," he says nodding toward the female tied to the chair in front of him.

Long brown hair falls over her shoulders and covers her breasts. I flick it away revealing the swell of a pale breast tipped with a firm, pink nipple. When I pinch it between my fingers, she lets out a cry of pain and wriggles on the chair trying to pull away from me. My cock hardens, and when I move forward, she pushes her feet out to push the chair back. I grab a handful of her hair and pull her head back before I rip the tape from her mouth.

She lets out a scream and Glen laughs. "You'd think she'd learn by now, stupid slut."

"Any news from Jeff?" I ask him.

He shakes his head and takes a puff of his cigarette. "He said she's still there, still pining for her dead husband."

I pace the office and scrub my hands down my face. It's been too long since I've seen her. Since I've felt her. Leaning against the wall, I crack open a beer and think about the day my life turned to shit and everything came to a head. The day I lost my sister.

Trystan
17 years old

"Bring him the fuck back. Now!" I shouted through the phone while I paced the kitchen.

"Tryst, calm down. We're leaving in ten. Rob said to tell you Eli Cole was undercover," Jeff said, "he's from Hearts of fucking Innocence.

My head was pounding. I knew enough about Hearts of Innocence to know this wasn't good. If they came after us, we'd all go down. My father said there was something familiar about Cole, but he couldn't place it.

He left shortly after Cathie was taken to check him out and see what he was hiding. The next thing I knew, my father was on the phone, his voice filled with rage. "He took them both! I'm going after him."

Six hours later, Jeff's at the local hospital picking up my father and I'm storming through the house packing bags and getting rid of evidence. Fuck!

"Tryst, you still there?"

"Yeah, I'm cleaning. Ready in an hour."

"Good boy, Tryst." I bit my tongue to stop myself calling the bastard every name under the sun. When he called me "good boy" I knew then and there I was going to up my game. I ended the call then dialled Glen's number. He answered on the first ring.

"What's up?"

"We need to leave, you coming?" I asked him.

There was a laugh, then a shout of celebration. "Fuck yes! I'll be there in ten."

I shoved the phone in my back pocket. Glen jumped at the chance. His parents were assholes. His father spent more time in brothels than he did at home, and his mother was a stripper at the local men's club. Glen

spent almost all his free time at my place. He was like a brother to me, though I'd never admit it to anyone.

Once the bags were packed and I'd cleaned out the girl's bedrooms, I lugged all the clothes and bedding outside and shoved them into the steel drums in the backyard, then poured petrol over them. When I threw in the match, they lit up and smoke rose into the air. No one ever questioned our 'bon fires' and if they did, nothing was ever done about it. Half the town was eating out of the palm of my father's hand, the other half was too afraid to open their stupid mouths.

By the time Jeff arrived home with my father, Glen and I had finished scrubbing down the house. Everything was ready to go.

"You got the money?" My father asked through gritted teeth. His face was bruised, and there was a cut extending from beneath his left eye down through his lip.

"Got it. What the fuck happened?" I asked.

"He took 'em both. We need to get out of here, lie low for a while." He turned his attention to Glen. "You up for this?"

Glen nodded. "I'm up for it."

We drove through the night while my father and Jeff filled us in on the story behind Eli Cole. Turns out that around twenty years ago, my grandfather, Coltyn Browne, was running Libertine back then and had sent my father and Jeff out to find some girls. They returned with four girls, one of them was Carlie Cole.

Hearing my own sister's name caused my cock to harden. I needed her back, and fast. Jeff continued with the story, telling Glen and I about the girls they had there, and how they wouldn't stop screaming and crying. One night, my grandfather had had enough of it and threatened to kill the next girl who opened her mouth. That girl was Carlie, and once she was murdered, they needed to move on again.

"Does Eli Cole know this?" I asked.

"Nope. And he'll never find out," Jeff said. "We've got men everywhere, Tryst. What they know, we know."

"Where's Coltyn now?" I asked.

Jeff laughed. "Nowhere you'll ever find him. The guy's a ghost."

“No more questions,” my father growled. Anger laced every word, and I knew as soon as we stopped, I would be punished. I dropped my head back on the seat and closed my eyes.

Jeff pulled into a house off a dirt road as the sun was coming up. He got out of the car and headed inside, my father followed a minute later. He warned Glen and I to stay put until he came back.

Glen scrubbed his hands down his face. “He’s pissed, man. This is gonna be bad, isn’t it?”

I shrugged. I heard the fear in his tone, but I wasn’t going to admit I felt it too. “If you can’t handle it, get out now. Because once we’re in there, there’s no turning back.”

“I’m not going anywhere. I’ll deal. I’m not a fucking pussy.”

With a grunt I turned to face him. “But soon, you’re gonna wish you had one.” His Adam’s apple bobbed when he swallowed, then he turned to look out the window.

When my father returned, we followed him into the house where another guy sat on a sofa with a young girl kneeling between his legs, sucking him off. Her blonde hair was twisted around his fist as he forced her head down.

My cock twitched again, but the feeling was torn away when my father ordered me to drop my pants. I didn’t hesitate. There was no fucking way I was going to look weak in front of Glen, or anyone else in the house for that matter. Glen already knew what my father was capable of, he’d experienced it first-hand one night when my father found us using Carlie without his permission. That was the first time Glen sucked my father’s cock, but it wouldn’t be the last.

For the next three weeks, my father, Jeff, and the guy I found out was my father’s friend, Lincoln, fucked me and Glen every single night. When we couldn’t walk, we were forced to suck their cocks. When we refused, we were beaten, whipped and forced to spend hours in the stinking cellar below the house. By the time the fourth week came, I couldn’t move any part of my body without pain. But I was alive, and determined not to let them break me.

At the end of the fourth week, Glen and I were forced to fuck each other while they sat in the living room watching us. They laughed, they drank, and they fucked and abused girls while Glen and I went through the motions, doing everything we were told to do, sucking cocks, fucking, dragging girls from the cellar to the bedrooms, all the while secretly plotting revenge.

They were going to pay for what they did to us.

“Tryst!” Glen shouts.

I slam my head back against the wall hoping to relieve the pounding headache. “What?”

“You zoned out or something... What the fuck, man?”

I finish off the bottle of beer and throw it in the trash can. “I’m good,” I say walking over to the girl sitting on the chair.

“Let me go, please...”

I cup her cheek and lean down to whisper against her ear. “Shhh... don’t cry, beautiful. I’ll make sure no one touches you, just trust me, okay?”

She blinks, nods, then swallows. “Thank you.” Her eyes grow wide with hope as she looks up at me. “Can you help me get out of here?”

A grin spreads across Glen’s face. He’ll never admit it, but I know he fucking loves it when I play the nice guy. They fall for it every time.

I laugh in her face. “Carlie, baby, you’re not going anywhere. You belong to me now.”

“Nooo, I’m not Carlie. My name is Bianca, please... I want to go home.” Tears roll down her flushed pink cheeks.

I unzip my pants and drop them to the floor. When I release my cock from my underwear, she cries out. “No, I don’t want to.”

Glen takes a puff of his cigarette before he comes over and stands behind the female I’ve named Carlie. He holds the chair steady as I cup her jaw with my hands and shove my cock in her mouth.

She fights against me, struggling, gagging and crying until I yank her head back and push my cock in deeper. “That shut you up didn’t it? Now suck, and this time do it properly and I won’t hurt you... much.”

When I’m done, I pull up my pants and lean down close to her ear. “Still not good enough.”

Her chest rises and falls rapidly with each sob, but it doesn't stop her talking. "I hate you."

A burst of laughter rolls through me. "You say it like I care." I turn to grab a bottle of beer from the refrigerator when I hear, "My name is not Carlie!"

Glen leans against the wall, one eyebrow raised as he stares down at the defiant bitch in the chair. I inhale. I exhale. Then, I pull my knife from my belt and hold it up, twisting and turning it so the silver blade catches the light. "What the fuck did you say to me?" I give her another chance to speak, but it won't help her, not now.

"My name..." she drops her head and murmurs, "is Carlie."

Pointing the tip of the knife at her throat, I glance at Glen. "What do you reckon?"

He shrugs. "She's useless. Doesn't even look like her anyway."

"True," I say as I push the knife into her throat. A gurgled breath is released before crimson blood flows down her bare chest and pools between her legs. I grip her jaw with one hand and press my lips to hers. "Sweet dreams, beautiful," I say before I drop the knife in the sink and walk out the door. "Clean this up, burn the body," I tell Glen.

"Consider it done," he replies.

In the back room of the warehouse is a bathroom and shower stall. I strip off my clothes and throw them in the trash can before I grab a clean set from the locker along with a towel. Turning the shower on, I look down at my body. Scars cover my flesh, the same scars my sister had. But mine are a reminder. One scar for each day she's been gone. When I get her back, she'll get the same in return, her punishment for thinking she could leave me... and our father.

She thinks her new little world is safe, but she has no idea of what's coming. Jeff's been keeping a close eye on what's going on in Rockburn Grove. His position in administration at Sundowner, the local hospital, has kept him in good with the locals. He's out of the public eye and has full access to all the medical records. *Soon*. I keep reminding myself not to push this.

Taking my cock in my hand, I pull on it while picturing Carlie's face... her eyes welling with tears and her pink lips parted and begging me

to stop. *I need her.* I let my head fall back as steam fills the room and the hot water cascades down my back. When the tension in my body is finally released, I breathe out a sigh of relief.

Another day, another murder. I try not to make it a habit, but fuck, some females are stupid.

As the water washes over me, I let my memories carry me back to the first time I killed a girl. The first time was an accident, but when I realised what a rush it was, I was desperate to do it again. To this day, no one knows I did it. *I'm one lucky bastard.*

Trystan

Age 14 years

"Come on. I'll take you to the lookout. It'll be fun." I encouraged her. I told her she was beautiful, and that I loved her eyes and the way she did her hair. She fell for it all, and after my third plea, she accepted my offer. I waited for her after school at the back of the Art Building where Luke and Glen would wait for me each day. We'd already planned it. All they had to do was keep her friends away so I could take her up the mountain.

"But I have to be home by six, or my dad will totally freak out," she said.

I nodded. "Six it is then, gives us plenty of time to talk." I grabbed her hand and led her away from the school and through the trees to where the path into the forest started.

"Trystan, why doesn't Carlie go to school? She must get bored at home with no friends."

I resisted the urge to roll my eyes and tell her to shut up. Everyone asked about Carlie. It was my father's fault. When she was thirteen, he brought her to the school to have some tests done.

Apparently, when you home school your kids, they have to do these general knowledge tests at an actual school. It wasn't long after that, that Principal Chamberson arrived at our house one Friday night to purchase my sister.

I was pissed off. That old bastard got to fuck her before I did. But it worked in my favour in the end. Anything I wanted at school, I got. There

was no such thing as detention, or extra work, or even homework. I sat in class all day and did fuck all, and for that, I got an A in every subject.

“She doesn’t know how to talk to people outside our home.” It was the same spiel I gave everyone who asked about her. “She doesn’t care,” I added.

“Do you think I could come to your house and see her, maybe be her friend?”

“Nope. She doesn’t want friends.”

“Oh.” Her voice was laced with disappointment, so I changed the subject.

“Have you ever kissed anyone?”

She shook her head and her cheeks turned pink. We continued up the mountain in silence until she asked me, “Have you? Kissed someone?”

“Yeah.”

“Who?”

I laughed. “Why do you care? Will you be jealous?”

She shrugged. “I was just asking, that’s all.”

I reeled off the names. “Trudy, Mari, Leanna, and some girl in the senior school, I can’t remember her name.”

She stops in her tracks and gasps. “You kissed a senior? You’re only fourteen.”

“So?”

She dropped her head and quickened her pace. “We’re almost there,” she called.

I jogged up behind her and wrapped my arms around her waist. When she turned around, her warm breath caressed my lips. Without asking, or hesitating, I pressed my lips to hers and she kissed me back, awkwardly at first, until a few seconds passed, and she was kissing me properly.

I raised my hand and rubbed it over her small, soft breast before I lowered it again to move it up under her t-shirt.

She tried to push my hand away, but I squeezed tighter and pressed my growing erection into her. When she let out a little moan, I had no idea if it was pleasure or pain, and I didn’t care. She wasn’t going to stop me.

Within minutes, we were both on the ground surrounded by bushy shrubs and large, tall trees. She writhed beneath me, and even though it was

my first time, I'd watched my father with Carlie enough to know what to do.

I pulled her underwear down beneath her skirt, and when she said "No" and started to cry, I pressed my hand over her mouth. "Shhh... it's okay. I won't hurt you if you keep still."

Her eyes were wide, and she tried with all her might to push me off. Punch after punch she swung at my face, each one missing me, each one only fuelling my desire for her. I needed to fuck her. I needed to know what was so good about it. And when I was done, I would do exactly the same thing with my sister. As I forced my cock inside her, she cried out.

I let my hand slide off her mouth and she cried while I whispered in her ear. "Relax, Taylah, you want me."

She didn't relax. She didn't shut up. I forced my hand over her mouth again and moved on top of her. Each movement sent bolts of electricity coursing through my veins. I was alive with pleasure, with power... but she shook her head, desperately trying to free herself.

When she attempted to squeeze her thighs together, I pushed harder and faster. Something was happening, the pleasure was increasing, but then it slowed... Taylah stilled. Her body went limp beneath mine. I moved my hand and her head lolled to the side. When I slid out of her and stood up to pull up my pants, she remained still.

I kicked her thigh, then gave her shoulder a shove.

She didn't move.

"Taylah, wake the fuck up."

No reply.

I knelt beside her and put my ear to her mouth.

Silence.

"Fuck!" I shouted then covered my mouth. I killed her. Or she died... somehow.

I scanned the area. In the distance, the large yellow sign that warned hikers about the steep cliffs stood tall. Without a second thought, I grabbed her ankles and dragged her across the forest floor until I reached the edge of the cliff. Rocky ledges jutted out the side of the mountain all the way down to the valley below. I dragged her closer, then ran back to grab her school bag. When I dropped her bag over the edge of the cliff, I watched it fall until it hit a ledge then continued to tumble down the mountain side.

Using my foot, I pushed Taylah's body to the very edge of the cliff before I gave her one last shove. I watched as her body tumbled and spun in the air. I laughed when her head hit a rocky ledge and her dead body spun like a tumbleweed in the wind. And I breathed a sigh of relief when I could no longer see her blue school jacket or her blonde hair. She was gone, and I was free.

No one would ever find out.

* * *

Libertine has been running for longer than I've been alive. Usually, they despise anyone under thirty being their leader, but since my father was the previous leader, and he's now a pathetic, space wasting piece of shit alcoholic, I've taken charge, and with my father's connections, no one can stop me. I'm not naïve enough to believe I'll never get caught, eventually it's bound to happen, but I've got men on the inside to keep me safe. Right now, everything is set up for Glen to take over if I end up in prison.

He's the only person I trust in this fucked up world.

If anyone else tries to take over, they'll end up dead like those who've challenged me in the past. I've got everyone eating out of the palm of my hand now, and with Luke and Glen on my side, we're unstoppable.

A year after Carlie was taken, Glen and I started going to the gym, working out, and practicing martial arts. Anything and everything we could do to get in shape and put on some muscle. We weren't prepared to resort to drugs that would cloud our judgement. We needed to be on the ball, nothing was going to stop us. Six short months later, we put our plan into motion.

Trystan

19 years old

My father and Jeff were sitting on the leather recliners watching porn while Glen and I were in the kitchen. Everything was ready. We had ten girls in a bedroom, ready to go. Another four were due to arrive any day. But we had to do one more thing.

*Glen leaned back on the chair and looked out to the living room.
“Let’s do it,” he whispered under his breath.*

I clenched my fists. “Sure you’re ready?” I asked him.

A nod.

We stood, walked quietly into the living room, and at the same time, pierced a syringe into their necks. My father jumped out of his chair and raised his hand to his neck. His eyes glazed over and he opened his mouth to speak, but less than a minute later, he fell to the floor, hitting his head on the glass coffee table on the way down. Jeff was slumped in the chair, his beer running out of the bottle and into his lap.

“Let’s take ‘em down,” I said to Glen.

Once we’d dragged them both down to the cellar beneath the house, we cuffed them to chains on the walls. On the opposite side of the room, two girls were sitting on the bed, naked. Lincoln had dropped them off earlier in the morning. We knew we’d have all day and night for this.

“Are you going to help us?” one of the girls asked.

Glen laughed.

“Shh...” I warned him. “Watch this.”

I walked over and sat on the end of the bed. The younger of the two girls scrambled back and pulled her knees to her chest. “Are you scared?” I asked them.

They both nodded, and the older one asked, “When can we go home?”

I put my hand on her thigh. “You want to go home?”

Another nod. Then they both started crying.

“You can’t go home.” My voice remained calm. “You’re going to live with us now. With me and Glen. We’re going to look after you real good.”

The younger one shook her head. “I want my mummy. I wanna go home.”

I tugged on her arm and pulled her across to me. When she was sitting on my lap, I pulled her hair back and breathed into her neck. I needed to remain calm and focused. There was too much to do. “I told you, you’re not going home. We’re going to fuck you, hard. Do you know what that means?”

She sobbed as she shook her head. The other girl backed away from me slowly, it was clear she understood exactly what I meant. “It means

we're going to do bad things to you, and you'll cry, and scream and beg us to stop. But we won't stop, because you were made to be used, made to be broken."

"No. No, I don't want to."

I rolled my eyes and stood from the bed, pushing her onto the floor where she landed with a thud. "The thing is, little whore..." I paced back and forth in front of her. "You don't have a choice. You are nothing more than money making holes now."

I walked back toward Glen, and without looking at the girls, I continued, "So you better get used to it."

When my father and Jeff woke up, they started carrying on and blubbering some shit about us being little pricks and that we'd pay for whatever we did to them. We didn't pay. But they sure did.

We spent the whole night in the cellar forcing them to do everything they had done to us. Glen and I whipped them, kicked them, fucked them, and used them. When they begged for mercy, we went harder; when they swore we'd pay—again, we made sure we laughed while we pulled the chains around their necks and watched them fuck each other.

By the time the night was over, they were both bruised, bloody, and begging for freedom. In one night, we'd fucked them over and taken everything. I was in charge, and Glen was by my side.

My father's drinking got worse after that, but he never questioned me again. Never touched me again. Jeff wasn't game enough to stand up to us, not without my father on his side.

We trained them so well that they spent the next few months cleaning blood, vomit and shit off the floor of the cellar while Glen and I sat back drinking whiskey and smoking cigarettes.

Finally, Libertine was mine.

I sit at the table in the second-floor office as Luke leads the first of the men in. The rules are strict. If they're late, they don't get in. If they bring anyone with them, they don't get in. If they don't pay the viewing fee, they're out, permanently.

The door opens and I stand to shake hands with Lionel and Rhett. They take their seats and Glen pours them a glass of whiskey while Luke

heads back downstairs to wait for the others. By the time the six men have arrived, my father has showered and is relatively sober apart from the stench of rum leeching from his flesh. He drops down into the seat beside me and lifts the whiskey bottle to pour himself a glass. I place my hand over it and glare at him.

A muffled laugh erupts from beside me, and Glen whips into action. He grabs Rhett in a headlock holding a knife to his throat. “Something amusing you, asshole?”

Rhett shakes his head slightly and my father laughs. I roll my eyes. “Right, ladies, are we here to make a purchase, or act like little bitches?”

Glen steps back keeping his eye on Rhett as he removes his phone from his pocket. The other men do the same, followed by their wallets. Luke and Glen walk around the room collecting the phones and wallets before putting them into the safe and locking it closed.

Downstairs, the sheet is drawn back and the girls sit on their mattresses. Some are crying, most are quiet. “Stand,” I command.

Slowly, they get to their feet but when I glance to my left, one of the younger ones is still sitting with her legs crossed and her head down. “I said STAND!” She whimpers and the girl beside her tilts her head. “She peed on her bed,” she says.

Luke walks over and grabs her by the arm, lifting her up off the bed. “What’s your name?” he asks.

She crosses her arms around herself. “Bridgette... I wanna go home...”

“Stand the fuck up,” Luke growls. “You’re not going anywhere unless we say so.” When he steps back, she remains standing but continues crying like a fucking baby.

One by one the men walk back and forth looking the girls up and down, telling them to turn around, and asking them how many times they’ve fucked. I’ve whipped them—literally—into line so well, they rarely disobey.

Lionel, my father’s friend and our inside source in Children’s Services, points to the youngest girl at the end. “I’ll take her, for thirty.”

I grind my teeth. I fucking hate this bastard. “Make it fifty and you’ve got a deal.”

He looks over at my father who’s leaning against the wall, watching.

Glen stands beside me, but glares at my father. “Don’t even think about it,” he warns.

“You think he’s going to go against me?” I ask Lionel. “She’s fifty, take it or fuck off.”

He sighs. “Come on, Tryst, give me a discount this time. I helped you find your sis—”

I turn slightly, then raise my hand, my knife tight in my grasp. “Mention my fucking sister again, and I’ll cut your cock off and shove it down your throat.” I lower my voice. “She’s fifty.”

Glen steps forward. “Actually, Tryst. I think I might take that one now. She’s a good fuck.” As always, it works.

Lionel shakes his head, then raises both his hands. “Fine. Fifty, you’re a hard man, Tryst.”

“And you’re a fuck head,” I say. “Try that shit again, and you’ll be dead. Got it?”

He shoves his hands into his pockets and nods before he walks over to my father, probably to whine about how much of a pussy he’s turned into. Glen watches them while I head over to the girls.

Brigitte, the little brunette with plump pink lips, stares up at me. “Can I go to the toilet, please?”

I kneel in front of her. “What are the rules?”

“No talking.”

“And what are the consequences?”

She pouts and crosses her arms around herself, then crosses her legs. “I really need to go,” she whines.

“You’ll have to hold on, won’t you?”

She shakes her head. “I can’t.” Tears stream down her cheeks, and at the same time, she pisses herself.

When I tug on her hand, she tries to step back. I stand and order her to take off her dress, then I lead her over to Glen. “I want this one ready for tonight.”

He nods and raises his brow. “I’ll have her when you’re done.”

In the next hour, out of the ten girls we have here, six are sold, netting us four hundred grand. But it's not enough. We need more buyers, and more girls. We need to get out of this dump of a warehouse, and move further away from the city and into a mansion surrounded by security guards. I need to grow this business.

"Glen, call Jeff, tell him it's urgent." I rub my hands together. Jeff has contacts everywhere, surely someone he knows has real estate. Once we're settled into a new place, I'll start planning my trip to Rockburn Grove.

Everything will be perfect. *Carlie, you're coming home.*

Nothing is the same
But I continue day by day
The truth is that without you
My love has lost its way

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ZAHRA**April 2***509 days since Declan died**26 years old*

I kneel at my husband's grave and weep tears of sorrow. Over the past 18 months, my life has been reduced to ruins and rebuilt, over and over. But nothing will truly ever be the same again. I can barely look into the eyes of my babies without breaking down in tears. Each day is a battle. I fight between hope and the promise of happiness, and begging whatever gods exist to take me from this earth and send me to heaven where I can once again be with Declan, if only for a moment.

For the first time in a long time, I don't *want* to die, I just want to see him again. The fleeting vision I had during my labour never returned. There's comfort in it though. A reminder that Declan was there at the moment I needed him most.

I live now because I refuse to put my family and friends—my children, through this type of pain. I never want another person to feel the despair I felt when my life flashed before my eyes, and I lost my will to live.

I live because I have to.

Because I want to.

Because I need to find the love I lost when Declan was taken from me. I want to be that girl again. The one who smiled. The one who saw the stars and dreamed of never-ending sunsets, and mountaintops, and oceans, and... life.

I've had so many chances, and this time I will get it right.

I want a life.

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Oceans of uncertainty
I cannot calm the storm
A life was lost too soon
A widow left to mourn

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XAVIER

27 years old

Standing by the trunk of an old oak tree beneath a canopy of shade, my search for my long-lost brother comes to an abrupt halt. I am too late, and I will never forgive myself for not trying harder, and for giving up too soon.

When I glance back at the black convertible, the driver gives me a wave, urging me forward. On an inhale, I take my first step toward the female kneeling at my brother's grave, sobbing. Long, wavy brown hair falls over her bare shoulders as she places her hand on the gravestone.

Another tentative step forward; I swallow the lump in my throat. A quick glance over my shoulder to the car where the driver—Charles—my brother's best friend, sits waiting for the female I know is my brother's widow.

Widow. The word doesn't fit the beautiful, sorrowful female before me.

Her white dress pools around her and beneath it, her bare feet are tucked under her. A pair of strappy white shoes sit beside her handbag. She looks too young to have lost her husband.

I take another step. Then another. My voice breaks when I say her name. "Zahra."

When she gasps, I already know why.

Charles told me, my voice is uncannily similar to Declan's. And my looks, well, we're definitely identical twins. I figured that out the moment I arrived in Rockburn Grove and people stared at me as though they were seeing a ghost. It made me terribly uncomfortable.

I've never been one to enjoy the spotlight; I'm a loner and quickly found out my brother was the total opposite in that regard.

Zahra's head snaps up and she stares at me, her eyes wide and her mouth agape before she scrambles back with her hands splayed behind her.

“Dec—Declan!” The shock on her face, the pain in her eyes... it kills me.

My intention was never to hurt Zahra, but my mere presence is going to do that, and possibly more.

I stutter, lost for words and desperate not to hurt this beautiful, but sad female before me. I shoved my hands into my pockets and kick my toe into the grass. “I... I’m Xavier... Xavier Harrison.” I swallow hard. “I’m Declan’s brother.”

Zahra clamps her eyes shut and when she opens them, she’s looking past me. I turn to see Charles walking toward us. He helps Zahra up and hugs her before whispering in her ear. When she nods, he heads back to the car.

“Do you want to sit again?” I ask, extending my hand.

Zahra nods and plonks down in front of Declan’s grave. She wipes her hand over it then clenches her fist closed as though her touch alone is enough to cling to something that’s left of Declan.

I sit beside her and read the plaque on the headstone.

***Declan Jacob Foxx
Devoted husband to Zahra
Much loved son of Ryan and Angela Foxx
We will love you, always and forever***

Another plaque below reads,

***Beloved father of
Jacob and Abigail***

He had children? Not one person I spoke to mentioned them. Are they still alive? Are they here in this town? I have so many questions.

“You look like him,” Zahra says.

“I’m sorry,” is all I can say. Of course, I’m not sorry I finally found my twin brother, or that we are—were—identical, but I am sorry a thousand times over for the pain it’s already causing everyone in Rockburn Grove.

Zahra twists her fingers together in her lap. “Declan looked for you. We... we were going to look again... but—Declan... It was too late. Where were you?”

I sigh and wish again that I'd tried harder. "I was searching too. But I kept coming up blank. It got hard, and the stress was taking its toll, so I decided to go off the grid for a while. I have a cabin in the mountains, there's nothing there, only nature and my thoughts. A friend of mine came out to see me, he brought a newspaper with him and there he was. Declan Foxx. The brother I'd been searching for since I was twelve years old."

That day, I moved faster than I'd ever moved before. My bag was packed in record time, and my small stash of money was shoved into the bottom of the bag along with my ID and wallet. After hiking down the mountain, I jumped into my boat and made the two-hour trip down the river to Bellarine Point where I caught the next plane out to the mainland. Another six-hour flight landed me in Greyshore, a bustling tourist town. From there I caught a cab to Rockburn Grove. I haven't slept since, and I'm exhausted, but I can't stop now.

Zahra wipes her tears and speaks softly. "I'm sorry, Xavier."

I shake my head. "You have nothing to be sorry for, Zahra, I wish I'd got here sooner."

Zahra nods again as a fresh lot of tears well in her eyes. I watch her with concern.

I've never been one to show an interest in females. Or people for that matter. I'd always been so consumed with finding my brother, I'd never made time for relationships, or a decent friendship. From the age of 12, I've done everything possible to avoid getting close to anyone.

Zahra is something else entirely. She's vulnerable and grieving, and I'm determined not to upset her, and cautious about being around her because of my looks. They never bothered me before, now, I wish I looked like someone else... anyone else.

Silence lingers between us for long drawn out minutes until Zahra speaks up. "Would you like to come to our... To my house? Our house? I have lots of photos of Declan and... well... it's okay. I shouldn't have asked." She runs her fingers through her hair then shakes her head. "I'm so stupid sometimes."

No. Not stupid. The way she questions and doubts herself sends a twinge of pain through my heart. It must be because of her grief. My own pain is bad enough, but to know Zahra is suffering from a worse pain, cuts me deep.

She gets to her feet and brushes off her flowing white dress. “You don’t have to. I’m sorry I asked.” She reaches down to grab her handbag as I stand.

“I’d like to, if that’s okay with you. If I don’t make you... uncomfortable.”

She looks over to Charles, then back to me. “Um, no. It’s not you... I mean it is you... but it’s.” She sighs and looks down at Declan’s grave.

“I know,” I say. “I understand.

* * *

After a quick whisper to Zahra, Charles heads outside while I stand nervously in the living room of Zahra’s home. Everything is perfect and spotlessly clean, but there’s no sign of the children whose names were on the plaque at the cemetery. *Did they die too? Surely someone would have mentioned that.* I scan the open plan living room looking for toys, or anything to tell me there were once children in this house... there’s nothing.

“Um... Zahra... did you...? Do you...? Oh, shit!” I scrub my hands down my face.

Zahra folds a dishcloth and places it beside the sink. “Is something wrong, Xavier?”

“I ah... I saw the plaque at the cemetery... Declan and you had children?” *There, I said it.*

Zahra places her hands on the kitchen counter and exhales slowly. “It’s your birthday today,” she says, changing the subject.

“Yeah, it is.” I haven’t celebrated my birthday since I turned twelve years old. The same year my adoptive parents died in a boating accident. I refused to acknowledge another birthday until I found the brother I shared it with.

“They’re one today,” Zahra says.

“One?” *Twins? Where are they?* If it’s their birthday, why isn’t she with them?

“Twins...”

She nods. “I um...”

She paces to the sofa and drops down into the plush cushion where she begins to sob into her hands.

I glance out the back door to see Charles on his phone. Rather than look like a fool and call out to him, I sit beside Zahra and place a gentle hand on her back, rubbing it slowly. When Zahra falls into my arms and cries against my shoulder, it takes me a minute to catch my breath. I don't know this girl—this woman—and I look identical to her husband... my brother.

As I exhale, I stroke her hair. It's soft and silky and smells like coconut and berries.

Through sobs, she says, "I gave them up. Declan promised I wouldn't have to do this alone—I couldn't do it... I was terrified, and I wanted to die."

Holy shit.

I had no idea things were this bad. Clearly Zahra needs support, but I have nothing to offer? I don't have much money. I don't have a car. Hell, I don't even have a job. I've been living pay check to pay check, travelling the coast on fishing trawlers, picking berries and fruit during the fruit seasons, and doing odd jobs in the towns I pass through before heading back to my mountain hideaway.

My plan was to come here, offer my condolences, maybe stay a couple days, then head back home. Now, the thought of leaving Zahra sends anxiety weaving through my veins. I owe it to my brother to care for her, to make sure his children are safe... I can't leave. Not yet.

In a split second, I make a decision. I'll stay here until I know with certainty Zahra and her children are going to be okay. Then, I'll leave. *Easy done.*

Fate walked up to me one day
And showed me what I'd lost
He's not mine and not this way
But if I choose him what's the cost

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ZAHRA

April 16*2 weeks later*

I wonder what my mother thought when I was born. Did she already know how my life would turn out? Did she know fate would play the cruellest tricks on me? I wonder if she realised the life I would live would be filled with abuse, torture, grief, and never-ending pain. If I was never born, would Cathie be standing in my place right now?

Questions churn in my mind, replaying moments from my past and the dreams I once had for the future. I'm balancing on a precipice once again, caught in the middle of a hurricane that's spinning out of control, threatening to destroy everything I've worked for.

Just when I think everything has finally fallen into place, I realise it's too late; I'm merely standing in the eye of the storm, waiting for it to change directions and force me down to my knees all over again.

Fate must truly hate me.

Why else would it bring my husband back from the dead in the form of a man who looks, smells, talks, and even moves the way Declan did? Maybe this is my second chance. Maybe this is my *final* chance.

With my feet dangling in the water, I twist my wedding band around my finger where it rubs against Declan's wedding band. *I miss you so much, Declan.* When I clamp my eyes shut, I let my mind carry me back to the night he proposed. The night I saw fireworks over this very lake for the first time. A tear falls from my eye as Jaymee's voice interrupts my thoughts.

"He's so much like Declan," she says.

I swallow the lump in my throat and turn to her. "It hurts to look at him," I admit.

She rubs my back and with a heavy sigh, she lowers her voice, "Charles said it might be best if he leaves now... he said he'd tell him to—"

NO! I need to see him. I tilt my head and narrow my eyes. “No. Why would he do that? He’s done nothing wrong, Jaymee. It’s not his fault.”

“But Zar, it’s hurting you. You were doing so well and since he’s—”

I cut her off, raising my voice slightly, “*His* name is Xavier. *He* is Declan’s brother.”

She drops her hand from my back and pulls her legs up to cross them. “All I’m saying is... he—Xavier looks like Declan. You’re still grieving for Declan, maybe it’s best if he’s not around...”

A strange, painful sensation builds in my heart as it beats hard against my ribcage. There’s a lump in my throat I can’t swallow down, and when I scramble back from the edge of the lake to stand, I realise... I am furious.

Glaring at Jaymee, I point a finger at her. “I’m not a child! I don’t need you to tell me how I feel. You’re not me Jaymee! You don’t know what I need, or what I want.” When Jaymee opens her mouth to speak, I ignore her and turn on my heels to run back to the house. In the kitchen, Charles and Jayden are sitting at the table.

Charles leaps from his seat. “Zahra, what’s wrong?”

“Leave me alone!” I shout as I storm to my bedroom and slam the door closed behind me.

Xavier’s been here for two weeks, and although it hurts so much to look at him, I like having him around. I love the sound of his voice and the way his cheeks blush when he smiles. I like having someone to talk about Declan with, someone who hasn’t heard about all the horrible details of my past and still wants to talk to me. Jaymee and Charles, and even Jayden have been constantly reminding me that Xavier isn’t Declan. *As if I don’t know.*

I lie back on my pillow and take my mobile phone off the bedside table wondering what Xavier is doing. He might be at Angela and Ryan’s house. They love having him there and love hearing about his life. I do too, but for the past few days, I feel as though he’s been avoiding me.

I decide to text him.

ME: Hi Xavier, how are you today?

Ten seconds later he replies.

XAVIER: Hey, I'm good, how are you?

ME: I'm okay. Have you seen Angela and Ryan today?

XAVIER: Yeah, I left a few minutes ago. Angela was telling me about the day Ryan proposed to her. LOL!

ME: Declan told me that story the day he proposed to me...

XAVIER: Oh I'm sorry. I didn't mean to upset you.

ME: You didn't upset me. It was one of the best days ever.

XAVIER: Are you sure you're okay? I was going to drop in before I head back to the hotel, but I don't want to if you're not up to it.

ME: That would be great. Are you coming now?

XAVIER: I need to stop by the store, do you need anything?

ME: No thank you. I'll see you soon.

XAVIER: See you in 20

I stand and smooth out my dress before I head out to the kitchen. I'm tired of everyone coming and going from my house as they please. I'm tired of them thinking they know what's best for me. I'm not a child. This is my life and I'm going to live it. Finally.

In the kitchen, Charles looks up at me from where he sits on the sofa beside Jaymee.

Opposite them, Jayden sits on the single seat sofa. I thought Jayden and I were friends, but when Jaymee and Charles told me that he was hoping for more from me, everything became awkward very quickly. Now, the friendship we had before has dwindled away, and I can't look at him without feeling like I've done something horribly wrong.

"Zar, I'm sorry," Jaymee says as she jumps to her feet to hug me.

I shrug before hugging her back. "It's okay. I'm sorry I shouted at you." I turn to the guys. "Xavier's on his way here, so you should probably leave now... since you don't want him around."

Charles stares up at me with his mouth agape before he gets to his feet. "Zar, that's not true. We like him, it's..." he scratches his head. "He's not Declan."

Jayden stands beside him and shoves his hands into his pockets. "We're worried about you, that's all."

I bite my lip playing the words over in my head before I release them into the world where I know I'll never be able to take them back. With an inhale, I close my eyes and imagine Declan beside me, giving me strength. When I open my eyes, Jaymee takes my hand. "Zar, are you okay?"

I nod. "I'm okay. I'd like you to leave now... all of you." Without another word, I go back to my bedroom and close the door before I slump to the floor and cry for the love I lost when Declan died, and the friends who no longer understand me.

* * *

We walk side by side toward the boundary fence of my property where an old timber gate leads toward a path in the forest. Declan and I walked this path many times, often in silence. We would hold hands and listen to the world that surrounded us.

There's a calming peacefulness that comes with Xavier's presence. He listens to me talk, and takes the time to ask questions... like Declan always did. Perhaps because they were identical twins, they have similar personalities. Or maybe it's another way fate has weaved its way through their lives.

"This is beautiful," Xavier says as he raises his head and looks up to the treetops. "I bet Declan loved it here."

His eyes are fixed on the canopy of branches above. He speaks Declan's name as though he's known him all his life, but beneath it I hear the grief he carries for his twin brother.

I kneel to pick up a small, smooth round stone. "He did. We came out here a lot. Is the forest where you live like this one?"

Xavier drops his head and runs his hand down the moss-covered trunk of the tree. "It's a bit more secluded than this... high up on a mountain too. You'd love it. The silence, the sounds of nature, the wind blowing through the trees. It's so peaceful."

"You miss it?"

He nods. "Yeah, I always do. What about you, have you always lived here?"

I bite my lip and drop my head to turn the little stone over in my hands. I trace my finger over its smooth surface. *I can talk about it.* I

haven't had a flashback for almost six months, and the nightmares that plagued me have started to wane. I'm finally taking control. Doctor Marshall always said talking about it would help. And I trust Xavier. *I do.*

"Zahra, are you okay?"

I raise my head, then nod before asking him if he'd like to continue walking. After a few minutes of silence, I let my words tumble out, and surprisingly, I remain calm. "I used to live in another town, but I was—" Trying to find the right words proves difficult.

"You don't have to tell me if you don't want to..." Xavier shoves his hands into his pockets and stops by a large fallen tree. He leans against the broken trunk and tilts his head. "If I'm asking something too personal, let me know."

I shake my head, still turning the stone in my hands. "No... it's okay. I ah... This is the first time I've talked about it to another..."

"To someone other than Declan?" he asks.

I shrug. "I was sexually abused when I was a child, until I was seventeen. That's when I was rescued by Eli, he works for Hearts of Innocence."

Xavier pulls his hands from his pockets and rubs them down his thighs. "I'm so sorry... that must be hard to talk about. Hearts of Innocence... Is that like a child protection agency?"

I tuck a strand of hair behind my ear before I nod. "They rescue children—girls—from sex trafficking and sex slavery rings. My ah..." I inhale and press my hands to my chest to calm my racing heart. *I can do this.* I'm braver now. Stronger.

Xavier's face softens and the sparkle of unshed tears well in his eyes. "Please don't talk about it if you can't, Zahra. I'm sor—"

I drop my hands. "I need to. I think..." One deep breath. Then another. "My father and brother used me for sex and my father sold me to other men... It started when I was a little girl." I swallow hard. "I thought it was normal, until I knew it wasn't. Eli was working undercover when he purchased me. He had come to rescue me. Then he brought me here, and that's when I met Declan."

I clench my fist around the stone as though it's giving me strength. "Charles called it a fairy tale." I smile as I recall Charles telling me about their camping trip the day after I arrived in Rockburn Grove. "I was the girl

who lost all hope, and he was the boy who saved my life. I loved him... God, I loved him more than life itself."

When tears spring to my eyes, Xavier extends his hand. "Zahra, can I hug you? Is that okay?"

I nod, take his hand and let Declan's twin brother envelope me in a warm, gentle hug that melds my broken pieces together. "Thank you for listening..."

He rubs my back but doesn't say a single word for long silent minutes, until he whispers through a strangled sob, "I'll protect you... for Declan."

When Xavier steps back, he scrubs his hands down his face and extends his hand. "Should we keep walking?"

"I'd like that."

In the middle of the forest is a small wooden bench seat where we sit down and take in the view. Canopies of leafy green trees hover above us while the ground is covered in soft ferns and moss-covered rocks. The scent of eucalypts and damp soil lingers, reminding me of the life the forest breathes into the world. Many times, I've sat in this exact spot taking in the beauty of the life flourishing on the outskirts of Rockburn Grove.

"Are they in prison?" Xavier asks. "The people who hurt you?"

"Not all of them. Eli said my father and brother are still on the run. Some men were caught, and some girls have been rescued too... Xavier..."

"Yeah?"

"I'm not supposed to talk about anything that happened... I mean, I'm here in Rockburn Grove for my own protection. You won't—" I sigh. I shouldn't have told Xavier anything, but a tiny voice inside my head tells me to spill all my secrets to this man I barely know.

He places his hand over mine on the bench seat between us. "I won't mention it, you have my word." Xavier squeezes my hand and a tiny smile tugs at the corner of my lips.

"Will you tell me some more about your cabin?" I ask curiously. From what Xavier has told me so far, it sounds like a piece of heaven right here on earth.

His smile is wide, and he leans back on the seat and relaxes. "Imagine a place in the middle of nowhere, surrounded by the tallest trees

you've ever seen, and waterfalls that run into rivers and streams beside lush green grassy river banks. Everything is alive and thriving."

My eyes are wide as I imagine the sights, the sounds, and smells.
"It's always green?"

He nods. "Always. There's none of the pollution you'd see or smell in a big city either, it's all fresh, clean air. You should come see it one day... you're always welcome."

I drop my head. I can't leave Rockburn Grove or the safety of my friends and my family. I can't leave my babies.

I can't leave Declan.

Xavier must sense my apprehension because he changes the subject. "What was Declan like, to you, Zahra?" His eyes meet mine. Deep blue eyes that hold so much hope and longing.

"He was gentle... kind, loving. He cared about everyone, and everything. He hated seeing people in pain or knowing that someone needed help and he couldn't fix it or help them." I let a smile dance across my lips as I remember Declan with tears in my eyes, and love in my heart. "He saved me, so many times he saved me by reminding me that I wasn't alone in the world. Everything he did was with purpose. Every touch, every kiss, every word held the promise of everlasting love." With a heavy sigh I close my eyes and raise my head to the sky. Tears dribble down my face. "He loved me." The words escape as though I never understood them until this very moment. But in my heart, I always knew. *Declan loved me.*

Xavier leans forward and rests his elbows on his knees. "I wish I'd found him sooner. I wish... Damn. He shouldn't have died." He gets to his feet and paces toward the huge tree. When he shakes his head, he kicks the toe of his boot into the earth. "I should have tried harder." He paces back and forth, his fists clenched by his sides and his hair a mess from him running his hands through it so many times. "I fucked up! He was my brother and I didn't protect him... I wasn't here for him."

When Xavier drops to his knees and lets out a groan of pain mingled with a shrill cry of defeat, I jump to my feet and rush over, dropping to my knees in front of him. I've never seen a man so broken, so lost... and in so much pain. I have to help him. Declan would help him.

I take his hands in mine and squeeze them tight. “Xavier, you didn’t know. You couldn’t have known what would happen. But I promise you... I promise you with all my heart, Declan loved you. He felt like a part of him was missing. He knew he had a brother, and he was getting ready to search for you again.”

He raises his head, his eyes red rimmed and filled with tears. “I loved him. I never met him, but I loved him. He was my broth—” When Xavier breaks down sobbing, I shuffle forward and wrap my arms around his shoulders. His tears of sorrow and grief for the brother he so desperately wanted to know, break my heart.

“It’s okay... you’re allowed to cry...” I whisper as I run my fingers through his soft, dark hair. “He loved you too, Xavier,” I remind him again. Closing my eyes, I press my cheek to his. “It will be okay. We will be okay.”

Five minutes later, Xavier has stopped crying and I realise quickly, I’ve been the one to comfort someone else. I *am* stronger now. And I will look after Xavier... *for Declan*. I have to.

Xavier and I lean against the trunk of the giant mountain ash, sitting on the grass, hand in hand in complete silence. We don’t talk. We don’t move. And for a fleeting moment, I forget to breathe when right in front of us, a swarm of bright blue butterflies flit in a cyclone of magnificent wings, before they take to the sky and disappear into the treetops.

I stare up at the sky in awe. *Is it a sign... from Declan?*

I close my eyes and whisper to the wind, “I will love you forever.”

Beside me, another whisper breaks the silence. “Me too,” Xavier says. “Forever.”

A smile graced her lips once
For a fleeting moment in time
And above the heavens I heard a voice
She will always be mine

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XAVIER**October 2**

Two months ago, to my complete surprise, Zahra asked me to move in with her. She said it was pointless using my hard-earned money on a hotel when she had a huge house all to herself. I jumped at the chance but assured her it was only because I didn't like the thought of her being alone all day and night.

Charles was furious and tried to put a stop to it, but when Zahra threatened to never speak to him again, he quickly changed his tune. I understand he lost his best friend, and to him, I appear as an intruder in his world. But the tension is getting to me. I've never had to deal with these emotions before and they're taking some getting used to.

The more time I spend with Zahra, the more I get to know her. I notice all the little things, like the way she has to have everything just right, and the way she points out every flaw she thinks she has as though the world can see them through a microscope. I have no idea why she is this way, but for unexplained reasons, I want to know everything about the woman my brother loved.

Jaymee has been a wealth of information and loves Zahra as though she's her sister. Declan's parent's, Angela and Ryan have welcomed me into their home with open arms.

Guilt weighs heavily on my chest when I see them, and when I see the pictures that adorn their walls. Ryan told me that Angela believes she's been given a second chance with me, although he was quick to say Declan is irreplaceable.

On my first visit with them, we spent hours sorting through photographs while Zahra recalled stories of their time together, and Ryan spared no details when he laughed, cried and smiled as he told me about their monthly camping trips. My brother was loved beyond anything I can

ever imagine. He was their world, their son, their child. He was Zahra's whole life.

Six months have passed, and it feels like I've been here forever. I find myself drawn to Zahra more and more with each passing day. I'm yet to meet her children, but I've seen hundreds of photographs and heard all about them from Angela and Ryan who visit them weekly. Zahra on the other hand, didn't say much about them at all, but I noticed her eyes welled with tears whenever Angela mentioned their names.

Since I arrived in Rockburn Grove, the town's people have been more than welcoming. Ryan—much to Charles' disgust—has given me a job at Foxx & Son as a delivery driver. I'm on my way to building myself a little nest egg which I'll use to extend my cottage in the mountains. I've told Zahra all about it and told her she's welcome to visit anytime. The silence that ensued leads me to believe she'll never wander far from this town and the people who love her.

I sit on the edge of the double bed in the guest room and stretch my arms before I open the drapes to reveal the sun shining across the lake at the back of the house. I pull on a pair of shorts and head to the kitchen to make a coffee. While I'm waiting for the coffee machine to finish, I glance over at the door to Zahra's bedroom. It's open a crack, so I walk over and knock lightly before I peek in to see if she's awake.

She's lying face down on the bed. The white sheet twisted around her thigh and over her back. The coffee machine beeps and when I turn to walk back to the kitchen, I hear a strangled sob.

Hesitating, I place my hand on the door frame. *Should I go in, or leave her?* Many times now, I've comforted her during her tears, but never in her bed, and never when she was barely clothed. That's a line I'm not prepared to cross without Zahra making the first move. I'm sure she's aware that my feelings for her have grown immensely over the past few months. But I've made a promise to myself. I won't act on those feelings unless I'm positive it's what Zahra wants.

"Zahra," I whisper from the doorway.

Her sobs grow louder. Maybe it's my voice that pushed her further over the edge. If only I could change it.

I take a step forward. The first step I've ever taken into the bedroom my brother shared with his wife. The stories I've heard about their love remind me of the fairy tales my mother read to me when I was young. Declan was Zahra's saviour. I can't imagine a love so pure and so strong.

Everywhere I turn, there's someone reminding me of how much Declan loved Zahra. From the old lady at the hotel where I stayed when I arrived, to the staff at Foxx & Son who at first, avoided me. Later, I realised I was trying just as hard to avoid them. When people speak to me now, I'm always referred to as "Declan Foxx's brother". It doesn't bother me at all. I'm proud of my brother's achievements, and grateful to have been welcomed into his community.

"Zahra, are you okay?"

Another sob.

I pace across the plush white carpet to the side of the bed. On the wall above the bedhead is a huge framed photograph of Declan and Zahra kissing at their wedding. She's wearing a sparkling tiara and her hand rests on Declan's shoulder showing off a stunning pink diamond ring. On the side wall are two frames. Each one holds a picture of their children as tiny babies. The photographs are like carbon copies, there's not one difference.

I place a hand on the very edge of the bed. The white satin sheet is cool beneath my fingertips, and the top sheet is bunched up and twisted beneath Zahra's slim, pale body. My eyes follow her thigh where scar after scar trails all the way down to her calf muscle.

When she moves slightly, I catch a fleeting glimpse of her white, lace underwear. I quickly avert my eyes to focus on her back where five long, thick scars mar her bare flesh. *Who hurt her that way?* There's still so much I want to ask her.

Sitting on the bed, I reach out and place a hand on Zahra's shoulder. "Zahra, do you want to talk?"

She sighs heavily and rolls over, pulling the white satin sheet with her. I catch a glimpse of her pale breast and rosy pink nipple, enough to stir something inside me. *Not the time. Not the place.* I shake my head to clear my thoughts.

Zahra opens her deep brown eyes and stares up at me through dark lashes. Her tear stained cheeks are pink, and her lips are full and slightly parted. I imagine my brother would have relished every moment he spent

with her. He would have worshipped her and cherished the mornings he got to wake up and gaze into her pretty brown eyes.

I wonder what true happiness would look like on her, how her cheeks would blush as she smiles, or laughs. The photographs I've seen of Zahra don't do her justice. In reality, she is the most beautiful woman I have ever seen. Admittedly, I haven't *seen* many women in the flesh, but I know Zahra is gorgeous.

When she doesn't reply, I ask, "Coffee?" There's not another word I can find that will get me out of her bedroom and away from her berries and coconut scent, and the knowledge she is near naked beneath the white satin sheets.

"I miss him so much." A tear trickles from her eye.

"I know, and I'm so sorry. I wish I could bring him back, I truly do, Zahra."

I wish I had known him.

She stretches her legs out and pulls the sheet to her chin. Through the soft satin, her nipples appear. I scold myself again. *Not the time. Not the place.*

"Would you lay with me?" she asks. "For a minute?"

No! Shouldn't. Won't. "Yes." The confusion running rampant in my mind is something I've never felt before. "No" was on the tip of my tongue, but the "Yes" forced its way through without my permission. My inexperience with females is playing havoc with my emotions. And with Zahra's fragile state I'm careful not to push her away. In fact, if I'm completely honest, I want her closer, and this could mean the end, for both of us.

Swallowing the lump in my throat, I lie beside her and stare at the ceiling until Zahra laces her fingers through mine.

She takes them up to her lips and kisses my fingertips before whispering, "Thank you, for being here, Xavier. For being my friend."

Friend. That's all. I turn my head, nervous apprehension coils in the pit of my stomach. My heart hammers beneath my ribcage and my breath is caught in my throat. When I finally find the words, I stutter. "Y—you're welcome." I clamp my eyes shut. *You're welcome? That's the best you've got?*

Zahra snuggles up closer and wraps her arms around my bicep. “You smell like him, you know. Declan wore the same cologne.”

Shock takes over. Another little bombshell has been dropped. I had no idea, but strangely, I find the information like a reminder I was never alone. I always had another half, another one like me.

She lifts her head and presses her cheek to my chest. I’m positive she can feel my heart racing. When her bare leg brushes against my thigh, all I want to do is get up and run. She needs me though, and according to Angela, Zahra hasn’t shown affection to anyone since Declan’s death. I’m doing this for her. *I remind her of him.*

Fighting against my thoughts, I run my fingers down her spine; goose bumps appear on her skin. *But she likes my touch?* I stroke her hair and twirl thick strands through my fingers, but when she lifts her head slightly and breathes against my jaw, the familiar ache returns, and I wish it away. If I can just lie beside her and comfort her... make her feel safe...

It’s no use.

I’m half naked, and in bed with my brother’s widow who is in her underwear. Right now, all I want to do is hold her and kiss her sweet pink lips.

As if she’s read my mind, she presses her lips against mine. Lingering beside my mouth for an achingly long moment. “Thank you,” she whispers again.

I open my mouth to speak, but instead my tongue glides across her lips.

She returns the favour with a gentle lick before our tongues fight for a place in one another’s mouths. Suddenly, I’m overcome with ardent desire as I pull her body onto mine and our lips clash with glorious passion.

I slide my hands down her waist and over the swell of her ass where I grip it gently with both hands and raise my hips toward her. Her fingers tangle through my hair and her breaths are erratic. Little moans heat me to the core.

She moves on me, slowly as first, then with desperation as I remove the sheet from between us and toss it aside. Eyes ablaze with passion, she looks down at me, “Please,” she begs.

I know what she wants, but I have no idea how to give it to her. Feeling as useless as a virginal teenage boy who’s just seen his first pair of

breasts, I freeze. Of course, I'm not *totally* clueless. Although I've never been with a female, I've read a lot, and heard a bit from a few mates and some guys I've worked with over the years.

What if I let Zahra lead me? Does she expect me to lead her? *What the hell do I do?*

The unanswered questions are almost as distracting as Zahra writhing on top of me, causing my dick to harden with each sensual movement of her soft, pale body.

Decision made. I go with my instincts and let my body, and Zahra's, guide me as I hook my fingers over her lace underwear and push them down. She kicks them off while I struggle to push my shorts down. When they're off, and my dick is free, Zahra spreads her legs over me.

She leans down and smothers my face in rapturous kisses I return with full force. When she moans quietly, I take it as a sign I'm doing everything right.

"You feel so good," I breathe the words against her ear. I rock my hips toward her, and her warmth envelopes me. She's so soft, so wet, and so, so, beautiful.

With a slow backward movement, she slides onto me and moans in pleasure. "You too," her voice, a whisper that caresses my lips.

At the same time, I groan. *Why did I wait so long for this?* Is Zahra why? Did fate play a part in our meeting? I don't know, but I can't imagine anything surpassing the pleasure I'm feeling right now. I need more of her... *want* more of her.

I roll over, still clinging to Zahra as I prop myself up on my elbows. One thrust, then another.

Deeper.

She spreads her legs wider.

Harder.

Fingernails dig into my shoulders. "Xav..."

Faster.

A moan. Another groan.

Suddenly, Zahra screams and pushes me off. "NO! No, no, no! Leave me alone."

I sit back on my heels and raise my hands to let her move away from me before I jump off the bed, pull on my shorts and step back against the

wall. "I'm sorry, Zahra. I'm so sorry." *What have I done?* I hate myself and I'm not even sure why yet. *She wanted it?* She didn't say no?

I squeeze my eyes shut and scrub my hands down my face. She didn't say no... Did she? Was I too caught up in the moment that I didn't hear her tell me to stop? *What have I done?*

When I open my eyes, Zahra is curled up in a ball on the side of the bed. "Declan," she screams. "Declan, please... help me."

Tears well in my own eyes as I sit on the opposite side of the bed. "Zahra, I'm so, so sorry. Please, let me help you," I beg.

Her screams drown out my voice.

Thoughts pound in my head causing an ache to bloom across my forehead. Regret and guilt coil in the pit of my stomach. I should have said no. I should have stayed out of the bedroom.

I should have stayed out of her life.

It's all too late.

I'm already in love with my brother's widow.

Love was taken from me
The rain clouds stole my smile
But one day I found the stars again
This time I'll stay a while

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ZAHRA

October 16*2 weeks later*

I arrive home from my visit with my children to find Xavier packing his bags. Terror envelops me. He can't leave. *No*. Not after everything that's happened between us. Not after I shared my secrets with him and told him about Declan.

He can't leave. Not now that I've fallen in—Wait... *Love? Xavier?*

No. Yes! *Oh, Zahra, what have you done?*

The front door is still open wide as I stand in the living room with my handbag over my shoulder, and a small paper bag in my hand. "Xavier, what's going on?"

When he looks up at me, he doesn't smile. *Did I break him too?*

"I ah, well I think it's time I leave, Zahra. I've put you through so much pain and I can never fix it or make it better. I'm so sorry, I want you to be happy again, and me... my voice... my looks." He shakes his head. "It's not fair. I'm hurting you every day."

I step forward and drop my handbag on the floor at my feet. Desperation laces every word. "Xavier, you can't leave. Don't leave, please."

He paces toward me. My hand—still holding the small paper bag—trembles. In it is a gift for him, and now it's going to be ruined. *It's all your fault*. Voices swarm in my mind. *You ruined Declan. Now, you've ruined Xavier, too.*

If I didn't get pregnant, Declan wouldn't have died.

If he didn't die, I wouldn't have fallen in love with Xavier.

And if I didn't fall in love with Xavier, I wouldn't be standing here in my living room, on the verge of tears, holding a gift I spent four hours choosing.

He places his hands on my hips. It's where I want him. I want him here. I want him everywhere. I want to share stories about Declan with someone who cares, someone who understands the way I loved him.

I want Xavier. Tell him, Zahra. Tell him before it's too late.

Xavier speaks before I get the chance. "Zahra, I'm sorry. I didn't come here with the intention of falling in love with you. I didn't come here to hurt you or to take you away from Declan or his memory. I couldn't help it. You were like a breath of fresh air to me, someone new. Someone with a connection to my past. Somehow along the way, over a few short months, I fell in love with you. It's not what you want, or what you need right now and that's why I have to leave."

He can't leave. I can't let him go, not now, not ever. My heart has already enveloped him. "No." I shake my head and place my hands on his chest. "Xavier, please don't do this. Give me another chance. Let me explain everything. Let me tell you why I can't give you what I want to give. Let me show you my scars and tell you all *my* stories. Please Xavier, let me love you. I want to love you. I *do* love you. I love you so much, and I'll die if I lose someone else."

"You love me?" he questions.

He takes my hands and I nod. The reality of my own words send tendrils of anxiety through my chest and into my heart. Declan will always be my first love, and the one who saved me from the world, but Xavier is an exhilarating breath of fresh air and a glimmer of hope.

"Yes. I love you, Xavier. Please... don't leave."

"You love me?" he asks again, his cheeks slightly pink, and his eyebrows bunched together.

I smile. The first true smile I've had for such a long, long time, and it feels good. My cheeks feel good. My lips feel good. And finally, my heart feels good again.

"You're smiling," he says, beaming.

I bite my lip nervously. *He doesn't love me?* No. Those voices aren't real.

Real is the man standing in front of me. The man I adore.

His thumb touches my chin and he pulls my lip from my teeth. "You are so beautiful, Zahra."

My cheeks blush and I drop my gaze until Xavier lifts my head slightly and looks into my eyes. “*You are beautiful,*” he says again, and he presses his lips to mine.

For long minutes we stay embraced in a passionate, gentle kiss.

“Your gift!” I shout, breaking our kiss. I pick the bag up off the floor and hand it to him.

“What is it?” he asks.

I laugh and my cheeks heat. “It’s a gift... a surprise. Open it.”

Xavier opens the bag to take out the small box that sits in the bottom. When he unties the black ribbon, my hands shoot up to my mouth. “I hope you like it,” I murmur nervously through my hands.

He opens the box and stares down at the thick silver ring.

I swallow hard. *He doesn’t like it?*

Taking it out of the box, he turns it between his fingers before he brings it up to read the inscription I had engraved around the band. Before he can read the words out loud, I take the ring and slide it onto his finger, turning it as I whisper, “My hope. My Love. My Life.”

Tears well in his eyes as he pulls me into his arms and holds me tight against his chest. “I love you so damn much, sweetheart.”

“And *I* love you, Xavier.”

* * *

XAVIER

4 hours later

“This one,” I ask, tracing the scar across her shoulder.

“A chain. My father punished me with it.” While anger builds inside me, I focus on Zahra’s soft, pale flesh. I follow the curve of her breast down to the centre of her belly where a long scar stretches across it. “This one,” I whisper, kissing her neck.

“He... A friend of my father. I wouldn’t keep still so he used a knife.”

I trail kisses down her belly and over her lace underwear, stopping inside her thigh to plant a gentle kiss over the myriad of thin scars.

“These?”

She traces her finger over the scars and speaks quietly. "I did them myself. I thought if I was bleeding and scarred, they wouldn't touch me. I was wrong."

I take her hand and rub my thumb over the scars on her wrist. "You did these too?"

"Mmhmm... I tried a few times... to ki—I wanted to die. Do they disgust you?"

Never. "Not at all. You're perfect to me." I move up onto her again, resting on my elbows and knees as I run my fingers across the scars on her neck.

She lowers her voice as though someone might hear her. "Some men put collars on me. Some used rope, or their hands." She raises her hand and rubs a small round scar with her fingertip. "My brother did this with a cigarette. He wanted to see if I could keep quiet while he hurt me."

"I hate them for hurting you," I tell her.

"Declan did too."

"What happened when you got here, to Rockburn Grove?"

I sit back on the bed and Zahra shuffles over to sit between my legs. Her back is hard against my chest where my heart is beating furiously. First with love for Zahra, second with rage for what has happened to her. I pull her hair to the side and kiss her neck.

She drops her head back and raises her hand to cup my cheek.

"Eli took me to Housing Hope first. Declan was there. He showed me around and talked to me. We had cupcakes in the attic where he showed me the view of the city. He talked to me like I was a normal girl. He treated me like I was a person, not a slave who was born to be sold to the highest bidder. I was never afraid of him."

"Did you love him right away?" I run my fingers up and down her arms and kiss her neck again. I'll never get enough of her.

"I'm not sure if it was love at first, or if I was desperate for someone to understand me. To care about me, properly. But it wasn't long before I realised I loved him. I was confused though. I grew up believing love was a mixture of torture, abuse, sex, and punishment. I truly believed my father loved me... my brother too. Zahra... Eli's Zahra, she helped me understand the difference between love and abuse."

“Zahra Cole? Wow... That must have been a weird coincidence having the same name.”

She lets out a heavy sigh. “Xavier...” she gets to her knees and turns around to face me. “When I got here, I was given a new identity. For my own protection.”

My heart breaks for her. What she’s endured sounds like something from a horrific horror movie. “Zahra’s not your real name?”

She shakes her head, then leans across to pull out a small black pouch from her top drawer. Her hands shake as she opens it.

I put my hands around hers. “You don’t have to do this, Zahra. I will love you no matter what.”

“I want to,” she says. “Please... I need to.” I nod as she opens the pouch and tips the contents into her hand. In her palm, rests a large silver locket attached to a necklace. She clamps her eyes shut, counts to ten slowly, then opens them again. “I’ll be okay,” she whispers.

She opens the locket to reveal two young children. A little boy, and a little girl. It’s obvious they’re twins by their little button noses and matching, deep brown eyes.

When she turns it over, the inscription on the back says the children’s names are Carlie and Trystan. “It’s you and your brother?”

“Yes.” She closes the locket and clenches her fist around it. “That’s how old I was when my father started...” She drops the locket back into the bag. “I wanted to make him happy... I wanted him...” She shakes her head hard. “No. He didn’t love me. It wasn’t love.”

For a moment, she seems caught in her thoughts, so instead of interrupting her, I hold her hands and wait until her eyes meet mine again. When they do, I say, “I love you, Zahra.”

A hint of a smile plays across her pretty lips. “I had a little sister.” Tears well in her eyes.

I hope my surprise doesn’t show. *Had...?* “You did?”

“Cathie. She was twelve years old when she died... I miss her so much.”

While her tears fall, I wipe them away with my thumbs. “Did they kill...?” I’m not sure I want to know, but I need to ask.

“My father used to give her drugs to make her sleep so she wouldn’t scream when they picked her up. She died from an overdose, but she had

been bleeding internally and had been beaten and raped by—She was only a little girl. I wish she'd survived.”

I pull her into my arms and rub her back as she cries into my shoulder. “I’m sorry... You’re so brave to have endured so much tragedy and still be here. I’m in awe of you, Zahra.”

She lifts her head, still crying. “Xavier, I want my babies back now,” she cries. “I’m ready to be a mother... to bring them home.”

I stroke her hair as she rests her head on my shoulder. “Then we will get them back.”

Storm clouds have finally parted
Sunshine was always meant to be
I've never been more certain
I want you home with me

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ZAHRA**November 1**

Everything is organised. Today I will bring my babies home. But while I'm standing at the front door of the foster carers house, guilt plays havoc with my emotions. Now that I'm finally getting my life back together, I'm suddenly anxious about all the things that could go wrong.

"What if I hurt them?" I say to Xavier for the third time this morning.

He takes my hand and rubs his thumb over the back of it. "You won't hurt them. You love them the way children are supposed to be loved."

With a heavy sigh, I knock on the door and wait.

When it opens, Martha greets us with a welcoming smile. "Come in, come in." We follow her into the living room where two small suitcases are packed by the sofa. On top of them are matching plush white blankets and two white teddy bears. The same teddy bears Declan and I bought for them before they made their way into this world.

I've come so far since then. Every day is a new beginning and another chance to prove to myself that I'm no longer a scared little girl. Charles spent a weekend working on Declan's old convertible, and now that I have my driver's licence, I can drive it around. I've even been visiting Jaymee during the day, and I've made the thirty-minute trip to Eli and Zahra's house a few times.

The rest of my days are spent gardening, reading and writing, or spending time with Xavier, who always manages to make me smile, and get me outside to enjoy the sunshine. He's been taking me hiking around the forests surrounding Rockburn Grove every weekend, and I've shown him the bike paths Declan and I used to ride when we were teenagers.

I chat quietly for a few minutes to Martha when suddenly a loud screech fills the air.

“Mumma!” Jacob toddles toward me, his little face a picture of happiness. I kneel to hug him, and when I look past him, Abby is standing with her hands clasped in front of her. Jacob is definitely more like Declan, and Abby is like me. Shy and reserved. While I cuddle Jacob, I look over to Abby. “Hello sweetheart.”

She smiles. “Mummy...”

I nod and extend my arm, and with that, she runs toward me then drops her little head to my shoulder and cries. “Aww, Abby what’s wrong?”

Martha whispers, “Overwhelmed. She’s missed you, she’s been asking for you constantly for the past few days.”

Jacob jumps up and points to Xavier. “Dadda!”

My heart breaks for Jacob, and for Xavier. He made it clear he didn’t want to take Declan’s place, but because Martha and Joel have spent so much time talking to the twins about Declan, they can’t tell the difference between him and Xavier.

Xavier picks up Jacob and roughs up his hair. “Hey mate. It’s Xavier, can you say that?”

“Daaa dia.”

Xavier laughs, and I turn my attention back to Abby, holding her little hands tight in mine. “I love you,” I say.

She presses her lips to mine then giggles. “Luv ooo mummy.” Looking into her eyes, I catch a glimpse of the little girl I used to be long before evil stole away my tiny smile. Surely my mother loved me. *She must have.* How could anyone look into eyes of purity and innocence and hate what they see in them?

The next few hours pass with a delicious lunch and tea in the back garden. The children play in a little sandpit shaped like a turtle and run around the yard picking flowers they sort between me and Xavier.

Jacob walks over to me rubbing his eyes, a few steps behind him, Abby is rubbing hers too. “Home, Mumma?” Jacob asks.

Abby runs over and drops her head on my lap, crying. “No go home Mummy... Mummy no go...”

I pick her up and hold her against my chest. “Not without you, Abby. You’re coming home with me today. Do you want to come home now?”

She nods, then points to Martha. “Ma Ma?”

Martha smiles and gets up to hug the twins. "I'll see you soon. It's time to go home with Mummy and Xavier now."

Tears fall from her eyes, but she doesn't wipe them away. When I stand to hug her, she wraps her arms tight around me and whispers against my ear. "You can do this. And if you need anything at all, you call me right away. No matter the time, okay?" I nod, crying.

"Thank you for caring for them... It means the world to me."

"No need for thank yous. It was my pleasure."

* * *

XAVIER

By the time we arrive home, the twins are fast asleep. Zahra unbuckles Abby and carries her inside. I lift Jacob into my arms then lock the car and follow her in. After we put the babies in their new beds, I look down at Jacob. There's no mistaking he's Declan's son, and he could pass for my son, but it breaks my heart when he calls me daddy and doesn't understand why it's wrong.

"I'm so worried, Xavier. Do you think it's normal to be this worried?"

I have no idea what to tell her. Before I arrived here, I'd never seen a baby, let alone held one. So far though, I've done well. "We can do it, I'll help you. Tell me what you need."

"Declan used to say that," she says. "We can do it. I'll help you." She sighs and walks out of the room.

I follow her out and sit on the sofa beside her. "Did you always know you had a twin brother?" she asks.

Resentment creeps into my heart. My parents loved me, and I was wanted. Of that I was certain. But their mistakes meant I would lose my brother, forever. "When I was ten, my parents told me I was adopted. My mum was a nurse at the hospital where I was—where we—were born. It wasn't until after they died that I found out the truth."

"The truth?" Zahra questions.

With a heavy sigh, I explain. "My parents were waiting on a baby to be born. They'd been waiting almost five years and had given up hope of

ever having a family of their own. Mum worked as a maternity nurse, and Dad was a surgeon.”

“They took you from the hospital?”

“They did—” I scrub my hands down my face. “There was a letter. It was given to me by my father’s friend not long after they died. It was from my mum. I wanted to show Declan, to let him know that it wasn’t his fault, or mine. To prove to him that we were torn apart before we had a chance to form a bond.”

“You have it here?”

I nod. “Do you want to read it?”

She pulls her legs up onto the sofa and takes my hand. “Not if it’s going to hurt you.”

I lean forward and press a kiss to her forehead before I get the letter from the bedroom. When I return, I hand Zahra the envelope and she opens it slowly. “Is it really sad?” she asks.

“Yeah, it is. They lied to me for so long. I was taken away from my brother and thrust into a life without him... I knew it, Zar. I always knew something was missing, even when I was a little kid.”

Sitting beside Zahra, I twist my fingers through her hair as she reads the letter out loud.

“My darling son, Xavier. There is so much I want to tell you, so much I need to say. But whenever I sit down with you and look into your bright blue eyes, I’m speechless. You brought joy into a life that was slowly unravelling at the seams. You gave us hope, and you gave me a purpose.”

My heart beats hard against my chest as Zahra continues. “Your birth mother showed up at the hospital shortly after midnight, alone and only hours away from giving birth. A young girl, no family, no friends. She refused to give us her name and had nothing but the tiny life inside her belly. It was a small hospital, only a couple of nurses on duty, and your father who’d been called into surgery. I rushed to get the girl into a bed and bring her baby safely into the world, but quickly found out there wasn’t just one baby, but two. Two precious little boys who entered the world on a cold, dark April night. That night, your father and I made a split-second decision that would change our lives.”

Zahra breathes out a sigh as a tear falls from her eye. She swipes it away, still looking down at the letter in her hands. “We were desperate, and this was our chance to have the baby we’d always dreamed of. My darling, Xavier, we never meant to take you away from your twin brother, we never imagined you’d ever feel anything but love and happiness with us. But as you grew up, it was clear something was always missing. Another piece of your heart we had removed from existence and hoped to fill with only our love.”

“They stole you... Xavier, they stole you from your mum, from your brother.” Zahra cries, but doesn’t stop reading through her tears. “I’m so sorry for the pain we caused you. For the lies we told, and for the moments you lost with your brother. As soon as you’re ready, we will help you find your twin, and we will do everything in our power to reunite you.” She stops reading and folds the piece of paper in half. “Were they good to you?”

I swallow hard, then nod. “They were the best parents I could have asked for. I never wanted for anything, never wondered if I was enough, or if they loved me.”

“Do you know who your mother is—was?”

“No. At the end of that letter, Mum says she put a picture of me and my brother in an envelope, with his birth certificate. Apparently, the other couple—Angela and Ryan obviously—were told I wasn’t suitable for adoption.”

Zahra nods. “That’s all they were told, but it never stopped them trying. They searched for you for so, so long.” She places the letter on the coffee table, then wraps her arms around my neck to hug me. “I’m sorry, Xavier. I wish they hadn’t done that to you.” A soft kiss caresses my lips and I pull her onto my lap.

Straddling my legs, she cups my cheeks with her hands. “Are you still angry?” she asks.

“Not anymore. Just... sad I suppose. There’s nothing I can do to change it now. It’s all too late.”

Twisting her fingers through my hair, she whispers against my ear. “I love you, Xavier, always.”

She wriggles closer, her breasts pressed against my chest. I wrap my arms around her waist and trace my fingers up and down her spine as I kiss her neck. “Zah, can I ask you something... personal?”

She nods. "Of course, anything at all."

"When you were with Declan, I mean in bed together, what made it...? Well... I guess what I'm asking is how can I...?" My words are all wrong, but Zahra smiles.

"It took a long time. At first, we held and touched one another. I guess Declan figured out what worked before I knew myself. He was good like that, he understood everything I wasn't saying." She gasps and covers her mouth. "Oh Xavier, I don't mean you're not good. Oh my gosh, I'm so sorry. Have I ruined everything?" She places her hands on my chest. Unshed tears well in her eyes.

"Hey babe, it's okay. I'm not upset. I want to know how to make you happy, how to make you smile; how to please you." I explain.

She closes her eyes and counts to ten. "I'm sorry I'm so emotional." Her quiet laugh causes my heart to skip a beat. *I love her!* "He was always slow. Always gentle, and he always reminded me I could say no at any time and he wouldn't be upset with me."

Now I'm getting somewhere. Now I understand what she needs. She needs to know that she has control. I won't take that from her, I refuse to force her into anything.

She drops her hands and laces her fingers through mine. "We could try again..." Her cheeks blush pink and she bites her lip.

"Now?" I ask.

She nods. "I'd like that."

Enthralled by the beauty
I found in your eyes
Safe and sound now, my darling
You can drop your disguise

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XAVIER

December 31*30 seconds to midnight*

There are no words to describe the love and adoration I have for Zahra Foxx. I am completely and utterly enthralled by her. Perhaps it's because I've spent so much time alone that I've finally realised life is so much better when you have someone to share it with. Sometimes, I like to believe Zahra was made for me, and it was only a matter of time before we found one another.

"It's almost time," she whispers in my ear before her fingertips trace my lips.

Taking in her beauty, I smile. The glow of her pale skin beneath the fairy lights that adorn the gazebo in the back garden, makes her appear ethereal. She is so beautiful.

Beneath us, a huge pink blanket and all the pillows from our bed. The bed we now share. *Everything is perfect.* I check my watch. "Thirty seconds," I say

She climbs over me and straddles my thighs before she laces her fingers through mine. "And at midnight, we kiss?" she asks.

I nod. "It's going to be our thing. The start of our new lives."

She smiles and her eyes light up. "The start of something beautiful —"

She's cut off by the voices across the other side of the lake. Sparklers dot the darkness with a glittering orange glow as the shouting grows louder. "Five. Four. Three. Two. One!"

Cheers erupt in the distance. "HAPPY NEW YEAR!"

As our lips meet, I pull her closer. Fireworks explode into the midnight sky, lighting up the night and filling the world with showering sparks. Her lips—pressed against mine—send electrifying bursts of pleasure through my body. Her fingers glide up my arms and over my

shoulders until she threads them through my hair and releases a tiny moan. “I want you, please, Xavier.” The way she pleads for my touch causes an ache in the pit of my stomach.

She rocks into me and through breathless moans, she pushes her hand between us and rubs my dick. “Love... you—” Her words are cut off by my desperate kiss and an almost carnal desire to be inside her.

“Should we go inside?” she whispers before nibbling at my earlobe.

Since we’ve been together—properly—Zahra has been more open and willing to talk about what she wants and needs. And the best part about it is, I don’t need to guess anymore, because the way her body beseeches me, tells me everything I need to know.

“We could stay here,” I say. I slide my hands up under her dress and grip her ass with my hands before I pull her closer.

Even beneath the fairy lights, I see the pink blush in her cheeks.

“Could we?” she whispers.

I laugh. “Sweetheart, there’s no one else here. No one will hear us or see us.”

When she moves against me, I slide my hand between her legs and into her underwear. Her breaths grow heavier and the rise and fall of her chest sets my heart racing. I slowly, gently, slip one finger inside her, and she gasps, still rocking her hips toward me.

I slide my finger in and out, each time going a little deeper until she’s begging me to pleasure her. Using my free hand, I tug on the front of her strapless top and cup her breast before I lean down and circle my tongue around her nipple.

“Xavier...”

Peppering kisses up her chest and across her collarbone, I say, “Yeah, gorgeous.”

“I love... You... This—Love it so much.”

I lie her back on the blanket, her head on the pillows and her hair a mess of long, flowing brown waves.

When my jeans are off, I tuck my hands under her back and lower myself down until she spreads her legs. Once I’m inside her, our breaths mingle before our lips meet.

Everything about this moment is perfect.

As I move inside Zahra, she closes her eyes and arches her back. Her face is a picture of beauty, and the long, soft curve of her neck begs for my tongue to trace its curves all the way up to her jaw.

Minutes pass by with nothing but our declarations of love and our breathtaking moans of passion. When Zahra reaches the climax, her fingernails grip my shoulders and she pulls me down to her. Her heart beats against my chest and a euphoric wave of ecstasy smothers me. *Will always want her.*

Zahra has come so far since I met her, and so have I. I've discovered the decadent beauty of making love. And Zahra has come to learn her body is a delicate expanse of supple flesh, waiting to be explored by gentle hands and eager lips. She's no longer afraid of being naked, or worried about the way her body will react to the heights of heavenly bliss. She craves in the most beautiful ways and begs for my touch as though she has never known pain.

I swipe my tongue across her lips and into her waiting mouth. My own climax pushes me over the edge where a billion tiny stars pierce my vision and beads of sweat form on my chest and brow. Enveloped by Zahra's warmth, I relax into her, pulling her to her side with me as I grab the blanket and tug it over us.

She presses a gentle, lingering kiss to my lips. "Happy New Year, my love," she says.

"The happiest one yet, sweetheart."

You reside only in memories
That's where you need to stay
But if by chance you find me
I'll need to run away

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ZAHRA**March 4th***27 years old*

After dropping the twins off at childcare, I make my way across town to Jaymee's house where I'm meeting her for coffee. Having Xavier in my life has given me so much more confidence. He's always ready to explore the forest and bushland surrounding my house, and every Sunday he takes me out on the lake in an old wooden rowboat he picked up at the local market.

Each day, I leave the house happier than the day before, although, my emotions are often wavering between guilt and happiness. I loved—and still love—Declan, but I've found a new love in Xavier. When I'm emotionally down, he's strong and demanding, but in the gentlest way. He doesn't let me sit alone and wallow in my thoughts. He encourages me to get out of the house and sit by the lake, or take the twins for a walk to the local park. His enthusiasm for adventure... for life, makes me love him even more. He pushes me to be the best version of myself, and to take the time to be grateful for what I have, rather than letting grief and heartache drag me back to my childhood.

On the days when Xavier is questioning everything from our relationship to his own guilt about not finding Declan sooner, I am the one who is strong. I encourage him, and I remind him that although storms have ravaged us both in one way or another, we have each other, and that's what matters now.

Declan would be so proud. The thought of him brings a fresh round of tears to my eyes. I don't blink them back or swipe them away anymore. I embrace them. Every tear I shed is for the life I was lucky enough to share with Declan. He gave me my life back. He saved me in every way. Xavier is helping me continue my journey.

Before I knock on Jaymee's front door, I smooth my hands down my dress and take a long, deep breath. When I knock, the door swings open as though she was on the other side, waiting for me. Jaymee is beaming, like she does every time I show up at her front door.

"Hiii!" She squeals. "Come in. How are the twins?"

"They're so good, Jaymee. I love them more and more each day, and gosh Jacob looks so much like Declan."

"Aww Zar, I'm unbelievably happy for you. And look at you, driving and getting around town."

I nod proudly. "I'm getting better. I'm happy now. And I want to apologise for everything I've put you and Charles through. I can't thank you enough for sticking by me."

Before Jaymee gets a chance to reply, Charles walks through the door and stops in his tracks. "Zahra," he shouts before squeezing me so hard I think I may actually burst. He steps back and takes my hands. "How did you get here? Did Xavier drop you off?"

Smiling, I shake my head. "I drove. And I took the twins to childcare." The happiness I find in my own voice causes my smile to spread wider.

"You drove, like a car?" Charles asks in shock.

Jaymee and I laugh. "Well yeah, of course a car," I say.

"Oh my god, Zar, Dec would be so proud of you, babe."

I wipe a trickling tear from my eye. "I miss him, Charles, so much," I admit.

"We all do," he says, pulling me in for another hug.

As we're sitting at the table, my phone rings. I grab it from my handbag and see Xavier's name come up.

"Hi Xavier."

"Zahra, something happened. Someone broke into your house."

"What?" I say confused. "How...? When?"

"What is it Zar," Charles asks.

With shaking hands, I grip the phone tighter and turn to Charles. "Someone broke into my house."

"What the hell?" Charles shouts.

"Zahra...?" Xavier's voice comes back.

"Xavier, are you okay?"

“I’m fine, I just got home and the window was broken.”

I shake my head. It doesn’t make sense. “But Xavier, I dropped the twins off and came to see Jaymee and Charles. I’ve been gone thirty minutes. Why are you home?”

“I forgot the paperwork for Ryan, it was still on the bench where you put it for me.”

Charles snatches my phone from my hand and storms across the kitchen. “What the hell happened?”

He’s furious. “I don’t care. You tell them it’s Zahra Foxx, and they need to get there right now.”

“Are you fucking kidding me?” As Charles’ anger reaches boiling point, I shake uncontrollably. Jaymee pulls me into her. *What if I’d been home? What if the twins were home? What if they have found me?*

Charles ends the call and places my phone on the table. Within seconds, it rings again, and I pick it up to answer the unknown number.

My voice cracks. “H—Hello.”

“Ah, Carlie, it is you.”

The voice. The voice from my past. The voice from my nightmares.

“You’re so fucking easy...”

“No wonder father loves your little whore mouth...”

“You like this, don’t you?”

I open my mouth but nothing comes out. Not words, not a sound, not even a breath. Everything has stopped. The last thing I hear is my phone hitting the floor before my world goes dark.

* * *

CHARLES

“Fuck!” I shout.

Jaymee gasps and I lean and scoop Zahra up off the floor and lie her on the sofa in the living room.

When I return, Jaymee’s holding the phone out to me, her hand shaking. “Who the fuck is this?” I roar into the phone.

“Tell Carlie we’ve come to take her home.” The line goes dead.

I turn to Jaymee, her face is ashen. "They found her..."

My heart drops. *Protect Zahra*. That was my promise to Declan. Scrubbing my hands down my face, I pace the kitchen, thinking. "Get the twins," I say to Jaymee. "Take them to Ryan and Angela's, now."

Jaymee's hands shoot up to her mouth. "No, no no no. No, Charles, please don't let them take her," she cries before she grabs her keys off the hook and races out the door.

"Charles," Zahra's scream pierces the air and I head into the living room to find her sitting on the floor, rocking back and forth. *Don't break now... please not now*.

"They're here. He's here, he's going to kill me. No... no... can't— Shouldn't have come... please no." Her words are an incoherent mess.

She looks up at me, her eyes wide with horror. "My babies. Please... don't let them—"

I kneel and take her hands. "Jaymee's gone to get them. She'll take them straight to Ryan and Angela. They'll be safe there while we organise your flights. I'll drop you off at the police station with my father, then I'll get your things." I run through a mental checklist, ticking off everything I need to do. Everyone I need to call. *Eli!*

"Charles," Zahra sobs. "I don't want to leave. This is my home, this is where Declan is; where we fell in love." She wraps her arms tight around her knees and cries.

"Zar, I know. But it's not safe, I promised Declan I'd protect you if anything happened to him. I *have* to do this."

A knock at the front door causes Zahra to jump. "Don't move," I say before I head back into the kitchen. It's Xavier. I pull open the door and invite him in. "Zar, it's Xavier."

Zahra comes out of the living room and for a moment, she stops frozen as she stares at him. Then, she runs forward and slams into his chest. He wraps his arms around her and kisses her head. The exact same thing Declan used to do for her. "I'm sorry, Zahra. The drawers we're all pulled out in the bedroom, your locket is... ah, sweetheart, it's gone."

"Enough, Xavier." I shake my head, the less she knows right now, the better. As long as the twins are safe, she will be okay.

"Xavier...?" Zahra questions.

"The twins?" he asks.

“Jaymee’s getting them now, she’s taking them to Angela’s.”

“The police are there,” Xavier tells me.

I nod. “I’ll take Zahra to the station, then I’ll head over.”

“Will they let you in?” he asks.

“My father is the Sherriff remember.”

Xavier nods as he strokes Zahra’s hair. “It’s okay, babe. We’ll get it cleaned up and everything will be okay.”

I glare at him, then stop as I realise Xavier has no idea who is responsible. “It’s them,” I say.

“Them?” he questions. His eyes grow dark. “How the hell did they find her?”

“No idea. You are the only other person outside of us who knows about Zahra’s past. She’s been perfectly safe, until now.” The rage in my tone is directed at him. The guy who walked into our town and tried to take the place of my best friend. I’ve put up with him for Zahra’s sake, but if I find out he was involved, I will kill him myself.

Zahra steps back into me and I wrap my arm around her shoulders.

She loves Xavier. *Could he be involved?* The Xavier who pulled Zahra out of her depression and showed her life was still worth living. The same Xavier who made her laugh within the first days of his arrival when no one could get her out of the house. I shake my head. He wouldn’t, but the niggling feeling in my chest tells me I can’t take any chances. Not with Zahra’s safety.

“What! What that hell? I would never do that.” He glares at me before his features soften and he drops his gaze to Zahra. “Zahra, you know me. You know everything about me. I wouldn’t do this to you.” A tear falls from the corner of his eye and Zahra wriggles from my grasp. “Oh my god, Xavier, what have I done?” she cries, falling into his arms.

I refuse to apologise. “I made a promise to Declan.”

Xavier gives me a stiff nod. “I love you, Zahra,” he whispers against her hair.

Back from the darkness
His demons must be fed
The sickness has consumed his soul
They'll soon leave me for dead

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ZAHRA

4 hours later

People shuffle through the airport, bustling into one another while dragging large suitcases along behind them. I've never seen so many people in one place. Charles said it's because the school holidays are ending, and everyone is heading home. Each departure queue is filled with families complaining about the weather and the wait. While others are chastising their children who are either running around laughing and shouting, or sulking about the queues.

I grip Xavier's hand so tight I'm worried I might break his knuckles, but he doesn't complain. Jacob is sleeping soundly in Charles' arms, and Jaymee is bouncing Abby on her hip while her little hands reach out to me. "Mummy... Mummy..." she whines.

I turn around to talk to her. "What's wrong, Abby?" she pushes her bottom lip out and pouts. "Potty mummy..."

Jaymee sighs. "I'll take her."

"Noooo!" Abby screams and people turn to look at her. My cheeks burn, so I pull her into my arms and shush her. "It's okay, you can go with Auntie Jaymee. Mummy needs to wait in line."

She shakes her head. "Mummy." Little arms wrap tight around my neck and she presses her cheek to mine.

"I'll take her," I say.

Jaymee points over to the toilets a few meters away. "They're over there, I'll come with you." The lines are moving slowly, but if we lose our place, we'll miss our flight.

Xavier nods and kisses my cheek. "Hurry back."

The toilets are as busy as the rest of the airport and I tap my foot anxiously waiting for a stall to open.

“Ugh airport toilets are always like this,” the girl in front of me says.

“I’ve never been here before,” I admit. The flight Declan and I took on our honeymoon departed from a private airport out of town. It was nothing like this one.

“What? You’ve never been to an airport?”

I shake my head.

“Oh hey, there’s another toilet block down the next waiting area, we could try that one.”

Jaymee pipes up from beside me. “This one is fine, we can wait.”

The girl shrugs and leaves through another door on the opposite side of the bathroom.

“Mummy potty,” Abby says trying to wriggle out of my arms.

Luck is on our side when two people leave the toilets at the same time. Abby runs to one of the stalls. I follow her in and lock the door behind us. She sits on the toilet seat and starts to sing her favourite song. I focus on my breathing while I listen to the words of Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star over and over again. “Almost done, sweetie?”

She shakes her head and raises two fingers. “Two minitsss.” I can’t help smiling at her. Her bright blue eyes and her beautiful brown hair that’s become a few shades lighter since she was a baby.

After counting the seconds in my head, I ask again, “All done?”

She nods. *Finally*. The small toilet cubicles are cramped and claustrophobic, and I need to get out as soon as possible before I break down, or worse, have a panic attack.

Once we’re out of the toilet, Abby rushes over to the bench and jumps up to reach the tap. When she can’t reach it, she starts crying, but stops when I help her up. Jaymee stands beside us washing her hands, and when I set Abby back on her feet to wash my hands, she takes off running.

“Abby, no!” I shout.

Jaymee runs after her, and I follow, but when I open the door, I pause for a moment to get my bearings. There are so many people. Finally, I spot Jaymee’s blonde ponytail through the crowd and take a step forward.

Suddenly, I’m pulled back violently by a strong arm. When I turn my head, I see the face that instils fear into the marrow of my bones. I open my mouth to scream but a rough, calloused hand tugs on my arm. “One word and those little brats of yours are dead.”

I swallow back the lump in my throat but it doesn't stop the bile from rising. My body trembles with fear while in the distance, a sweet little voice is carried through the airport. "Mummy..." *Abby!*

As I scan the airport searching for my daughter, his hand covers my mouth. I try to fight; to kick him and lash out, but he's too strong, and the bustling crowds don't notice my struggle.

He whispers in my ear. "Try to run and lover boy is dead too." I nod, the ever-obedient slave. There is no way I will put my babies lives in danger. No way I'll put Xavier's life in danger.

My father has my arm in a death grip twisted behind my back as he leads me through the airport and into a small corridor. Silence has taken over. I'm terrified but determined not to scream.

When a security guard rounds the corner, he looks at us suspiciously, and I take my chance. "Help me!" I shout.

The security guard stops. "Let her go." He pulls his gun from his belt at the same time my father puts a knife to my throat.

"Drop it, or she's dead," my father growls. It's a lie, he doesn't want me dead. He'll use me first, punish me; *then*, if I'm lucky, he'll kill me.

"Drop the knife," the guard shouts.

With a flick of his wrist, my father flings the knife. It flies through the air in a flash before it pierces the guard's left eyeball. He slumps to the floor, blood oozing from the red orb. I'm so stupid. I should have known better. Now, someone is dead, and it's my fault.

My heart has never wanted
I've never craved a love that's true
But if you're stolen from my arms
I'll search the world for you

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XAVIER

6.00pm

There's been no sign of Zahra. I'm beside myself, and the twins and Jaymee haven't stopped crying. Charles is furious, and when he tried to blame me, I didn't hesitate before I clenched my fist and punched him square in the face. Man, it felt good, but now that he's sporting a black eye and a bruised cheekbone, the only thing I feel is regret. He loves Zahra, and he loved Declan. He was only doing what he thought was right. On the plus side, he's being less of an ass to me than he's ever been.

The police have extended their search and put up roadblocks but are yet to find any leads. The last we heard, an airport security guard was murdered while we were searching for Zahra.

I pace the kitchen of Charles' house waiting for news. Hour after hour passes and still there's nothing. "This is stupid." I slam my fist on the bench top. "We can't stand around and wait. We need to find her."

"And where do you suppose we look, Xavier?" Charles' jaw clenches and his brows bunch together. He leans against the kitchen bench with his arms crossed over his chest while Jaymee holds an ice pack to his cheek.

I throw my arms up in frustration. "There must be some place around here they'd be hidden from sight. This is your goddamn town, Charles, you don't sound too worried she's missing." I pace to the window and pull the curtain across to see three police cars parked outside. When I turn back, I glare at Charles, seething with anger. "You made a promise to my brother."

Charles closes the gap between us and clenches his fists. "Do not talk to me about Declan. I was more of a brother to him than you ever were! You did not know him. You may share the same DNA, but he was *my* best friend."

"Charles," Jaymee shouts. She tugs on his hand and pulls him back until he drops onto a chair.

I wave a hand toward him. "You know what, Charles, fuck you! Do you think I chose to be stolen from the fucking hospital while my brother was adopted?" I swallow hard trying not to let my anger control me. "I love Zahra, and I'll find her myself if I have to."

Jaymee gasps and takes a step toward me. "Xavier... what are you talking about? What happened to you?"

I shake my head. "Nothing." When I turn to walk out the door, Jacob's voice stops me. "Dadda, dadda."

I scoop him up and kiss his little cheeks. "Jacob, mate, you need to stay with Uncle Charles while I go and get Mummy, okay?"

I set him on his feet and he runs back to Charles. Before I leave, I lift Abby into my arms and kiss her head. "Mummy will be home soon, sweetheart."

She nods as tiny salted tears drip from her big blue eyes. She reminds me so much of Zahra. *I have to find her.*

"Xavier, please be careful," Jaymee calls as I walk out the door.

For three hours, I drive around Rockburn Grove, through the back streets, and down behind the old warehouses and factories before I stop on the outskirts of town to get fuel. Heading further out of town, I tighten my hands on the steering wheel remembering everything Zahra told me about her father and brother. She's come so far, and they will destroy her. I can't let that happen. I make a silent wish to the heavens. "Please let her be safe."

At the start of the highway, there's a police checkpoint. As I pull over, I wind down the window. The officer shines a torch into the car, checking the back seat before he comes back to me. "Oh... hey, you're Declan's brother."

I nod. "Have you got any leads yet?"

The young cop shrugs. "I'm on check point duty. The Sherriff's up there, you could ask him. He loved Dec like a son. Everyone did."

"I know," I say. I make my way over. "Sherriff Stone."

He extends his hand and we shake. "Xavier, mate, you can call me William."

I only nod, I'm too on edge to focus on pleasantries. "Found anything?"

He shakes his head. "I'd say they've gone bush. They weren't on any flights out and not one car looked suspicious."

"I can help," I tell him. "I know the bush, I've been living off the grid for almost ten years."

"You could have been helping us, and you... didn't?" There's suspicion in his tone and I don't like it one bit.

"Well... Charles warned me to stay put. Said I'd only get in the way."

He narrows his eyes and there's a sharp edge to his tone. "Charles isn't in charge of this. He needs to keep his goddamn mouth shut." Scrubbing his hands down his face, he murmurs, "He's not the only one hurting."

I give him a nod, knowing how close they were. Everyone in Rockburn is hurting, I've seen it firsthand, and now Zahra's missing, it's bound to get worse.

With a wave of his hand and quick instructions to be back within the hour, William gives me the go ahead, along with four of his officers who follow me into the darkness, their torches the only light for miles.

"Zahra!" One calls. Another call follows as we search for Zahra, the only woman to ever find a place in my heart.

The darkness will not ravage me
I'm stronger than before
I'm not a little girl now
And I'll fight forever more

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66

Survival

ZAHRA

6.00pm

Even with my eyes closed tight, everything is spinning. Dizziness has taken over and my thoughts are in disarray. A weight settles on my chest before a rush of something cold courses through my veins. I shake my head, but the movements are slow. I tighten my hand into a fist then stretch my fingers out again. Pins and needles cause my hands to throb before the tingling sensation travels through my body and moves down to my feet.

“She’s still perfect...” the deep voice reverberates off the walls as though there’s an echo surrounding me. “Few more minutes...” There it is again. Deep rumbling, then echo... echo... echo...

I blink, but my eyelids are too heavy. When I lift my hand to rub them, I can’t move. I shake my head again.

Blink.

Blink.

Blink.

A dark ceiling looms above me.

Another blink.

Hot, stagnant stench wafts past my nose. *Is that rum and cigarettes?*

Blink again.

The lump in my throat won’t budge, no matter how hard I swallow.

The voice returns. “Carlie... oh, Carr-r-liiiiie, wake up.”

Freezing water assaults my senses. My face is drenched, and for a split second I’m positive I’m going to drown. Coughing and spluttering, I blink again. When his face appears above mine, everything comes flooding back. *They found me.*

My eyes grow wide and terror envelops me. My body goes rigid and I hold my breath and count to ten before I shake my head hard and raise my

hand... but wait... I can't move. From the corner of my eye, I see the chain. It's twisted around my wrist, holding me down, forcing me to lie on the bed while they glare at me.

Through gritted teeth, I muster up all the strength I have. "Let me go."

Trystan laughs, he actually leans down and laughs in my face. "Ahh, Carlie baby, you've got a lot to learn about your new, improved brother." He traces his fingers up my thigh, only stopping to slide one between my legs. "I needed you, sis, and you left me."

As a tremor of fear runs down my spine, I realise I'm naked. I pull on the restraints, desperately trying to free myself even though I know my luck has run out.

Trystan forces his fingers inside me while I clamp my thighs shut. It's no use, he's too strong; too determined to destroy me. He pulls a knife from his belt and points the tip between my breasts. "You're going to stay nice and still for me, aren't you?"

Don't let him scare you. When I don't reply, he presses the tip of the knife into my flesh causing me to let out a wince of pain.

"Aren't you?"

I nod.

"SAY IT!" he bellows.

"Yes, Trystan. I'll keep still for you."

A smile spreads across his lips. "Rob," he yells.

He calls our father by his name now?

Trystan must notice the confusion in my eyes.

He sits on the side of the bed leaving the knife resting between my breasts as he circles my nipple with his fingertip. "I should fill you in on everything that's happened since you fucked off and left us." He pinches my nipple, but I grit my teeth and remain silent. "Hmm, I might make you scream after all. A long hard fuck should fix it."

Please no. Footsteps enter the room before I hear his voice. "Carlie." He sounds... happy? "Daddy's favourite little girl is home."

"Yes, Father," is all I say.

He comes closer, looking down at me like he always did. Now, I see the depraved gleam in his eyes I never noticed before. He hands Trystan a set of keys before sliding his hand up my leg.

Trystan proceeds to move around the bed unlocking the chains while reminding me that if I try to escape, I'll die.

"My little girl has grown." My father presses a finger to my lips. "I've missed these sweet lips my precious little princess."

Rather than fight him, or anger him, I give him a slight smile, expecting one in return. But all I get is the slap of his hand across my cheek. When I bite my tongue, blood pools in my mouth and drips from the corner of my lips where he swipes it with his finger. "You'll have to be punished for leaving Daddy all alone..." He clicks his tongue as he paces the room. "Hmm... What to do?"

"I'm sorry," I whisper.

Trystan laughs again. "I should let you know, I make the rules now. I'll decide on your punishment, and trust me, it's going to fit the crime." He steps back. "Sit up, look around. I've got some things to show you."

I force the bile back and sit slowly, my head still slightly dizzy. Immediately, I know where I am. Back in the basement of my old house. How did they get back in? How have they hidden for this long? I shake my head then turn to look at the bed beside the one I'm sitting on.

My heart catches in my throat and this time, the bile comes up followed by vomit. I can't breathe. *Can't breathe. Must breathe.* I get to my knees and drop my head down. "No, No..." I tell myself it isn't real. My mind is playing cruel tricks on me. "What's happening?" My words follow another bout of vomiting. "What... have—NO!" More vomit.

"Isn't it perfect?" Trystan says. "Gotta start them young, like you, sis. Train them, get them used to sucking cock and having their bodies touched alllll over."

He pulls my hair back. "I bet she'll scream for me once I'm inside that tight little pussy."

Vomit. "Please... no—" Vomit. *Will this ever end?* Black spots form in my vision and tears stream down my cheeks.

Trystan pats my shoulder then kisses my head. "Don't worry, sis, I'll treat her real good. A couple of weeks and she'll be begging for my cock."

White hot rage pierces my vision and I explode. "NO!" I scream and lunge at him, wrapping my fingers around his throat and squeezing as tight as I can. "NEVER. EVER. TOUCH. HER!"

In an instant, I'm flung back into the wall like a rag doll. A splitting headache pierces my head and Trystan lunges at me. I scramble back, my hands still covered in vomit—and blood. *Where did the blood come from?* It's too late. He forces me down to the cold, hard ground and clamps a hand around my throat.

His dark eyes stare into mine with... *What is that?* Lust? Desperation?

Focusing, I gasp for air, swinging my arms at his face but missing every time. The slap of his hand stops me fighting, but it doesn't end there.

"I've been waiting so long to fuck you." He rolls me onto my stomach and grabs a handful of my hair before he pulls my head back. "What does it say?" he growls.

I clamp my eyes shut. I don't want to see it. Anything but that.

"What does it say?" He slams my face into the concrete. "Say it."

Choking on tears, my gaze locks one more time onto the child size single bed covered in pink satin sheets. The bedhead is also pink, and above it, a little wooden sign. I clamp my eyes shut and murmur, "Abby."

Trystan leans down to my ear. "That's right. A special bed for a special little girl who's going to be Uncle Trystan's favourite."

Dread.

Terror.

Hopelessness.

He hasn't got Abby. She's safe, she will always be safe. He's trying to scare me. *Please don't let him have her.*

For the next ten minutes, I lie on the cold concrete while Trystan rapes me. He forces his dick into me, each time harder and faster than the one before. Minutes pass slowly while he moves on top of me, groaning. He never says my name, instead, he says my daughter's name, and even when I vomit the contents of my stomach until nothing but blood streaked bile remains, he continues to tell me about the vile things he's going to do to her, if I don't cooperate. Before he releases me, he licks and sucks the side of my neck, murmuring, "You... are... mine."

When he gets off me and stands, he kicks his jeans off from around his ankles. He tears his t-shirt off and throws it in the corner. "Look at me." He extends his arms. "Look what you did to me when you left. Now, it's your turn."

Unblinking, I stare up at my brother. His arms, legs, and torso are covered in hundreds of scars. Each one the same length, some have healed, others only weeks or days old. He's been cutting himself... *For how long? And why?*

Slowly, I move to sit, pulling my knees to my chest before I wrap my arms around them and press my back against the wall. "W—What happened to you?" *Calm.* No matter what happens, I cannot fight him. I know Abby is safe, but in the back of my mind there's lingering doubt.

He raises his brow. Behind him, standing against the opposite wall, my father is smoking a cigarette, his eyes fixed on me.

"You left me." His voice remains calm, but there's a sinister tone behind it. "You made me feel something for you... then you took it away from me. I wanted you. I *needed* you. I had no choice." He traces a fingertip up his own arm. "Because of you, I'm like this. We're twins, Carlie, we need to be the same."

No. Realisation hits me. *Don't fight.* Over and over I say the words only in my head. *Do not fight.* I've survived everything life has thrown at me. *I can survive this.*

* * *

March 5

12.05am

I'm sure it's been hours since my father and Trystan left with the promise they would return at midnight. During that time, I've paced the cellar that's only changed slightly since I was here last.

The glass wall that once separated the play room and the purchase room, is now gone. The pink bed remains, so does the blonde haired, blue eyed doll I used to play with when I was a little girl. The other bed, I cannot bring myself to look at. How did they know about Abby? How did they know where I was? How long have they been watching me?

I pull my hair to the side and run my fingers through it before I braid it again. Pacing, I search the room for anything that could help me escape. But there's nothing. When I drop down to the bed, I think back to the days after Eli rescued me. Back then, I was still desperate for my father's love... for my brother's love. So many times, I wanted to go home.

The creak of the door causes me to stiffen. Standing, I smooth my hands over my hair then drop them by my sides. I will do absolutely anything to protect my daughter. He cannot have her. Abby will never know the pain of abuse, I refuse to allow it.

My father enters the cellar first, the stench of rum and beer follows him, a vile odour I remember all too well. He stands in front of me, looking me up and down before he extends his hand and cups my cheek. “Daddy’s precious little girl...” When he leans forward, I resist the urge to gag as I wait for his mouth to make contact with mine. It doesn’t. Instead, he whispers, “Guess where you’re sleeping tonight?” *Do not vomit.*

With an inhale, I close my eyes, then exhale slowly. *Calm.* “With you, Daddy?”

A sinister smile spreads across his lips. He raises his brow then steps back, turns, and goes to the table on the other side of the room where he pours a drink.

I can do this. I am stronger now. I will survive. I know what to expect, and if I can avoid being punished, I’ll be okay.

Trystan walks toward me. He’s changed so much. His muscles are huge and he’s now more than double my size. His biceps are hard, taut muscle, and his abs are clearly defined. He must be going to the gym, or working out a lot. His face is so similar to mine, so similar that I force myself not to shed a tear when I catch a glimpse of my son. Trystan isn’t unattractive at all, on the outside. On the inside though, he is a revolting, heartless human being.

Like my father did, Trystan looks me up and down before he takes my hand and traces the scars on my wrist. “What happened?” There’s no concern in his tone, only rage.

“I... I tried to kill myself.”

He laughs. “Don’t do it again.”

I swallow hard.

When he holds out his other hand, between his fingers is a razor. I suck in a breath. He’s not going to kill me. Trystan presses the sharp blade into my wrist, then, while looking me dead in the eyes, he drags the razor across my flesh. I don’t move, I don’t react other than letting my tears drip from my eyes. This is a pain I can handle, a pain I’m used to.

A pain I deserve.

“Do you know how long you were gone?” He cuts another mark into my arm.

I shake my head. *So, so long.*

Trystan narrows his eyes. He wants me to talk to him. *Don't break down.* “No. I'm sorry, Trystan.”

There's a minute of silence as he continues cutting my forearm one slow slice after another. Blood drips down my arm, a sticky, warm mess that doesn't bother me in the slightest.

“Why?” I ask him.

He cocks his head. “Why what?”

“This? When we were young... Why did you do it?”

He puts the bloody razor on the table and places his hand on my neck where the bruises from him sucking my flesh taint my pale skin. “Hmm... I like you being marked by me now.” He rubs his dick and groans. “Rob, get me the medical kit.”

My father—to my utter shock—obeys and leaves the cellar. *What happened to them?*

“He made me what I am. You made it worse.” He walks to the table and opens a bottle of beer.

“You didn't have to be like him. I'm not.”

He shrugs then takes a mouthful of beer. “Too late now.” He paces across to me again. I keep my eyes focused on the wall. “He killed Auntie Dianne you know.”

“Why?” I should be surprised, but I'm not.

“She was getting in the way. Was trying to help mother escape with you. He took me with him, made me watch while he did it.” Another mouthful of beer before he continues, “Do you know what it looks like when someone is strangled with a rope? Their face turns this blue grey colour and their eyes bulge out of their head...” He's standing right in front of me again, his hand around my throat. “It's fascinating.”

When he releases his hand, I lower my voice. “He killed Cathie too.”

A laugh. “That little whore deserved everything she got. She never shut the fuck up.”

“She was my sister... your sister. How can you be so—” I stop. There's no point asking.

“She wasn't your sister, or mine.”

He's lying.

When I don't respond, he grabs my breast and squeezes it hard before pushing his body against mine. "Mother was a whore... she fucked some random bastard and got herself pregnant. Rob took the kid, another girl to add to his collection. Half-sister... half slut. Whatever she was, she was a waste of space."

No. Tears well in my eyes. My little jellybean, my baby sister who never had a chance at life. Refusing to let Trystan see the depths of my pain, I change the subject. "Why do you call father by his name now?"

He drops his hand then rubs it over his dick again before he pushes me down. "Sit."

I drop to the bed as he removes his underwear.

"Now suck."

I've been reduced to being a slave all over again. My heart is broken but my mind wants to fight. If I do though, I'll be punished. Trystan grabs a fistful of my hair and repeats, "SUCK!"

When I open my mouth, he forces his dick in and I gag immediately. He continues talking, "Rob. He had this idea that he could use me instead since you ran off..." He tugs on my hair forcing my head back. "He needed to get off, and I was the only one left." I gag again as tears stream from my eyes. He won't stop talking. "Fuck that! I wasn't being anyone's fucking bitch. I turned that shit around on him faster than he could blink." Using both his hands, he pulls my head into him. When I can't breathe, I punch my fists against him. A grunt of satisfaction follows a sinister chuckle. "You're so good, baby. Have you been practicing for me? Show me how deep you can take it." Still trying to push him back, I shake my head hard. He doesn't stop. "Turns out good old Daddy isn't too bad at sucking cock either. Hates it up the ass though... stupid fuck."

This revelation hits me hard. Is it my fault? Should I have stayed and tried harder to be a sister to Trystan? Maybe I could have helped him... saved him? *It's too late now.* The sickness I thought my father had, has consumed Trystan completely. There's nothing left of him, no light, no hope... he's shut off to the world and void of any emotion. *And he's still my brother.*

Trystan lets out one final groan before he steps back and I fall to my side and vomit on the floor. When I start gagging again, I put my finger

down my throat to force another round of vomiting.

“Get in the fucking shower, you’re filthy.” Trystan sits at the table and drinks the rest of his beer as he watches me. “Then we’re fucking again. Whenever I want you, you need to be ready.”

“No,” I beg. “Please, Trystan... I’m too weak.”

He points to the small bathroom. “Shower. Or I’ll fuck you again right now.”

I struggle to sit, and it hurts more to stand. My stomach is in knots from vomiting so much. Walking slowly to the shower, I glance back over my shoulder to see Trystan on his phone. I need that phone. If I can get a phone, I can call Xavier and tell him where I am. *Then he’ll be in danger.* I could call Eli. I know with certainty my family and friends will be looking for me.

Death has finally found me
Beneath a savage blood red sea
I'm drowning in a crimson wave
Set me free now, set me free

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ZAHRA**March 10**

Days have passed. I don't know how many, but it must be at least five or six by now. My body is weak. I'm covered in cuts, and the bruises that bloom across my skin from head to toe show where my father and Trystan have left their marks. Keeping my eyes open is difficult now, but I continue to fight.

When the nausea finally subsides, I stand from the toilet and grip the bathroom sink with two hands, and stare at my reflection in the mirror. An ugly, bruised and swollen face stares back at me. There is no life left in my eyes.

Trystan has used my body so many times I've lost count. He says I owe him for all the times he missed out and had to "fuck some other whore". He said he wants my body covered in his marks, and that if I continue to "please" him, he'll stop letting my father use me, as though it's some kind of consolation. My father used me six times to be exact. Each time, Trystan watched him like a hawk, even sitting on the bed right beside us as my father used and abused my body. He is truly obsessed.

Each time my father used me, he spoke to me as though I was a little girl again. As though he didn't realise my disgust for him has grown, and my love has all but faded.

The punishments I expected came too. The cuts were only the start. I've been whipped, punched, kicked, slapped, and forced to have sex until I was bleeding and screaming in pain. Those were the times Trystan told me how much he enjoyed hearing me scream, and how he would make Abby do the same. They were also the times I ended up huddled in the corner of the room, sitting in my own vomit and blood.

When I lie on the bed, I close my eyes and picture my children and Xavier. Their smiling faces, their laughter, their love.

“Carrriieee...” Trystan’s voice echoes down the stairwell.

I can’t move again, it hurts too much.

He stands over the bed, staring down at me before he grazes his knuckles across my cheek. “I have a surprise for you, sis.” My last *surprise* was pancakes with strawberries and ice cream, which I forced down my throat while I shed tears for Declan and the morning after our wedding when we had breakfast together.

“Not hungry,” I murmur.

His hand smooths over my breast and down my stomach before he stops between my legs. “There’s no food this time.” He pulls my legs apart. My eyelids are heavy, so I don’t bother opening them. “Bleeding’s stopped.” That was a statement, not a question. “All good to go. Can’t wait to shove my cock inside your tight pussy again.”

“No.” My voice is barely a whisper. “Tryst... it hurts... all hurts.”

“You’ll say yes when you see what I’ve got for you.”

Trystan calls our father. With his heavy footsteps I hear a whimper, then a childlike cry.

God no. Don’t let it be Abby. I force my eyes open and sit up quickly. Too fast. I’m back down again with stars in my eyes as my vision blurs in and out. *Did he drug me?* Something doesn’t feel right.

“Put her on Abby’s bed for now,” Trystan commands.

A tidal wave of relief washes over me. It’s not Abby. But who is it?

I blink before turning to my side. The little girl is wearing a blue dress covered in white polka dots. Her face is pale and her big brown eyes are puffy and filled with tears. She can’t be more than ten years old.

Trystan sits on the bed and the little girl scrambles back against the headboard. He reaches out and takes her hand, tugging on it until she’s sitting beside him. “Look at this, sis, I got us a new little sister. This one’s name is Taylah.”

The little girl shakes her head. “My name is Bridgette.”

Trystan cups her cheek, then he moves his hand ever so slowly to her neck where he squeezes it tight. She tries to scream; she kicks and hits and gasps for air.

“None of that, or I’ll fuck you right now,” he growls. “And I know you don’t want that, do you?”

She whimpers and drops her head in her hands.

I sit up slowly. "Let her go... please... use me. You want me."

Trystan raises his brow and smiles as he releases her. "I'll let her go, all you need to do is call lover boy and have him bring Abby here."

"Never." The word comes from my mouth without a second thought for Bridgette's life. But disgust for myself consumes me. Could I let this little girl suffer to save my own daughter? "You're not touching her, Trystan. Not now, not ever."

"Taylah, stand up and take your dress off," Trystan says.

She shakes her head. "My name is Bridgette. I don't wanna take it off, Trystan."

"Take it off," he repeats.

"I don't want to."

"Trystan, stop. Let her go, please. You have me here, there's no need to keep her." I need to talk him out of this, there must be a tiny shred of compassion left inside him. "I'll do anything you want. Anything at all." I extend my arms. "Cut me again. Make me bleed, you like it when I bleed." The words I never imagined I say continue pouring out of me in the hope that this poor little girl will be spared the same pain I've endured. "Trystan, please. I *want* you to use me."

He cocks his head and scratches at the stubble that's grown on his jaw over the past few days. As though he's considering my offer, he stands and walks over to the table. When he returns with his mobile phone and hands it to me, I beg, "Please, I'll do anything. What do you want?"

"I want to fuck you, and I *will* make you bleed. But first, I want to meet my niece."

I shake my head and clench my fists. This could be my chance to talk to Xavier. *NO!* I can't risk it. "I won't do it."

Trystan grabs Bridgette's hand and unzips her dress while she cries and begs him to stop. When she's standing in her underwear, he drops his gaze and licks his lips. "Take it off," he commands.

I swallow hard and stand in front of my brother. How did we come from the same womb? We are complete opposites. He disgusts me, but I have to do this.

I raise my hand and cup his cheek. His eyes stop on mine—he looks confused.

“Let me please you. She doesn’t know what you like... I do. I always did. And she’ll—” I swallow against the acrid taste at the back of my throat. “She’ll fight you. Use me, I’ll give you everything you want.”

He lifts his hand and tucks a strand of hair behind my ear before he slides it behind my neck. His other hand glides up to my breast and he pinches my nipple hard between his fingers. “Mmm... I like it when you beg, it makes my cock hard.” He presses his hips to mine until there’s no space between us.

“Let her go,” I whisper. “She’s not good enough for you...” *Focus. Don’t fall apart.* “She’s not good enough for my brother.”

He glares at Bridgette whose arms are wrapped around her middle. “I want to meet my niece.”

“You can,” I say quickly. “But not here. She’s... She’s afraid of the dark, and small places—cellars.”

His mouth inches closer, his breath hot on my lips. “I *want* her here.”

He’s not giving up. *Why?* He reaches down and holds up his phone before pressing his lips to mine. I open my mouth and let it happen, my mind only on how to keep my daughter as far away from here as possible. When he stops kissing me, he twists my hair around his fist. “Make the call, Carlie. And hurry, I need to fuck you again, now.”

I nod and bring the phone up between us. My chest heaves with each wave of panic.

This is the end.

After all I’ve been through and all I’ve survived, this is the last time I’ll ever speak to someone I love... someone who loves me.

When I dial his number, I pray he doesn’t answer.

“Hello?” His voice sends a wave of calm washing over me and I close my eyes for the shortest second to commit it to memory.

“Xavier.”

There’s a loud gasp, then a panicked reply. “Zahra! Where are you? Are you okay? What happened to you? Tell me where you are, I’ll come get you right now.”

“Xavier,” I say his name again, perhaps for the last time. “You need to do something for me, it’s important, okay?”

“Zahra, tell me where you are.”

“I’m home—” *No. I can’t let him come here.* “Listen to me, you need to take the twins and run as far as you can, don’t ever look for me again.”

Trystan snatches the phone from my hand and pushes me back onto the bed.

“Bring me my fucking niece, or Carlie dies!” It’s the last thing I hear before a punch to my cheek knocks me out.

* * *

March 14

10.45pm

Moments flicker in my mind. Horrific images of what’s happened to me while I’ve been trapped here. As each one flashes before my eyes, I’m not sure if they’re real, or merely a figment of my imagination.

I see myself chained to the bed, my father over me, grunting, smiling, and touching my body while I stare up at him with my eyes glazed over and a blank expression. Another flicker, another image. This time it’s Bridgette. Trystan is holding her face down on the bed while he groans. Her muffled screams catch my attention, but dizziness blurs my vision. I’m so weak I can’t move, let alone form coherent words.

A quiet cry draws me back to reality, and when I open my eyes, I’m staring directly at Bridgette. She’s huddled in the corner of the room. Her knees pulled up to her chest and her thin arms wrapped tight around them. Her head is down, and a mop of brownish red hair falls over her shoulders and arms.

I raise my head. I’m chained to the metal pole across the roof; my feet barely touch the floor. Blood trickles from the fresh cuts scattered over my arm. Turning, I notice the other arm is the same. A twinge of pain pierces my stomach, and when I drop my head... more cuts. *Why didn’t I feel it?*

I study my arm again and choke on a sob when I see the trail of syringe marks inside my elbow. *They drugged me.* “Bridgette,” I whisper. “Did they give me drugs? Needles?”

She raises her head slowly, a deep purple bruise covers the side of her face. “I wanna go home now,” she cries.

“Shhh... you have to be very quiet, okay?”

She nods slightly. “He put needles in your arms... Why aren’t you crying?”

I sigh. “I’m trying to be brave. Bridgette, have I been asleep for long?”

She nods again. “The bad man with grey hair did sex with you but you wouldn’t wake up.” Her eyes are wide, but her expression is completely blank. “I thought you were dead but Try—the monster boy said you were sleeping. He said you liked sleeping because it makes you better for him.”

“Monster boy? That’s what you call Trystan?”

“We all do but very, very quiet so he doesn’t hear.”

All do? What’s going on? “What do you mean, you all do?”

Bridgette drops her knees and stretches her legs out. “All the girls at Libertine. He keeps us in a big building...” she scrunches her nose. “A warehouse. Then all the other bad men pay lots of money to take us to their houses. Sometimes fifty or sixty. Is that where you lived when you were a little girl?”

There are more little girls? *Oh no.* I need to get out of here, alive. I need to find those girls and save them from the life I endured. No one else can be put through this torment. It has to end.

“Yes. The bad man is my dadd—” I can’t say it. “He’s my father, and Trystan is my brother.”

She tilts her head and narrows her eyes. “But Daddies are supposed to love their kids... *my* daddy said so.”

“I know.” I sigh again.

The cellar door slams and Bridgette gasps as she pulls her knees up and drops her head.

My father stands in front of me, a hunting knife in his hand. “Daddy’s little girl is awake.” He stalks around me before stopping behind me and wrapping an arm around my waist. He breathes into my neck and his tongue traces my shoulder. “Awake and ready for another round,” he murmurs. “Gotta get some of this sweet little ass before your brother comes down.”

Bridgette lifts her head and stares up at me.

“Please don’t make her watch.”

He tugs me closer and I feel him already naked against me. "Oh, she'll watch, then it'll be her turn."

"No! Don't touch her."

Bridgette squeezes her eyes shut and drops her head again.

My father's knife drops to the floor with a clang before he grips my waist with two hands and forces himself into me. The pain is excruciating and my body quivers with an ache that reaches into the marrow of my bones. My eyes are shut tight and my mind is wandering... There has to be a way out of this nightmare. Tears spring to my eyes and I sob relentlessly.

Before my father is done, Trystan storms into the room. "Get the fuck off her!" he shouts.

"Almost do—"

Trystan cuts him off. "Unless you want my cock rammed down your fucking throat again, you'll step back old man."

Freedom. For a brief, fleeting moment. Until Trystan approaches and looks me up and down. "You're awake."

I nod, still crying. "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have done what I did."

He leans down and grabs the knife off the floor. "Sorry doesn't cut it, sis." Trystan turns his back on me and walks over to Bridgette, he lifts her off her feet and throws her small body onto the bed. With one hand around her throat, he presses the tip of the knife into her thigh. She lets out a bloodcurdling scream.

"Let her go!" I scream. "Leave her alone, do it to me, Trystan. Please, let her go."

He looks over his shoulder and a sinister smile dances across his lips. "You want this?" he asks holding the knife up.

Another nod. "I want the pain. I *need* the pain. I *need* you." I need to gain his trust back.

He slaps Bridgette's face causing her to scream again. "Stay there, little whore. My sister *needs me*," he says before turning his back to her.

My father takes a seat at the table, watching Trystan's every move. "Make her bleed, Tryst," he says.

Trystan laughs. "She'll bleed," he says as an ominous promise. "But you won't be fucking her again." One of the chains is removed from my wrist, leaving my arm to fall dead by my side. With barely a glance at my father, he murmurs, "She's all mine now."

Trystan releases his dick from his underwear and grabs my hand. “Touch me,” he commands.

I obey and tighten my hand around his dick while he drags the knife up my thigh. “More,” he says. I continue, but the more I move, the harder he presses the knife into my leg. Breathing heavily, Trystan twists my hair around his fist and brings my face closer to his. “Harder... FUCK!” he hisses through gritted teeth.

I force back the bile as I glance at Bridgette who’s curled up in the foetal position, crying. Thankfully she’s not watching. I have to save her from witnessing more of this hell.

When the knife pierces my flesh, I suck in a breath, determined not to let my tears consume me. Trystan’s eyes meet mine, he’s not there anymore. Someone—something—else has taken his place.

A monster.

He pulls the knife out and moves it to my abdomen where he pierces my flesh again. “More...” is all he says before he licks my lips and forces my mouth open with his tongue.

“You’re hurting me,” I whisper through a sob.

One hand slides down between my legs. “Good. Because soon, I’m gonna make you scream.” He pulls my hand off his dick and takes it in his own hand. He positions himself in front of me, then, with the knife still tight in his hand, he grips my hip and forces himself inside me. One thrust after another he moves while I let my body go limp.

The tip of the knife pierces my flesh with every move he makes. Blood drips down my side, but he doesn’t seem to care. My breaths are shallow. I’m awake and alive, but my strength is draining, and nausea is taking over.

“Tryst... please... stop—”

Another thrust.

More blood. “Stop... it hurts—”

A groan cuts me off. “Good girl, Carlie. Keep begging for me, baby.”

Then another.

He steps back, blood smeared on his hip and thigh. I blink a few times as Trystan wipes the blood off me then smooths his hand across my breasts. “All mine now...” he growls.

This is the end. I will die here by my brother's hand, in one bloody, final act.

I swallow hard and let my eyes close, but it doesn't stop him. The clang of the knife hitting the ground is all I hear. For a fleeting moment, deathly silence lingers before something cold and hard is forced inside me.

There's a laugh, a grunt, then a whisper beside my ear. "You like that, sis? 'Cause there's so much more coming." With every word he speaks, I struggle not to vomit. "Once I've destroyed you, inside and out, you're gonna carry *my* babies..." my eyelids flicker open to watch him bring a half empty bottle of rum to his lips. He licks around the rim of it, then takes a mouthful. "Remember what I told you all those years ago? Soon, it's just gonna be you and me—"

From above, there's a bang, then a crash, and voices. So many voices.

I force my eyes open. Glass shatters at my feet and the scent of rum permeates the air.

My father jumps to his feet. Trystan steps back and pulls up his underwear. "Fuck!" he shouts. "Rob, go see what's going on," he orders.

My father doesn't budge. Instead, he draws a knife from his belt and steps back beside me.

I turn my head at the same time an explosion tears open the cellar door. Like a scene from a movie, the door lands on the floor a few metres away from me followed by a cloud of thick, white smoke. *What's going on?*

Trystan stands in front of me, the knife tight in his hand again. But when he takes a step back and drops it, he groans. "Fucking hell." Another step back. And another until he's out of reach.

Footsteps pound down the stairwell.

When I see his face, relief washes over me.

Then, my father wraps an arm around my naked body and holds his knife to my throat.

"Rob! NO!" Trystan shouts.

You're no one now, not anymore
You were nothing but a lie
A walking, talking traitor
Who was content to watch her die

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XAVIER**March 14***11.11pm*

She's naked and covered in blood. Her left arm is twisted and attached to a chain above her head that's coiled around a metal pole. She's alive. Her eyes are wide, and her lips slightly parted. Even covered in blood and bruises, I can see the strength in her eyes.

The scene before me is burned into my mind in seconds.

A bruised and naked little girl sits on a small bed covered to her knees in a pink sheet, the sign on the wall behind her reads 'Abby'. The bed beside her is also pink, above it, a sign reads 'Carlie'. Blood is pooled in spots on the floor along with what must be vomit. *What the hell?*

Eli raises his gun, the three officers flanking him do the same.

An older man has an arm wrapped around Zahra's waist, his other arm is up higher, and in his hand, a hunting knife is held at her throat. Blood is smeared across her bare chest and running down her side. When I drop my gaze, a wound in her thigh is oozing blood into a pool at her feet. A broken bottle of rum lies discarded on the floor.

"Drop your weapon!" Eli shouts.

One of the officers trains his gun on the younger guy whose head is bowed down. "Hands up, on your knees." The guy doesn't budge, but he stutters, "I didn't d—do anything. He... h—he made me. F—forced me to come here..."

The older guy narrows his eyes and looks over his shoulder. "You little fucking bastard."

Eli takes a step forward, but he stops when the guy holding the knife slices it across Zahra's throat. She gasps, then shakes her head slightly.

"Go." Her sweet, soft voice is barely audible. "Forget about me."

"Robert Browne, drop your weapon," the officer commands.

He drags the knife down between Zahra's breasts and stops below her rib cage before piercing her flesh again. "She belongs to me." He whispers something against her ear, causing her to close her eyes. Tears fall down her cheeks.

"This is your last chance," the officer shouts.

"She will always belong to me," he says as he presses the tip of the knife into Zahra's flesh.

"Noooo!" I shout.

Eli steps forward.

BANG.

Blood splatters across Zahra's face. The man falls backwards. He's dead. There's a bullet hole in the middle of his forehead. Zahra screams.

"Noooooooo! Da—"

The little girl's eyes are wide with horror.

I glance at the other guy, he still doesn't lift his head. *Why am I noticing that?*

Focus on Zahra. "Zahra!" My voice is shrill.

BANG. Eli's gun fires again, this time into the dead guy's chest. Why is he shooting a dead guy?

More blood. Another scream. A radio crackles.

Silence.

Then a voice. "He's down. We got him."

My legs don't move. The screaming grows louder.

Zahra's head drops.

The other guy raises his hands. The officer handcuffs him then drags him to the other side of the room. The little girl leaps from the bed and runs to Zahra, wrapping her thin arms around Zahra's bloody waist.

Eli approaches slowly then drops to one knee. "I'm Eli, I'm here to help you."

The little girl shakes her head. "No. Don't take her away, she's not dead. She's sleeping, the monster boy said she likes sleeping. It makes her better. Please don't take her."

One of the officers walks over, his gun still in his hand. He presses his fingers to Zahra's neck. "She's alive, we need to get her out of here."

* * *

March 15

8 hours later

The emergency waiting room at Harrisville Base Hospital is a hive of activity. Police officers come and go, men in black suits rush in and out while holding mobile phones to their ears, and Eli's team, who have come in as well, stand to the side of the room flicking through folders of paperwork.

All I can do is pace back and forth and wait for answers.

We searched everywhere for Zahra, and William was growing more furious by the day. Everything had come to a standstill. I'd just put the twins to bed when my phone rang with an unknown number. When I heard her voice, it pushed me into overdrive. Adrenaline coursed through my veins with renewed hope until I heard the male's voice. In that moment, I knew it was imperative to find Zahra.

I got on the phone to Eli and told him about the call. He asked a hundred questions and, in the end, made the split-second decision to check Zahra's old house one more time. Within the hour he had a team ready to go, and we were on our way.

Once she was out, the officers refused to let me see her. I was pushed back behind police tape and reporters who seemed to appear from nowhere. Then, I was told to stay put while paramedics loaded Zahra into a waiting ambulance. The little girl was brought out next, and while she was being taken to another ambulance, a group of plain clothed police officers headed inside with Eli.

I sat in the front seat of Eli's SUV, desperate to get to the hospital and see Zahra. When I called Ryan to let him know she was alive, he said he'd let William and Charles know and they'd meet me at the hospital as soon as they could.

Hours passed. My heart was in my throat wondering if the guy—who must be Zahra's father—had somehow miraculously survived being shot in the head. When they finally brought him out, I breathed a sigh of relief.

The younger guy came out surrounded by police officers. I couldn't get a good look at him because he had a t-shirt draped over his head. It

didn't stop the reporters going into a frenzy, shouting out questions, asking for names, and taking pictures as he was led into a police car.

Not long after that, the crowd dispersed. The only ones left behind were a few investigators carrying large bags and cameras.

Eli came back to the car saying he needed to meet his commanding officer at the local police station, and that the two local officers would give me a lift to the hospital. I sat in the back seat of the police car in silence. My mind only on Zahra, hoping against hope she would survive.

While I'm pacing, a doctor barges through the doors and calls out. "Xavier Harrison?"

I rush forward. "That's me, what is it? Is Zahra okay?"

He turns his back to me. "This way, Mr Harrison."

I follow him through one corridor after another until we reach a room with bright white lights shining from above the bed. On the bed in front of me, is Zahra. On the bed beside her, the little girl from the cellar. *Do they think she's Zahra's daughter? Could she be Zahra's daughter?*

I scrub my hands down my face as the doctor explains. "Mrs Foxx is sedated for now, her injuries are not life threatening, but the toxicology report found a plethora of drugs in her system. There's also..." He hesitates as though he's searching for the right words. "She has severe sexual trauma, her injuries required internal stitches. We'll do a scan as soon as we can. She'll need some time to heal, but physically, she will get through this."

I nod taking it all in. But rage burns in my chest. Those sick fucking bastards! Shaking my head hard, I focus only on the positives. She's alive. Her injuries aren't life threatening.

The doctor extends his hand toward the little girl. "Your daughter—"

I cut him off. "She's not my daughter. I don't know who she is, but she could be Zahra's..."

He scratches his head. "Okay, I'll see what I can find out. Do you mind that she's in here with your wife?"

"Zahra's not my wife. She's my..." I sigh. "My girlfriend. We live together."

"I see. Okay, my apologies, Mr Harrison. You don't mind if she's in here?"

I shake my head. "I don't want her to be alone."

The door opens behind us and a scream fills the air before a woman runs to the bed where the little girl lies. “Bridgette! My baby, what happened to her?” Her eyes meet with mine and I step back as the doctor steps forward. “You’re her mother?” he asks.

She nods, tears streaming down her face as she sobs. “Will she be okay?”

“She’s been sedated. Your daughter...” he looks over his shoulder at me.

I step back again. “I ah... can I talk to Zahra... touch her, before I go?”

He nods.

I stand by Zahra’s bed, focused only on her, but the words of the doctor are clear as day. “Internal injuries.” “Severe sexual trauma.” “Rape.” “Drugged.”

I squeeze Zahra’s hand tight and lean down to her ear. “You’re safe now. You did it, you got out. It’s all over.” I kiss her cheek and stand, looking at the mother whose child has been the victim of something so horrific she may never recover.

When I walk out of the room, I sprint to the first bathroom I can find and vomit the entire contents of my stomach up. How can someone be so cruel? So sadistic and twisted that they’d hurt a child in that way? With the tap running, I splash cold water over my face. Sighing, I lean against the wall. My phone rings and I pull it from my back pocket.

“Hey, this isn’t a good time.”

“Xavier, it’s Eli. Everyone’s here, mate. Are you okay to talk to them?”

I swallow the lump in my throat. “I’m okay. On my way out now. Did you find out anything else?”

“Yeah. This is big, real big. I can’t talk right now, but I’ll fill you in ASAP.”

“No worries, Eli. And thanks... you know, for listening.”

“No problem, mate. Talk soon.”

Back in the waiting room, Zahra’s family rushes toward me. Angela throws her arms around my neck and hugs me tight. “Oh my god, thank you for finding her, Xavier. Thank you. Is she okay?”

I fill them in on what the doctor told me, and Ryan makes a phone call to have Zahra transferred to Sundowner Hospital where she can have her own doctors caring for her.

Charles holds Jacob in his arms, but when he sees me, he cries out. “Daddy!”

I pull him into my arms, watching Jaymee rock Abby who’s fast asleep. The poor thing has been beside herself since Zahra was taken. She’s barely slept through a night, and constantly cries for her mummy. I was doing okay, but it got to the point where my inexperience with children was showing and the twins needed more than I could give them. For that reason, they’ve been spending a lot of time with Angela and Ryan. Their whole world has been tipped upside down, but now that Zahra’s safe, we’ll be able to start over again.

Three hours later, I’m sitting on a chair in the emergency waiting room. The little girl’s mother walks through the doors, her eyes red and bloodshot from crying. She makes eye contact with me and heads my way.

“Hello, I’m Rose, Bridgette’s mum.” She extends her trembling hand and I take it gently.

“Xavier,” I say. “Is your daughter going to be okay?”

She nods then drops into the seat beside me. “She woke up about an hour ago. The doctor wanted to move her to the children’s ward, but she started screaming and thrashing saying she couldn’t leave Zahra.”

“I’m so sorry.” I shake my head. “I—Was Zahra awake?”

“No. Briddy wanted to talk to her, she couldn’t understand why the doctor wouldn’t wake her up.”

I lean back on the small plastic seat and sigh. “She’s a brave girl... your daughter I mean.”

A hint of a smile turns up the corner of Rose’s mouth. “She... Briddy, ah... she told me some of what happened... I—I don’t know what to say.”

“I don’t know much yet,” I admit. “And nothing about what happened to your daughter.”

Rose places her hand gently on mine. “She said your wife—”

“Zahra’s my girlfr—”

Rose cuts me off. “She said Zahra saved her. That she told the... the boy to stab her instead of Briddy.”

Another sigh. I don't want to talk. I want to see Zahra, I want to hear it from her lips, not this stranger. I clamp my eyes shut thinking about the pain Zahra must have endured for the little girl to survive.

"Rose. Rose!" A man calls as he rushes through the doors.

Rose leaps to her feet and into the arms of the man. "She's okay, she's going to be okay." The man scans the room and his gaze stops on the officers who stand by the emergency room doors drinking coffee from Styrofoam cups.

"Why aren't you out there looking for the bastards who took my little girl." Spittle flies from the man's mouth as he storms toward the two officers.

They both place their cups on the small table beside a stack of magazines. "Sir." One officer raises his hand. "There are officers out now searching for anyone else involved in your daughter's disappearance. Please, calm down."

The man's face reddens. "CALM DOWN!" he bellows. "Those sick bastards took my daughter from her bed in the middle of the night. They raped her!"

Gasps fill the room and the officer closes the gap between himself and the man. "Sir, I understand your pain, but please, there are other families here... children."

The man drops to his knees, sobbing. "She's ten... ten years old and those monsters raped her..." Rose drops down beside him and rubs his back. A few minutes later, the officers escort them through the doors.

Charles takes a seat beside me. "How was she when you got there? Was she conscious?"

"She was..." I run my hands through my hair. "She was chained to the ceiling of the cellar... there was a pole with a chain attached to her wrist. She was... naked. The guy..." *Her father!* "Fuck!"

"What?" Charles asks.

"I—I didn't think before because I was so focused on Zahra. It *was* her father, and her brother. He looked like her. But not her." Her brother, the coward who tried to pin all the blame on his father.

"Her father had a knife to her throat, he cut her a couple of times but just after he was shot, her head dropped. I think she fainted."

"He's dead? Her father..." Charles whispers.

I nod. "Eli shot him in the head. He's definitely dead."

"Do you think she'll get over this, Charles?"

"She's stronger now, braver too. You've helped her see that."

I rest my elbows on my knees and drop my head into my hands. "I should have done more to protect her."

Charles pats my back. "You did enough. This isn't your fault. And, Xavier... I'm sorry I was so hard on you. Declan would have kicked my ass."

We share a quiet laugh before I lean back on the seat and close my eyes.

For all the little girls
Who have broken little souls
You are worthy of so much more
And your stories will be told

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ELI

March 15*9.00am*

“We fucking got him!” I raise my beer with Callum. “Finally.”

Callum leans back in his chair. “Tell me that bastard’s brains splattered across the room,” he says with a sly smile.

“They splattered. I made sure he was dead.”

“And the kid?”

“Says he doesn’t know anything. Says his father forced him into the cellar then drugged him.”

“He’s lying?” Callum asks.

“Absolutely. That bastard will do anything to stay out of prison.” I take a mouthful of beer. I’m pissed off I had to shoot Rob Browne, I wanted to get him talking first. What’s done is done. He got what was coming to him.

Callum’s phone rings and he shoves his hand into his pocket to retrieve it.

“Yeah.”

He sighs and rolls his eyes. “Why him?”

There’s a minute of silence, then, “Fine. I’ll tell him now.”

Callum puts his phone on the desk. “The kid wants to talk to you, alone.”

“Me? What the fuck for?”

He shrugs. “Nelson said he asked for you by name.” Callum checks his watch. “Can you go now?”

“Yep.” I stand and put my beer on the desk. “This better be worth it.”

Trystan Browne sits on a chair at a small round table. Officially, he’s not under arrest yet, but the police are confident he’ll be locked up within

the next few hours. I sit on the chair opposite him. He's grown up a lot since I saw him last. "You wanted to see me?"

"You killed my father," he says. He leans back in the chair and clasps his hands behind his head. "You tricked us. You took Carlie and killed Cathie."

I resist the urge to roll my eyes. "What do you want, Trystan?"

"I want to make a deal. I'll tell you everything... for a price."

"You haven't been charged yet, why are you trying to make a deal?"

He laughs. "You saw it. You know who I am... What I am. My fingerprints are all over that place. They're on the walls, the floor, the bed where I fucked my sister and made her scream my name. The bed where I fucked that little girl..." He taps his finger to his temple. "Hmm... what was her name?"

Rage boils inside me. The fucking bastard is trying to play me. Not a shred of remorse. "What do you want?" I ask again.

"Protection. I want to be separated... in prison."

Ahh. The truth comes out. He knows he's going down, and he knows what happens to guys who mess around with kids. "Tell me."

He raises his brow, then smirks. *Prick!* "I want it in writing first. Then I'll tell you everything."

I stand and make the call.

Thirty minutes later, an officer walks in and hands me an envelope before leaving again. I slide it across the table and Trystan opens it. When he's satisfied, he nods.

"Well?"

"First of all, how's your daughter, Gracie, right? She must be about ten now."

Do not react. My chest rises and falls with each breath. I'm itching to stand up and smash the fuckers face into the table. *Calm.* "What happened to you?"

He picks at his fingernails. "My father fucked me when I was ten, did you know that?"

"No. I didn't."

As expected, he continues. "He used to let me watch him with Carlie. Everything was, "Carlie is perfect... Carlie can sleep with daddy... Carlie's pussy is so tight." That bastard did everything for her. I wanted to be his

favourite. I wanted him to notice me, but all I got was a few quick fucks and his cock rammed down my throat.”

“How old were you when it started?”

He shrugs. “Five or six. Can’t remember.”

A sliver of emotion weaves through my heart. *NO!* Carlie endured worse and she didn’t end up like him. He had a choice.

“What about the business, how did it work?”

“As if you don’t know.” He sniggers. “You came to us.”

“So your father sold Carl—Zahra to anyone?”

“You don’t get it, do you?” Trystan leans forward and rests his elbows on the table. “My father was the leader of Libertine. It’s a family business, passed down from one generation to the next.” He raises his brow. “There was no shortage of girls, but *Carlie* was his special one. She did what she was told, so she got to stay at home. You know how much men will pay to fuck a little girl like Carlie?”

Fucking hell. Rob Browne was running Libertine all this damn time. “How many girls?” I ask.

“We had thirty, but since we were on the run, we had to cut back to ten. Do you know how fucking annoying it is to have to move every couple of weeks when you’ve got a bunch of whining little whores to cart around?” He runs his fingers through his hair.

I lean down to take the folder out of my bag. In it, over fifty missing girls we suspect are victims of sex trafficking rings. I open it up and slide it across the table to Trystan. “Have you seen any of these girls?”

He looks at the first picture, cocks his head, then flicks it across the table toward me. “No idea. This one,” he says, holding up the picture of a ten-year-old girl, “she’s dead.”

“Dead?” I ask. “You killed her?”

“Nope. Randall Eastlake. Too bad he’s already dead too. He liked ‘em real young.”

The next three pictures he says he has no idea. After that, there’s a pile of ten girls he says he’s had at Libertine. He stops on the next one and lifts the page. “Taylah,” he says. “She’s dead.”

I swallow hard. “You’re sure?”

“Well, I kicked her off the cliff at Mount Blackmeade, she hit her head a couple times on the way down.” He shrugs. “I’d say she’s pretty

fucking dead.”

“*You* killed her? Bullshit!” I don’t believe him. But it adds up. She’s the same age as Trystan, they were from the same area. The same school. “Why did you do it?”

“We were fucking around, she wouldn’t shut up.” He rolls his eyes. “Screaming and crying. I put my hand over her mouth and sure as fuck, she shut up. Must have passed out or something, I didn’t get to finish. I wasn’t fucking a dead bitch.”

No reaction. Not slamming his head into the table. Trystan is a psychopath. He has no feelings whatsoever.

“The rest of them?” I ask.

He sorts through the pictures putting them into piles until he gets to the last one. He glances up at me, then back down at the page. *He knows?* “This one...” he holds it up and turns it around. “I haven’t seen in person, but this picture’s in the Slate.”

My heart pounds against my ribcage. “The Slate?”

He smirks. “You’re not too bright, are you? The Slate is a list... a directory of girls from all over the world, girls chosen specifically for their looks, height, weight, hair colour... whatever our clients request. This girl’s in it. I remember her, those lips are made for sucking cock.”

With a growled curse my body reacts before my mind can play catch up. I’m on the floor on top of Trystan with my hand around his throat. I swing a punch, then another, he doesn’t react, doesn’t even flinch or move his head to protect himself. Another punch. The bastard laughs. He’s enjoying every fucking minute of this.

“Rob said her name was Carlie... Your kid, right? Too bad you couldn’t save her.” He wipes his arm across his mouth smearing the blood across his face. “My father was the one who took her—bet you didn’t know that.”

Don’t react.

Don’t let him win.

The officer storms into the room, his gun drawn. I stand and brush off my suit, then step back. “Get the fuck up!” I command. “Cuff him,” I say to the officer.

Trystan extends his hands. “I like ‘em tight,” he says, “just like *Carlie*.” His eyes are on mine, and a pathetic smirk on his face.

I'll kill the bastard.

When the officer leaves, I sit in the chair and cross my arms over my chest. "You're going away for a long time."

Another shrug. "It was bound to happen. If you hadn't come for Carlie, we would've got away with it a lot longer."

"Who else is involved, I want names."

"You sure about that?" Still smirking, he taps his fingers on the table.

"Names," I repeat.

Trystan reels off names as I write them down. Some don't surprise me, some leave a foul taste in my mouth. On the list are police officers and doctors, children's services officers, school teachers and principals, and well known—and respected—members of communities in and around Harrisville.

Something still doesn't add up, he's giving in too easily. "I don't get it. Why come clean? What's in it for you? Once you're in prison, you'll have nothing."

He cracks his neck and leans back on the chair. "That's where you're wrong. I'm a victim. Sexually abused by my father, forced to watch him sexually abuse my sisters and other girls. Forced to watch him murder my mother and aunty. He groomed me, made me believe it was all okay. I'll be lucky if I get twenty years." He laughs. "I'll be out by the time I'm fifty."

He believes he's going to have it easy after everything he's done. *Bastard.* I take out my pen and sign the letter Trystan assumes will protect him in prison. When I slide it across the table and hand him the pen, he signs it. "What happens now," he asks.

I stand to leave. "You'll be arrested, you'll have your chance to speak to a lawyer. After that, you'll be sentenced."

"Hmm. Sounds good. Do I get a phone call?"

Hesitating, I glare down at him. "Who are you calling?"

"A friend, gotta tie up loose ends."

A phone sits on the desk on the other side of the room. "Use that one."

Trystan raises his hands. "Uncuff me."

"Nope. You'll manage."

He narrows his eyes and stands. When he picks up the phone, I dial the number to make an outgoing call then step back. Surely he knows the

call will be traceable from here. Maybe he doesn't care. Fucking psychopath.

"Hey, it's over."

He lowers his voice. "Exactly what I said, don't fuck it up."

There's a grunt of frustration, then he laughs. "Fuck that. Clean slate, it's not worth it."

"I'll be in touch."

He sets the phone down.

"Who was that?" I ask.

"A friend."

"Name?"

"Can't for the life of me remember." He rubs his head.

With an exhale, I step back to leave and when I reach the door, he calls out to me. "Hey, Eli..."

Looking over my shoulder, I watch him rub his crotch. "Take care of Gracie, she's perfect for Libertine."

Without hesitation, I turn on my heels and storm toward him. One punch hits his jaw with a crack, the next slams against his eye socket. One more punch sends him to his knees, and a kick in the guts lands him on his back.

By the time I reach the door, Trystan's muffled laughter is grating on my nerves and I want to turn around and kill him. *Let it go.* I will ensure he gets what he deserves. I slam the door closed behind me. "Fucking bastard!"

With my phone in my hand, I dial the number for Edgewater Prison and ask to speak to Joe Anderson. Thirty minutes later, he finally gets to the phone.

"Eli? What the hell?"

"I got him, Joe. I got him."

A long silence, then, "Tell me his name."

"It was Trystan Browne."

A low growl comes through the phone. "Bull-fucking-shit! He would've been a kid."

“Fourteen... He admitted it, mate... I’m sorry.”

—”
“He’s going away? I swear to fucking god, Eli, if that prick gets off

“He won’t,” I assure him.

“How long?” He lowers his voice. “Here?”

I drop down into a seat. “Yeah. Not sure. You’ll know.”

“Time’s up,” a voice calls in the background.

Joe’s voice returns. “I’ll do it. And Eli, thank you.”

Heaven doesn't realise
White wings don't make you fly
It's the love inside your heart
That helps you touch the sky

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XAVIER**April 2***28 years old**19 days later*

Today would have been my twin brother's 28th birthday. He should never have died so young. Today also reminds me of how precious life is. I lived alone for so long. For so many years, I believed independence was a gift created for me, and that somehow, I was destined to live a life without knowing what a family was.

The day I met Zahra, everything changed. She was the hope I needed. She showed strength when she should have been weak. She was open when she had every reason to shut down and hide away. And she survived... through everything, she survived.

It's been almost four weeks since Zahra was rescued, and she still bears the scars, wounds, and some bruises from her ordeal. But she tells me that this time, she's more determined than ever not to let this ruin her. While she still jumps at loud noises and has already had a few panic attacks, she's trying. Every day she wakes up and marks a pink cross on the calendar before she makes breakfast for all of us. Jacob and Abby are the lights of her life. They've bought the sunshine back into her dark world and their smiles and laughter fill our home with happiness and hope.

"Daddy." Jacob tugs on my hand, and I lean down to lift him into my arms. To begin with, I was hesitant about letting the twins call me Daddy, but after speaking to Zahra's psychiatrist, and a children's psychologist, we decided together that if it made Jacob and Abby happy, we wouldn't stop them. At home, we have albums filled with pictures of Declan and Zahra, and in time, we hope the twins will come to understand. For now, though, they're thriving.

"What's wrong, mate?" I ask him.

“Want baa-oon.” He points at the stand where a young girl dressed in a princess costume holds a bunch of coloured balloons.

“Meeee too!” Abby jumps up and down.

I scan the crowd looking for Zahra. When I spot her sitting on a picnic blanket with Angela and Ryan, I return my focus to the twins and the balloons they’ve spotted.

Gripping Abby’s hand tighter, I make my way through the throng of people who’ve come to celebrate Declan Foxx Memorial Day. Zahra wasn’t happy about it to begin with. She was furious the town wanted to remember the day Declan died and begged Ryan to do something to change it or shut down the idea entirely. In the end, a unanimous decision was made to celebrate it on Declan’s birthday.

Once we make it through the crowd, Abby tugs on my hand, dragging me toward the girl with the balloons. I set Jacob on his feet and he stares up at them, wide eyed and smiling.

The girl gets to one knee and points to Abby’s giant badge on her pink dress. “Hello,” her high-pitched voice squeaks. “What does this say?” she asks Abby.

Abby looks down and points to her badge. “I birfday girl.” She turns and points to Jacob’s badge. “Jakey birfday boy.” When she takes Jacob’s hand, he smiles. “Twins!” she announces.

The princess smiles and lets out a fake, over the top gasp that makes the twins giggle. “Oh my. You are very lucky. Today is a brilliant day for a birthday!”

They both nod eagerly.

“Let me guess how old you are...” Princess taps her finger against her cheek. “I think you’re ten!”

They giggle and shake their heads.

“Hmmm... twelve?” she asks narrowing her eyes.

“We small,” Jacob says holding his hand above his head as though he’s measuring his height.

The princess stands and twirls around in her blue dress showing off sparkling silver heels. Abby and Jacob stand in awe waiting for her reply.

She touches both their heads and announces, “You’re both TWO!”

“YES!” the twins shout in unison.

After receiving their balloons, the princess waves goodbye to us and I head toward the fenced playground. Jacob hands me his balloon. “I play, Daddy?”

I nod. “Be careful.” I hold the gate open and let him run through. “You want to go too, Abby?”

Her eyes dart around the park. “Want Mummy.”

I lift her into my arms and kiss her head. “She’ll be back soon.”

“Mummy go way?” she asks.

“No. No, sweetheart. Mummy’s not going away again.”

She pouts and her eyes well with tears. Separation anxiety started the moment Abby saw Zahra in the hospital. Abby cries into my shoulder as I rub her back to comfort her. “Mummy loves you, Abby, she’s just talking to Grandma, okay?”

ZAHRA

It’s been four weeks since I was rescued by Eli—again. This time though, it was different. My father is dead, shot in the head right beside me, by Eli. In the heat of the moment when Eli raised his gun and pointed it at my father, I panicked. I would have done anything to save him, but my body had gone into shock, and I couldn’t move. Blood sprayed across my face; the cellar became a hive of activity with voices shouting, Bridgette screaming, and my heart beat pounding in my ears so loud I couldn’t think straight, let alone focus.

My father. The man I truly believed loved me, was dead, and I wanted him back.

When I woke in the hospital, I screamed at Eli and told him I hated him for what he’d done. I begged him to let me see Trystan so I could tell him how sorry I was. Rage had consumed all that was left of me. My words had been tainted with guilt that threatened to destroy the people I loved the most. Nothing made sense, and when I lashed out at Xavier, I knew in that moment, there was something wrong with me.

Twelve hours later, I woke in a hospital room surrounded by my family. None of them left my side while I was sleeping—or, as I later found out—sedated.

Doctor Phillips came in and talked to me about the shock I had experienced and how, in that moment, it affected my ability to think logically. He assured me it was merely a reaction to trauma and there was nothing permanently wrong with my mind.

After apologising to everyone, I managed to relax and while they all left to get some food, Eli stayed behind saying he had something important to tell me.

While he sat on the side of my hospital bed with his hand tight around mine, he told me about his daughter, Carlie. He smiled when he recalled the day she was born and how she screamed for an hour straight because Heather, Eli's wife at the time, was having trouble breastfeeding. He shed tears when he told me about the day Carlie went missing while she was out with her mum shopping. And he sobbed as he told me about her murder and the evidence he found afterwards. It all pointed to his little girl being kidnapped and sold as a sex slave.

Heather died a few days after Carlie was found. She couldn't stand the pain of living in a world without her precious daughter, and in a moment of despair, she took her own life on what would have been Carlie's birthday.

I shuffled closer and wrapped my arms tight around Eli's neck. "It wasn't your fault. You did everything you could have done," I reminded him. My own tears streamed down my cheeks, but I refused to give in, I had to be strong for Eli. He saved me from the same world his daughter was thrust into. "Eli," I whispered, "You are the strongest, bravest man I've ever met. I'm so, so proud of you, and honoured to call you my friend."

He rubbed his eyes and sat up, staring at me while he tilted his head and smiled through tears. "She would have loved you," he said. "You would have loved her, too."

Later on, when Eli left, and I'd had time to process what had happened, I realised just how lucky I was.

"Zahra, honey?" Ryan's voice draws me out of my thoughts.

"Sorry," I say, shaking my head slightly.

“And you will come back?” Angela asks. The sadness in her eyes is enough to make me second guess my decision and make me say, I’ll stay. But I would be doing it for her, for Ryan... for all of them. I wouldn’t be doing it for me.

With an inhale, I focus on what *I* want, and what *I* need. “Of course,” I assure her. “I need to do this. I need to start this new journey without the chains of the past holding me down.”

Ryan wraps an arm around Angela as she dabs at her eyes with a tissue. Guilt coils in my chest and my lungs feel heavy. *Don’t give in.* While I love Ryan and Angela with all my heart and soul, I need a break. And Xavier’s offer to move to the cabin for a while, feels right.

I take Angela’s hand and make her a promise. “I will come back. I will bring Jacob and Abby here for holidays... for Memorial Day, and you’ll get to spend as much time as you want to with them. They’re your grandbabies, and I want them to know you, to love you, and to see you as much as possible.”

She gives me a little nod and Ryan speaks up. “It’s okay, love,” he says to Angela. “You know Zahra’s safe now, Xavier will look after her, and the twins. She’s not leaving forever.”

I smile as he reaches out to squeeze my hand.

“You’ll come back for Christmas? And their birthdays?” she asks.

I nod, then stand and take her hand. When Angela stands, I wrap my arms around her and hold her tight. “I’ll always come back to you. You’re my mum now, remember?”

She breaks into a sob, but still smiles. “I’ll miss you. You take hundreds of photos for us, and I mean *hundreds*. Every single day if you can. And I want letters and notes and stories about your adventures.”

Ryan laughs and it causes a smile to spread across my lips. “She’s going for a break, love, not to spend every hour of every day taking pictures and writing stories for you.”

“She’s my little girl,” Angela chides. “I’m just making sure she knows.”

“I know,” I tell her. “And I’ll always, always remember how much you loved me, when I forgot what love was.”

With a kiss on my cheek, she whispers, “Perhaps another grandchild while you’re away?”

I bite my tongue, but when Ryan shouts, “ANGELA!” and rolls his eyes, I burst into laughter. At the same time, I realise, I am complete... finally.

XAVIER

A hand on my other shoulder startles me and I spin around to see her. My Zahra. “Heyyy, Abby,” I whisper.

She lifts her head, her little face red and wet with tears. “Mummy!” she screams and practically jumps into Zahra’s arms.

“Aww, Abby, why are you sad?” Zahra asks.

“Want Mummy.”

“Mummy’s here now, it’s okay.” Zahra kisses her cheeks and Abby giggles through her tears before pointing at the playground. “Play wif Jakey?”

Zahra sets her on her feet and opens the gate to let Abby in. When she finds Jacob, she hugs him, and hand in hand they run through the park until they reach the sandpit. Both of them wave then continue playing.

“Hey, I missed you,” I say, wrapping an arm around Zahra’s waist.

She rests her head on my arm. “I was talking to Angela and Ryan. I have good news, but I want to wait until we get home.”

“You’re going to keep me in suspense?” I run my fingers through her hair and kiss her head.

“Only for a little while.” A smile graces her lips and her eyes sparkle with happiness. Gone are the half smiles and the shadowed pain I used to find in her eyes. After everything she’s been through, she’s still determined to live, determined to love.

“Do you think he would have liked this?” I ask her.

“He would have loved it. Everything is perfect.”

We sit side by side on a park bench watching the twins and talking when a little girl stops in front of us. Zahra gasps and covers her mouth with her hands. A muffled, “Bridgette” is all I hear.

She smiles and nods. “Mum said I could come say hi, is that okay? She said you might not want to see me, Zahra. That I might make you sad.”

Unshed tears sparkle in Zahra's eyes. "Of course I want to see you." She extends her arms and Bridgette falls into them, crying.

"Thank you for saving me," she says.

Zahra shakes her head. "I think you..." she takes Bridgette's hands. "You saved me. I knew I had to be strong for you."

Bridgette brings her hand up to Zahra's cheek. "Does it still hurt?"

Zahra nods. "A little. But I'll be okay. Are you okay?"

She shrugs. "I don't know. It hurts a lot in my head, and my heart." She rubs her chest. "And I always get sad because I have bad dreams that the monster boy is coming back."

I squeeze Zahra's hand and even though it's trembling, her voice is calm. "He won't. You're safe now."

"Briddy, come on back now," her mother calls.

We turn and wave to her, and she waves back with a smile. "Thank you for coming to say hello," Zahra says. "Maybe we'll see you again soon."

She smiles and nods then leans forward and kisses Zahra's cheek. "Bye Zahra, I love you," she calls as she runs back to her mother.

I pull Zahra into my arms. "Want to go for a walk?" I ask her.

"That would be nice," she says before she presses a kiss to my lips.

* * *

Lying in bed beside Zahra is the only place I want to be. After almost losing her, I've realised I can never take anything for granted. Life is fleeting, and I want to make every moment with Zahra and the twins count.

She turns to face me and traces her fingers over my chest. "Thank you, for everything, Xavier. You've made my life worth living again."

I tuck her hair behind her ear and kiss the tip of her nose. "Thank you for choosing me, and for letting me be a part of your life. I would have understood if you'd told me to leave the day I arrived."

She smiles. "I think I was waiting for you. I don't know, but I'd started searching for you again, and everything was leading to dead ends. It was so close to Declan's birthday that I wanted to curl up in a ball and cry my days away. But then you showed up and a glimmer of hope came with you."

Damn, I love her. Words fail me, so instead, I pull her close and pepper gentle kisses across her jaw until I reach her soft, pink lips.

She kisses me back with rapturous passion, her hands gliding over my chest and sliding up to my shoulders where she grips them tight before continuing further up to my neck. Running her fingers through my hair, she whispers against my lips, “I want to go.”

My breath catches in my throat. We’ve talked about going to my cabin for an extended break. Zahra was apprehensive and afraid of leaving a place that’s become home to her, plus all her memories of Declan are right here in this town. I didn’t push the subject, I want her to be one hundred percent sure she is ready.

I cup her cheeks and gaze into her beautiful, deep brown eyes. “You’re sure?”

She nods. “I told Ryan and Angela. I’m ready for an adventure, Xavier. I want the twins to have some fun before they start school. I want...” Tears well in her eyes.

I pull her onto me and rub her back. “Sweetheart, you can say it.”

Through tears she says, “I want to move on now... I mean, I still love Declan, so, so much. But I want to live now. I’m *ready* to live.” She drops her head to my shoulder.

Tracing my fingers up and down her spine, I say, “You’re allowed to be happy. It doesn’t mean you’ve forgotten about him. Anytime you want to be alone to think, or cry, or talk to him... you let me know and I’ll give you some space.”

“He would have loved you,” she says.

After talking for a while, Zahra begins to smile again. “I’m excited to tell the twins. It will be their first time on a boat that’s not in our lake.”

“I still can’t believe you want to go, are you sure?”

She nods. “Positive.” Then she whispers against my ear, “Xavier... could we try... um... making love now? I miss being close to you.”

I lift her head. Her cheeks are pink and her lips are plump and adorably kissable.

My dick hardens and a shiver of pleasure coils in my stomach. When she drops her gaze to my lips, I pull her down and kiss her as she writhes on top of me. “I would *love* to,” I say sliding my hand between her thighs.

“Will you kiss me there again?” her chest presses against mine as she breathes heavily.

Yes! “I will kiss you all over, and when I’m done, I’ll start again.”

“Xavier?”

“Yeah, babe?”

“Please hurry...”

A quiet laugh bursts from my throat. *Will never give her up.*

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I am life wrapped in serenity
And the moments that have passed me by
I am every dream and wish that will come true
Yours forever, there is no goodbye

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ZAHRA**October 2***27 years old**6 months later*

Fate is the strangest thing. It brings hope and happiness, but it also brings heartache and sorrow. There are moments of pure joy I will forever remember along with moments of despair I long to forget. The fear that was once ingrained into my heart and soul, no longer has the power to crush me beneath its weight. I am stronger now. Braver too.

I sit on the veranda of Xavier's log cabin in the middle of the most brilliant green forest I've ever laid eyes upon. While I pull the white satin ribbons from Abby's hair and untangle her braids, she points toward the trees. "Mummy, I seed a birdy." Her head moves as she tries to follow the feathered wings of a bluebird before it disappears into the treetops.

Abby kicks off her bright pink gumboots then reaches down to pull her socks off. The morning is crisp, and although she refuses to wear anything but dresses, she won't leave the cabin without her gumboots firmly attached to her little feet. Being here is like living in a piece of paradise.

Jacob and Abby can run free and climb trees or throw stones into the river. Xavier's shown them how to grow vegetables from seeds, and how to care for the chickens he bought so we can have fresh eggs. The cabin is self-sustainable with solar panels for power and hot water, and a huge tank that catches rainwater during the winter months. Xavier said we could make the two-hour trip to the closest town once a month if we need to. So far, he's only made one trip—with Jacob—to pick up the mail and grab a six-month supply of chocolate and lollies. The twins have him wrapped around their little fingers, and he adores them.

I was hesitant about coming here at first, mainly because I was anxious about leaving Rockburn Grove for so long, and missing my family and friends. In the end, I made the decision to go when I realised, I was clinging to Declan's memory and still held a tiny spark of hope that he'd miraculously come home. *It's okay to move on.* Angela's words swirl through my mind. She reminded me that moving on didn't mean I was letting go or giving up on the love Declan and I shared. Instead, I was choosing to live in happiness instead of utter, heartbreaking despair.

The choice was made.

When we arrived, the tiny log cabin I expected, was more like a magnificent mansion. The A-Frame cabin is positioned perfectly so that the morning sun shines through the bedroom windows waking us with the beautiful colours of the mountains in the distance. At sunset, the view from the front of the cabin looks out across the river where silver ripples form on the water's surface.

Inside, there's a kitchen, two bathrooms and two bedrooms. Upstairs is a loft set up with cushions and a telescope where we sit at night and gaze up at the stars.

Jacob has decided that like Xavier—and Declan—he loves nothing more than traipsing through the forest and fishing in the river with Xavier beside him. Abby on the other hand, has decided she doesn't like dead animals and refuses to eat anything that looks like it could be meat. Thankfully, she's taken charge of the vegetable garden and we've found her a few times, sitting in the middle of the veggie patch stuffing her pockets with beans and tomatoes.

This new life is a reality I never dreamed possible. I live in a world filled with life, a world of pristine rivers and streams, and strong, tall trees that create awe inspiring canopies above. I live in hope, and I breathe in the beauty of life, no longer choking on regret, guilt, or the abuse and torture of my past.

Abby jumps to her feet and squishes her toes into the wet grass. "So soft Mummy," she says.

"You'll get cold feet," I tell her.

She shakes her head. "I like cold feet."

I laugh as a little pair of arms wraps around my neck. Jacob squeals in my ear. "Mummy! I got a truck, look." I turn around to see Xavier

holding a yellow, plastic dump truck. He smiles, but my heart lurches into my throat and I clamp my eyes shut. *It's over now. He's gone.*

I cover my face with my hands and count to ten in my head. Flashes of memories swirl through my mind. Each one of them an image of Trystan as a little boy with a big smile, but dark, empty eyes.

A hand wraps around my shoulders and a whispered breath sends warmth coursing through my veins. "Breathe. It's okay now, I've got you."

Inhale.

Exhale.

Inhale.

I swallow hard then exhale slowly. "I'm okay." I say it out loud.

By the time I look up again, Jacob is kneeling on the grass pushing the little truck around while Abby scoops up handfuls of dirt and leaves to fill the back of it.

"What was it?" Xavier asks.

"The truck," I admit before I tell him about Trystan playing in the rain with his toy truck.

He presses his lips to my cheek. "You're so brave, babe. I'm so proud of you."

With a heavy, contented sigh, I turn my head and kiss Xavier's lips.

Abby and Jacob giggle, and Xavier smiles against my lips. "You and Dec made the most beautiful babies," he says. "I'm so lucky to have you all in my life."

After another quick kiss, we get up and head inside to give the twins a bath.

As I pass by the kitchen table, I notice the stack of envelopes. "Xavier," I call. "You still haven't opened the mail."

He comes out the bathroom and Jacob and Abby follow him, squeezing their rubber ducks and giggling like crazy. "Baff time, Daddy," Abby squeals.

Xavier sits on the chair and she jumps into his lap. "I need to check this mail, then it's bath time." He tickles her sides and she laughs out loud.

Xavier sorts through the envelopes that contain job offers for him to go out on fishing trawlers. He drops them on the table. "Not interested," he says.

“You don’t miss it,” I ask.

“Nope. Besides, I have a family now.” His smile is beautiful.

Opening the next envelope, he pauses. “Abby, sweetheart, can you hop down for a minute, I need to talk to Mummy.”

“Okay, Daddy.” Abby jumps off his lap and runs back to Jacob, still squeaking her rubber duck.

Xavier pulls me onto his lap and wraps an arm around my waist. He kisses my neck. “Sweetheart, this one is from Edgewater Prison. Do you want to read it?”

A heavy weight settles on my chest. *No. Yes. No.* I can’t decide. I turn back to see the twins playing, their laughter fills the cabin.

“I’ll read it.” I say quickly.

I pull the letter from the envelope.

Dear Ms Foxx,

It is with regret that I must inform you, your brother, Trystan Robert Browne, was found dead on Monday 9th September. Please accept this as our sincere condolences and trust we will investigate this matter thoroughly.

Regards,

C. Threadfall.

I slip the letter back into the envelope. A fleeting moment of grief passes by, quickly replaced by relief and an overwhelming sense of freedom. Xavier remains silent as he flicks through the rest of the mail only stopping when he reaches one of the newspapers.

He lifts it up. “Who dat, daddy?” Jacob asks, pointing to the male on the front page.

“A bad man,” I tell him. “The police caught him and put him in prison so he can never hurt anyone.”

“All da bad mans go, Mummy?”

I nod. “All of them.”

He drops back to the floor and starts chatting with Abby again.

The front page of the newspaper shows a picture of Trystan. It’s the mugshot the police must have taken when they arrested him. Beside it, a

smaller image shows a picture of Edgewater Prison.

“Holy shit,” Xavier murmurs under his breath.

I stare at the picture of my twin brother. I always believed he had the perfect life, now I realise he was so broken that he’d lost every shred of humanity. Sadness spirals through my heart as I come to understand the abuse my father must have inflicted on Trystan to turn him into a monster.

With a heavy sigh, I read the news report.

Tuesday 17th September

Convicted paedophile and leader of Libertine, one of the largest child sex trafficking rings in our country, Trystan Robert Browne, has been found dead in a shower stall of Edgewater Prison. The gruesome discovery was made by a prison guard when Browne failed to return to his cell. Inside sources say Browne was found in a pool of his own blood with more than three makeshift weapons inserted into his rectum and an electrical cord wrapped around his throat. Another source claims Brown’s genitals were removed in the attack and forced down the throat of the criminal known as ‘The Monster’.

Police say criminals like Browne are often targeted by other inmates due to the nature of their crimes.

A source close to the family said Browne was sexually abused as a child, and forced to accompany his father, Robert Browne, into Libertine’s underground society where girls as young as five were purchased and sold for sex.

Since his incarceration, Browne had admitted to at least two murders. One dating back to when he was fourteen, and the last, a week before his sensational arrest made headlines around the world.

Commander Callum Brady, founder of Hearts of Innocence declined an interview, but went on to say he was appalled and sickened to find upwards of fifty well-known public figures from various communities were involved with Libertine.

Those who’ve been arrested and charged were named by Harrisville Police and included Principal Derrick Chamberson and four teaching staff from Harrisville High School, where Browne was said to be a star student for almost 6 years.

A former student of the school, said to be one of Browne's closest friends, Luke Gallany was also arrested and charged and is currently serving time in Edgewater Prison where he's been relegated to solitary confinement for his own protection.

Other names on the list include Police Officer Randall Eastlake who was also murdered in prison, as well as Doctor Jeffery Northmandy, and Children's Services Officers Lincoln Martinesca and Rhett Sedoya.

"Oh my god." The words have been branded into my mind. "People want to read this stuff?" I say mostly to myself.

"They must. The newspapers are always full of stuff like this that's why I don't read them. They're good for lighting the fire, nothing else." Xavier presses his lips to my neck. "They're all gone now, for good. And you never have to worry about your brother again."

"But... is this what people are capable of?" I press my hand to my chest. "It's so... shocking."

He nods in agreement. "I'll get rid of it, babe. Is that okay?"

"Yes. I... I guess I... I knew there was evil in the world, but that—" I rub my head. "I'm relieved he's gone, and when I read the letter, I guessed that was it. But to hear what they did to him—What kind of person does that?"

"Criminals. Killers. The kind of people who despise anyone who hurts children. But also the type of people who belong in prison, for a long, long time." Xavier lifts me up as he stands and wraps his arms around my waist. "There are some messed up people in the world, sweetheart."

"I know." The more I think about it, the more I want to stay here in the cabin forever where the ugliness of society can't reach us. Where my children are safe, and life is simple and wonderful, and everything makes sense.

While I sit back down with Xavier, I think about the envelope in our bedroom. The one from Cathie's real father. I've put off opening it for so long. The timing was never right, and I never felt like I needed to know what was inside. *It's time.* "Xav, I think I want to read the letter now."

He pulls my hair back and rubs my shoulders. "Are you sure?"

"I think so. I guess I could read a little, then if it's too hard I'll put it away again."

He kisses my cheek before I stand to let him up. While he goes into the bedroom to get the letter, I sit and watch my children play together. There are no longer fleeting moments where I worry about their relationship. They are fiercely protective of one another, and the secret language they share fills my heart with happiness.

Xavier returns from the bedroom, smiling. But when he sits at the table and hands me the envelope, his brow creases. "Remember you can stop. You don't have to keep reading if gets too hard."

He extends his hand and squeezes mine before I open the envelope. A lump forms in my throat when a Polaroid picture drops into my lap. The woman, my mother, is young, and wears the biggest, happiest smile I've ever seen. The man beside her, obviously Cathie's father, is smiling just as bright. Behind them, the sun sets in the background, the image faded over the years, but still beautiful.

I hand it to Xavier and he tilts his head, his eyes flicking between me and the photograph. "You look a little like her."

I try to smile, but the memories of her are too tainted now, and all that comes from my lips is a defeated sigh. With trembling hands, I unfold the letter.

Dear Carlie,

I'll try to say this the best way I know how.

I'm sitting here in this police station knowing that somewhere not far from here is the young girl who suffered years of abuse and torture to try to save my little girl. Eli Cole told me a bit about your past. The guy made me promise not to repeat the things I said about your father, so I'm going to try my best to keep this short.

I met your mum back in high school, she was hanging around with your father then, and didn't want to know me. Anyway, years later I was at the local store and there she was. She had that look like when you see a rabbit at night, and they're all scared, but curious. You know the big eyes and the worried expression?

We got talking and one thing led to another and eventually we started meeting in secret. She was so scared of your father, always covered in bruises and welts, horrible stuff. It wasn't until six months later that she told me about you. I told her to leave, told her to take you and come live with

me. I promised her I'd protect you both, and help her get clean and back on her feet again. Guess she was more afraid than I thought.

When she found out she was pregnant, I took her away. I locked the car doors and drove until I ran out of gas. Your mum was furious, and desperate to get back to you. She loved you Carlie. I know it doesn't make what she did right, but just know she loved you, okay?

The next day I drove her home and thought I could confront your father, maybe threaten to call the cops if he hurt her again. He was so calm and normal, I suppose. But when he showed up at my door the next day and beat me to near death, I knew I had no choice but to leave town.

Your mum called me not long after she had Cathie. Said she wanted to run, take you with her and save you from him. She told me what he'd been doing to you and how he never let her be alone with you.

A couple of weeks passed, and I got a call from Dianne, your aunt, we'd been talking since your mum got pregnant. She said she'd seen Cathie and told me how beautiful she was and how she had my eyes. I was over the moon, but too much of a coward to go get her and your mum.

While I was doing some research of my own and trying to figure out a way to get you, and Cathie and your mum out of there, I came across a website about child abuse. I called a few places and begged them to check on you girls, but never heard a thing back.

Until the day I picked up the newspaper and read that Dianne was dead, and your mum was missing. Somehow, I just knew your father was involved, but I had no proof. For a while, I tried to forget about it all. Took off and moved interstate, tried to get on with my life. But I couldn't rest. Every time I saw something on the news about kids being abused, or a paedophile being sent to prison, I got this guilt in my chest and it was eating away at me.

I headed back to Harrisville and decided to follow your father around. I watched what he was doing, took pictures, and kept tabs on him. I spent years of my life sneaking around in the dark with one goal, to make sure your father paid for what he was doing.

Carlie, I'm so sorry I didn't have the courage to do more. I'll never forgive myself for that. But please know I don't blame you. You loved Cathie, and you did what you could to protect her, and I'll always be thankful for that.

Stay safe, and you keep your chin up and don't let what they did to you control your life. And Carlie, never apologise for telling your story. You're a brave girl, and you deserve the world.

Martin Richardson

* * *

7.00pm

From the loft we can already see the stars appearing in the sky. A dotted blanket of midnight blue speckled with the silvery glint of crystalline stars. The twins fell asleep right after their bath, so Xavier and I came up to star gaze before we go to bed.

Lying back in his arms, I raise my hand to the sky. "I once believed Cathie was up there, looking down on me, telling me she was safe among the stars she always wanted to see."

"She never saw them?"

I snuggle into the crook of his arm. "Never. She was rarely allowed out of her bedroom."

"I'm sorry you lost her."

"Me too."

Xavier glides his hand across my stomach. "Zar, do you think we did the right thing?"

I rest on my elbow and put my head in my hand. "Coming here?"

His eyes glisten and well with tears. "You and me. Do you think it was wrong?"

I don't hesitate. "No. Not at all. Why?" Panic coils in my chest. "You've changed your mind?" I sit up quickly and wrap my arms around myself.

He sits and tugs on my hands then pulls me onto him so I'm straddling his thighs. "God no. I love you so damn much it hurts. But sometimes... I get this feeling of guilt... or maybe sadness. I never planned to fall in love. But with you, it's like I'm in a dream and I never want to wake up. In some ways I wish I'd met you sooner, but when I hear you talk

about Declan, guilt eats away at me because the love you had for him was unending.”

My eyes well with tears now. Does Xavier think I don’t love him as much as I loved Declan? I’m so confused. I never considered the amount of love, only that it was different. “Xavier, I love you. And yes, I do love Declan, and my heart may never heal, and I will always long for one final embrace, but you are who I want now.” I shuffle forward until I can feel his heart beat against my chest. “I was caught in the darkness all over again, but this time it was you. You stirred my heart with promises of friendship and loyalty, but somewhere along the way, it turned into breathtaking passion. I was at war with myself. Fighting to hold on to a love that was lost, and at the same time I was reaching for you, dreaming of you... waiting for your fingers to wander across my scarred flesh and find beauty between the lines of pain.”

“Why are you so beautiful? So perfect?” he asks.

My lip curves into a smile. “Someone once told me I had angels in my heart. I guess it’s true after all.”

Xavier’s hand slides up beneath my hoodie. He lifts it over my head and drops it on the floor. He cups my breasts and he leans down to kiss them before trailing delicate kisses up to my shoulder. “Cold?” he asks as goose bumps cover my skin.

I push myself against him and slide my hands up his shirt. “I trust you to keep me warm,” I whisper before nibbling at his earlobe.

A decadent sigh of pleasure leaves his lips as we lie back, wrapped in a soft, fleece blanket. Each tender kiss sends waves of desire bursting through my veins. Tiny beads of sweat form on my brow and my back arches as Xavier’s hands explore every inch of my body.

“I could stay here forever,” Xavier breathes.

“Let’s do it,” I agree before a breathless moan escapes my lips.

“You want to?” he asks. His eyes alight with happiness.

“I do. I want this to be our home.”

As Xavier claims my mouth with another breathtaking kiss, I glance at the stars before I close my eyes and savour the taste of his lips on mine.

I never believed in love before Declan. I never believed in love *after* Declan. But as I lie here with Xavier, I finally believe in fate.

The stars aligned for us, like two pieces of a jigsaw puzzle, we fit together perfectly. He's not Prince Charming, or a knight in shining armour. He didn't come from a fairy tale and appear on a white horse to ride off into the sunset with me. Xavier appeared when I needed him most. He rescued me from the shadows of my soul. He saw what I could become before I ever had a chance to dream him into existence. He was the love I needed when everything else had been torn from my arms. He was the light that led me out of the dark, and the hands that pulled me back into a world of hope and serenity.

I was alone. I was empty. I was broken.
Until Xavier.

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PART THREE

THE EPILOGUE

In the moments between my breaths
I think of you
In the spaces between my fingers
I wait for you
In the songs I hear each day
I yearn for you
In the silence where I live
I hear you
In the stars above the earth
I wish for you
In the ocean's deep abyss
I search for you
In the sunset's golden glow
I call for you
And in the beating of my heart
You shall live forever

Julie Anne Addicott

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by

ZAHRA GRACE FOXX

On a Monday afternoon on the 11th November, a baby was born into a world
that would threaten to destroy her.

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A fight that would take her on a journey of discovery.
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during the first seventeen years of her life.

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EPILOGUE

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Epilogue Chapter 1

ZAHRA

April 16

29 years old

11 years since Zahra's rescue

The reporters raise their hands and Amy, the owner of Foxxstone Publishing points out to the crowd. “You,” she says, pointing to the female reporter dressed in a black skirt and white shirt. She speaks into the microphone before extending it toward me. “Ms Foxx, can you tell us about your story? What made you write this book?”

Nerves creep in, but Xavier gives my hand a squeeze beneath the table. In the front row, Jaymee and Charles sit wearing huge smiles and urging me on with nods and waves.

When I start talking, the words flow. “Mine is not a story of love and light and the beauty of hope that has the power to crush all that threatened to destroy me. It wasn’t a story I intended to tell. It was a journey I took long, long ago when I had no idea what love was supposed to be—”

The reporter cuts me off, the microphone at her lips again. “What is love to you now?”

Beside me, Xavier lets out an annoyed groan. “If she let you finish...” he murmurs.

I stifle a laugh, suddenly remembering how easily happiness finds me now. “Before, I thought love was in my father’s hands when he touched me. I thought it rested on his pillow at night where I—a little girl of just six years old—laid beside him listening to his words as though they would be the mantra I would live by. Love, to me, was the moments I spent crushed beneath the weight of my brother’s body while his hand squeezed my throat, and he promised me that if I stayed quiet, he’d keep my little sister safe. Love had no meaning. Until Declan.”

Cameras flash around me, blinding me with their bright, white light. Xavier leans in and whispers, “You still okay?”

I nod, and once the flashes stop, Amy asks if there are any more questions. This time, the reporter, an older male with grey hair and a neatly trimmed moustache, asks, “Why didn’t you run away? Why didn’t you fight back or try to call for help?”

“Idiot,” Xavier murmurs.

I squeeze his hand this time.

“What’s your name?” I ask the man.

“Leonard Hollow, Channel Ten News.” He smiles and extends the microphone toward me again.

“Mr Hollow, the abuse started when I was four years old, perhaps earlier, although I can’t remember much before that. My father led me to believe that everything he was doing to me was normal. I didn’t go outside. I didn’t go to school, or to parties. I didn’t see other children outside my house. I lived—and I use that term loosely—in a house where I did what I was told, when I was told. All I knew was punishment and reward. I didn’t run away because I didn’t know how to. My little sister was five years younger than me, and for all intents and purposes, I was her mother.”

“But you never tried to call for help? Even as a child you must have known what was happening, was wrong. Do you believe you should have, or could have tried harder?” The doubt in his tone sends a wave of anxiety rushing over me.

Count to ten. Stay calm.

“Mr Hollow, do you have children?”

He nods proudly. “Two girls.”

Xavier mumbles to Amy, “Let me punch him.”

She laughs and leans down to me. “Want me to end it there?”

I shake my head. Eleven years later, I’m no longer the shy, silent girl I once was. Advocating for children, for little girls who were like me, is my life’s mission. “Mr Hollow, imagine your little girls trapped inside a house, terrified of the men who’ve taken them from their beds in the middle of the night. Imagine them being threatened with death if they so much as speak without being told to.”

Silence falls across the crowd gathered outside Dream Weaver Book Store. *Don’t say it.* I tell myself over and over, but ten seconds later, I say the words. “Imagine your daughters... your little girls being purchased by men who will rape them until they can’t walk, and then imagine them being

told that if they ever try to escape it will happen again, over and over and over. But then... it happens anyway.”

Leonard Hollow drops his microphone, his mouth agape.

“Don’t ask me *why* I didn’t try harder. Ask those men why they thought it was okay to use me. To purchase me as though I was nothing more than a commodity to be used for their sick entertainment. Ask them what twisted thoughts went through their minds when they broke my eight-year-old body and showed me that monsters do exist. And when you’re done, Mr Hollow, ask yourself what you were thinking when you asked if I should have tried harder.”

More silence.

Stay calm. Staring at the faces in the crowd, I imagine I’m on a downhill slope and the bottom is coming up fast. This may be my first and last book signing. Xavier wraps an arm around my shoulders and pulls me close. “I’m so damn proud of you, sweetheart.”

Silence.

Then... cheers.

My name is screamed out loud by the people in the crowd, all of them clapping, whistling, cheering... for me.

Once the cheers die down, Amy nods toward me, urging me to continue.

I exhale slowly, then focus on the crowd, searching for a familiar face. When she makes eye contact with me, she smiles and waves. “Before I go...” I tap my foot, focusing only on Bridgette’s smiling face. *She’s safe... because of me.* “I want to say... I *need* to say. To all the little girls who’ve lost their voices, and to those who’ve helped find them again... *Never* apologise for telling your story.”

Amy stands at the front of the stage. “Thank you all for coming here today for Zahra’s first book signing. It’s time for a short break, then we’ll get you all in line and ready to have your books signed. There will be another Q and A later this afternoon.”

As the crowd dissipates, Jaymee and Charles rush up to the stage to hug me. “Oh my god, Zahra you were amazing! That reporter was an ass.”

“Do you think I was rude?” I ask her.

She shakes her head. “Not at all. Who does he think he is blaming you?”

“I was ready to knock him out,” Charles says, clenching his fist.

“Mummyyyy! Daddyyyy!” Their screams pierce the air. Ahead, a flustered Angela is running after the twins. Another scream comes a second later. “Auntzy Zahra, they keep running away,” Maggie calls.

Xavier and I walk down the steps and the twins barrel into us, still squealing with delight. Eli and Zahra watched the Q&A from inside the bookstore with the children. When I see them in the distance, they wave their arms in the air and shout my name, making me laugh.

“Mummy, can we eat now?” Jacob asks.

I nod. “We sure can. We get to have a special lunch in the fancy restaurant.”

“Can I sit with the twins?” Maggie asks.

“Of course,” I say giving her a hug.

“Mummy,” Abby says. “Do they cook animals here?” Tears well in her eyes. Her compassion for all living things is the most precious and beautiful thing about her. The time we spend in the cabin allows her to explore nature and learn about the beauty of life, but it breaks my heart to see her upset when we come back to Rockburn Grove, and she refuses to eat.

“I think so, sweetheart. But they have vegetables and salad too, and you don’t have to eat anything you don’t like.”

Jacob gives her a hug. “I will have only vegetables too, Abby, I don’t want you to be sad.”

“Me too!” Maggie says.

Grace kneels in front of Abby and takes her hands. “Abby, guess what?”

“What?” Abby asks with a little pout.

“I don’t eat animals either. So maybe we can sit outside on the balcony and eat our lunch.” She looks up at me and Xavier. “Would that be okay?”

“Absolutely,” Xavier says as he takes Abby’s hand and we head into the restaurant.

* * *

It's almost sunset when we reach the top of Mount Blessing. Jacob and Abby run toward the viewing area to peer down at the rocky cliffs below while Xavier takes my hand and tugs me closer. "You did so well today. You signed over two hundred books."

I can't wipe the smile off my face. People want to read my story. They care about my words and the secrets between the pages I never imagined would see the light of day. They care about *me*. But lingering doubt is never far from my mind.

"I hope they don't hate it," I say nervously. "What if they hate it, Xavier?"

He laughs. "What if they read it, and they understand what it was like for you?"

"But what if—"

"Zahra, sweetheart. Stop worrying. You wrote the story, you had it published, the world is going to read it. And when they do, they will know that a piece of your precious heart and soul is on every single page. That between the lines of those words, was a little girl who so desperately wanted to be loved."

"I'm scared they won't understand." I drop my head to hide my tears.

Xavier lifts my chin and wipes them away. "It's okay to be scared... but that's not all you are. You're brave, Zahra. You put every moment of your life into words that will one day heal another heart or encourage another girl to tell her story." He presses a kiss to my lips.

"The sun. Mummy, Daddy, the sun," Abby shouts.

"The sun!" Jacob repeats, pointing to the horizon.

We stand at the barrier and look out to the sunset. Xavier takes my hand. "It's so beautiful," I say.

"Zar, can I tell you something?"

"Of course, you can tell me anything."

He tugs me closer. "I want you to know how much I love you. How much I adore you. When you look at me, everything makes sense, everything falls into place. When you speak, your voice is the only thing that matters to me. Everything else is background noise with no meaning. And when you accepted me into your heart, the rest of the world became invisible, and you were all I could see. I love you, Zahra, and it's a love I've never felt before. A love I only want to feel with you."

“Xavier...” I whisper.

He shakes his head and digs his hand into his pocket. “Shhh...”

Déjà Vu washes over me as Xavier continues, “Zahra Grace Foxx, will you do me the honour of becoming my wife?” He drops to his knee and holds out a tiny black box. Inside is a stunning diamond ring. Xavier takes it out and I extend my hand, shaking as I do it. As he slips the ring onto my finger, I notice it fits perfectly against my rings from Declan. As though they were made to be together. “Um... you didn’t say yes,” Xavier says.

He stands and tilts his head, his brows bunched in confusion.

“YES!” I shout. “Yes, Xavier, I will be your wife.”

As the sun sets on the horizon, we scoop our children into our arms and gaze up at the sky. It glows with a pink and orange hue, and as we watch, Abby begins to cry. “Abby, baby what’s wrong?” I ask.

“The world is so beautiful, Mummy, my heart is dancing.”

Xavier closes the gap between us. He takes my hand and laces his fingers through mine. Jacob and Abby are squished between us.

“I love our little family,” I say. “I can’t wait to go home.”

“Home to our forest!” Abby cries.

“To our forest!” Jacob repeats.

Xavier presses a kiss to my cheek and raises his head to the sky.

“Thank you, brother,” he whispers with tears in his eyes.

EPILOGUE

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Epilogue Chapter 2

ABBY

April 2

10 years old

My treehouse is the most extraordinary place in the world. My dad built it for my brother and I when we were five years old. We even helped carry the wood, hang the curtains, and make the long rope ladder that we climb up to reach the tree top hideaway. Sitting on the wooden floor, I peer down to the ground below where our dog, Layla, a Siberian Husky, is whining at the bottom of the ladder.

“It’s too high, Layla,” I call down, but of course, she doesn’t understand what I’m saying, and she continues circling the tree and whining until my brother, Jacob runs over and kneels to pat her soft, thick fur.

Jacob cranes his neck to look up at me. “Are you coming to the river?”

I lie on my tummy and push my hair back off my face. “I don’t want to. I’d rather stay up here for a while.” Jacob doesn’t understand why I love it up here in the tree tops. He thinks it’s boring and he always wants to go hiking, or fishing, or swimming in the river at the bottom of the mountain. Mum says “adventure” should have been his middle name, and that he gets it from our dad.

I’m more like my mum. Everyone says so, even my grandma and grandpa, and my aunty Jaymee and uncle Charles. I love my mum so much, so it always makes me happy to hear that.

“It’s gonna be hot today, come swimming,” Jacob calls. “We can go finish our cave before our birthday dinner!” The excitement in his voice makes me smile. I would love to go swimming, but I can’t. I’d especially love to go back to the secret cave we found six months ago when we were exploring the forest. But that’s across the river, and we need to swim across to get there or, head up stream and use the old, rickety bridge.

I shake my head. “I can’t. I want to stay up here and write in my journal.”

Jacob frowns. “You don’t have to cover your marks, Abby. You’re beautiful how you are, just like Mum and Dad said. It’s our birthday! It’s supposed to be a *good* day.”

Tears spring to my eyes and I quickly wipe them away. I don’t like crying, and I don’t like feeling melancholy. Melancholy is a new word I found a few weeks ago when I was doing my school work. Jacob and I learn by distance education, so we don’t need to go to boarding school. I couldn’t imagine having to live away from home, away from my forest, my trees, and my beautiful life.

For one of our learning tasks, we had to write an emotive piece about our feelings on a certain topic. Of course, I took the chance to write about my love for animals and how I believe they should never be killed for food. Melancholy was one of my emotions. It’s one I feel more when we leave the forest to visit our family in Rockburn Grove. Although I love it there, my heart seems to be stuck in the forest and it’s the only place I ever really feel at home.

“Maybe later,” I say, but I know he won’t believe me. Because I never go swimming anymore.

When I was six years old, my mum noticed a mark on my tummy. It was a round circle the same size as the palm of my hand and it was a pretty, pink colour. When we went back to Rockburn Grove to see our family for a few months, Mum and Dad took me to see Doctor Phillips. He was mum’s doctor when she was young, and he’s always kind and tells silly jokes that make me laugh.

Doctor Phillips told us that the pink circle on my tummy was a birthmark, and that sometimes they don’t actually appear when you’re born. Sometimes they appear when you’re a little older, but still a child. He said it could get bigger, or smaller, or it could disappear completely.

I was excited. I wanted to show everyone because I was proud that my body made something so pretty. But then we went to the swimming pool, and I found out it wasn’t pretty at all.

Abby

6 years old

On the way back from the toilet block, I hold Daddy's hand tight while we walk through the people sitting on the grass at the water park. It's very busy because it's summer and it's so, so hot. When we get back to where mummy is sitting with our towels and picnic basket, I plonk down beside her. She gives me a hug and a kiss on my head.

"Are you ready to play in the water now, Abby?" Jacob asks.

I do a big sigh, but I smile too. "Okay, I will play now."

We stand up and hold hands as Mummy and Daddy remind us to stay in the kid's pool and to be kind to the other children.

When we get to the steps, Jacob runs forward and jumps into the water. I stand by the steps and slowly take my time to get used to the chilly water lapping at my legs. When it's up to the top of my thighs, I stop because goose bumps cover my body and make me shiver. Mummy waves to me from the grass area, and I wave back with a big smile. I'm so happy to be here, and later today, my cousin Maggie is coming to meet us here too.

"What's that?" a little girl asks, pointing to the birthmark on my tummy.

"It's a birthmark."

"Does it hurt?" she asks.

I shake my head. "It doesn't do anything."

She stands up in the water and puts her hand out to me. "Wanna be friends? My name is Ella."

I nod, excited. "Yes. My name is Abigail, but everyone calls me Abby." I point to Jacob who's running around under the sprinklers that are shaped like giant mushrooms. "That's my brother, Jacob, we're twins."

Her mouth opens to an O before she takes my hand. "Come on, let's go to the sprinklers too." We run across the grass to where Jacob is playing, but I quickly remember what Mummy and Daddy said about staying in the kid's pool. I spin around to see if I can still see them. Daddy is walking toward me. "That's my daddy," I tell Ella.

"Are you in trouble now?"

I shake my head as Daddy comes closer. When he kneels on the grass, I run over and jump up to wrap my arms around his neck. "I almost forgot the rules, Daddy, I'm sorry."

He kisses my head. "It's okay, I was watching you both. But you need to be careful. Remember what we talked about?"

I nod. "Stay together. Don't talk to grown ups unless you're with us, and come right back if we don't feel safe."

Daddy smiles. "I'm so proud of you, sweetheart. Who's your new friend?"

"That's Ella. We were going to play with Jacob."

Daddy gives me another big hug, then tells me to go play while he sits on the grass nearby. I'm worried about Mummy being all by herself, but when I look over to her, she waves and gives me an extra big smile, so I know she's happy.

Me and Ella and Jacob run around and around under the water, giggling, shouting, and playing catch with Ella's big yellow ball. When the ball slips out of my hands, I run toward the pool to catch it before it drops into the water. "Got it!" I shout to myself.

"What's that?" a little boy asks pointing to me.

My head asks a silly question. Hasn't he seen a ball before? "It's a ball. Do you want to play with us?"

He scrunches up his face and his brown eyes go dark and shadowy. "Not the ball dumb-dumb. That! On you. The red spot, what is that?"

My mouth goes all dry and my heart feels funny and does skippity beats that make my throat get tight. I chew on the inside of my mouth before I tell him, "It's a birthmark."

"Ewww, it's dee-sgust-ing."

"No it's not. It's pretty," I say, but my eyes have tears in them and I'm not sure why.

Ella and Jacob come over and stand beside me. "Hi, Trystan," Ella says to the little boy in the pool.

He looks up at her, but he doesn't smile. "Why are you playing with her?" he asks Ella.

"She's my friend. You can play with us too if you want, but you have to behave, or I'll tell my daddy again."

"Is he your friend?" Jacob asks Ella.

She shrugs. "He goes to my school."

Trystan shakes his head. "I don't wanna play with her." He points at me again, and I step back and hold the ball close to my tummy. "She's got a

disgusting spot on her. It's gross. If you touch her, you'll get spots too. Gross spots all over you!"

"No she hasn't," Jacob says. "It's a birthmark, and you're being mean to my sister."

"Ewww... she's your sister? Girls are dumb," Trystan shouts.

"Stop it, Trystan!" Ella shouts back. "You're hurting Abby's feelings."

Trystan climbs out of the pool and stands in front of Ella. He puts his hands up and pushes her chest so hard she falls on her bottom and starts crying.

"Stop it, you're hurting her," I say. "Leave her alone."

"Yeah, stop it," Jacob says tugging on my hand. "You shouldn't hurt girls, or anyone at all."

But he doesn't stop. Trystan's eyes go to small lines and he makes fists with his hands, then he pushes me hard. "Get lost ugly-spotty-gross-girl."

I fall on my bottom and cry, and when Jacob calls Daddy, I scramble to my feet and try to help Ella up, but she's still crying too. Daddy kneels down and holds me close to him while Ella screams for her own daddy.

"What happened?" Daddy asks.

"That boy," I point to Trystan. He's already back in the water playing with another boy. "He pushed Ella, and he pushed me too." I don't tell Daddy what he said about my birthmark because it hurts my tummy to think about it, but Jacob tells him.

"Daddy, he said Abby's birthmark is disgusting and she's ugly. That's mean, isn't it? It's not true. Abby is beautiful."

Daddy's face gets a little angry like it did one time when we went to a busy carnival.

A man tried to give me a hug when I won a big, stuffed teddy bear. I didn't want the man to touch me at all and said really loud, "Don't touch me!" But he said all the kids get a free hug if they win a toy. Daddy was very mad and said the man had to ask first, and that if I said no, he had better leave me alone. I said no again, but this time I was so loud that the man got angry too. He said lots of bad words to Daddy and told him I was being rude, and that I should do what I was told.

Daddy told the man about the rules for not touching people unless you have their permission. I thought all grown-ups knew the rules already. A police man came and talked to the man while we went to get fairy floss and go on the Ferris wheel. Daddy said he wouldn't let that mean man ruin our special day at the carnival.

Daddy nods to Jacob. "Yeah, Jake. That's mean, and it's not true at all. Abby, you're beautiful just the way you are, sweetheart." Daddy takes my hand away from my tummy and gives me a special make-it-better-kiss on my palm. "You don't have to hide your birthmark. It's special, just like you."

I press my hand over it again, hoping that the magic make-it-better-kiss on my hand makes my mark go away and never come back. I don't want it anymore.

Thinking about my birthmark always makes me feel sad now. Especially since it's grown to be bigger than a circle. Now, it's a big pink mess all over my tummy, my leg, my arm and my chest. It looks like I fell into a bucket of pink paint. *I wish it was gone.* Wishes are for babies, I remind myself.

"Please come, Abby," Jacob shouts.

I sigh really loud hoping he will hear it. "I don't want to."

"Whyyyy?" he whines. "It's our *BIRTHDAY!!!* Come and have fun."

I giggle. Jacob sounds so silly when he whines like a baby.

"I'll tell mum to come get you!" he shouts. Before I can tell him to stop, he runs back toward our cabin.

I roll onto my back and look up to the treetops. The patterns above me are so beautiful it makes me smile and my eyes grow wide in awe. Tiny rays of light pierce through the leaves and branches creating rippling spots of sunlight all over me. I lift my arm to see the spots of light on my skin, then I trace over them with my fingertips.

"Abby, sweetheart?" Mum calls from the ground. "Can I come up?"

I pull my sleeves down and turn around to sit and look down to my mum. Her hair is all up on top of her head in a messy bun. When she looks up at me, I can see the long scars around her neck. My mum is so brave and

so strong. She's never afraid to show her scars, and she never tries to hide her marks away like I do. I wish I were more like my mum.

"You can come up," I call.

When she reaches the top of the ladder, she looks up to the tree tops, then down at the tree house where the sunlight is sprinkled all around. "It's beautiful up here today," she says as she sits beside me on the floor. "Have you done any writing?" she asks.

I shake my head. "I was just thinking."

"About what, sweetheart? Do you want to talk about it?"

I shrug. I don't want to ever make my mum sad. She's already had enough sad things happen in her life. The saddest was when my real dad died before I was even born. Sometimes, I miss him, and sometimes, me and Jacob talk about him and imagine what he would have been like in real life. We both decided that he'd probably be just like our dad, Xavier, since they were identical twins.

"I'm okay," I say quietly.

Mum doesn't believe me. "Abby." She takes my hand and kisses my palm. Mum and Dad made up magic make-it-better-kisses when we were little. Jacob got really sick when we were five. Every time we tried to hug him, he would cry and say it hurt. So, Dad gave him a kiss on the palm of his hand, then told Jacob to put his own hand where the pain was, and the magic kiss would make it better.

Mum and Dad found out Jacob had a really dangerous thing called appendicitis, and it was hurting him a lot. I was so glad when he got better, he's my best friend in all the world.

When I close my fist tight, my heart flutters because I'm worried about so many things. I take a deep breath and flatten my hand against my heart that's beating fast.

Mum's voice gets softer like it does when she's about to cry. When I look at her, sparkly tears shine in her eyes. "Sweetheart, what's wrong? Did someone hurt you?"

I shake my head, then rest it against Mum's arm. "I feel ugly and yucky because of my birthmark," I finally say. "What if one day I have friends who don't like me because I'm different?"

Tears fall down Mum's cheeks and I get to my knees and hug her. "Abby, my beautiful darling, you are not ugly. Not on the outside, not on

the inside. You are the most beautiful girl I've ever seen, and your heart is more beautiful than all the stars in the sky. Your birthmark doesn't make you different, sweetheart, it makes you unique." She strokes my hair and kisses my head. "No one in the entire world has the same mark as you. And when your friends see it, they will love you for who you are, not for what you look like, or how many marks are on your skin."

I place my hand gently on my mum's neck. "Why are you so brave? Why don't you get worried that people will be mean to you?" She crosses her legs then pats the floor of the treehouse in front of her. When I sit down, mum starts braiding my hair while she talks. "One day, when you're a bit older, I'll tell you everything, but for now, I can only tell you a little, okay?"

I nod. "Okay."

"When I was a little girl, some very bad people were mean to me. They did horrible things that hurt me and made me believe I was ugly and worthless."

"Did they do the scars on your neck?"

"Yes, sweetheart. They did."

I try not to cry. "And the ones all over your body?"

"Yes."

Tears fill up my eyes until they dribble down my cheeks. Mum reaches her hand over my shoulder and I hold hers tight. "I love you so much, Mum," I remind her.

"I love you too, Abby."

"How did you love yourself again?"

"Well, when I moved to Rockburn grove and met your dad, Declan, he taught me what love was supposed to feel like. He made me smile when all I wanted to do was cry. He reminded me every day that despite what had happened to me, I was still beautiful."

"Do you miss him a lot?" I ask her.

"I do. But I love Xavier with my whole heart."

"Did he help you too?"

"Oh yes. Xavier helped me so, so much. He helped me believe that being beautiful was more than what I looked like. With him, I learned that beauty is strength, courage, bravery and honesty. Beauty is in the words we speak, and the way we listen to one another. It's so much more than the skin you were born in."

I gasp, then jump to my feet. One side of my hair is braided, the other side hangs down to my waist in a twisty mess of curly ends.

Mum laughs. "What?" she asks.

"I know!" I shout. "I know what I have to do."

"You do?" she looks confused, and it makes me giggle.

I nod and drop to my knees in front of her. I pull off my thick hoodie and throw it over the edge of the treehouse. Mum looks over the edge, then turns back to me, her eyebrows bunched together.

I extend my arms. On one side, smooth, soft creamy flesh the colour of milky tea, that's what I call it. The other arm is smooth and soft, but the blotchy pink spots make patterns all over it. "I don't have to love my marks."

Mum's face turns into a frown. "No," she whispers. "You don't, sweetheart."

"But I can still be brave, right, Mum? And my heart is still beautiful."

"Abigail Grace, you are right. Your heart will always be beautiful."

I lean forward and wrap my arms around her neck. "When I grow up, Mum, I want to be exactly like you!"

She laughs into my neck then presses a big kiss to my cheek. "Every single day I am grateful for you, Abby, please don't ever forget that."

I smile and jump to my feet again. "JACOB!" I shout into the distance. "Let's go swimming!"

A few minutes later, Mum and I are standing at the bottom of the rope ladder and Dad and Jacob are running toward us. "You really wanna go?" Jacob asks, puffing.

I nod. "I want to finish our cave too."

Dad's smiling bright and when I wrap my arms around his waist, he strokes my hair. "What happened to your hair? And where's your hoodie?"

I step back and pull my hair into a messy pony tail. "Mum was braiding it, and I got excited about something."

"About what?" Dad asks with a grin.

I extend my arms, and Dad takes my hands. "I'm beautiful," I say.

His brows bunch together like mum's had. Jacob laughs then rolls his eyes. "Duh, I said that like a hundred times, Abby."

"What do you mean, sweetheart," Dad asks.

“I mean... I’m beautiful if I’m brave. I’m beautiful if I’m strong. It doesn’t matter if I have one mark or a hundred marks, I’ll always be beautiful in my heart... just like Mum.”

Now Dad has tears in his eyes too. Mum walks over and hugs him, then Jacob joins in. I put my arms around them all as much as I can, and I squeeze them tight.

“This is the best birthday ever!” I say. “And we haven’t even had dinner yet.”

“Well,” Dad says with a laugh, “I think we can make it a little better.”

Mum’s smile grows wide, and me and Jacob step back. “How?” We both ask at the same time, then laugh.

“Do you want to tell them?” Dad asks Mum.

She nods, then puts her hands on her belly. “I’m pregnant.”

“PREGNANT?” I scream.

Mum nods.

“We’re having a baby?” I ask.

This time Dad shakes his head, and I pout. “You tricked us?”

“Nope. We’re not having a baby. We’re having twins.”

“YES!!” Jacob and I shout in unison.

I kiss the palms of my hands and press them to Mum’s belly. “I love you both with all my beautiful heart.”

THE END

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

If you're looking to feed the darkness in your soul, you've come to the right place. Julie Anne Addicott started her author journey in 2016 with her debut novel, Untamed Demon Soul.

Julie Anne resides in Victoria, Australia, and lives with her husband and four children who encourage her writing, and keep the coffee flowing.

Since The Untamed Series, Julie Anne has continued to write and now has five novels, and five poetry compilations including The Curse of the Fallen Series that follows the lives of four cursed fallen angels.

For wickedly sinful, and delightfully devilish reads that will carry you through serenity and chaos, follow Julie Anne Addicott on Amazon, Facebook, Goodreads, Twitter, and Instagram.

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